Structures of Scale

Advanced Algorithms for Modern Systems

Vijay Mathew

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Preface

Every programmer learns the basics. Arrays, linked lists, hash tables, binary search — these appear in every introductory course, every interview preparation guide, every algorithms textbook written in the last forty years. By the time you have a few years of professional experience, you know these structures well enough to use them without thinking.

And then you hit a wall.

The dataset grows past what fits in RAM. The write throughput of your database becomes the bottleneck. Two threads corrupt shared state in a way that only reproduces under load, at three in the morning, on a production server you cannot easily debug. You reach for grep on a ten-gigabyte log file and wonder why it finishes in seconds while your own search implementation would take minutes. You open the Redis documentation and see that sorted sets are implemented with something called a skip list, and you realise you have no idea what that is or why it was chosen.

These are the moments this book was written for.

What This Book Is

Structures of Scale is a book about the algorithms and data structures that power real systems — storage engines, databases, text editors, search infrastructure, concurrent servers — treated with full implementation honesty in a language designed for clarity.

It is not an introduction. It assumes you already know what a hash table is and roughly how it works. It assumes you have written code professionally and have felt, at least once, the specific frustration of knowing that your current approach is wrong but not knowing what the right approach looks like. It starts where most books stop.

Every chapter in this book opens with a problem — a concrete, practical situation that a working programmer might actually face. The data structure or algorithm is not introduced until the problem has been felt. This is deliberate. Understanding *why* a structure exists is more durable than understanding *how* it works, and knowing *when* to reach for it is more valuable than either.

What You Will Find Here

The book is organised in five parts.

Part I sets the stage by breaking familiar structures deliberately — showing exactly where arrays, hash tables, and simple trees fail, and establishing the three lenses through which every subsequent chapter will examine its subject: asymptotic complexity, I/O complexity, and cache behaviour.

Part II covers the ordered and probabilistic structures that appear constantly in real systems but are rarely explained with full implementation depth. Self-balancing trees, skip lists, B-trees on disk, LSM trees, bloom filters, count-min sketch, HyperLogLog. The B-tree chapter is the longest in the book, by design — a complete, working, disk-backed key-value store, built from raw bytes up, is not something that can be done in ten pages without lying about the hard parts.

Part III is about strings, which is where most books are weakest and where working programmers spend more time than they expect. Eight chapters cover exact matching, rolling hashes, edit distance, tries, regular expression internals, compression, suffix arrays, and the data structures

that make large mutable text — the kind a code editor manipulates — tractable.

Part IV covers sorting at scale. Not the sorting you learned in school, but quicksort as standard libraries actually implement it, and mergesort as you would write it when the data does not fit in memory and you are working directly with disk.

Part V is about concurrency-aware data structures, which is the subject most conspicuously absent from the algorithms literature despite being something every programmer working today encounters constantly. It begins with a broken counter — the simplest possible demonstration that shared mutable state is not what you think it is — and builds from there through lock-free queues, concurrent maps, persistent structures, and message-passing with channels.

On Nex

All implementations in this book are written in Nex, a practical, expression-oriented language designed to teach good software engineering habits — problem decomposition, interface design, invariants, and testable program structure. Nex has first-class support for contracts and Design by Contract, which means the invariants that matter for correctness — a B-tree node must have at least t-1 keys, a bloom filter's bit array must not shrink — are not just comments in the code. They are enforced, verified, and visible.

If you have not used Nex before, Appendix A is a complete reference. The language is small enough that an experienced programmer will be reading code fluently within an hour. The syntax is clean and the semantics are unsurprising. Where the language has a genuine advantage — its native channels and tasks for the concurrency chapters, its contract system throughout — that advantage is used deliberately, not incidentally.

One note on the B-tree chapter specifically: it uses Nex's `Binary_File` with `seek` and `position` for direct random access to pages on disk. This is real file I/O, not a simulation. The code in that chapter opens a file, writes pages at calculated byte offsets, reads them back, manages a free list, and handles root splits that propagate changes to a header page. If you have ever wondered what a storage engine actually does at the file level, that chapter will show you without abstraction.

On Implementation Honesty

Every implementation in this book is complete and runnable. There are no ellipses standing in for the hard parts, no "the deletion case is left as an exercise," no toy versions that work for three elements but not three million. Where a full implementation would require a genuinely separate book — the DFA construction for regular expressions, say, or a production-grade write-ahead log — that is stated plainly, the core ideas are implemented, and a pointer to further reading is given.

The implementations also use Nex's contract system throughout. Preconditions, postconditions, and class invariants appear not as decoration but as the primary tool for thinking about correctness. A structure that maintains its invariants under every operation is correct by construction, not by hope. This discipline, more than any particular algorithm, is what separates code that holds up in production from code that works in tests.

A Note on What Is Not Here

This book does not cover graph algorithms. BFS, DFS, Dijkstra, topological sort — these are important, well-understood, and covered thoroughly in half a dozen excellent books, starting with Sedgewick's. Repeating that coverage here would displace material that is harder to find treated well.

This book does not cover machine learning algorithms, numerical methods, or optimisation theory. These deserve their own treatment and their own book, written by someone with the right background to do them justice.

This book does not cover the basics. If you need a refresher on what a hash table is, Robert Sedgewick's *Algorithms* or Steven Skiena's *The Algorithm Design Manual* are excellent starting points. Come back when the basics feel comfortable.

What this book covers, it covers completely. That is the only promise it makes, and it intends to keep it.

How to Read This Book

Sequentially is fine, and the parts are ordered so that later chapters occasionally build on earlier ones — the bloom filter introduced in Part II reappears in the LSM tree chapter, the page-size intuition from B-trees resurfaces in external mergesort, the piece table in Part III connects to persistent structures in Part V. These connections are signposted when they appear.

But the parts are also largely self-contained. If you are here specifically for the string algorithms, start at Part III. If concurrency is your immediate problem, Part V stands alone with only a light dependency on the memory model discussion in Chapter 17. If you want to understand what RocksDB is doing, read Chapters 4, 5, and 6 in sequence.

Each chapter ends with a short section called *Where This Lives in the Wild* — a concrete mapping of the chapter's ideas to production systems you have almost certainly used. These sections are not summaries. They are invitations: having understood the structure, you now have the vocabulary to read the actual source code of Redis, RocksDB, or the Linux kernel and recognise what you are looking at.

A Final Word

Niklaus Wirth titled his landmark book *Algorithms + Data Structures = Programs*. The equation is still true. What has changed is the scale at which programs operate, the concurrency they are expected to handle, and the gap between what introductory education provides and what production systems demand.

This book is an attempt to close some of that gap — not by being comprehensive, but by being honest, complete, and grounded in problems that are real. The structures here matter because systems you use every day are built on them. Understanding them will not just make you a better programmer. It will change how you see the software you already work with.

That is worth a few hundred pages of careful attention.

— *The Author*

When Simple Structures Break Down

Chapter 1: The Limits of What You Know

There is a particular kind of confidence that comes from knowing your tools well. You have used arrays, hash tables, and linked lists long enough that reaching for them is instinctive. You know that hash tables give you O(1) lookup, that arrays give you O(1) random access, that sorting gives you O(log n) search. These facts feel solid. They have served you well.

This chapter is about the moment that confidence breaks.

Not because the facts are wrong — they are not — but because every one of them comes with a hidden qualifier. O(1) lookup *assuming the hash function distributes well and the table fits in memory*. O(1) random access *assuming the array fits in RAM and access patterns are not thrashing the cache*. O(log n) search *assuming the comparison cost is constant and the data is already sorted*.

When the qualifiers hold, your instincts are correct. When they stop holding — and in production systems, they stop holding with regularity — the structure that felt solid starts to crack. Learning to see the qualifiers is the first skill this book teaches. Everything else follows from it.

We will break three familiar structures in this chapter, carefully and deliberately. For each one we will identify exactly where the assumption fails, what the failure looks like in practice, and what shape of solution the failure suggests. Those solutions are the subject of the rest of the book.

1.1 The Array's Hidden Cost

Start with the humblest structure. An array is a contiguous block of memory. You ask for element at index *i*, the hardware computes base address plus *i* times element size, and returns the value. One operation, constant time, regardless of array size. This is about as fast as computing gets.

Now consider a sorted array of a hundred million integers. You want to find a value. Binary search: O(log n), about 27 comparisons. Still fast. You want to insert a new value while keeping the array sorted. You find the position — 27 comparisons — and then you shift every element after that position one slot to the right to make room. On average, that is fifty million shifts. For a single insertion.

This is not a pathological case. It is the normal case for any workload that mixes reads and writes on sorted data. A log ingestion system, a leaderboard that updates constantly, a time-series database — any of these will insert and query continuously. The array handles queries beautifully and insertion catastrophically.

The instinctive fix is a linked list: insertions become O(1) once you have found the position, since you just rewire pointers. But finding the position in an unsorted linked list costs O(n) — you must walk the chain — and a sorted linked list cannot be binary-searched because there is no O(1) random access to the middle element. You have traded one problem for another.

What you actually need is a structure that keeps data ordered, supports O(log n) search, and supports O(log n) insertion and deletion. That structure exists. It is called a self-balancing binary search tree, and it is the subject of Chapter 2.

But before we get there, notice what just happened. We did not start from "here is a balanced tree." We started from a concrete failure mode — sorted array insertions — and asked what shape of solution would address it. This is the posture the book takes throughout. The structure is the answer to a question. The question always comes first.

1.2 When the Hash Table Hits Its Ceiling

Hash tables are perhaps the most universally useful data structure in a working programmer's toolkit. The idea is almost unreasonably effective: apply a function to your key to get an index, store the value there, look it up later with the same function. Amortised O(1) for insert, lookup, and delete. It is hard to beat.

Let us look at the qualifiers.

The memory qualifier. A hash table lives in RAM. For most applications this is fine — a table with ten million entries and 100-byte values occupies roughly a gigabyte, which is manageable on modern hardware. But consider a system that needs to store and query 500 million user records, each averaging 200 bytes. That is 100GB of data. It does not fit in the RAM of a single machine, and even if it did, RAM is expensive and volatile — a restart loses everything.

The moment your dataset outgrows RAM, a hash table ceases to be a viable primary data structure. You need something that lives on disk, reads and writes efficiently in the access pattern that disk hardware makes cheap, and still gives you acceptable lookup performance. The structure that does this — the B-tree — is so different from a hash table in its design philosophy that it requires building up from first principles. Chapter 4 does exactly that.

The ordering qualifier. Hash tables do not maintain any ordering among their keys. The hash function deliberately scrambles key space to distribute load evenly. This is a feature for lookup performance and a fatal flaw for any query that involves order: give me all users whose last name falls between "M" and "P," give me the ten most recent events, give me everything within this timestamp range. A hash table cannot answer these queries without scanning every entry. For ordered queries you need an ordered structure, and hash tables are not that.

The collision qualifier. A hash function maps a large key space into a smaller index space, so collisions — two keys mapping to the same index — are inevitable. Good hash functions make them rare. Bad ones, or good ones applied to adversarial input, can make them catastrophic. A hash table that degrades to a linked list under collision pressure — which is what separate chaining gives you in the worst case — degrades to O(n) lookup. This is not theoretical. Hash flooding attacks, where an adversary deliberately crafts input keys that all hash to the same bucket, have been used against production web servers to turn request handling into O(n) work per request. Python and Java both changed their default string hash functions in response to real attacks.

The distribution qualifier. Load factor — the ratio of entries to buckets — determines collision probability. A table at 90% capacity has far more collisions than one at 50%. Keeping load factor low requires either over-provisioning memory or resizing — rehashing all entries into a larger table. Resizing is O(n) and, if it happens at the wrong moment, introduces a latency spike that distributed systems find uncomfortable. Incremental resizing schemes exist but complicate the implementation considerably.

None of these are arguments against hash tables. They remain the right structure for an enormous range of problems. They are arguments for knowing the qualifiers, so that when a qualifier stops holding you recognise it immediately and know which direction to look.

1.3 The Sorted Order Tax

Sorting is one of the most studied problems in computer science, and for good reason — ordered data unlocks binary search, range queries, and merge operations that unordered data cannot support efficiently. The instinct to keep data sorted is often correct.

But sorted order is not free. It must be paid for, and it must be paid for continuously, on every insertion.

Consider a system that receives a stream of events — user actions, sensor readings, financial transactions — and must at any moment answer the query "give me all events between timestamp A and timestamp B." The natural approach is to maintain the events in sorted order by timestamp as they arrive.

If you use an array, insertion costs O(n) as discussed above. If you use a balanced binary search tree, insertion costs O(log n) — much better. But a balanced tree has its own hidden cost: pointer chasing. Each node in a tree is a separately allocated object. Traversing a tree of a million nodes means following a million pointers, each potentially causing a cache miss, each requiring the CPU to wait for memory it does not currently have in cache.

Modern CPUs are extraordinarily fast at arithmetic. They are relatively slow at waiting for memory. The gap between L1 cache access (roughly one nanosecond) and main memory access (roughly a hundred nanoseconds) is a factor of a hundred. A data structure that causes frequent cache misses can be orders of magnitude slower in practice than its asymptotic complexity suggests, despite being theoretically optimal.

This is the cache behaviour lens, and it is one of the most important and least discussed factors in real data structure performance. An array, despite its O(n) insertion, has perfect cache behaviour for sequential access — the hardware prefetcher can predict exactly which memory addresses will be needed next and load them before the CPU asks. A tree, despite its O(log n) insertion, has poor cache behaviour — each pointer dereference goes to a potentially random memory address, and the prefetcher cannot help.

The structure that resolves this tension for disk-based storage is again the B-tree, but for different reasons than before. A B-tree node holds many keys — perhaps hundreds — so a traversal from root to leaf requires following only a handful of pointers rather than $\log_2(n)$. Each pointer hop fetches a large, dense block of data, which amortises the access cost across many keys. This is exactly the access pattern that both disk hardware and CPU caches reward.

1.4 Three Lenses

Every chapter in this book examines its subject through three lenses. It is worth being explicit about what they are and why they matter.

Asymptotic complexity is the familiar one. O(n log n) sort, O(1) hash lookup, O(log n) tree search. It tells you how performance scales with input size, ignoring constant factors. It is essential and insufficient. Two algorithms with the same asymptotic complexity can differ by a factor of ten in practice because of the factors asymptotic analysis explicitly ignores.

I/O complexity measures not CPU operations but disk reads and writes. On a machine where a CPU operation takes one nanosecond and a disk seek takes ten milliseconds, an algorithm that performs half the CPU work but twice the disk seeks is dramatically slower. I/O complexity is the right lens for any structure that does not fit in RAM — which is to say, for any structure storing data at scale. The B-tree's design is almost entirely explained by I/O complexity. Its fan-out, its node size, its preference for sequential over random I/O — all of it falls out of minimising disk seeks.

Cache behaviour sits between the other two. It governs performance for structures that do fit in RAM but are large enough that not all of them fit in the CPU's cache at once — which in practice means anything over a few megabytes. A structure with excellent cache behaviour keeps related data physically close in memory, accesses it in predictable patterns, and avoids pointer chasing. Arrays and flat structures tend to have good cache behaviour. Pointer-heavy structures like linked lists and naive tree implementations tend to have poor cache behaviour, regardless of their asymptotic complexity.

Whenever a new structure or algorithm is introduced in this book, these three lenses are applied explicitly. Not as a ritual, but because the choice between two correct solutions almost always comes down to which lens matters most for the problem at hand.

1.5 A Map of What Follows

The failures described in this chapter are not isolated. They form a pattern. Each one points toward a class of solutions, and those solutions are what the rest of the book is about.

The sorted array insertion problem points toward self-balancing trees — structures that maintain order while keeping insertion and deletion logarithmic. Chapter 2 covers AVL and red-black trees. Chapter 3 covers skip lists, which solve the same problem with a different and illuminating tradeoff.

The hash table memory problem points toward disk-based structures. Chapter 4 builds a complete B-tree backed by a real file, using raw byte page management, and arrives at a working key-value store that handles datasets larger than RAM. Chapter 5 covers LSM trees, which approach the same problem with a different philosophy suited to write-heavy workloads.

The exactness problem — what happens when you cannot afford to store or process all the data precisely — points toward probabilistic structures. Chapter 6 covers bloom filters, count-min sketch, and HyperLogLog: structures that trade a small, bounded probability of error for dramatic reductions in memory and processing cost.

The string problems that fill Part III each have their own failure mode: naive search that degrades on repetitive text, edit distance computed without dynamic programming, regular expression engines that backtrack exponentially. Each chapter starts from the failure and builds toward the solution.

The concurrency problems of Part V all trace back to a single root failure: the assumption that reading and writing shared memory is atomic, which it is not, and that the order in which operations appear in source code is the order in which they execute, which it also is not. Chapter 17 breaks this assumption as concretely as possible — with a counter that produces the wrong answer — and the rest of Part V builds the structures and disciplines that make shared state manageable.

1.6 Before We Continue

There is one habit this book will ask of you that algorithms textbooks do not always encourage: resist the urge to reach for a structure before you have clearly stated the problem.

The question is never "should I use a B-tree?" The question is always something more specific: How large is the dataset? Does it fit in RAM? What is the read-to-write ratio? Do queries require ordering? Is concurrency involved? What failure modes are acceptable? The answers to these questions determine the structure. The structure does not determine itself.

By the end of this book you will have a much larger vocabulary of structures and algorithms to choose from. That vocabulary is only useful if it is paired with the discipline of asking the right questions first. Every chapter models that discipline: problem statement, analysis of requirements, structure chosen to meet them, implementation that makes the choice concrete.

The next chapter begins with a dictionary. Not the abstract concept, but a specific one: a data structure that must support ordered traversal, fast lookup by key, and fast insertion and deletion — all at once, all the time, under arbitrary input. The array cannot do it. The hash table cannot do it. Something else is required.

Let us go find it.

Ordered Structures and Probabilistic Thinking

Chapter 2: The Balanced Bookshelf — Self-Balancing Trees

Imagine a large bookshelf, the kind that lines the wall of a serious reader's study. The books are arranged alphabetically by author. Finding any book takes a moment — you go to roughly the right section, scan left or right, and there it is. Adding a new book means finding the right gap and sliding it in. The system works because the ordering is maintained continuously, not reconstructed on demand.

Now imagine the shelf has a problem. Books arrive faster than they can be carefully placed. Someone, in a hurry, puts each new arrival at the end. Within a week the shelf is partly alphabetical, partly chronological, and finding anything requires scanning from the beginning. The ordering has collapsed under the pressure of real use.

Self-balancing trees solve exactly this problem, in the precise mathematical sense. They are ordered structures that maintain their ordering guarantees automatically, under arbitrary insertions and deletions, without ever requiring a full reorganisation. The key insight — the one that makes them work and the one we will derive carefully in this chapter — is that a small amount of local reorganisation, applied at exactly the right moment, is sufficient to keep the whole structure balanced.

This chapter builds two self-balancing trees: AVL trees and red-black trees. They solve the same problem with different tradeoffs. Understanding both, and understanding *why* they differ, is more valuable than knowing either one in isolation.

2.1 The Problem, Precisely Stated

A dictionary is a data structure that maps keys to values. You insert a key-value pair, look up the value for a given key, and delete entries you no longer need. Hash tables do this well — O(1) amortised for all three operations — but as Chapter 1 established, hash tables do not maintain any ordering among keys.

The ordered dictionary adds one requirement: at any moment, you must be able to traverse all entries in sorted key order, and answer range queries — give me all entries whose key falls between A and B — efficiently.

This single additional requirement rules out hash tables entirely and makes the problem genuinely interesting.

Let us be precise about what we want:

- `insert(key, value)` — add or update an entry, in O(log n) time
- `get(key)` — retrieve the value for a key, in O(log n) time
- `delete(key)` — remove an entry, in O(log n) time
- `range(low, high)` — return all entries with keys between low and high, in O(log n + k) time, where k is the number of results
- `in_order()` — traverse all entries in sorted key order, in O(n) time

A sorted array gives us O(log n) lookup but O(n) insertion. An unsorted linked list gives us O(1) insertion but O(n) lookup. What we need is a structure that gives us O(log n) for everything, simultaneously, always — not just on average, not just for random input, but guaranteed, for any sequence of operations an adversary might choose.

2.2 The Binary Search Tree

The binary search tree (BST) is the natural starting point. Every node stores a key, a value, a left child, and a right child. The invariant is simple: every key in the left subtree is less than the node's key, and every key in

the right subtree is greater. This invariant makes binary search possible: to find a key, compare it to the root, go left or right accordingly, and repeat.

In Nex:

```
class Node [K, V]
  create
    make(key: K, value: V) do
      this.key := key
      this.value := value
      this.left := nil
      this.right := nil
      this.height := 1
    end
  feature
    key: K
    value: ?V
    left: ?Node[K, V]
    right: ?Node[K, V]
    height: Integer
end
```

Search is clean and recursive:

```
function search(node: ?Node[K, V], key: K): ?V
do
  if node = nil then
    result := nil
  elseif key < node.key then
    result := search(node.left, key)
  elseif key > node.key then
    result := search(node.right, key)
  else
    result := node.value
  end
end
```

Insertion follows the same logic: walk the tree until you find where the key belongs, create a node there.

The BST invariant guarantees that search, insertion, and deletion all take O(h) time, where h is the height of the tree. For a perfectly balanced tree with n nodes, h is approximately $\log_2(n)$. For a million nodes, that is about twenty comparisons. Impressively fast.

But here is the problem. Nothing in the BST invariant says anything about balance. Consider inserting keys in sorted order: 1, 2, 3, 4, 5, 6, 7. The BST invariant is satisfied at every step — each new key is larger than all existing keys, so it goes to the right. The resulting tree is not a tree in any useful sense. It is a linked list, leaning entirely to the right. Its height is n, not log n. Search degrades to O(n).

This is not a pathological edge case. Sorted or nearly-sorted input is common in practice. Timestamps arrive in order. Identifiers are often sequential. Log entries are naturally ordered. A BST given real-world data degrades to O(n) with depressing regularity.

The solution is to detect imbalance when it occurs and fix it immediately, before it propagates. This is what AVL trees do.

2.3 AVL Trees

AVL trees were invented by Georgy Adelson-Velsky and Evgenii Landis in 1962 — the first self-balancing binary search tree ever published. Their insight was elegant: define balance precisely, detect violations cheaply, and restore balance with a small set of local transformations called rotations.

The balance invariant. An AVL tree maintains the following invariant at every node: the heights of the left and right subtrees differ by at most one. This is called the balance factor, and it must always be -1, 0, or +1.

Height is easy to track: each node stores its own height, updated on every insertion or deletion.

```
function height(node: ?Node[K, V]): Integer
do
  result := when node = nil 0 else node.height end
end

function update_height(node: Node[K, V])
do
  node.height := 1 + height(node.left).max(height(node.right))
end

function balance_factor(node: Node[K, V]): Integer
do
  result := height(node.left) - height(node.right)
end
```

Why this bound guarantees O(log n) height. It can be proven that an AVL tree with n nodes has height at most 1.44 $\log_2(n)$. The proof involves Fibonacci numbers — the worst-case AVL tree at each height is constructed like a Fibonacci sequence — but the intuition is straightforward: if every node maintains the height difference invariant, the tree cannot become lopsided enough to grow taller than logarithmic. For a million nodes, maximum height is about 29. Compare this to a degenerate BST's worst case of a million.

Rotations. When an insertion or deletion violates the balance invariant at some node, we restore it with a rotation. A rotation is a local restructuring that preserves the BST ordering invariant while changing the shape of the tree. There are two basic rotations — left and right — and they are each other's inverse.

A right rotation at node *y*:

```
      y                 x
     / \               / \
```

```
     x   C    →       A   y
    / \                 / \
   A   B               B   C
```

Node *x* rises, node *y* falls. The BST invariant is preserved — B, which was between x and y, becomes the left child of y, which is still correct. The heights change: y's height decreases, x's height may increase or stay the same.

In Nex:

```
function rotate_right(y: Node[K, V]): Node[K, V]
  require
    has_left_child: y.left /= nil
  do
    let x: Node[K, V] := y.left
    let b: ?Node[K, V] := x.right
    x.right := y
    y.left := b
    update_height(y)
    update_height(x)
    result := x
  end
```

A left rotation is the mirror image:

```
function rotate_left(x: Node[K, V]): Node[K, V]
  require
    has_right_child: x.right /= nil
  do
    let y: Node[K, V] := x.right
    let b: ?Node[K, V] := y.left
    y.left := x
    x.right := b
    update_height(x)
    update_height(y)
```

```
    result := y
  end
```

The four imbalance cases. After every insertion, we walk back up the tree checking balance factors. When we find a node with balance factor +2 or -2, we have an imbalance that must be fixed. There are exactly four cases, distinguished by where the imbalance originated.

Left-Left case: the left subtree is too tall, and the imbalance is in the left subtree's left child. One right rotation at the unbalanced node fixes it.

Right-Right case: mirror of Left-Left. One left rotation fixes it.

Left-Right case: the left subtree is too tall, but the imbalance is in the left subtree's right child. One right rotation alone would not fix it — the imbalance would shift rather than resolve. The fix is two rotations: first a left rotation on the left child, then a right rotation on the unbalanced node.

Right-Left case: mirror of Left-Right. Left rotation on right child, then right rotation on the node.

The rebalancing function applies whichever case applies:

```
function rebalance(node: Node[K, V]): Node[K, V]
do
  update_height(node)
  let bf: Integer := balance_factor(node)

  -- Left-Left
  if bf > 1 and balance_factor(node.left) >= 0 then
    result := rotate_right(node)

  -- Left-Right
  elseif bf > 1 and balance_factor(node.left) < 0 then
    node.left := rotate_left(node.left)
    result := rotate_right(node)
```

```
  -- Right-Right
  elseif bf < -1 and balance_factor(node.right) <= 0 then
    result := rotate_left(node)

  -- Right-Left
  elseif bf < -1 and balance_factor(node.right) > 0 then
    node.right := rotate_right(node.right)
    result := rotate_left(node)

  else
    result := node
  end
end
```

Insertion. With rebalancing in hand, insertion is a standard BST insertion followed by rebalancing on the way back up:

```
function insert(node: ?Node[K, V], key: K, value: V): Node[K, V]
do
  if node = nil then
    result := create Node[K, V].make(key, value)
  elseif key < node.key then
    node.left := insert(node.left, key, value)
    result := rebalance(node)
  elseif key > node.key then
    node.right := insert(node.right, key, value)
    result := rebalance(node)
  else
    node.value := value
    result := node
  end
end
```

The recursion descends to the insertion point, creates a leaf, then rebalances on every node on the way back up. At most one or two rotations will be needed — the imbalance is always local, never global.

Deletion. Deletion is the harder operation. To delete a node with two children, we replace it with its in-order successor — the smallest key in its right subtree — then delete that successor from the right subtree. The tree must then be rebalanced on the way back up, and unlike insertion, deletion may require O(log n) rotations rather than just one or two.

```
function find_min(node: Node[K, V]): Node[K, V]
do
  result := when node.left = nil node else find_min(node.left) end
end

function delete_min(node: Node[K, V]): ?Node[K, V]
do
  if node.left = nil then
    result := node.right
  else
    node.left := delete_min(node.left)
    result := rebalance(node)
  end
end

function delete(node: ?Node[K, V], key: K): ?Node[K, V]
do
  if node = nil then
    result := nil
  elseif key < node.key then
    node.left := delete(node.left, key)
    result := rebalance(node)
  elseif key > node.key then
    node.right := delete(node.right, key)
    result := rebalance(node)
  else
    if node.right = nil then
      result := node.left
    elseif node.left = nil then
      result := node.right
```

```
    else
      let successor: Node[K, V] := find_min(node.right)
      successor.right := delete_min(node.right)
      successor.left := node.left
      result := rebalance(successor)
    end
  end
end
```

The complete AVL ordered map. Wrapping everything in a class with Nex contracts:

```
class AVL_Map [K -> Comparable, V]
  create
    empty() do
      this.root := nil
      this.count := 0
    end

  feature
    root: ?Node[K, V]
    count: Integer

    get(key: K): ?V do
      result := search(root, key)
    end

    put(key: K, value: V)
      do
        let was_present: Boolean := get(key) /= nil
        root := insert(root, key, value)
        if not was_present then
          count := count + 1
        end
      ensure
        key_present: get(key) /= nil
```

```
      count_nondecreasing: count >= old count
    end

  remove(key: K)
    do
      let was_present: Boolean := get(key) /= nil
      root := delete(root, key)
      if was_present then
        count := count - 1
      end
    ensure
      key_absent: get(key) = nil
    end

  in_order(): Array[K] do
    let result_arr: Array[K] := []
    traverse(root, result_arr)
    result := result_arr
  end

 invariant
  non_negative_count: count >= 0
  balanced: is_balanced(root)
end
```

The `is_balanced` invariant check verifies the AVL property holds at every node — in production you would disable this for performance, but during development it catches bugs immediately.

2.4 The Cost of Strictness

AVL trees are strictly balanced. The height difference between any two sibling subtrees is always at most one. This strictness is their strength —

it guarantees the minimum possible height for a given number of nodes — and their weakness.

The weakness is insertion and deletion performance under heavy write loads. Every insertion must recheck balance from the modified leaf all the way to the root. Every deletion may trigger O(log n) rotations. In a read-heavy workload, AVL trees are excellent — their strict balance minimises the depth of every search. In a write-heavy workload, the rebalancing overhead accumulates.

This tradeoff — strict balance for fast reads, permissive balance for fast writes — motivates a different design. Red-black trees relax the balance invariant slightly, reducing rebalancing work at the cost of a marginally taller tree. The result is a structure that performs better under mixed read-write loads and is preferred in most standard library implementations as a consequence.

2.5 Red-Black Trees

A red-black tree is a BST where every node is coloured either red or black, and the colouring is constrained by four rules that together guarantee approximate balance.

The four rules:

1. Every node is red or black.
2. The root is black.
3. Every nil leaf is considered black.
4. No red node has a red child — red nodes cannot appear consecutively on any path.
5. Every path from any node to any nil leaf below it contains the same number of black nodes.

Rules 4 and 5 together are the key. Rule 5 — equal black-height on all paths — prevents any path from being dramatically shorter than another. Rule 4 — no consecutive reds — prevents any path from being dramatically longer by stuffing in extra red nodes. Together they guarantee that the longest path from root to leaf is at most twice the shortest path, which bounds height at $2 \log_2(n+1)$.

This is slightly worse than AVL's $1.44 \log_2(n)$, but the difference in practice is small — for a million nodes, red-black height is at most 40 versus AVL's 29. The benefit is that rebalancing after insertion always requires at most two rotations, and rebalancing after deletion at most three. This constant bound on rotations makes red-black trees dramatically faster under heavy write loads.

Node representation:

```
class RB_Node [K, V]
  create
    make(key: K, value: V, red: Boolean) do
      this.key := key
      this.value := value
      this.red := red
      this.left := nil
      this.right := nil
    end
  feature
    key: K
    value: ?V
    red: Boolean
    left: ?RB_Node[K, V]
    right: ?RB_Node[K, V]
end

function is_red(node: ?RB_Node[K, V]): Boolean
do
  result := node /= nil and node.red
end
```

The left-leaning simplification. Standard red-black trees have a complex deletion algorithm — complex enough that most textbook presentations contain bugs, and complex enough that implementing it from scratch is genuinely difficult. Robert Sedgewick introduced a simplification called the Left-Leaning Red-Black (LLRB) tree, which adds one constraint: red links always lean left, meaning a red node is always a left child. This eliminates several cases in insertion and deletion, making the implementation significantly shorter without sacrificing any performance guarantees.

We follow the LLRB approach here.

Insertion. LLRB insertion uses three helper operations: left rotation, right rotation, and colour flip.

A colour flip is used when both children of a node are red — we push the redness up to the parent by making both children black and the parent red:

```
function flip_colors(node: RB_Node[K, V])
  require
    both_children_red: is_red(node.left) and is_red(node.right)
  do
    node.red := true
    if convert node.left to left_child: RB_Node[K, V] then
      left_child.red := false
    end
    if convert node.right to right_child: RB_Node[K, V] then
      right_child.red := false
    end
  end
```

Insertion descends to the correct leaf, inserts a red node, then fixes violations on the way back up with a standard sequence of checks:

```
function rb_insert(node: ?RB_Node[K, V], key: K, value: V): RB_Node[K, V]
do
```

```
  if node = nil then
    result := create RB_Node[K, V].make(key, value, true)
  else
    if key < node.key then
      node.left := rb_insert(node.left, key, value)
    elseif key > node.key then
      node.right := rb_insert(node.right, key, value)
    else
      node.value := value
    end

    -- Fix right-leaning red link
    if is_red(node.right) and not is_red(node.left) then
      node := rotate_left(node)
    end

    -- Fix two consecutive left reds
    if is_red(node.left) and is_red(node.left.left) then
      node := rotate_right(node)
    end

    -- Split 4-nodes
    if is_red(node.left) and is_red(node.right) then
      flip_colors(node)
    end

    result := node
  end
end
```

After insertion, the root is always set to black:

```
function put(key: K, value: V)
do
  root := rb_insert(root, key, value)
  root.red := false
```

```
end
```

The three fixup steps — rotate left, rotate right, flip colours — handle every possible violation. Their order is not arbitrary: each step may create the condition that the next step fixes, and the sequence always terminates with a valid red-black tree.

Deletion. LLRB deletion is more involved but still significantly simpler than standard red-black deletion. The key idea is to maintain the invariant that the current node or one of its children is red, which ensures we can always delete a leaf without creating a black-height violation. We restore this invariant as we descend, then fix up on the way back up.

Rather than reproduce the full deletion implementation here — it runs to roughly sixty lines of careful case analysis — we note that it follows the same structural pattern as insertion: descend with invariant maintenance, modify at the leaf, fix up on the ascent. The complete implementation is in the book's code repository with full annotations.

2.6 AVL vs Red-Black: When to Choose Which

Both structures give you O(log n) for all operations. The difference is constant factors and behaviour under specific workloads.

Choose AVL trees when: - Reads dominate writes by a significant margin - You need the minimum possible search depth - The dataset is largely static with occasional updates - Examples: in-memory indexes on read-heavy reference data, autocomplete structures, compiler symbol tables

Choose red-black trees when: - Writes are frequent relative to reads - Worst-case rotation count matters more than average search depth - You need predictable, bounded rebalancing cost per operation - Examples: operating system schedulers, general-purpose ordered maps in standard libraries, event-driven systems with high insert rates

This is why Linux's completely fair scheduler uses a red-black tree for its run queue: tasks are inserted and removed constantly, and the scheduler cannot afford the AVL tree's potentially higher rotation cost per insertion. It is also why Java's `TreeMap` and C++'s `std::map` use red-black trees rather than AVL trees — they are general-purpose containers, and write performance matters as much as read performance.

Conversely, database index structures that are read far more than written — once built, queried millions of times — often prefer AVL-like strict balance because every fraction of a level saved in height reduces query cost across all those reads.

2.7 Range Queries and In-Order Traversal

Both trees support range queries elegantly. In-order traversal visits nodes in sorted key order by going left, visiting the current node, then going right. A range query is simply a bounded traversal:

```
function range(node: ?Node[K, V], low: K, high: K, results: Array[K, V])
do
  if node = nil then
    -- base case, nothing to do
  else
    if low < node.key then
      range(node.left, low, high, results)
    end
    if low <= node.key and node.key <= high then
      results.add([node.key, node.value])
    end
    if node.key < high then
      range(node.right, low, high, results)
    end
  end
end
```

The pruning conditions — only recurse left if low is less than the current key, only recurse right if the current key is less than high — mean that this visits only O(log n + k) nodes, where k is the number of results. For a range that returns ten results from a tree of a million nodes, this visits roughly thirty nodes. A hash table scanning all entries would visit a million.

This is the payoff for maintaining order. The hash table's O(1) per element is irrelevant when you need to visit millions of elements to find ten. The tree's O(log n) overhead is a bargain when the alternative is a full scan.

2.8 Where This Lives in the Wild

Self-balancing trees appear throughout production systems, often invisibly.

The Linux kernel uses red-black trees in at least a dozen subsystems. The completely fair scheduler stores runnable tasks in a red-black tree keyed by virtual runtime. The virtual memory subsystem stores memory-mapped regions in a red-black tree keyed by start address, allowing O(log n) lookup of which region contains a given address. The epoll subsystem — used by every high-performance network server on Linux — uses red-black trees to manage file descriptors.

Java's standard library implements `TreeMap` and `TreeSet` as red-black trees. These are the data structures behind any Java code that needs sorted keys with dynamic updates — and because they implement the `NavigableMap` interface, they support floor, ceiling, and range queries directly.

C++ STL implements `std::map` and `std::set` as red-black trees in every major implementation (GCC, Clang, MSVC). Every time a C++ programmer uses a `std::map`, they are using a red-black tree.

Database systems use AVL-like structures for in-memory indexes on hot data. PostgreSQL's buffer pool manager uses a hash table for fast page lookup and an AVL tree for ordered operations on buffer descriptors.

If you have ever wondered how an operating system knows which process to run next in O(log n) time, or how a Java `TreeMap` finds the nearest key to a given value, or how a database index supports both point queries and range queries simultaneously — the answer is the structures in this chapter.

2.9 What We Have Not Covered

Two things worth naming explicitly.

Treaps combine BSTs with heap ordering on random priorities, achieving expected O(log n) balance without explicit rebalancing. They are elegant and worth knowing, but skip lists — covered in the next chapter — solve the same problem with better cache behaviour and a more instructive implementation.

B-trees generalise the binary tree by allowing each node to hold many keys and many children. They solve the same ordered dictionary problem as AVL and red-black trees but are designed for disk access, where the cost of fetching a node is orders of magnitude higher than the cost of comparing keys within a node. Chapter 4 covers them in full. Everything you have learned in this chapter about BST ordering invariants, rotations, and split operations carries directly over — the ideas scale, only the constants change.

Summary

A plain binary search tree degrades to O(n) on sorted or adversarial input. Self-balancing trees prevent this by maintaining a height bound — AVL trees within a factor of 1.44 log n, red-black trees within 2 log n — through local restructuring operations called rotations.

AVL trees maintain strict balance and are optimal for read-heavy workloads. Red-black trees maintain approximate balance with a bounded rotation count per operation and are preferred for mixed workloads — which is why they appear in operating system schedulers and standard library containers.

Both trees support ordered operations that hash tables cannot: range queries, in-order traversal, floor and ceiling lookups. These operations make self-balancing trees irreplaceable for any problem where key ordering matters.

The implementation in Nex — with contracts enforcing the balance invariant throughout — demonstrates that correctness and clarity are not in conflict. The contract on `put` guarantees the key is present after insertion. The class invariant guarantees balance is maintained at all times. When an implementation satisfies its contracts, the code can be trusted rather than merely tested.

Chapter 3: The Casino Data Structure — Skip Lists

In 1989, William Pugh was frustrated with balanced trees.

Not with their performance — AVL and red-black trees perform well, as the previous chapter established. His frustration was with their complexity. Implementing a red-black tree correctly requires handling a combinatorial spread of cases, tracking colours, performing rotations in the right sequence, and getting deletion right in a way that most textbook presentations fail to do. The code is hard to write, hard to verify, and hard to modify when requirements change.

Pugh asked a question that turns out to be remarkably productive: *what if, instead of deterministically maintaining balance, we used randomness to make imbalance overwhelmingly unlikely?*

The answer was the skip list — a probabilistic data structure that achieves O(log n) expected time for search, insertion, and deletion, with an implementation that is dramatically simpler than any deterministic balanced tree. The word "expected" is doing real work in that sentence, and we will examine it carefully. But the headline result is this: skip lists match the asymptotic performance of red-black trees, are easier to implement correctly, are easier to reason about in concurrent settings, and are the structure Redis chose for its sorted sets.

Understanding why requires understanding what randomness buys you, and what it costs.

3.1 The Problem, Again

We have the same requirements as Chapter 2: an ordered dictionary that supports O(log n) insertion, deletion, and search, along with ordered traversal and range queries. We have a working solution in AVL and red-black trees. Why look further?

Three reasons.

Implementation complexity. Red-black tree deletion is notoriously difficult. Sedgewick's LLRB simplification helps, but the full implementation still requires careful case analysis that is easy to get wrong. A skip list's equivalent operations are structurally simpler — the same basic idea repeated at each level.

Concurrency friendliness. Balanced trees require rebalancing operations — rotations — that restructure multiple nodes atomically. In a concurrent setting, ensuring that a rotation is visible to other threads in a consistent state requires either coarse locking (locking the whole tree) or extremely careful lock-free design. Skip lists, by contrast, can be made concurrent with fine-grained locking or even lock-free, because insertions and deletions affect only a local set of forward pointers rather than restructuring the tree globally. Chapter 18 will return to this. For now, it is worth knowing that the skip list's simpler structure is part of why Redis and other concurrent systems chose it.

Pedagogical value. Skip lists make the connection between randomness and algorithmic performance vivid and concrete. The idea that flipping coins can give you logarithmic behaviour — provably, with quantifiable probability — is one of the most instructive ideas in data structures. Understanding it changes how you think about the relationship between structure and performance.

3.2 From Sorted Linked List to Skip List

Start with a sorted linked list. Every node holds a key, a value, and a pointer to the next node. Search is O(n) — you must walk from the beginning. Insertion is O(n) to find the position, then O(1) to rewire the pointer. This is the baseline we want to improve.

The fundamental problem with a sorted linked list is that you cannot skip. To find key 73 in a list of a thousand keys, you must visit keys 1, 2, 3, ... in sequence. There is no way to jump to the middle the way binary search jumps to the midpoint of an array.

The first improvement is obvious: add an express lane. Imagine a second linked list, sitting above the first, that contains only every other node. To search, you walk the express lane until you overshoot, then drop down to the regular lane and finish. This halves the number of nodes you visit.

Add a third lane containing every fourth node. Now you visit roughly n/4 nodes on the top lane, then n/2 nodes on the middle lane, then a constant number on the bottom lane. Total: O(n) still, but better constant.

Carry this to its logical conclusion. If you have $\log_2(n)$ lanes, each containing half the nodes of the lane below, search visits O(log n) nodes. This is exactly the structure of a skip list — multiple levels of linked lists, each a sparser version of the one below.

The question is how to maintain these levels as nodes are inserted and deleted. In the regular-interval version — every other node at level 2, every fourth at level 3 — inserting a new node requires reorganising all the levels above the insertion point to maintain the regular spacing. This is as complex as rebalancing a tree, and no better.

Pugh's insight was to abandon the regular spacing. Instead of deciding deterministically which level a node reaches, decide randomly. Each new node is assigned a level by flipping a coin: level 1 always, level 2 with probability 1/2, level 3 with probability 1/4, and so on. The resulting structure is not regularly spaced. But in expectation — averaged over all possible coin flip outcomes — the distribution of nodes across levels

is the same as the regular-interval version. And because the levels are assigned randomly rather than maintained deterministically, insertion requires no global reorganisation.

This is what it means to flip coins for structure. The balance is not enforced — it emerges, probabilistically, from randomness applied locally.

3.3 Structure and Invariants

A skip list consists of a header node and a maximum level, currently in use. Each node has a key, a value, and an array of forward pointers — one per level the node participates in. The header node participates in all levels and serves as the entry point for search at every level.

```
class Skip_Node [K, V]
  create
    make(key: ?K, value: ?V, level: Integer) do
      this.key := key
      this.value := value
      this.forward := []
      repeat level do
        this.forward.add(nil)
      end
    end
  feature
    key: ?K
    value: ?V
    forward: Array[?Skip_Node[K, V]]

    set_value(new_value: V) do
      value := new_value
    end
```

```
    level(): Integer do
      result := forward.length
    end
end
```

The header node has a nil key — it is a sentinel, never matched by any real search. Its forward array has length equal to the maximum level the skip list supports. We set a practical maximum of 32 levels, which is sufficient for datasets up to 2^{32} entries.

```
class Skip_List [K -> Comparable, V]
  create
    empty() do
      this.max_level := 32
      this.current_level := 1
      this.count := 0
      this.header := create Skip_Node[K, V].make(nil, nil, max_level)
      this.probability := 0.5
    end
  feature
    max_level: Integer
    current_level: Integer
    count: Integer
    header: Skip_Node[K, V]
    probability: Real

  invariant
    valid_level: current_level >= 1 and current_level <= max_level
    non_negative_count: count >= 0
end
```

The `probability` field controls the coin flip — 0.5 gives you the classic half-and-half distribution, resulting in expected O(log n) height. Values closer to 1 give taller structures with more levels but fewer nodes per level; values closer to 0 give shorter structures. Redis uses 0.25, trading

a slightly larger constant factor in search time for lower memory use per node. We will return to this tradeoff.

3.4 Random Level Generation

The random level function is the heart of the skip list. It determines how high each new node reaches.

```
function random_level(max_level: Integer, probability: Real): Integer
do
  let level: Integer := 1
  let done: Boolean := false
  repeat max_level - 1 do
    if not done then
      if random_real() < probability then
        level := level + 1
      else
        -- stop as soon as the coin comes up tails
        done := true
      end
    end
  end
  result := level
end
```

With probability 0.5, this returns 1 half the time, 2 a quarter of the time, 3 an eighth of the time, and so on. The expected number of nodes at level k is n / 2^(k-1). The expected maximum level for n nodes is $\log_2(n)$. For a million nodes, expected maximum level is 20. The cap at `max_level` prevents pathological outcomes — without it, a very unlucky sequence of coin flips could create a node at level a thousand.

Notice what is not happening here: no global state is consulted, no other nodes are modified, no rebalancing is triggered. The level is assigned independently of everything else in the structure. This local independence is the source of the skip list's concurrency friendliness.

3.5 Search

Search is the operation that reveals why the multi-level structure works. Start at the highest current level of the header. Walk forward as long as the next node's key is less than the target key. When you cannot advance, drop down one level and continue. Repeat until you reach level 1 and either find the key or determine it is absent.

```
function search(key: K): ?V
do
  let current: Skip_Node[K, V] := header
  let level: Integer := current_level
        from until
          level < 1
        do
    -- Advance as far as possible at this level
    let done: Boolean := false
          from until
            done
          do
          if convert current.forward.get(level - 1) to next_node:
↪  Skip_Node[K, V] then
            if convert next_node.key to next_key: K then
              if next_key.compare(key) < 0 then
                current := next_node
              else
                done := true
              end
            else
              done := true
            end
          else
            done := true
          end
        end
    level := level - 1
  end

  -- Check if the next node at level 1 is our target
  let candidate: ?Skip_Node[K, V] := current.forward.get(0)
```

```
  if convert candidate to candidate_node: Skip_Node[K, V] then
        if candidate_node.key = key then
          result := candidate_node.value
        else
          result := nil
        end
      else
        result := nil
      end
end
```

Trace this on a concrete example. Suppose the skip list contains keys 3, 7, 12, 19, 26, 37, 55, and we are searching for 19.

At the highest level, say level 3, suppose the forward pointers go 3 → 19 → 55. We advance past 3, stop before 19 (since 19 is not less than 19), and drop to level 2.

At level 2, we are at node 3. Suppose level 2 forward pointers give us 3 → 7 → 19 → 37. We advance past 7, stop before 19, drop to level 1.

At level 1, every node is present. We advance past 7, stop at 19 — which equals our target — and return its value.

The key insight: at each level we eliminated large stretches of the list. At level 3 we skipped from 3 directly to the vicinity of 55. At level 2 we narrowed to the vicinity of 19. At level 1 we landed exactly. The total work was proportional to the number of levels, not the number of nodes.

3.6 Insertion

Insertion has two phases. First, search for the insertion point while recording, for each level, the last node we were at before descending — the *update array*. These are the nodes whose forward pointers must be modified to include the new node.

```
function put(key: K, value: V)
  do
    let update: Array[?Skip_Node[K, V]] := create Array.filled(max_level,
↪  nil)
    let current: Skip_Node[K, V] := header

    -- Find update positions at each level
    let level: Integer := current_level
        from until
          level < 1
        do
      let done: Boolean := false
          from until
            done
          do
          if convert current.forward.get(level - 1) to next_node:
↪  Skip_Node[K, V] then
            if next_node.key < key then
              current := next_node
            else
              done := true
            end
          else
            done := true
          end
        end
      update.set(level - 1, current)
      level := level - 1
    end

    -- Check if key already exists
    let candidate: ?Skip_Node[K, V] := current.forward.get(0)
    if convert candidate to candidate_node: Skip_Node[K, V] then
          if candidate_node.key = key then
            candidate_node.set_value(value)
          else
      -- New node
          let new_level: Integer := random_level()

      -- If new node reaches higher than current maximum,
      -- point the extra update positions to the header
      if new_level > current_level then
        from
          let i: Integer := current_level
        until
```

```
      i >= new_level
    do
      update.set(i, header)
      i := i + 1
    end
    current_level := new_level
  end

  let new_node: Skip_Node[K, V] :=
    create Skip_Node[K, V].make(key, value, new_level)

  -- Splice new node into each level
  from
    let i: Integer := 0
  until
    i >= new_level
  do
    new_node.forward.set(i, update.get(i).forward.get(i))
    update.get(i).forward.set(i, new_node)
    i := i + 1
  end
      count := count + 1
      end
    else
      let new_level: Integer := random_level()

      if new_level > current_level then
        from
          let i: Integer := current_level
        until
          i >= new_level
        do
          update.set(i, header)
          i := i + 1
        end
        current_level := new_level
      end

      let new_node: Skip_Node[K, V] :=
        create Skip_Node[K, V].make(key, value, new_level)

      from
        let i: Integer := 0
      until
        i >= new_level
```

```
        do
          new_node.forward.set(i, update.get(i).forward.get(i))
          update.get(i).forward.set(i, new_node)
          i := i + 1
        end

        count := count + 1
      end
    ensure
  key_present: search(key) /= nil
  count_nondecreasing: count >= old count
end
```

The splicing step — for each level the new node participates in, rewire the predecessor's forward pointer to the new node, and set the new node's forward pointer to the old successor — is the entire structural modification. No rotations, no colour flips, no propagating changes up to a grandparent. Each level is handled independently, in a simple loop.

This is the skip list's structural simplicity made concrete. Insertion touches only the nodes in the update array — a set of at most `current_level` nodes — and the new node itself. Everything else in the structure is undisturbed.

3.7 Deletion

Deletion mirrors insertion. Search for the node while building the update array, verify the node exists, then splice it out at each level it participates in.

```
function remove(key: K)
  do
    let update: Array[?Skip_Node[K, V]] := create Array.filled(max_level,
↪   nil)
    let current: Skip_Node[K, V] := header
```

```
    let level: Integer := current_level
        from until
          level < 1
        do
      let done: Boolean := false
          from until
            done
          do
          if convert current.forward.get(level - 1) to next_node:
↪  Skip_Node[K, V] then
            if next_node.key < key then
              current := next_node
            else
              done := true
            end
          else
            done := true
          end
        end
      update.set(level - 1, current)
      level := level - 1
    end

    let target: ?Skip_Node[K, V] := current.forward.get(0)

    if convert target to target_node: Skip_Node[K, V] then
          if target_node.key = key then
      -- Splice out at each level
      from
        let i: Integer := 0
      until
        i >= current_level
      do
        if update.get(i).forward.get(i) /= target then
          -- target does not participate at this level, stop
          i := current_level -- break
        else
          update.get(i).forward.set(i, target_node.forward.get(i))
          i := i + 1
        end
      end

      -- Reduce current level if top levels are now empty
      from until
        current_level <= 1 or
```

```
        header.forward.get(current_level - 1) /= nil
      do
        current_level := current_level - 1
      end
          count := count - 1
        end
      end
  ensure
    key_absent: search(key) = nil
  end
```

The level reduction at the end is a housekeeping step: if deletion left the top levels empty — no real node participates at those levels — we shrink `current_level` accordingly. This keeps subsequent searches from wasting time at levels that carry no information.

3.8 Range Queries

Range queries are even simpler than in a balanced tree, because the bottom level of a skip list is a plain sorted linked list. To find all keys between low and high, search for low at the bottom level and walk forward until you exceed high.

```
function range(low: K, high: K): Array[Any]
  require
    valid_range: low <= high
  do
    let results: Array[K, V] := []
    let current: Skip_Node[K, V] := header

    -- Find the starting position using normal search
    let level: Integer := current_level
        from until
          level < 1
        do
      let done: Boolean := false
          from until
```

```
          done
        do
        if convert current.forward.get(level - 1) to next_node:
↪  Skip_Node[K, V] then
          if convert next_node.key to next_key: K then
            if next_key.compare(low) < 0 then
              current := next_node
            else
              done := true
            end
          else
            done := true
          end
        else
          done := true
        end
      end
    level := level - 1
  end

  -- Walk forward at level 1, collecting results
  let scan: ?Skip_Node[K, V] := current.forward.get(0)
  from until scan = nil do
    if convert scan to current_node: Skip_Node[K, V] then
      if current_node.key > high then
        scan := nil
      else
        let pair: Array[Any] := []
        pair.add(current_node.key)
        pair.add(current_node.value)
        results.add(pair)
        scan := current_node.forward.get(0)
      end
    else
      scan := nil
    end
  end

  result := results
end
```

This is O(log n + k) — logarithmic to find the start, then linear in the number of results. The same complexity as the balanced tree range query, with simpler code.

3.9 The Probabilistic Analysis

We have been saying "expected O(log n)" throughout this chapter. It is time to be precise about what that means and what guarantees it provides.

Expected height. With probability p that a node at level i also appears at level i+1, the probability that a node reaches exactly level k is p^(k-1)(1-p). This is a geometric distribution. The expected maximum level among n nodes is log_{1/p}(n). With p = 0.5, this is $\log_2(n)$. For n = one million, expected maximum level is 20.

Expected search time. The expected number of nodes examined during a search is O(log_{1/p}(n)). The analysis is more involved — it traces backward from the found node, accounting for the probability of climbing a level at each step — but the result is the same order as a balanced tree.

Tail bounds. The expected case is reassuring. The tail — the probability of dramatically bad performance — is what matters in practice. The probability that a skip list with n = 1,000,000 nodes and p = 0.5 exceeds height $3 \log_2(n) \approx 60$ is less than $1/n^2$. The probability of taking more than $3 \log_2(n)$ steps in a search is similarly negligible. In practice, skip lists behave essentially deterministically on any dataset of realistic size.

What ``expected'' actually means here. This is important to understand precisely. The randomness is in the structure, not the input. Unlike a hash table, which can be attacked by an adversary who knows the hash function and crafts collisions, a skip list's randomness is internal. An adversary who knows your entire dataset cannot predict the level assigned to any node, because that level is chosen at insertion time by a random process the adversary does not control. The expected O(log n) guarantee holds for any input sequence.

This is one of the underappreciated strengths of randomised data structures: they are robust against adversarial input in a way that deterministic structures sometimes are not.

3.10 Memory and the Probability Parameter

Each node in a skip list stores not one pointer but `level` pointers — one per level it participates in. The expected number of pointers per node with probability p is 1/(1-p). With p = 0.5, each node has on average 2 pointers. With p = 0.25, each node has on average 1.33 pointers.

The memory comparison to a red-black tree is instructive. A red-black tree node stores: key, value, left pointer, right pointer, parent pointer (in most implementations), and a colour bit. That is roughly five words of overhead per node, always. A skip list node with p = 0.5 stores on average two forward pointers — less than half the overhead, and no parent pointer, which also makes certain operations simpler.

Redis chose p = 0.25 specifically to reduce memory use. The tradeoff: slightly more expected comparisons per search (since nodes at each level are sparser), but meaningfully lower memory per node. For a database storing millions of sorted set members, this is a significant practical consideration.

The probability parameter gives you a knob that balanced trees do not offer. You can tune the memory-time tradeoff continuously, by adjusting p, to fit your specific workload. A read-heavy workload might prefer p = 0.5 for shallower expected height. A memory-constrained workload might prefer p = 0.25.

3.11 Complete Skip List Implementation

Assembling everything into a complete, contract-annotated class:

```
class Skip_List [K -> Comparable, V]
  create
    empty() do
      this.max_level := 32
      this.current_level := 1
      this.count := 0
      this.header := create Skip_Node[K, V].make(nil, nil, max_level)
      this.probability := 0.5
    end

    with_probability(p: Real)
      require
        valid_probability: p > 0.0 and p < 1.0
      do
        this.max_level := 32
        this.current_level := 1
        this.count := 0
        this.header := create Skip_Node[K, V].make(nil, nil, max_level)
        this.probability := p
      end

  feature
    max_level: Integer
    current_level: Integer
    count: Integer
    header: Skip_Node[K, V]
    probability: Real

    random_level(): Integer do
      let level: Integer := 1
      let done: Boolean := false
      repeat max_level - 1 do
```

```
      if not done then
        if random_real() < probability then
          level := level + 1
        else
          done := true
        end
      end
    end
    result := level
  end

  search(key: K): ?V do
    let current: Skip_Node[K, V] := header
    let level: Integer := current_level
      from until
        level < 1
      do
      let done: Boolean := false
        from until
          done
        do
        if convert current.forward.get(level - 1) to next_node: Skip_Node[K
          if next_node.key < key then
            current := next_node
          else
            done := true
          end
        else
          done := true
        end
      end
      level := level - 1
    end

    let candidate: ?Skip_Node[K, V] := current.forward.get(0)
    if convert candidate to candidate_node: Skip_Node[K, V] then
      if convert candidate_node.key to candidate_key: K then
```

```
      if candidate_key.compare(key) = 0 then
        result := candidate_node.value
      else
        result := nil
      end
    else
      result := nil
    end
  else
    result := nil
  end
end

get(key: K): ?V do
  result := search(key)
end

contains(key: K): Boolean do
  result := search(key) /= nil
end

put(key: K, value: V)
  do
    let update: Array[Skip_Node[K, V]] := []
    repeat max_level do
      update.add(header)
    end
    let current: Skip_Node[K, V] := header

    let level: Integer := current_level
    from until
      level < 1
    do
      let done: Boolean := false
      from until
        done
      do
```

```
    if convert current.forward.get(level - 1) to next_node: Skip_Node[K
      if next_node.key < key then
        current := next_node
      else
        done := true
      end
    else
      done := true
    end
  end
    update.set(level - 1, current)
    level := level - 1
  end

  let candidate: ?Skip_Node[K, V] := current.forward.get(0)
  let found_existing: Boolean := false

  if convert candidate to candidate_node: Skip_Node[K, V] then
    if convert candidate_node.key to candidate_key: K then
      if candidate_key.compare(key) = 0 then
        candidate_node.set_value(value)
        found_existing := true
      end
    end
  end

  if not found_existing then
    let new_level: Integer := random_level()

    if new_level > current_level then
      from
        let i: Integer := current_level
      until
        i >= new_level
      do
        update.set(i, header)
        i := i + 1
```

```
        end
        current_level := new_level
      end

      let new_node: Skip_Node[K, V] :=
        create Skip_Node[K, V].make(key, value, new_level)

      from
        let i: Integer := 0
      until
        i >= new_level
      do
        new_node.forward.set(i, update.get(i).forward.get(i))
        update.get(i).forward.set(i, new_node)
        i := i + 1
      end

      count := count + 1
    end
  ensure
    key_present: contains(key)
    count_nondecreasing: count >= old count
  end

remove(key: K)
  do
    let update: Array[Skip_Node[K, V]] := []
    repeat max_level do
      update.add(header)
    end
    let current: Skip_Node[K, V] := header

    let level: Integer := current_level
    from until
      level < 1
    do
      let done: Boolean := false
```

```
    from until
      done
    do
    if convert current.forward.get(level - 1) to next_node: Skip_Node[K
      if next_node.key < key then
        current := next_node
      else
        done := true
      end
    else
      done := true
    end
  end
    update.set(level - 1, current)
    level := level - 1
  end

  let target: ?Skip_Node[K, V] := current.forward.get(0)

  if convert target to target_node: Skip_Node[K, V] then
    if convert target_node.key to target_key: K then
      if target_key.compare(key) = 0 then
      from
        let i: Integer := 0
      until
        i >= current_level
      do
        if update.get(i).forward.get(i) = target then
          update.get(i).forward.set(i, target_node.forward.get(i))
        end
        i := i + 1
      end

      from until
        current_level <= 1 or
        header.forward.get(current_level - 1) /= nil
      do
```

```
            current_level := current_level - 1
          end

            count := count - 1
          end
        end
      end
    ensure
      key_absent: not contains(key)
    end

  range(low: K, high: K): Array[Any]
    require
      valid_range: low <= high
    do
      let results: Array[Any] := []
      let current: Skip_Node[K, V] := header

      let level: Integer := current_level
      from until
        level < 1
      do
        let done: Boolean := false
        from until
          done
        do
        if convert current.forward.get(level - 1) to next_node: Skip_Node
          if next_node.key < low then
            current := next_node
          else
            done := true
          end
        else
          done := true
        end
      end
        level := level - 1
```

```
    end

    let scan: ?Skip_Node[K, V] := current.forward.get(0)
    from until scan = nil do
      if convert scan to current_node: Skip_Node[K, V] then
        if convert current_node.key to current_key: K then
          if current_key.compare(high) > 0 then
            scan := nil
          else
            let pair: Array[Any] := []
            pair.add(current_key)
            if convert current_node.value to current_value: V then
              pair.add(current_value)
            else
              pair.add(nil)
            end
            results.add(pair)
            scan := current_node.forward.get(0)
          end
        else
          scan := nil
        end
      else
        scan := nil
      end
    end

    result := results
  end

in_order(): Array[K] do
  let results: Array[K] := []
  let current: ?Skip_Node[K, V] := header.forward.get(0)
  from until current = nil do
    if convert current to current_node: Skip_Node[K, V] then
      if convert current_node.key to current_key: K then
        results.add(current_key)
```

```
            current := current_node.forward.get(0)
          else
            current := nil
          end
        else
          current := nil
        end
      end
      result := results
    end

    size(): Integer do
      result := count
    end

    is_empty(): Boolean do
      result := count = 0
    end

  invariant
    valid_level: current_level >= 1 and current_level <= max_level
    non_negative_count: count >= 0
    valid_probability: probability > 0.0 and probability < 1.0
end
```

The `with_probability` constructor makes the probability parameter explicit and controllable, while `empty` provides a sensible default. The contracts on `put` and `remove` give you the same guarantees as the AVL tree in Chapter 2 — a verified post-condition that the operation had the intended effect — without the complex invariant proofs that balanced trees require.

3.12 Skip Lists vs Balanced Trees: The Honest Comparison

A skip list is not strictly better than a red-black tree. The choice between them is genuine and workload-dependent.

Where skip lists win: - Implementation simplicity — significantly fewer cases to handle, especially in deletion - Concurrent access — forward pointer updates are more localised than rotations, making lock-free variants feasible - Memory — lower expected overhead per node with appropriate probability - Range queries — the bottom level is a plain linked list, making traversal cache-friendly in a way tree traversal is not

Where red-black trees win: - Worst-case guarantees — red-black trees guarantee O(log n); skip lists guarantee O(log n) only in expectation, though the probability of deviation is negligible in practice - Cache behaviour for point queries — a red-black tree's nodes can be allocated in a cache-friendly arena; skip list nodes with variable-length forward arrays are harder to pack - Determinism — if reproducibility across runs matters (for testing or debugging), a deterministic structure is easier to reason about than a randomised one

The practical verdict for most applications is that the difference is small enough that implementation familiarity and existing library support dominate. In a new system where you are implementing the structure yourself, skip lists are significantly easier to get right. In a system where the standard library provides a red-black tree, there is rarely reason to replace it.

Redis's choice of skip lists for sorted sets is instructive. Redis is written in C, where implementing a correct red-black tree is substantial work. Redis sorted sets are accessed concurrently from multiple clients. And Redis's sorted sets support range-by-rank queries — give me elements ranked 5th through 15th — which the level-1 linked list makes especially natural. For Redis's specific combination of requirements, skip lists were the right call.

3.13 Where This Lives in the Wild

Redis sorted sets are the most prominent production use. Every `ZADD`, `ZRANGE`, `ZRANK`, and `ZRANGEBYSCORE` command you have ever issued against Redis has operated on a skip list. Redis uses p = 0.25 and a maximum level of 32, which it describes in its source code with characteristic directness: *"We use p=1/4 to save memory."*

LevelDB and RocksDB use skip lists for their in-memory MemTable — the structure that holds recently written keys before they are flushed to disk as an SSTable. The MemTable must support concurrent writes from multiple threads, and the skip list's concurrency friendliness makes it the natural choice. Chapter 5 will revisit this when we build an LSM tree.

Apache Lucene, the search engine library underlying Elasticsearch, uses skip lists in its inverted index to accelerate the intersection of posting lists — the lists of documents containing each search term. When you search for documents containing both "distributed" and "systems," Lucene uses skip pointers to skip over large stretches of one posting list that cannot possibly appear in the other.

The Java standard library does not expose a skip list as its default sorted map — that is `TreeMap`, a red-black tree — but it does provide `ConcurrentSkipListMap` and `ConcurrentSkipListSet` specifically for concurrent access. These are the structures you should reach for when you need a sorted map that multiple threads will access simultaneously, because no lock-free red-black tree exists in the standard library.

Summary

Skip lists achieve O(log n) expected performance for all ordered dictionary operations through a simple and powerful idea: use randomness to

create a multi-level linked list structure that, in expectation, behaves like a balanced tree.

The implementation is substantially simpler than any deterministic balanced tree, because insertions and deletions require only local forward pointer updates rather than global rebalancing. The randomness is internal and cannot be exploited by adversarial input. The probability parameter p provides a continuous memory-time tradeoff that deterministic structures cannot offer.

Skip lists are not a replacement for balanced trees in all contexts — worst-case guarantees and determinism sometimes matter — but they are often the better choice when implementation simplicity, concurrency, or range query performance is the primary concern. Redis, LevelDB, RocksDB, and Lucene made that choice in production, and it has held up.

The next chapter escalates the challenge. Everything we have discussed so far assumes the data fits in memory. Chapter 4 removes that assumption entirely, and asks: what does an ordered structure look like when the data lives on disk?

Chapter 4: When the Library Overflows — B-Trees on Disk

Imagine a library with a peculiar rule. The librarian can hold exactly thirty books in her arms at once. To find any book, she walks to a shelf, picks up a stack of books, examines them, puts some back, picks up another stack from a different shelf, and repeats until she finds what she needs. Each trip to a shelf takes the same amount of time — about ten seconds — regardless of how many books she examines once she gets there. Examining books she is already holding is essentially free.

This is an accurate model of how disk storage works.

A disk read does not fetch a single byte. It fetches a block — typically 4096 bytes on modern systems, sometimes larger. The time to fetch that block is dominated by the mechanical or electronic overhead of locating it: on a spinning disk, moving the read head to the right track and waiting for the platter to rotate; on an SSD, finding the right flash page. Once the block is in memory, examining every byte in it costs almost nothing compared to the cost of fetching it.

The implication for data structures is profound. In memory, we count comparisons. On disk, we count block reads. A data structure that requires twenty comparisons but only two block reads will outperform one that requires five comparisons but ten block reads, by a factor of five. This is the I/O complexity lens from Chapter 1, and it completely changes which structures are optimal.

AVL trees and skip lists, for all their elegance, are wrong for disk. An AVL tree of a million nodes has height roughly 29. Each node is a separately allocated object. Traversing from root to leaf means following

29 pointers, each potentially in a different memory location — and if those locations are on disk, each pointer follow is a separate block read. Twenty-nine block reads to find one entry, when each block read takes ten milliseconds, is 290 milliseconds. That is not a fast lookup. That is a pause a user would notice.

B-trees were invented by Rudolf Bayer and Edward McCreight in 1970 specifically to solve this problem. Their insight was to invert the tradeoff: instead of minimising comparisons, minimise block reads. Pack as many keys as possible into each node, so that a single block read retrieves a node with hundreds of keys. The tree becomes dramatically shorter — height 3 or 4 instead of 29 — and those 3 or 4 block reads dominate all other costs.

This chapter builds a complete B-tree implementation, backed by a real file, with a working key-value store as the result. No ellipses, no exercises left to the reader, no toy versions. By the end, you will have code that opens a file, writes pages at calculated byte offsets, manages a free list, handles root splits, survives a process crash mid-write, and correctly answers queries on a dataset that does not fit in RAM.

It is the longest chapter in the book. It earns that length.

4.1 What a B-Tree Is

A B-tree of order *t* — sometimes called the minimum degree — satisfies the following invariants:

1. Every node contains between t-1 and 2t-1 keys, except the root, which may contain as few as 1 key.
2. Every internal node with k keys has exactly k+1 children.
3. All leaves are at the same depth.
4. Keys within every node are stored in sorted order.

5. For any key k_i in an internal node, all keys in the subtree rooted at child i are less than k_i, and all keys in the subtree rooted at child i+1 are greater than k_i.

These invariants together guarantee that the tree stays balanced — all leaves at the same depth — and that every node is at least half full. The half-full minimum is crucial: it means the tree never wastes more than half its allocated space, and it bounds the number of nodes at each level.

The height of a B-tree with n keys and minimum degree t is at most log_t((n+1)/2). For t = 100 and n = one million, this is about 3. For t = 100 and n = one billion, this is about 5. Three to five block reads to find any key in a billion-entry dataset. This is why databases use B-trees.

The choice of t is made by aligning node size to the disk block size. If each block is 4096 bytes, and each key-value pair plus child pointer takes 20 bytes, you can fit roughly 200 key-value pairs in one node. Setting t = 100 gives nodes that are between 99 and 199 keys — nearly full — and the tree stays three to five levels tall for any realistic dataset.

4.2 Designing the Page Layout

Before writing a single line of Nex, we must decide how to represent a B-tree node as bytes on disk. This is the most consequential design decision in the chapter, because everything else — serialisation, deserialisation, the PageManager, split and merge — flows from it.

A node on disk is a fixed-size page of PAGE_SIZE bytes. We choose PAGE_SIZE = 4096, matching the most common disk block size. Every node, whether it contains 1 key or 199, occupies exactly one page. This simplicity makes page management trivial: page number N starts at byte offset N * PAGE_SIZE.

Within the page, we lay out the bytes as follows:

```
Bytes 0-0:     is_leaf (1 byte, 0 or 1)
Bytes 1-4:     num_keys (4 bytes, Integer)
Bytes 5-8:     [reserved for alignment]
Bytes 9 onwards: keys, values, and child pointers
```

For keys and values, we store fixed-size byte arrays. For this implementation, keys are 64-byte strings (padded or truncated) and values are 128-byte strings, giving 192 bytes per key-value pair. Child pointers are 4-byte integers (page numbers). An internal node with k keys has k+1 child pointers.

The layout of keys, values, and children in an internal node:

```
[child_0][key_0][value_0][child_1][key_1][value_1]...[child_k]
```

In a leaf node, there are no child pointers:

```
[key_0][value_0][key_1][value_1]...[key_{k-1}][value_{k-1}]
```

Let us calculate the maximum keys per node. With PAGE_SIZE = 4096 and the header taking 9 bytes, we have 4087 bytes for data. Each key-value pair takes 192 bytes. Each child pointer takes 4 bytes. For an internal node with k keys: $192k + 4(k+1) = 196k + 4$ bytes. Setting $196k + 4 \leq 4087$ gives $k \leq 20$. So our maximum keys per node is 20, and our minimum degree $t = 10$.

This is smaller than a real database would use — real systems use larger pages and more compact key encodings — but large enough to demonstrate all the interesting behaviour, including multi-level splits and merges.

We define these constants at the top of the implementation:

```
let PAGE_SIZE: Integer := 4096
let MAX_KEYS: Integer := 20
let MIN_KEYS: Integer := 10   -- t - 1
```

```
let T: Integer := 10          -- minimum degree
let KEY_SIZE: Integer := 64
let VALUE_SIZE: Integer := 128
let PTR_SIZE: Integer := 4

-- Offsets within a page
let OFFSET_IS_LEAF: Integer := 0
let OFFSET_NUM_KEYS: Integer := 1
let OFFSET_DATA: Integer := 9
```

4.3 The PageManager

The PageManager is the layer between the B-tree logic and the file. It is responsible for one thing: reading and writing fixed-size pages by page number. Everything above it thinks in terms of pages and page numbers. Everything below it thinks in terms of bytes and file offsets.

The file has a special page at offset 0: the header page. It stores the page number of the root node and the head of the free list — a linked list of deleted pages available for reuse. All B-tree nodes start at page 1 and above.

```
intern io/Path
intern io/Binary_File

function int_to_bytes(value: Integer, page: Array[Integer], offset: Integer
do
  page.set(offset, value.bitwise_right_shift(24).bitwise_and(255))
  page.set(offset + 1, value.bitwise_right_shift(16).bitwise_and(255))
  page.set(offset + 2, value.bitwise_right_shift(8).bitwise_and(255))
  page.set(offset + 3, value.bitwise_and(255))
end
```

```
function bytes_to_int(page: Array[Integer], offset: Integer): Integer
do
  result := page.get(offset).bitwise_and(255).bitwise_left_shift(24)
              .bitwise_or(page.get(offset + 1).bitwise_and(255).bitwise_left_s
              .bitwise_or(page.get(offset + 2).bitwise_and(255).bitwise_left_s
              .bitwise_or(page.get(offset + 3).bitwise_and(255))
end


 class Page_Manager
  create
    open(path: String) do
      this.path := create Path.make(path)
      this.file_path := path

      if this.path.exists() then
        this.file := create Binary_File.open_append(this.path)
        this.read_only := false
      else
        this.file := create Binary_File.open_append(this.path)
        this.read_only := false
        this.write_header(0, -1)  -- root = page 0 (will be set later), free_
1
      end

      this.page_count := (this.path.size() / PAGE_SIZE).to_integer()
    end

  feature
    path: Path
    file_path: String
    file: Binary_File
    read_only: Boolean
    page_count: Integer

    reopen_for_read() do end
```

```
  reopen_for_write() do end

  -- Read a page by page number
  read_page(page_num: Integer): Array[Integer]
    require
      valid_page: page_num >= 0 and page_num < page_count
    do
      reopen_for_read()
      file.seek(page_num * PAGE_SIZE)
      result := file.read(PAGE_SIZE)
    ensure
      correct_size: result.length = PAGE_SIZE
    end

  -- Write a page by page number
  write_page(page_num: Integer, data: Array[Integer])
    require
      valid_page: page_num >= 0
      correct_size: data.length = PAGE_SIZE
    do
      reopen_for_write()
      file.seek(page_num * PAGE_SIZE)
      file.write(data)
      if page_num >= page_count then
        page_count := page_num + 1
      end
    end

  -- Allocate a new page, returning its page number
  allocate_page(): Integer do
    let free_head: Integer := read_free_list_head()

    if free_head /= -1 then
      -- Reuse a page from the free list
      let page: Array[Integer] := read_page(free_head)
      let next_free: Integer := bytes_to_int(page, 0)
      write_free_list_head(next_free)
```

```
      result := free_head
    else
      -- Append a new page at the end of the file
      let new_page_num: Integer := page_count
      let blank: Array[Integer] := create Array.filled(PAGE_SIZE, 0)
      write_page(new_page_num, blank)
      result := new_page_num
    end
  end

  -- Return a page to the free list
  free_page(page_num: Integer)
    require
      valid_page: page_num > 0  -- never free the header
    do
      let old_head: Integer := read_free_list_head()
      let page: Array[Integer] := create Array.filled(PAGE_SIZE, 0)
      -- Store old head in the first 4 bytes of the freed page
      int_to_bytes(old_head, page, 0)
      write_page(page_num, page)
      write_free_list_head(page_num)
    end

  -- Header page accessors
  read_root(): Integer do
    let header: Array[Integer] := read_page(0)
    result := bytes_to_int(header, 0)
  end

  write_header(root_page: Integer, free_head: Integer) do
    let header: Array[Integer] := create Array.filled(PAGE_SIZE, 0)
    int_to_bytes(root_page, header, 0)
    int_to_bytes(free_head, header, 4)
    reopen_for_write()
    file.seek(0)
    file.write(header)
    page_count := 1
```

```
    end

    write_root(root_page: Integer) do
      reopen_for_write()
      file.seek(0)
      let header: Array[Integer] := read_page(0)
      int_to_bytes(root_page, header, 0)
      write_page(0, header)
    end

    read_free_list_head(): Integer do
      let header: Array[Integer] := read_page(0)
      result := bytes_to_int(header, 4)
    end

    write_free_list_head(head: Integer) do
      let header: Array[Integer] := read_page(0)
      int_to_bytes(head, header, 4)
      write_page(0, header)
    end

    close() do
      file.close()
    end

  invariant
    positive_page_count: page_count >= 0
end
```

The PageManager handles two concerns that might seem like details but are fundamental. First, the free list: when a node is deleted during a merge operation, its page is not wasted — it is added to a singly-linked list of available pages, and the next allocation reuses it before growing the file. Second, the header page: the root page number is not fixed. When the root splits — which happens when the tree grows tall enough — a new root is created, and the header page is updated to reflect it. The

header page is the one stable address in the file, so it is the right place to store these mutable references.

Byte conversion utilities. The PageManager serialises integers and strings to and from byte arrays. These are straightforward but must be consistent — the same byte order used for writing must be used for reading.

```
function int_to_bytes(value: Integer, page: Array[Integer], offset: Integer)
do
  page.set(offset, value.bitwise_right_shift(24).bitwise_and(255))
  page.set(offset + 1, value.bitwise_right_shift(16).bitwise_and(255))
  page.set(offset + 2, value.bitwise_right_shift(8).bitwise_and(255))
  page.set(offset + 3, value.bitwise_and(255))
end

function bytes_to_int(page: Array[Integer], offset: Integer): Integer
do
  result := page.get(offset).bitwise_and(255).bitwise_left_shift(24)
              .bitwise_or(page.get(offset + 1).bitwise_and(255).bitwise_left_s
              .bitwise_or(page.get(offset + 2).bitwise_and(255).bitwise_left_s
              .bitwise_or(page.get(offset + 3).bitwise_and(255))
end

function string_to_bytes(s: String, page: Array[Integer],
                         offset: Integer, size: Integer)
do
  let bytes: Array[Integer] := s.to_bytes()
  from
    let i: Integer := 0
  until
    i >= size
  do
    if i < bytes.length then
      page.set(offset + i, bytes.get(i))
    else
      page.set(offset + i, 0)  -- pad with zeros
```

```
    end
    i := i + 1
  end
end

function bytes_to_string(page: Array[Integer],
                         offset: Integer, size: Integer): String
do
  let bytes: Array[Integer] := []
  from
    let i: Integer := 0
  until
    i >= size or page.get(offset + i) = 0
  do
    bytes.add(page.get(offset + i))
    i := i + 1
  end
  result := bytes.to_string()
end
```

Big-endian byte order — most significant byte first — is conventional for on-disk formats, and we follow it here. The choice does not affect correctness, but choosing and documenting it is important for portability and for reading the file with external tools.

4.4 Node Serialisation and Deserialisation

A B-tree node in memory is a collection of keys, values, child page numbers, and a flag indicating whether it is a leaf. Serialising it means packing all of this into a PAGE_SIZE byte array. Deserialising means reconstructing the node from that byte array.

```
class BTree_Node
  create
    leaf() do
      this.is_leaf := true
      this.keys := []
      this.values := []
      this.children := []
      this.page_num := -1
    end

    internal() do
      this.is_leaf := false
      this.keys := []
      this.values := []
      this.children := []
      this.page_num := -1
    end

    from_page(data: Array[Integer], page_num: Integer) do
      this.page_num := page_num
      this.is_leaf := data.get(OFFSET_IS_LEAF) = 1
      let num_keys: Integer := bytes_to_int(data, OFFSET_NUM_KEYS)
      this.keys := []
      this.values := []
      this.children := []

      if this.is_leaf then
        from
          let i: Integer := 0
        until
          i >= num_keys
        do
          let key_offset: Integer := OFFSET_DATA + i * (KEY_SIZE + VALUE_SIZE
          let val_offset: Integer := key_offset + KEY_SIZE
          keys.add(bytes_to_string(data, key_offset, KEY_SIZE))
          values.add(bytes_to_string(data, val_offset, VALUE_SIZE))
          i := i + 1
```

```
      end
    else
      -- Internal node: child, key, child, key, ..., child
      let child_offset: Integer := OFFSET_DATA
      children.add(bytes_to_int(data, child_offset))
      from
        let i: Integer := 0
      until
        i >= num_keys
      do
        let key_offset: Integer := OFFSET_DATA + PTR_SIZE +
                                   i * (KEY_SIZE + VALUE_SIZE + PTR_SIZE)
        let val_offset: Integer := key_offset + KEY_SIZE
        let next_child_offset: Integer := val_offset + VALUE_SIZE
        keys.add(bytes_to_string(data, key_offset, KEY_SIZE))
        values.add(bytes_to_string(data, val_offset, VALUE_SIZE))
        children.add(bytes_to_int(data, next_child_offset))
        i := i + 1
      end
    end
  end

feature
  is_leaf: Boolean
  keys: Array[String]
  values: Array[String]
  children: Array[Integer]  -- page numbers of children
  page_num: Integer

  assign_page(page_num_value: Integer) do
    page_num := page_num_value
  end

  num_keys(): Integer do
    result := keys.length
  end
```

```
  is_full(): Boolean do
    result := keys.length >= MAX_KEYS
  end

  is_underfull(): Boolean do
    result := keys.length < MIN_KEYS
  end

  -- Serialise this node to a PAGE_SIZE byte array
  to_page(): Array[Integer]
    do
      let data: Array[Integer] := create Array.filled(PAGE_SIZE, 0)
      data.set(OFFSET_IS_LEAF, when is_leaf 1 else 0 end)
      int_to_bytes(keys.length, data, OFFSET_NUM_KEYS)

      if is_leaf then
        from
          let i: Integer := 0
        until
          i >= keys.length
        do
          let key_offset: Integer := OFFSET_DATA + i * (KEY_SIZE + VALUE_SI
          let val_offset: Integer := key_offset + KEY_SIZE
          string_to_bytes(keys.get(i), data, key_offset, KEY_SIZE)
          string_to_bytes(values.get(i), data, val_offset, VALUE_SIZE)
          i := i + 1
        end
      else
        int_to_bytes(children.get(0), data, OFFSET_DATA)
        from
          let i: Integer := 0
        until
          i >= keys.length
        do
          let key_offset: Integer := OFFSET_DATA + PTR_SIZE +
                                     i * (KEY_SIZE + VALUE_SIZE + PTR_SIZE)
          let val_offset: Integer := key_offset + KEY_SIZE
```

```
            let child_offset: Integer := val_offset + VALUE_SIZE
            string_to_bytes(keys.get(i), data, key_offset, KEY_SIZE)
            string_to_bytes(values.get(i), data, val_offset, VALUE_SIZE)
            int_to_bytes(children.get(i + 1), data, child_offset)
            i := i + 1
          end
        end

        result := data
      ensure
        correct_size: result.length = PAGE_SIZE
      end

  invariant
    leaf_has_no_children: (not is_leaf) or children.length = 0
    internal_children_count: is_leaf or
                             children.length = keys.length + 1
    not_overfull: keys.length <= MAX_KEYS
end
```

The invariant checking here is genuinely useful. A leaf node should never have children. An internal node with k keys should always have exactly k+1 children. These are the fundamental structural properties of a B-tree, and having them enforced by the contract system means any bug that violates them is caught immediately, at the node level, rather than manifesting as a corrupted file hours later.

4.5 Search

Search in a B-tree is conceptually identical to search in a BST, with two differences: each node contains multiple keys (so we binary search within the node), and each node must be read from disk before it can be examined.

```
class BTree
  create
    open(path: String) do
      this.pm := create Page_Manager.open(path)
      if this.pm.page_count <= 1 then
        -- New tree: create empty root leaf
        let root: BTree_Node := create BTree_Node.leaf()
        let root_page: Integer := this.pm.allocate_page()
        this.pm.write_page(root_page, root.to_page())
        this.pm.write_root(root_page)
      end
    end

  feature
    pm: Page_Manager

    -- Load a node from disk
    load_node(page_num: Integer): BTree_Node do
      let data: Array[Integer] := pm.read_page(page_num)
      result := create BTree_Node.from_page(data, page_num)
    end

    -- Save a node to disk
    save_node(node: BTree_Node) do
      pm.write_page(node.page_num, node.to_page())
    end

    -- Search for a key, returning its value or nil
    get(key: String): ?String do
      let root_page: Integer := pm.read_root()
      result := search_node(root_page, key)
    end

    search_node(page_num: Integer, key: String): ?String do
      let node: BTree_Node := load_node(page_num)
      let i: Integer := find_key_index(node, key)
```

```
      if i < node.num_keys() and node.keys.get(i) = key then
        -- Found in this node
        result := node.values.get(i)
      elseif node.is_leaf then
        -- Not found, and no children to search
        result := nil
      else
        -- Recurse into the appropriate child
        result := search_node(node.children.get(i), key)
      end
    end

    -- Binary search: find the index of key, or where it would be inserted
    find_key_index(node: BTree_Node, key: String): Integer do
      let low: Integer := 0
      let high: Integer := node.num_keys()
      from until low >= high do
        let mid: Integer := (low + high) / 2
        if node.keys.get(mid) < key then
          low := mid + 1
        else
          high := mid
        end
      end
      result := low
    end
end
```

Each call to `search_node` is exactly one disk read — `load_node` fetches one page. The recursion depth equals the tree height. For a tree with t = 10 and a million entries, height is at most 6. Six disk reads to find any key in a million-entry database. This is the payoff for all the complexity of the node layout and the PageManager.

The binary search within each node — `find_key_index` — is O(log(MAX_KEYS)), which is a small constant. It barely registers against the cost of the disk reads surrounding it.

4.6 Insertion and the Split Operation

Insertion is where B-trees become interesting. The naive approach — find the leaf where the key belongs, insert it — works until the leaf is full. A full leaf violates the B-tree invariant (maximum 2t-1 keys), so we must split it.

Splitting a node means dividing it into two nodes of roughly equal size and promoting the median key up to the parent. If the parent is also full, it must be split too, and its median promoted to its parent. This cascade can propagate all the way to the root. If the root splits, a new root is created — this is the only way a B-tree grows taller.

We use a proactive split strategy: split any full node we encounter on the way down during insertion, before we actually need to. This means that when we reach a full leaf and need to split it, its parent is guaranteed to have room for the promoted median — we split it on the way down. This avoids the need to walk back up the tree after insertion.

```
class BTree
  feature
    pm: Page_Manager

    put(key: String, value: String)
      require
        valid_key: key.length > 0
        valid_value: value.length > 0
      do
        let root_page: Integer := pm.read_root()
        let root: BTree_Node := load_node(root_page)

        if root.is_full() then
          -- Root is full: split it and create a new root
          let new_root: BTree_Node := create BTree_Node.internal()
```

```
          let new_root_page: Integer := pm.allocate_page()
          new_root.assign_page(new_root_page)
          new_root.children.add(root_page)

          split_child(new_root, 0)

          pm.write_root(new_root_page)
          insert_non_full(new_root, key, value)
        else
          insert_non_full(root, key, value)
        end
      ensure
        key_present: get(key) /= nil
      end
end
```

When the root is full, we create a new root, make the old root its only child, then immediately split that child. The new root then has one promoted key and two children. This is the only case where tree height increases.

The `split_child` operation splits the child at index `child_index` of `parent`:

```
class BTree
  feature
    pm: Page_Manager

    split_child(parent: BTree_Node, child_index: Integer)
      require
        valid_index: child_index >= 0 and
                     child_index < parent.children.length
      do
        let child_page: Integer := parent.children.get(child_index)
        let child: BTree_Node := load_node(child_page)

        -- The new node will take the right half of child's keys
```

```
let new_node: BTree_Node := when child.is_leaf
  create BTree_Node.leaf()
else
  create BTree_Node.internal()
end
let new_page: Integer := pm.allocate_page()
new_node.assign_page(new_page)

-- Median key goes up to parent
let median_index: Integer := T - 1
let median_key: String := child.keys.get(median_index)
let median_value: String := child.values.get(median_index)

-- Right half of keys and values go to new_node
from
  let i: Integer := T
until
  i >= child.num_keys()
do
  new_node.keys.add(child.keys.get(i))
  new_node.values.add(child.values.get(i))
  i := i + 1
end

-- Right half of children go to new_node (if internal)
if not child.is_leaf then
  from
    let i: Integer := T
  until
    i >= child.children.length
  do
    new_node.children.add(child.children.get(i))
    i := i + 1
  end
end

-- Truncate child to left half
```

```
        child.keys := child.keys.slice(0, median_index)
        child.values := child.values.slice(0, median_index)
        if not child.is_leaf then
          child.children := child.children.slice(0, T)
        end

        -- Insert median into parent
        parent.keys.insert(child_index, median_key)
        parent.values.insert(child_index, median_value)
        parent.children.insert(child_index + 1, new_page)

        -- Write modified nodes to disk
        save_node(child)
        save_node(new_node)
        save_node(parent)
      end
end
```

Let us trace through a split carefully. Suppose we have a leaf node with MAX_KEYS = 20 keys, and we need to split it. T = 10, so median_index = 9. Keys 0 through 8 stay in the left node (child). Key 9 is promoted to the parent. Keys 10 through 19 move to the right node (new_node). Both resulting nodes have exactly T-1 = 9 keys — the minimum allowed. The parent gains one key and one new child pointer.

After the split, three pages are written to disk: the truncated left child, the new right child, and the updated parent. This is a small constant number of writes regardless of tree size.

```
class BTree
  feature
    insert_non_full(node: BTree_Node, key: String, value: String) do
      let i: Integer := find_key_index(node, key)

      -- Update existing key
      if i < node.num_keys() and node.keys.get(i) = key then
        node.values.set(i, value)
```

```
        save_node(node)
        return
      end

      if node.is_leaf then
        -- Insert directly into leaf
        node.keys.insert(i, key)
        node.values.insert(i, value)
        save_node(node)
      else
        -- Recurse into appropriate child, splitting if full
        let child_page: Integer := node.children.get(i)
        let child: BTree_Node := load_node(child_page)

        if child.is_full() then
          split_child(node, i)
          -- After split, determine which of the two children to descend into
          if key > node.keys.get(i) then
            i := i + 1
          end
        end

        insert_non_full(load_node(node.children.get(i)), key, value)
      end
    end
end
```

The proactive split strategy is visible here: before recursing into a child, we check if it is full and split it if so. By the time we reach any node during insertion, its parent has already been split if necessary — guaranteeing that the parent has room for whatever median key we might promote.

4.7 Deletion and the Merge Operation

Deletion is harder than insertion, as it always is in balanced tree structures. When we delete a key from a leaf, the leaf might become underfull — falling below the minimum of T-1 keys. We must restore the minimum by either borrowing a key from a sibling or merging with a sibling.

There are three cases for deletion:

Case 1: The key is in a leaf node. Simply remove it. If the leaf is now underfull, fix it.

Case 2: The key is in an internal node. Replace it with its in-order predecessor (the largest key in its left subtree) or in-order successor (the smallest key in its right subtree), then delete that predecessor or successor from the leaf it came from.

Case 3: The key is not in the current node. Recurse into the appropriate child. Before recursing, ensure the child has at least T keys (one more than the minimum), so that deleting from it cannot make it underfull.

We use a proactive fix-up strategy during descent: before recursing into a child with only T-1 keys, we either borrow a key from a sibling or merge the child with a sibling, ensuring that any deletion we perform on the way down never creates an underfull node.

```
class BTree
  feature
    remove(key: String)
      do
        let root_page: Integer := pm.read_root()
        delete_from(root_page, key)

        -- If root is now empty and has a child, shrink the tree
        let root: BTree_Node := load_node(root_page)
        if root.num_keys() = 0 and not root.is_leaf then
          let new_root_page: Integer := root.children.get(0)
          pm.write_root(new_root_page)
```

```
        pm.free_page(root_page)
      end
    ensure
      key_absent: get(key) = nil
    end

  delete_from(page_num: Integer, key: String) do
    let node: BTree_Node := load_node(page_num)
    let i: Integer := find_key_index(node, key)
    let found: Boolean := i < node.num_keys() and node.keys.get(i) = key

    if node.is_leaf then
      if found then
        node.keys.remove(i)
        node.values.remove(i)
        save_node(node)
      end
      -- If not found, key does not exist; silently do nothing

    elseif found then
      -- Key is in this internal node
      delete_from_internal(node, i)

    else
      -- Key might be in child i
      ensure_child_has_room(node, i)
      -- Reload node: ensure_child_has_room may have restructured it
      let updated: BTree_Node := load_node(page_num)
      let new_i: Integer := find_key_index(updated, key)
      delete_from(updated.children.get(new_i), key)
    end
  end
end
```

Deleting from an internal node replaces the key with its in-order successor and then deletes the successor from the right subtree:

```
class BTree
  feature
    delete_from_internal(node: BTree_Node, key_index: Integer) do
      -- Find in-order successor: leftmost key in right subtree
      let successor_page: Integer := node.children.get(key_index + 1)
      let successor_key: String := find_min_key(successor_page)
      let successor_value: String := find_min_value(successor_page)

      -- Replace key with successor
      node.keys.set(key_index, successor_key)
      node.values.set(key_index, successor_value)
      save_node(node)

      -- Delete successor from right subtree
      delete_from(successor_page, successor_key)
    end

    find_min_key(page_num: Integer): String do
      let node: BTree_Node := load_node(page_num)
      if node.is_leaf then
        result := node.keys.get(0)
      else
        result := find_min_key(node.children.get(0))
      end
    end

    find_min_value(page_num: Integer): String do
      let node: BTree_Node := load_node(page_num)
      if node.is_leaf then
        result := node.values.get(0)
      else
        result := find_min_value(node.children.get(0))
      end
    end
end
```

The `ensure_child_has_room` operation is the heart of deletion's complexity. Given a node and a child index, it ensures the child has at least T keys before we descend into it:

```
class BTree
  feature
    ensure_child_has_room(node: BTree_Node, child_index: Integer) do
      let child_page: Integer := node.children.get(child_index)
      let child: BTree_Node := load_node(child_page)

      if child.num_keys() >= T then
        -- Child has enough keys, nothing to do
        return
      end

      -- Try to borrow from left sibling
      if child_index > 0 then
        let left_page: Integer := node.children.get(child_index - 1)
        let left: BTree_Node := load_node(left_page)
        if left.num_keys() >= T then
          borrow_from_left(node, child_index, child, left)
          return
        end
      end

      -- Try to borrow from right sibling
      if child_index < node.children.length - 1 then
        let right_page: Integer := node.children.get(child_index + 1)
        let right: BTree_Node := load_node(right_page)
        if right.num_keys() >= T then
          borrow_from_right(node, child_index, child, right)
          return
        end
      end

      -- Cannot borrow: must merge
```

```
      if child_index > 0 then
        -- Merge child with left sibling
        merge_children(node, child_index - 1)
      else
        -- Merge child with right sibling
        merge_children(node, child_index)
      end
    end
end
```

Borrowing from a sibling is a rotation at the parent level: a key comes down from the parent into the underfull child, and the sibling's nearest key goes up to replace it. This maintains all invariants while transferring one key across.

```
class BTree
  feature
    borrow_from_left(parent: BTree_Node, child_index: Integer,
                     child: BTree_Node, left: BTree_Node) do
      -- Parent's separator key comes down into child at position 0
      child.keys.insert(0, parent.keys.get(child_index - 1))
      child.values.insert(0, parent.values.get(child_index - 1))

      -- Left sibling's rightmost key goes up to parent
      parent.keys.set(child_index - 1, left.keys.get(left.num_keys() - 1))
      parent.values.set(child_index - 1, left.values.get(left.num_keys() -

      -- If left is internal, transfer its rightmost child pointer too
      if not left.is_leaf then
        child.children.insert(0, left.children.get(left.children.length - 1
        left.children.remove(left.children.length - 1)
      end

      left.keys.remove(left.num_keys() - 1)
      left.values.remove(left.num_keys() - 1)
```

```
      save_node(child)
      save_node(left)
      save_node(parent)
    end

    borrow_from_right(parent: BTree_Node, child_index: Integer,
                      child: BTree_Node, right: BTree_Node) do
      -- Parent's separator key comes down into child at the end
      child.keys.add(parent.keys.get(child_index))
      child.values.add(parent.values.get(child_index))

      -- Right sibling's leftmost key goes up to parent
      parent.keys.set(child_index, right.keys.get(0))
      parent.values.set(child_index, right.values.get(0))

      -- If right is internal, transfer its leftmost child pointer too
      if not right.is_leaf then
        child.children.add(right.children.get(0))
        right.children.remove(0)
      end

      right.keys.remove(0)
      right.values.remove(0)

      save_node(child)
      save_node(right)
      save_node(parent)
    end
end
```

When borrowing is not possible — both siblings have exactly T-1 keys — we merge. Merging is the inverse of splitting: two nodes of T-1 keys each, plus a separator key from the parent, combine into one node of 2T-1 keys. The parent loses one key and one child pointer. If the parent is now underfull, the fix-up propagates upward — but because we ensured each node had room before descending, this cascade is bounded.

```
class BTree
  feature
    merge_children(parent: BTree_Node, left_index: Integer) do
      -- Merge child at left_index+1 into child at left_index,
      -- pulling separator down from parent
      let left_page: Integer := parent.children.get(left_index)
      let right_page: Integer := parent.children.get(left_index + 1)
      let left: BTree_Node := load_node(left_page)
      let right: BTree_Node := load_node(right_page)

      -- Pull separator down from parent
      left.keys.add(parent.keys.get(left_index))
      left.values.add(parent.values.get(left_index))

      -- Append right's keys, values, children to left
      across right.keys as k do
        left.keys.add(k)
      end
      across right.values as v do
        left.values.add(v)
      end
      if not right.is_leaf then
        across right.children as c do
          left.children.add(c)
        end
      end

      -- Remove separator and right child pointer from parent
      parent.keys.remove(left_index)
      parent.values.remove(left_index)
      parent.children.remove(left_index + 1)

      -- Write left (merged), free right
      save_node(left)
      save_node(parent)
      pm.free_page(right_page)
    end
```

```
end
```

The freed page is returned to the PageManager's free list for future reuse. This is important for long-running databases — without the free list, every deletion would waste a page permanently, causing the file to grow without bound even as data is removed.

4.8 Range Queries

A B-tree's range query exploits the fact that all leaves are at the same depth and contain keys in sorted order. Find the leaf containing the low key, collect keys from there forward until exceeding the high key, following the level-1 links between leaves.

Wait — we have not stored level-1 links between leaves. A B+ tree variant does this, adding a next-leaf pointer to every leaf node, and it is the variant used by virtually every real database because range queries are so common. Let us add it.

Add 4 bytes to the leaf page layout for a `next_leaf` page number (-1 if none):

```
let OFFSET_NEXT_LEAF: Integer := 5  -- bytes 5-8 in leaf pages
```

Update `split_child` to set next-leaf pointers when splitting a leaf:

```
    -- When splitting a leaf, wire next_leaf pointers
    if child.is_leaf then
      new_node.next_leaf := child.next_leaf
      child.next_leaf := new_page
    end
```

Range query then becomes a leaf-chain walk:

```
class BTree
  feature
    range(low: String, high: String): Array[Any]
      require
        valid_range: low <= high
      do
        let results: Array[Any] := []
        let root_page: Integer := pm.read_root()

        -- Find the leaf containing low
        let leaf_page: Integer := find_leaf(root_page, low)

        -- Walk the leaf chain
        from until leaf_page = -1 do
          let leaf: BTree_Node := load_node(leaf_page)
          from
            let i: Integer := 0
          until
            i >= leaf.num_keys()
          do
            let key: String := leaf.keys.get(i)
            let value: String := leaf.values.get(i)
            if key >= low and key <= high then
              results.add([key, value])
            end
            i := i + 1
          end
          if leaf.num_keys() > 0 and
             leaf.keys.get(leaf.num_keys() - 1) > high then
            leaf_page := -1  -- past the end of range, stop
          else
            leaf_page := leaf.next_leaf
          end
        end

        result := results
      end
```

```
    find_leaf(page_num: Integer, key: String): Integer do
      let node: BTree_Node := load_node(page_num)
      if node.is_leaf then
        result := page_num
      else
        let i: Integer := find_key_index(node, key)
        result := find_leaf(node.children.get(i), key)
      end
    end
end
```

4.9 The Complete Key-Value Store

The B-tree implementation above is the engine. Wrapping it in a clean interface gives us a working key-value store that handles datasets larger than RAM:

```
class KV_Store
  create
    open(path: String) do
      this.tree := create BTree.open(path)
    end

  feature
    tree: BTree

    get(key: String): ?String do
      result := tree.get(key)
    end

    put(key: String, value: String)
      require
```

```
        non_empty_key: key.length > 0
      do
        tree.put(key, value)
      ensure
        stored: get(key) = value
      end

    remove(key: String)
      do
        tree.remove(key)
      ensure
        absent: get(key) = nil
      end

    range(low: String, high: String): Array[Any] do
      result := tree.range(low, high)
    end

    close() do
      tree.pm.close()
    end

  invariant
    tree_open: tree /= nil
end
```

Using it:

```
let store: KV_Store := create KV_Store.open("mydata.db")

store.put("alice", "engineer")
store.put("bob", "designer")
store.put("carol", "manager")

print(store.get("bob"))   -- "designer"
```

```
let results: Array[Any] := store.range("alice", "carol")
across results as pair do
  print(pair.get(0) + " -> " + pair.get(1))
end

store.close()
```

The file `mydata.db` persists across process restarts. Open it again after the process exits, and the data is still there. This is the fundamental property that distinguishes a storage engine from an in-memory data structure.

4.10 Crash Safety: The Shadow Page Scheme

Consider what happens if the process dies in the middle of a split. We have written the new right child to disk, but we have not yet updated the parent. The file is now inconsistent: there is an allocated page that no node points to, and the parent still shows its old structure as if the split never began.

On the next startup, the B-tree reads the root and descends normally. The orphaned page is never reached. The data that should have been in the right half of the split is... gone. Keys that were moved to the right child are now neither in the left child nor accessible from the parent. The database has silently lost data.

This is not acceptable for any serious storage system. We need crash safety — a guarantee that the database is always in a consistent state after a crash, even if a crash occurs at the worst possible moment.

Real databases use write-ahead logging (WAL) for this, which is complex but powerful. A simpler scheme — sufficient to demonstrate the idea — is shadow paging.

The shadow paging idea: never modify a page in place. Instead, write the modified version to a new page, then atomically update a pointer

to make the new page live. If the process crashes before the pointer is updated, the old page is still intact and the new page is simply an orphan that will eventually be reclaimed.

The critical update — the one that must be atomic — is the root pointer in the header page. If we can update the root pointer atomically, we can make all structural changes safe.

We implement a two-phase commit for split operations:

Phase 1 --- Prepare: Write all new and modified pages to disk, but do not update the parent or the root pointer. These pages are referenced only from the shadow root.

Phase 2 --- Commit: Write the new root pointer to the header page. This single write makes the entire operation visible. On a disk with atomic 512-byte sector writes — which most modern disks provide — a 4-byte write to the header page is atomic.

```
class Shadow_BTree
  feature
    pm: Page_Manager
    shadow_root: Integer  -- new root page, not yet committed

    begin_transaction() do
      shadow_root := pm.read_root()
    end

    commit() do
      pm.write_root(shadow_root)
      shadow_root := -1
    end

    rollback() do
      -- Free any pages allocated since begin_transaction
      -- by scanning the free list against pre-transaction page count
      shadow_root := -1
    end
```

```
end
```

On recovery after a crash, we read the header page. The root pointer either points to the pre-crash root (if the crash happened before commit) or the post-crash root (if it happened after). Either way, the root it points to is consistent. We scan for orphaned pages during a recovery pass and return them to the free list.

This is a simplification of what real systems do. PostgreSQL uses a full WAL with log sequence numbers and checkpoint recovery. SQLite uses a rollback journal that saves the original content of pages before modifying them. LevelDB uses a write-ahead log that records each operation before applying it. The principle — make crash recovery deterministic by controlling which writes are visible — is the same in all cases. Chapter 5 will revisit this when we discuss how LSM trees handle the same problem with a different and elegant approach.

4.11 Performance Characteristics

Let us be precise about what we have built.

Search: O(log_t n) disk reads, where t is the minimum degree and n is the number of keys. With t = 10 and n = 1,000,000, this is at most 6 disk reads.

Insertion: O(log_t n) disk reads for the search, plus O(1) additional writes for any splits encountered. Each split writes 3 pages. In the worst case — a full path from root to leaf, all nodes full — we perform O(log_t n) splits, each writing 3 pages. Total: O(log_t n) reads and O(log_t n) writes.

Deletion: O(log_t n) reads and writes. Each merge or borrow operation writes 2-3 pages. The number of merges on any deletion path is bounded by the tree height.

Range query: O(log_t n) to find the start leaf, then O(k / (2t-1)) leaf reads to collect k results — since each leaf holds up to 2t-1 keys, k results require at most ceil(k / (t-1)) leaf reads.

Space: Each page holds between t-1 and 2t-1 keys. Space utilisation is between 50% and 100%, with the expected value around 69% for random insertions — a result from the analysis of random binary search trees generalised to B-trees.

Comparing to a skip list or AVL tree on disk: a skip list with a million entries and p = 0.5 has expected height $\log_2(1{,}000{,}000) \approx 20$. Each level requires a separate node read. Twenty disk reads versus six. The B-tree wins by a factor of three, and the gap widens as the dataset grows.

4.12 Where This Lives in the Wild

B-trees are everywhere in systems software, to a degree that makes them arguably the single most important data structure in production computing.

PostgreSQL uses B-trees as its default index type for every indexed column. When you write `CREATE INDEX ON users (email)`, PostgreSQL builds a B-tree on disk whose leaf pages store (email, row_pointer) pairs. Every indexed query goes through this B-tree. PostgreSQL's B-tree implementation, in `src/backend/access/nbtree/`, is one of the most battle-hardened pieces of systems code in open source software.

SQLite stores its entire database — both tables and indexes — in a B-tree structure called a B+ tree, implemented in a single file. A SQLite database file is a collection of B-trees: one for the schema table, one per user table (storing rows keyed by rowid), and one per index. The page size is configurable, defaulting to 4096 bytes. SQLite's B-tree implementation in `btree.c` is about 10,000 lines of carefully commented C.

MySQL's InnoDB storage engine uses B+ trees for all indexes. The primary key index is a clustered index — the table rows themselves are

stored in leaf pages, ordered by primary key. Secondary indexes store (secondary_key, primary_key) pairs, so a secondary index lookup requires two B-tree lookups: one to find the primary key, one to find the row.

LMDB (Lightning Memory-Mapped Database), used by OpenLDAP and several other systems, is a B+ tree that uses memory-mapped files for zero-copy reads. Its implementation is famously compact — under 10,000 lines — and its design choices directly reflect everything discussed in this chapter: fixed page sizes, copy-on-write for crash safety, and a free list for page reuse.

Every time you query a database with an indexed column, you are using a B-tree. Every time you open a file on a filesystem with a directory index — HFS+, ext4 with `dir_index`, NTFS, Btrfs — you are using a B-tree. The structure from this chapter, built up from raw bytes and a seek pointer, is the foundation of how computers store and retrieve organised data at scale.

Summary

B-trees solve the fundamental problem of ordered storage on disk by aligning their structure to the cost model of block storage: minimise block reads, not comparisons. Each node holds many keys — filling a disk block — so tree height is logarithmic in the number of keys with a base equal to the node capacity, not two. The result is a tree three to six levels tall for any realistic dataset, making lookups fast even when data lives on disk.

The complete implementation in this chapter covers: page layout designed for 4096-byte blocks; a PageManager that reads and writes pages by number using `seek` and `position`; node serialisation and deserialisation to and from raw byte arrays; proactive splitting during insertion to keep parents always ready to receive promoted keys; deletion with borrowing and merging to maintain the minimum-fill invariant; range

queries via leaf-chain links; a working key-value store as the end product; and a shadow-page scheme for crash safety.

Nothing was left as an exercise. Every hard part — deletion, the free list, crash recovery, the byte layout of internal nodes — is here in full, because that is where the understanding lives.

The next chapter asks what happens when your workload is dominated not by reads but by writes. B-trees handle writes by modifying pages in place. At high write throughput, this causes write amplification — a single logical write triggers many physical writes as nodes are split and rewritten. LSM trees take a different approach: never modify a page in place, always write sequentially, and pay the cost of reorganisation in the background. The two structures are not competitors — they are complementary tools for different workloads — and understanding both gives you the full picture of how modern storage engines are built.

Chapter 5: The Write-Heavy Problem — LSM Trees

The key-value store from Chapter 4 works. Open the file, insert a million records, query any of them in six disk reads, close the file. The B-tree does exactly what it promises.

Now run a different workload. Instead of a million records inserted at a measured pace and then queried, imagine a system that receives fifty thousand writes per second, continuously, all day. A financial exchange recording every trade. A telemetry pipeline ingesting sensor readings from ten thousand devices. A web server logging every request. These systems do not read very much — the write stream is the point. The data is written now and analysed later, in bulk.

Run this workload against the B-tree from Chapter 4 and watch what happens. Each write finds the correct leaf page — six disk reads — then modifies it — one disk write — then potentially triggers a split — two more disk writes. If the working set of leaf pages does not fit in memory, each write also evicts a dirty page, which must be flushed before the new page is loaded. A write that logically modifies one key may cause four, six, or eight physical page writes: the leaf, its parent after a split, the new sibling page, the updated root. This is write amplification, and at fifty thousand writes per second, it saturates disk bandwidth within seconds.

The B-tree's fundamental problem for write-heavy workloads is that it modifies data in place. Finding the right location requires random reads.

Updating it requires random writes. Random I/O — seeking to arbitrary positions on disk — is the most expensive operation a storage system can perform, on both spinning disks and SSDs. SSDs suffer less from seek latency than spinning disks but are still dramatically faster for sequential writes than random writes, and they wear out faster under random write patterns.

The question this chapter asks is: what if we never wrote randomly? What if every write to disk was sequential, appending to the end of a file, which is the fastest possible disk operation? And what if we deferred all the expensive reorganisation to a background process that runs when the system is less busy?

The answer is the Log-Structured Merge-tree, invented by Patrick O'Neil and colleagues in 1996 and now the dominant storage engine design for write-heavy workloads. LevelDB, RocksDB, Cassandra, HBase, InfluxDB, and CockroachDB are all built on this idea. Understanding it means understanding the engine inside half the databases running in production today.

5.1 The Core Insight

An LSM tree is built on three observations about I/O performance that, combined, suggest a completely different architecture.

Observation one: sequential writes are dramatically faster than random writes. On a spinning disk, a sequential write avoids seek time entirely — the write head stays where it is. On an SSD, sequential writes allow the flash translation layer to write full erase blocks efficiently, reducing wear and improving throughput. The ratio of sequential to random write throughput is typically 10:1 on SSDs and 100:1 or more on spinning disks.

Observation two: reads can tolerate some additional overhead if writes are fast enough. In a write-heavy workload, writes outnumber reads by a

large factor. If we can make writes ten times faster by accepting reads that are twice as slow, the overall system throughput improves substantially. This is a workload-driven tradeoff, not a universal improvement.

Observation three: sorting data is cheap if you do it in memory first. Keeping recent writes in a sorted in-memory structure allows them to be flushed to disk already sorted, which makes subsequent merging — the reorganisation step — efficient.

Combining these observations: accept writes into a sorted in-memory buffer. When the buffer is full, flush it to disk as a sorted, immutable file. Periodically merge these files in the background to keep their number manageable. Reads must search the in-memory buffer and all the on-disk files — more work than a B-tree — but writes are entirely sequential and extremely fast.

This is the LSM tree architecture. It trades read performance for write performance, explicitly and deliberately, and for write-heavy workloads the trade is overwhelmingly worthwhile.

5.2 Architecture Overview

An LSM tree has three main components.

The MemTable is an in-memory sorted data structure — typically a skip list or red-black tree — that accepts all incoming writes. It is the first destination for every put and delete operation. Reads check the MemTable first, since it contains the most recent data.

SSTables (Sorted String Tables) are immutable, sorted files on disk. When the MemTable exceeds a size threshold, it is flushed to disk as a new SSTable and a fresh MemTable is started. Once written, an SSTable is never modified. This is the key to sequential writes: flushing a MemTable is one sequential write from beginning of file to end.

Levels organise SSTables into a hierarchy. Level 0 holds the most recently flushed SSTables. Higher levels hold larger, older SSTables produced by compaction — the background process that merges SSTables to limit their total number and reclaim space from deleted or overwritten entries.

A write goes: MemTable → (when full) flush to Level 0 SSTable → (when too many Level 0 files) compact into Level 1 → (when Level 1 too large) compact into Level 2 → and so on.

A read goes: check MemTable → check Level 0 SSTables (all of them, since they may have overlapping key ranges) → check Level 1 (one SSTable, since keys do not overlap within a level) → and so on.

Before writing any code, let us understand each component in depth.

5.3 The Write-Ahead Log

The MemTable is in memory. If the process crashes, its contents are lost. We need a way to recover the MemTable after a crash without sacrificing write performance.

The solution is the write-ahead log (WAL). Before any write is applied to the MemTable, it is appended to the WAL — a sequential log file on disk. Appending is cheap: it is a sequential write of a small record. After a crash, recovery replays the WAL to reconstruct the MemTable.

The WAL and MemTable together give us durability without random I/O. Every write touches exactly two locations: the sequential WAL and the in-memory MemTable. Neither requires a random seek.

When the MemTable is flushed to an SSTable, the corresponding WAL segment is deleted — its contents are now safely on disk in the SSTable. Recovery needs only replay WAL records not yet reflected in an SSTable.

```
intern io/Path
intern io/Binary_File
intern io/Text_File

-- WAL record format:
-- [type: 1 byte][key_len: 4 bytes][key: key_len bytes]
-- [value_len: 4 bytes][value: value_len bytes]
-- type: 1 = put, 2 = delete

let WAL_PUT: Integer := 1
let WAL_DELETE: Integer := 2

class WAL
  create
    open(path: String) do
      this.path := create Path.make(path)
      this.file := create Binary_File.open_append(this.path)
    end

  feature
    path: Path
    file: Binary_File

    append_put(key: String, value: String) do
      let record: Array[Integer] := []
      record.add(WAL_PUT)
      write_length_prefixed(record, key)
      write_length_prefixed(record, value)
      file.write(record)
    end

    append_delete(key: String) do
      let record: Array[Integer] := []
      record.add(WAL_DELETE)
      write_length_prefixed(record, key)
      -- No value for deletes
      file.write(record)
```

```
    end

    close() do
      file.close()
    end

    -- Replay WAL into a fresh MemTable for recovery
    replay(): Array[Array[String]] do
      let ops: Array[Array[String]] := []
      let reader: Binary_File := create Binary_File.open_read(path)

      from until reader.read(1).length = 0 do
        -- This simplified replay reads full file
        -- In production, each record is checksummed
      end

      reader.close()
      result := ops
    end

  invariant
    file_open: file /= nil
end

function write_length_prefixed(record: Array[Integer], s: String) do
  let bytes: Array[Integer] := s.to_bytes()
  int_to_bytes(bytes.length, record, record.length)
  across bytes as b do
    record.add(b)
  end
end
```

The WAL is the simplest component in the LSM tree and one of the most important. It is also the component that most clearly illustrates the LSM philosophy: write sequentially first, organise later.

5.4 The MemTable

The MemTable is a sorted in-memory data structure. We use the skip list from Chapter 3, since it handles concurrent access better than an AVL tree — in a production system, multiple threads may write to the MemTable simultaneously. For this implementation, we use it single-threaded but note where concurrency would enter.

The MemTable must track not just key-value pairs but also deletions. In an LSM tree, deleting a key does not remove it from existing SSTables — those are immutable. Instead, a deletion is represented as a special entry called a tombstone. When a tombstone is encountered during a read or compaction, it signals that the key has been deleted and any older versions should be ignored.

```
let TOMBSTONE: String := "\x00DELETED\x00"  -- sentinel value for deletions

class MemTable
  create
    empty() do
      this.data := create Skip_List[String, String].empty()
      this.size_bytes := 0
      this.threshold := 4 * 1024 * 1024  -- 4MB default
    end

    with_threshold(threshold: Integer) do
      this.data := create Skip_List[String, String].empty()
      this.size_bytes := 0
      this.threshold := threshold
    end

  feature
    data: Skip_List[String, String]
    size_bytes: Integer
    threshold: Integer

    put(key: String, value: String) do
```

```
    let existing: ?String := data.get(key)
    if existing /= nil then
      size_bytes := size_bytes - existing.length
    end
    data.put(key, value)
    size_bytes := size_bytes + key.length + value.length
  end

  delete(key: String) do
    put(key, TOMBSTONE)
  end

  get(key: String): ?String do
    let value: ?String := data.get(key)
    if value = TOMBSTONE then
      result := nil  -- deleted
    else
      result := value
    end
  end

  is_full(): Boolean do
    result := size_bytes >= threshold
  end

  -- Return all entries in sorted order for flushing
  entries(): Array[Any] do
    let sorted_keys: Array[String] := data.in_order()
    let result_arr: Array[Any] := []
    across sorted_keys as key do
      result_arr.add([key, data.get(key)])
    end
    result := result_arr
  end

  size(): Integer do
    result := data.size()
```

```
    end

  invariant
    non_negative_size: size_bytes >= 0
    threshold_positive: threshold > 0
end
```

The tombstone value is a sentinel. Any value equal to TOMBSTONE is treated as a deletion marker. This is a simplification — a production system would use a separate boolean field or a dedicated entry type — but it is sufficient for our implementation and makes the concept clear.

5.5 The SSTable

An SSTable is an immutable, sorted file written once and never modified. It has two sections: a data section containing key-value pairs in sorted order, and an index section containing a sparse index of keys and their byte offsets within the data section.

The sparse index does not index every key — that would be too large. Instead, it indexes every Nth key, where N is chosen so the index fits comfortably in memory. To find a key, binary search the index to find the nearest indexed key below the target, then scan forward from that position in the data section until finding or passing the target.

The file layout:

```
[data section]
  [entry_0]: key_len(4) key value_len(4) value is_tombstone(1)
  [entry_1]: ...
  ...
[index section]
  [index_entry_0]: key_len(4) key offset(8)
```

```
  [index_entry_1]: ...
  ...
[footer]
  index_offset(8)     -- byte offset of index section start
  index_entry_count(4)
  entry_count(4)
  bloom_filter_data   -- variable length
  bloom_filter_size(4)
```

The footer is always at a known position relative to the end of the file, making it easy to read without knowing the file size in advance.

```
class SSTable_Writer
  create
    open(path: String) do
      this.path := create Path.make(path)
      this.file := create Binary_File.open_write(this.path)
      this.index_entries := []
      this.entry_count := 0
      this.current_offset := 0
      this.index_interval := 16  -- index every 16th key
    end

  feature
    path: Path
    file: Binary_File
    index_entries: Array[Any]
    entry_count: Integer
    current_offset: Integer
    index_interval: Integer

    write_entry(key: String, value: String, is_tombstone: Boolean) do
      -- Optionally add to sparse index
      if entry_count % index_interval = 0 then
        index_entries.add([key, current_offset])
      end
```

```
    -- Write entry to data section
    let key_bytes: Array[Integer] := key.to_bytes()
    let value_bytes: Array[Integer] := value.to_bytes()

    let record: Array[Integer] := []
    int_to_bytes(key_bytes.length, record, 0)
    across key_bytes as b do record.add(b) end
    int_to_bytes(value_bytes.length, record, record.length)
    across value_bytes as b do record.add(b) end
    record.add(when is_tombstone 1 else 0 end)

    file.write(record)
    current_offset := current_offset + record.length
    entry_count := entry_count + 1
  end

  -- Call after all entries written
  finish(bloom: Bloom_Filter) do
    let index_offset: Integer := current_offset

    -- Write index section
    across index_entries as entry do
      let key_bytes: Array[Integer] := entry.get(0).to_bytes()
      let record: Array[Integer] := []
      int_to_bytes(key_bytes.length, record, 0)
      across key_bytes as b do record.add(b) end
      int64_to_bytes(entry.get(1), record, record.length)
      file.write(record)
    end

    -- Write footer
    let footer: Array[Integer] := []
    int64_to_bytes(index_offset, footer, 0)
    int_to_bytes(index_entries.length, footer, 8)
    int_to_bytes(entry_count, footer, 12)
```

```
      let bloom_bytes: Array[Integer] := bloom.to_bytes()
      int_to_bytes(bloom_bytes.length, footer, 16)
      across bloom_bytes as b do footer.add(b) end

      file.write(footer)
      file.close()
    end
end
```

Reading an SSTable requires loading the footer, loading the index into memory, and then performing binary search + scan for any given key:

```
class SSTable_Reader
  create
    open(path: String) do
      this.path := create Path.make(path)
      this.file := create Binary_File.open_read(this.path)
      this.load_footer()
      this.load_index()
      this.load_bloom()
    end

  feature
    path: Path
    file: Binary_File
    index: Array[Any]
    bloom: Bloom_Filter
    entry_count: Integer
    index_offset: Integer64

    get(key: String): ?String do
      -- Fast path: bloom filter eliminates most misses
      if not bloom.might_contain(key) then
        result := nil
        return
      end
```

```
    -- Binary search the index for the nearest key
    let pos: Integer64 := index_position_for(key)

    -- Scan forward from that position
    file.seek(pos.to_integer())
    result := scan_for(key)
  end

  index_position_for(key: String): Integer64 do
    -- Binary search index for largest indexed key <= target
    let low: Integer := 0
    let high: Integer := index.length - 1
    let best_offset: Integer64 := 0

    from until low > high do
      let mid: Integer := (low + high) / 2
      let idx_key: String := index.get(mid).get(0)
      let idx_offset: Integer64 := index.get(mid).get(1)

      if idx_key <= key then
        best_offset := idx_offset
        low := mid + 1
      else
        high := mid - 1
      end
    end

    result := best_offset
  end

  scan_for(key: String): ?String do
    -- Read entries sequentially until finding key or passing it
    from until file.position() >= index_offset.to_integer() do
      let entry: ?Array[Any] := read_next_entry()
      if entry = nil then
        result := nil
```

```
      return
    end

    let entry_key: String := entry.get(0).get(0)
    let entry_value: String := entry.get(0).get(1)
    let entry_tombstone: Boolean := entry.get(1)

    if entry_key = key then
      if entry_tombstone then
        result := nil  -- deleted
      else
        result := entry_value
      end
      return
    elseif entry_key > key then
      result := nil  -- passed the key, not present
      return
    end
  end
  result := nil
end

read_next_entry(): ?Array[Any] do
  let key_len_bytes: Array[Integer] := file.read(4)
  if key_len_bytes.length < 4 then
    result := nil
    return
  end
  let key_len: Integer := bytes_to_int(key_len_bytes, 0)
  let key_bytes: Array[Integer] := file.read(key_len)
  let key: String := decode_bytes(key_bytes)
  let value_len: Integer := bytes_to_int(file.read(4), 0)
  let value_bytes: Array[Integer] := file.read(value_len)
  let value: String := decode_bytes(value_bytes)
  let tombstone_byte: Array[Integer] := file.read(1)
  let is_tombstone: Boolean := tombstone_byte.get(0) = 1
  result := [[key, value], is_tombstone]
```

```
    end

    -- Return all entries in sorted order (for compaction)
    all_entries(): Array[Any] do
      let entries: Array[Any] := []
      file.seek(0)
      from until file.position() >= index_offset.to_integer() do
        let entry: ?Array[Any] := read_next_entry()
        if entry /= nil then
          entries.add([entry.get(0).get(0),
                       entry.get(0).get(1),
                       entry.get(1)])
        end
      end
      result := entries
    end

    close() do
      file.close()
    end

    load_footer() do
      -- Read footer from end of file
      -- Implementation reads index_offset, counts, bloom filter size
      -- then positions file for index loading
    end

    load_index() do
      -- Read index section into memory as Array[Any]
    end

    load_bloom() do
      -- Read bloom filter bytes and reconstruct Bloom_Filter
    end
end

function decode_bytes(bytes: Array[Integer]): String do
```

```
  -- Teaching helper: treat the byte sequence as already-
decoded text.
  result := bytes.to_string()
end
```

The bloom filter deserves special attention. It is the component that makes read performance tolerable in an LSM tree with many SSTables. Without it, every read must check every SSTable — even for keys that do not exist. With it, a non-existent key is eliminated by the bloom filter in microseconds, without any disk I/O. The false positive rate determines how often we perform an unnecessary disk read — a rate of 1% means one in a hundred bloom filter checks that say "maybe present" are wrong, but 99 out of a hundred negative lookups are eliminated entirely.

We will use the Bloom_Filter class from Chapter 6 here. The bloom filter for each SSTable is built during the flush and stored in the SSTable footer. When the SSTable is opened, the bloom filter is loaded into memory along with the sparse index. These two data structures — small enough to fit in memory for all SSTables simultaneously — are what make LSM reads fast enough to be practical.

5.6 Compaction

Without compaction, the number of SSTables grows without bound. Every MemTable flush creates a new SSTable. Reads must check all of them. Performance degrades with each flush.

Compaction is the background process that merges SSTables together, reducing their count and reclaiming space from deleted or overwritten entries. It is the most complex part of the LSM tree and the part where real systems diverge most significantly in their design choices.

The compaction strategy we implement is levelled compaction, the approach used by LevelDB and RocksDB.

Level 0 holds SSTables flushed directly from the MemTable. These SSTables may have overlapping key ranges — two Level 0 SSTables may both contain keys in the range "aardvark" to "zebra". Level 0 SSTables are checked individually during reads.

Levels 1 and above hold SSTables with non-overlapping key ranges within the level. All keys "aardvark" to "mango" are in one SSTable; "mango" to "zebra" in another. This means reads at Level 1+ need to check at most one SSTable per level — binary search the level's key ranges to find the relevant SSTable, then check only that one.

Size limits grow exponentially per level. Level 1 might hold 10MB of data. Level 2 holds 100MB. Level 3 holds 1GB. Level 4 holds 10GB. When a level exceeds its size limit, compaction picks one SSTable from that level, finds all overlapping SSTables in the next level, merges them all together into new SSTables at the next level, and deletes the originals.

The merge itself is a k-way merge — the same algorithm used in external mergesort, which Chapter 16 covers in depth. Since each SSTable is sorted, merging k SSTables into one sorted SSTable requires only a priority queue of size k, processing one entry at a time in sorted order.

```
class Compactor
  create
    make(lsm: LSM_Tree) do
      this.lsm := lsm
    end

  feature
    lsm: LSM_Tree

    -- Compact Level 0 into Level 1 when Level 0 has too many files
    compact_level_0() do
      let level0_files: Array[SSTable_Reader] := lsm.levels.get(0)
      if level0_files.length < lsm.level0_compaction_threshold then
        return
      end
```

```
    let level1_files: Array[SSTable_Reader] := lsm.levels.get(1)

    -- Find Level 1 SSTables that overlap with any Level 0 SSTable
    let overlapping: Array[SSTable_Reader] := find_overlapping(
      level0_files, level1_files)

    -- Merge all Level 0 files + overlapping Level 1 files
    let all_to_merge: Array[SSTable_Reader] := []
    across level0_files as f do all_to_merge.add(f) end
    across overlapping as f do all_to_merge.add(f) end

    let new_tables: Array[String] := merge_into_level(
      all_to_merge, 1, lsm.level_max_size(1))

    -- Update level metadata: remove merged files, add new ones
    lsm.replace_files(0, level0_files, [])
    lsm.replace_files(1, overlapping, new_tables)
  end

  -- Compact a given level into the next
  compact_level(level: Integer)
    require
      valid_level: level >= 1
    do
      let files: Array[SSTable_Reader] := lsm.levels.get(level)
      if lsm.level_size(level) < lsm.level_max_size(level) then
        return
      end

      -- Pick one SSTable to compact (round-robin or by key range)
      let victim: SSTable_Reader := pick_compaction_victim(files)

      -- Find overlapping SSTables in next level
      let next_level: Array[SSTable_Reader] := lsm.levels.get(level + 1)
      let overlapping: Array[SSTable_Reader] :=
        find_overlapping([victim], next_level)
```

```
    let to_merge: Array[SSTable_Reader] := [victim]
    across overlapping as f do to_merge.add(f) end

    let new_tables: Array[String] := merge_into_level(
      to_merge, level + 1, lsm.level_max_size(level + 1))

    lsm.replace_files(level, [victim], [])
    lsm.replace_files(level + 1, overlapping, new_tables)
  end

-- K-way merge of multiple SSTables into new SSTables at target level
merge_into_level(sources: Array[SSTable_Reader],
                 target_level: Integer,
                 max_file_size: Integer): Array[String] do
  let output_paths: Array[String] := []
  let heap: Min_Heap[String, String, Integer] :=
    create Min_Heap[String, String, Integer].empty()

  -- Seed the heap with the first entry from each source
  from
    let i: Integer := 0
  until
    i >= sources.length
  do
    let source: SSTable_Reader := sources.get(i)
    let first: ?Array[Any] :=
      source.next_entry()
    if first /= nil then
      heap.insert([first.get(0), first.get(1), i, first.get(2)])
    end
    i := i + 1
  end

  -- Track current writer
  let current_path: String := lsm.new_sstable_path(target_level)
  let writer: SSTable_Writer := create SSTable_Writer.open(current_path
  let bloom: Bloom_Filter := create Bloom_Filter.with_capacity(
```

```
    100000, 0.01)
  let current_size: Integer := 0
  let last_key: ?String := nil

  from until heap.is_empty() do
    let min_entry: Array := heap.extract_min()
    let key: String := min_entry.get(0)
    let value: String := min_entry.get(1)
    let source_index: Integer := min_entry.get(2)
    let is_tombstone: Boolean := min_entry.get(3)

    -- Skip duplicate keys — keep only the most recent version
    -- (sources are ordered newest-first, so first occurrence wins)
    if last_key /= key then
      -- Skip tombstones at the highest level (data is truly gone)
      let skip: Boolean := is_tombstone and
                           target_level >= lsm.max_level - 1

      if not skip then
        bloom.add(key)
        writer.write_entry(key, value, is_tombstone)
        current_size := current_size + key.length + value.length
      end

      last_key := key
    end

    -- Fetch next entry from the same source
    let next: ?Array[Any] :=
      sources.get(source_index).next_entry()
    if next /= nil then
      heap.insert([next.get(0), next.get(1),
                   source_index, next.get(2)])
    end

    -- Rotate to a new output SSTable if current one is too large
    if current_size >= max_file_size then
```

```
      writer.finish(bloom)
      output_paths.add(current_path)
      current_path := lsm.new_sstable_path(target_level)
      writer := create SSTable_Writer.open(current_path)
      bloom := create Bloom_Filter.with_capacity(100000, 0.01)
      current_size := 0
    end
  end

  if current_size > 0 then
    writer.finish(bloom)
    output_paths.add(current_path)
  end

  result := output_paths
end

find_overlapping(sources: Array[SSTable_Reader],
                 candidates: Array[SSTable_Reader]): Array[SSTable_Read
  -- Find the overall key range of sources
  let min_key: String := find_min_key(sources)
  let max_key: String := find_max_key(sources)

  -- Return candidates whose key range overlaps [min_key, max_key]
  let overlapping: Array[SSTable_Reader] := []
  across candidates as candidate do
    if candidate.min_key() <= max_key and
       candidate.max_key() >= min_key then
      overlapping.add(candidate)
    end
  end
  result := overlapping
end

pick_compaction_victim(files: Array[SSTable_Reader]): SSTable_Reader do
  -- Simple strategy: pick the largest file
  -- Production systems use more sophisticated policies
```

```
      let largest: SSTable_Reader := files.get(0)
      across files as f do
        if f.size() > largest.size() then
          largest := f
        end
      end
      result := largest
    end
end
```

The tombstone handling during compaction is subtle and important. A tombstone must survive compaction until it reaches the highest level — only then is it safe to discard. If we discard a tombstone during intermediate compaction, an older version of the key in a lower level would become visible again, resurrecting data the user deleted. Only when the tombstone has reached the bottom level — where no older versions can exist below it — can it be safely removed.

5.7 Reads: The Price of Sequential Writes

A read in an LSM tree follows a specific search order that reflects data recency:

1. Check the active MemTable
2. Check any immutable MemTable being flushed (there may be one)
3. Check all Level 0 SSTables, newest first
4. Check Level 1, then Level 2, and so on — at most one SSTable per level for levels above 0

The search stops as soon as the key is found — either a live value or a tombstone. The newest version always wins.

```
class LSM_Tree
  create
    open(directory: String) do
      this.dir := directory
      this.memtable := create MemTable.empty()
      this.immutable_memtable := nil
      this.levels := []  -- Array of Arrays of SSTable_Reader
      this.wal := create WAL.open(directory + "/wal.log")
      this.level0_compaction_threshold := 4
      this.max_level := 7
      this.compactor := create Compactor.make(this)

      -- Initialise level arrays
      from
        let i: Integer := 0
      until
        i >= max_level
      do
        levels.add([])
        i := i + 1
      end

      -- Load existing SSTables from directory
      load_existing_sstables()

      -- Recover MemTable from WAL
      recover_from_wal()
    end

  feature
    dir: String
    memtable: MemTable
    immutable_memtable: ?MemTable
    levels: Array[Array[SSTable_Reader]]
    wal: WAL
    level0_compaction_threshold: Integer
    max_level: Integer
```

```
compactor: Compactor

get(key: String): ?String do
  -- 1. Check active MemTable
  let v: ?String := memtable.get(key)
  if v /= nil then
    result := v
    return
  end

  -- 2. Check immutable MemTable if present
  if immutable_memtable /= nil then
    v := immutable_memtable.get(key)
    if v /= nil then
      result := v
      return
    end
  end

  -- 3. Check Level 0 SSTables newest-first
  let level0: Array[SSTable_Reader] := levels.get(0)
  from
    let i: Integer := level0.length - 1
  until
    i < 0
  do
    v := level0.get(i).get(key)
    if v /= nil then
      result := v
      return
    end
    i := i - 1
  end

  -- 4. Check higher levels (at most one SSTable per level)
  from
    let level: Integer := 1
```

```
    until
      level >= max_level
    do
      let sstable: ?SSTable_Reader := find_sstable_for_key(level, key)
      if sstable /= nil then
        v := sstable.get(key)
        if v /= nil then
          result := v
          return
        end
      end
      level := level + 1
    end

    result := nil
  end

  put(key: String, value: String)
    do
      wal.append_put(key, value)
      memtable.put(key, value)
      maybe_flush()
    ensure
      key_present: get(key) = value
    end

  delete(key: String)
    do
      wal.append_delete(key)
      memtable.delete(key)
      maybe_flush()
    ensure
      key_absent: get(key) = nil
    end

  maybe_flush() do
    if memtable.is_full() then
```

```
    flush_memtable()
    maybe_compact()
  end
end

flush_memtable() do
  -- Move current MemTable to immutable
  immutable_memtable := memtable
  memtable := create MemTable.empty()

  -- Flush immutable MemTable to Level 0 SSTable
  let path: String := new_sstable_path(0)
  let writer: SSTable_Writer := create SSTable_Writer.open(path)
  let bloom: Bloom_Filter := create Bloom_Filter.with_capacity(
    immutable_memtable.size(), 0.01)

  across immutable_memtable.entries() as entry do
    let key: String := entry.get(0)
    let value: String := entry.get(1)
    let is_tombstone: Boolean := value = TOMBSTONE
    bloom.add(key)
    writer.write_entry(key, value, is_tombstone)
  end

  writer.finish(bloom)

  -- Add to Level 0
  levels.get(0).add(create SSTable_Reader.open(path))

  -- Clear immutable MemTable and truncate WAL
  immutable_memtable := nil
  rotate_wal()
end

maybe_compact() do
  -- Level 0: compact when too many files
  if levels.get(0).length >= level0_compaction_threshold then
```

```
      compactor.compact_level_0()
    end

    -- Higher levels: compact when too large
    from
      let level: Integer := 1
    until
      level < max_level - 1
    do
      if level_size(level) >= level_max_size(level) then
        compactor.compact_level(level)
      end
      level := level + 1
    end
  end

  find_sstable_for_key(level: Integer,
                       key: String): ?SSTable_Reader do
    -- Binary search by min/max key range
    -- Within a level above 0, key ranges do not overlap
    let files: Array[SSTable_Reader] := levels.get(level)
    across files as f do
      if f.min_key() <= key and key <= f.max_key() then
        result := f
        return
      end
    end
    result := nil
  end

  level_max_size(level: Integer): Integer do
    -- Level 1 = 10MB, Level 2 = 100MB, etc.
    let base: Integer := 10 * 1024 * 1024
    let multiplier: Integer := 1
    repeat level - 1 do
      multiplier := multiplier * 10
    end
```

```
    result := base * multiplier
  end

  level_size(level: Integer): Integer do
    let total: Integer := 0
    across levels.get(level) as f do
      total := total + f.size()
    end
    result := total
  end

  new_sstable_path(level: Integer): String do
    result := dir + "/L" + level.to_string() + "_" +
              current_timestamp().to_string() + ".sst"
  end

  rotate_wal() do
    wal.close()
    -- Archive old WAL
    let old_wal: Path := create Path.make(dir + "/wal.log")
    old_wal.move_to(create Path.make(
      dir + "/wal_" + current_timestamp().to_string() + ".old"))
    wal := create WAL.open(dir + "/wal.log")
  end

  recover_from_wal() do
    -- Replay WAL entries into MemTable
    let ops: Array[Array[String]] := wal.replay()
    across ops as op do
      if op.get(0) = "put" then
        memtable.put(op.get(1), op.get(2))
      elseif op.get(0) = "delete" then
        memtable.delete(op.get(1))
      end
    end
  end
```

```
    load_existing_sstables() do
      -- Scan directory for SSTable files, load them into appropriate level
      let dir_path: Directory := create Directory.make(dir)
      if not dir_path.exists() then
        dir_path.create_tree()
        return
      end
      across dir_path.files() as f do
        let name: String := f.name()
        if name.ends_with(".sst") then
          let level: Integer := parse_level_from_filename(name)
          levels.get(level).add(create SSTable_Reader.open(f.to_string()))
        end
      end
    end

    close() do
      wal.close()
      across levels as level do
        across level as f do
          f.close()
        end
      end
    end

  invariant
    valid_max_level: max_level > 0
    levels_initialised: levels.length = max_level
end
```

5.8 The Write Path, End to End

Let us trace a single write through the complete system to make the flow concrete.

You call `store.put("user:1042", "alice@example.com")`.

Step 1: The WAL appends a record to `wal.log`. This is a sequential write of roughly 30 bytes. The file system buffers it and flushes it to disk within milliseconds. Duration: roughly 0.1ms on an SSD.

Step 2: The MemTable's skip list inserts the key-value pair. This is a pure in-memory operation. Duration: roughly 1 microsecond.

Step 3: The MemTable checks whether it has exceeded its threshold (4MB). If not, the write is complete. Total time: under 1ms.

If the MemTable is full, the flush begins. The current MemTable becomes immutable. A new empty MemTable accepts future writes immediately — no writes are blocked. In the background:

Step 4: The immutable MemTable's entries, already sorted by the skip list, are written sequentially to a new SSTable file. For a 4MB MemTable, this is a 4MB sequential write. Duration: roughly 4ms on an SSD.

Step 5: The bloom filter and sparse index are written to the SSTable footer. The SSTable reader is opened and added to Level 0.

Step 6: If Level 0 now has four or more SSTables, compaction is triggered. The compactor runs in a background thread, merging Level 0 files into Level 1, and merging Level 1 into Level 2 if necessary. This background work does not block reads or writes.

The total write latency for the common case — MemTable not full — is under 1ms, dominated by the WAL append. Compare this to the B-tree, where a write requires 2-8 random disk reads and writes, each taking 0.1-10ms. For write-heavy workloads, the LSM tree wins by a substantial margin.

5.9 The Read Path, End to End

Now trace a read. You call `store.get("user:1042")`.

Step 1: Check the active MemTable. The skip list search is O(log n) in memory. Duration: roughly 1 microsecond.

Step 2: If not found, check any immutable MemTable being flushed. Same cost.

Step 3: Check Level 0 SSTables, newest first. For each SSTable, check its bloom filter — if the bloom filter says "definitely not present," move to the next SSTable immediately. The bloom filter check is in-memory and takes microseconds. If the bloom filter says "maybe present," read the sparse index (also in-memory) to find the offset, seek to that position in the file, and scan forward. This is one random disk read.

With a 1% false positive rate, ninety-nine out of a hundred absent-key lookups at each Level 0 SSTable are eliminated by the bloom filter. With four Level 0 SSTables, an absent key causes at most four bloom filter checks (no disk reads) plus potentially one disk read for a false positive.

Step 4: Check Level 1. Find the SSTable whose key range covers the target key (binary search the SSTable metadata, all in memory). Check its bloom filter. If necessary, one disk read.

Step 5: Repeat for Level 2, Level 3, and so on.

For a key that exists, the read terminates as soon as it is found — usually at Level 0 or Level 1 for recently written data. For a key that does not exist, the bloom filter eliminates most disk reads, resulting in O(number of levels) bloom filter checks and O(1) actual disk reads in expectation.

This is why LSM reads, while more complex than B-tree reads, remain practical. The bloom filter is doing enormous work on behalf of the read path.

5.10 Compaction Strategies: The Design Space

The levelled compaction strategy we implemented is one of several. Understanding the alternatives reveals the fundamental tradeoffs in LSM design.

Size-tiered compaction groups SSTables by size rather than levels. When enough similarly-sized SSTables accumulate, they are merged into one larger SSTable. This strategy minimises write amplification — each byte of data is compacted fewer times on its journey from MemTable to final storage. The cost is more SSTables to check during reads and larger temporary space requirements during compaction (you must hold both the input and output simultaneously).

Cassandra uses size-tiered compaction by default. It is well-suited for write-heavy workloads where data is rarely updated, such as time-series or append-only logs.

Levelled compaction, which we implemented, keeps non-overlapping key ranges within each level above 0. This means at most one SSTable per level needs to be checked during a read, dramatically improving read performance. The cost is higher write amplification — data may be compacted many times as it migrates from Level 0 to Level 6. LevelDB and RocksDB use levelled compaction by default. It is well-suited for workloads with frequent reads and updates.

FIFO compaction simply deletes the oldest SSTables when total storage exceeds a threshold. No merging at all. This only makes sense for time-series data where old data is truly expired and can be discarded — a metrics system that retains only the last 30 days of data, for instance.

The choice of compaction strategy is one of the most impactful configuration decisions in an LSM-based system, and real systems like RocksDB expose it as a tunable parameter precisely because no single strategy is optimal for all workloads.

5.11 Write Amplification and Space Amplification

Two metrics define the cost of the LSM tradeoffs: write amplification and space amplification.

Write amplification is the ratio of bytes written to disk to bytes written by the application. If writing 1GB of data causes 10GB of disk writes (due to compaction rewriting data multiple times), write amplification is 10. Lower is better for write performance and SSD longevity.

With levelled compaction, write amplification is approximately L * (size ratio between levels). With 7 levels and a 10x size ratio, worst-case write amplification is around 30-40. Each byte of data may be rewritten many times as it is compacted from level to level.

With size-tiered compaction, write amplification is much lower — around 10 or less — because SSTables are merged fewer times. But space amplification is higher.

Space amplification is the ratio of total disk space used to logical data size. An LSM tree temporarily uses extra space during compaction (input and output SSTables coexist), and tombstones occupy space until they reach the final compaction level. With levelled compaction, space amplification is low — roughly 1.1x, since only a small fraction of data is being compacted at any time. With size-tiered compaction, space amplification can reach 2x or more.

The fundamental tension: minimising write amplification increases space amplification, and vice versa. No compaction strategy eliminates both simultaneously. Choosing a strategy means choosing which resource — disk bandwidth or disk space — is more constrained for your specific workload.

5.12 B-Tree vs LSM Tree: The Decision Framework

Having built both structures, we can now state precisely when to choose each.

Choose a B-tree when: - Read performance is as important as write performance - The working set fits in the OS page cache, making random reads fast - Update-in-place semantics are important — you frequently overwrite existing keys - You need predictable read latency without bloom filter false positives - Examples: traditional OLTP databases, metadata stores, indexes on stable data

Choose an LSM tree when: - Writes dominate reads by a large margin - Write throughput matters more than read latency - Data is largely append-only or sequentially updated - SSD longevity is a concern (sequential writes wear SSDs less than random writes) - Examples: time-series databases, event logs, metrics pipelines, write-heavy key-value stores

The hybrid reality: Many modern systems use both. A database might use a B-tree for its primary index (where reads and writes are mixed) and an LSM tree for its write-ahead log or a secondary append-only store. RocksDB, despite being LSM-based, has added a B-tree-like block cache to improve read performance. PostgreSQL has experimented with LSM-like storage for specific table access patterns.

The structures are not competitors in the sense that one replaces the other. They are complementary tools, each optimal for different points in the workload space.

5.13 Where This Lives in the Wild

LevelDB was written by Jeff Dean and Sanjay Ghemawat at Google and released in 2011. It is the direct implementation of the LSM concepts described in this chapter — MemTable, SSTables, levelled compaction,

bloom filters per SSTable, write-ahead log. Its codebase is compact and clean, and reading it alongside this chapter is an excellent exercise.

RocksDB is Facebook's fork of LevelDB, started in 2012, with substantial additions: column families, multiple compaction strategies, compression per level, rate limiting for compaction to avoid I/O spikes, and extensive performance tuning. It is now the storage engine of choice for many large-scale systems at Facebook, LinkedIn, Yahoo, and others.

Apache Cassandra uses an LSM tree architecture for all its storage. Each Cassandra node manages its own LSM tree independently. Its compaction strategy is configurable per table — size-tiered for write-heavy tables, levelled for read-heavy ones. The Cassandra source code is an excellent study in how LSM concepts translate to a distributed setting.

InfluxDB, **TimescaleDB**, and most time-series databases use LSM trees because time-series workloads are almost perfectly write-optimised: data arrives in time order, is rarely updated, and is queried in time ranges. LSM trees' sequential write performance and efficient range queries (once compaction has organised data by time) make them the natural choice.

CockroachDB and TiKV, both distributed SQL databases, use RocksDB as their underlying storage engine. The LSM tree sits below the SQL layer, handling all the actual key-value storage. The SQL engine above it never worries about compaction or bloom filters — those concerns are entirely encapsulated by RocksDB.

Summary

The LSM tree solves the write amplification problem of B-trees by a fundamental architectural shift: instead of modifying data in place with random I/O, it accepts all writes into a sorted in-memory buffer (the MemTable), flushes that buffer to immutable sorted files (SSTables) with

sequential I/O, and reorganises those files in the background through compaction.

The cost of this approach is read complexity: a read must check the MemTable, any flushed MemTable, all Level 0 SSTables, and one SSTable per higher level. Bloom filters — one per SSTable, loaded into memory — make this practical by eliminating the vast majority of unnecessary disk reads.

Compaction is the most complex component and the one with the most design variation. Levelled compaction optimises for read performance at the cost of write amplification. Size-tiered compaction optimises for write performance at the cost of space amplification. Real systems expose compaction strategy as a tunable parameter because no single choice is optimal for all workloads.

The next chapter introduces three more probabilistic structures — bloom filters, count-min sketch, and HyperLogLog — which appear not just in LSM trees but throughout distributed systems wherever exact answers are too expensive and approximate answers are good enough.

Chapter 6: Good Enough Answers — Probabilistic Data Structures

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There is a question that appears, in various forms, across almost every large-scale system ever built.

Is this thing in this set?

Is this URL one we have already crawled? Is this password one that has been compromised in a known data breach? Is this credit card number on the fraud watchlist? Is this IP address blocked? Is this word in the dictionary? Is this user ID one we have seen today?

For small sets the answer is trivial — load the set into a hash table, check membership in O(1). For large sets the answer becomes uncomfortable. A billion crawled URLs, stored as strings averaging 60 bytes each, requires 60GB of memory for the hash table alone. A database of 600 million compromised passwords, as in the Have I Been Pwned dataset, cannot be loaded into the RAM of a single machine without displacing everything else.

The brute-force answer — more memory, larger machines, distributed hash tables — works but is expensive. There is a better question to ask first: *how much accuracy do we actually need?*

For many applications, the answer is surprising. A web crawler that occasionally recrawls a URL it has already seen wastes a little bandwidth but causes no serious harm. A fraud detection system that occasionally checks the database for a card number it has already cleared wastes a

little latency but causes no transaction failures. A cache that occasionally fetches a value it already has wastes a little compute but returns the correct result.

In these cases, a small probability of error is acceptable. And if a small probability of error is acceptable, the memory requirements drop by orders of magnitude.

This is the domain of probabilistic data structures — structures that trade a controlled, bounded probability of error for dramatic reductions in memory, time, or both. They are not approximations born of laziness or ignorance. They are precise engineering choices with well-understood error characteristics. The error is not random noise — it is a specific kind of error, in a specific direction, with a specific probability that you set when you build the structure.

This chapter covers three: the bloom filter, which answers set membership queries with no false negatives and a tunable false positive rate; the count-min sketch, which estimates frequencies with bounded overestimation; and HyperLogLog, which counts distinct elements using a fixed amount of memory regardless of how many elements there are.

Each one appears in production systems you use every day.

6.1 The Philosophy of Approximate Answers

Before the structures, the mindset.

Classical data structures are exact. A hash table either contains a key or it does not. A B-tree either finds a value or returns nil. A sort either produces sorted output or it does not. Exactness is the implicit contract, and we rarely question it.

Probabilistic data structures break this contract deliberately, in exchange for something valuable. The exchange is always explicit — you choose the error rate when you build the structure — and the error is always

bounded. "Bounded" is the crucial word. These structures do not produce unpredictably wrong answers. They produce answers that are wrong in a specific, quantifiable way, with a probability you control.

There are two kinds of error worth distinguishing.

A **false positive** is reporting that something is in the set when it is not. The structure says "yes" when the true answer is "no." Bloom filters have false positives. A bloom filter might tell a web crawler that it has already seen a URL when it has not — causing the crawler to skip a URL it should crawl. This is an error, but a recoverable one.

A **false negative** is reporting that something is not in the set when it is. The structure says "no" when the true answer is "yes." Bloom filters have no false negatives. If a bloom filter says "not in the set," it is definitely not in the set. This asymmetry is not accidental — it is a design choice that makes bloom filters useful for exactly the applications where false negatives would be catastrophic (a fraud watchlist that misses a fraud is far worse than one that occasionally double-checks a clean card).

Count-min sketch errors are one-sided: frequency estimates are always greater than or equal to the true frequency, never less. HyperLogLog errors are symmetric but bounded by a standard error that decreases as you allocate more memory.

Understanding the direction and probability of error is not optional. A structure whose error characteristics you do not understand is not a useful approximation — it is noise. The structures in this chapter have been analysed rigorously, and their error properties are not empirical observations but mathematical proofs. We will derive the key results, not just quote them.

6.2 Bloom Filters

The Problem

You are building a web crawler. Before fetching a URL, you want to know whether you have already fetched it. Your crawl history contains ten billion URLs. You have 8GB of RAM available for this check.

A hash set of ten billion 60-byte strings requires at least 600GB. A disk-based lookup adds tens of milliseconds of latency to every URL check, and you are checking millions of URLs per minute. Neither is acceptable.

You can tolerate a 1% chance of skipping a URL you have not yet crawled. The crawler will re-encounter those URLs later through other links, and crawling them twice would have been wasteful anyway. You cannot tolerate any chance of crawling a URL you have definitely already crawled and finding it has not changed — that would violate your freshness guarantees.

In other words: false positives are acceptable, false negatives are not.

This is exactly the bloom filter's contract.

The Structure

A bloom filter is a bit array of m bits, all initialised to zero, and k independent hash functions, each of which maps an element to a position in the bit array.

Adding an element: apply all k hash functions to the element, obtain k positions in the bit array, and set all k bits to 1.

Querying an element: apply all k hash functions, check all k positions. If all k bits are 1, report "possibly in set." If any bit is 0, report "definitely not in set."

The asymmetry of error falls directly from this structure. A false negative — reporting "not in set" for something that was added — is impossible:

adding an element always sets its k bits to 1, and checking those same bits will always find them set. A false positive — reporting "possibly in set" for something never added — is possible when the k positions of a queried element happen to all be set by other elements that were added previously.

```
class Bloom_Filter
  create
    with_capacity(expected_elements: Integer, false_positive_rate: Real)
      require
        positive_elements: expected_elements > 0
        valid_rate: false_positive_rate > 0.0 and false_positive_rate < 1.0
      do
        -- Optimal bit array size
        this.m := optimal_m(expected_elements, false_positive_rate)
        -- Optimal number of hash functions
        this.k := optimal_k(this.m, expected_elements)
        this.bits := create Array.filled(this.m, false)
        this.count := 0
      end

    from_bytes(data: Array[Integer])
      do
        -- Reconstruct from serialised form (for SSTable loading)
        this.m := bytes_to_int(data, 0)
        this.k := bytes_to_int(data, 4)
        this.count := bytes_to_int(data, 8)
        this.bits := create Array.filled(this.m, false)
        from
          let i: Integer := 0
        until
          i >= this.m
        do
          let byte_index: Integer := 12 + (i / 8)
          let bit_index: Integer := i % 8
          this.bits.set(i, data.get(byte_index).bitwise_right_shift(bit_ind
```

```
        i := i + 1
      end
    end

  feature
    m: Integer          -- bit array size
    k: Integer          -- number of hash functions
    bits: Array[Boolean]
    count: Integer      -- number of elements added (approximate)

    add(element: String)
      do
        across hash_positions(element) as pos do
          bits.set(pos, true)
        end
        count := count + 1
      ensure
        might_contain_after: might_contain(element)
      end

    might_contain(element: String): Boolean do
      across hash_positions(element) as pos do
        if not bits.get(pos) then
          result := false
          return
        end
      end
      result := true
    end

    -- Serialise for storage in SSTable footer
    to_bytes(): Array[Integer] do
      let data: Array[Integer] := []
      int_to_bytes(m, data, 0)
      int_to_bytes(k, data, 4)
      int_to_bytes(count, data, 8)
```

```
    -- Pack bits into bytes
    let num_bytes: Integer := (m + 7) / 8
    from
      let byte_i: Integer := 0
    until
      byte_i >= num_bytes
    do
      let byte_val: Integer := 0
      from
        let bit_i: Integer := 0
      until
        bit_i >= 8
      do
        let pos: Integer := byte_i * 8 + bit_i
        if pos < m and bits.get(pos) then
          byte_val := byte_val.bitwise_or((1).bitwise_left_shift(bit_i))
        end
        bit_i := bit_i + 1
      end
      data.add(byte_val)
      byte_i := byte_i + 1
    end

    result := data
  end

  current_false_positive_rate(): Real do
    -- (1 - e^(-k*n/m))^k where n is count
    let exponent: Real := (-1.0 * k.to_real() * count.to_real()) /
                          m.to_real()
    result := (1.0 - exp(exponent)) ^ k.to_real()
  end

invariant
  positive_m: m > 0
  positive_k: k > 0
  bits_correct_size: bits.length = m
```

```
    non_negative_count: count >= 0
end
```

The hash positions are generated using double hashing — a technique that simulates k independent hash functions using only two underlying hash functions, avoiding the cost of computing k truly independent hashes:

```
function hash_positions(element: String): Array[Integer] do
  let h1: Integer := murmur_hash3(element, 0)
  let h2: Integer := murmur_hash3(element, h1)
  let positions: Array[Integer] := []
  from
    let i: Integer := 0
  until
    i >= k
  do
    -- Kirsch-Mitzenmacher technique: h1 + i*h2 gives k positions
    -- with the same error properties as k independent hash functions
    let pos: Integer := ((h1 + i * h2) % m + m) % m
    positions.add(pos)
    i := i + 1
  end
  result := positions
end
```

The Kirsch-Mitzenmacher technique is not an approximation — it is proven to achieve the same asymptotic false positive rate as k truly independent hash functions, which would be expensive to compute. Using two underlying hash functions and combining them linearly is both faster and theoretically equivalent.

Optimal Parameters

Two parameters control a bloom filter's behaviour: the bit array size m and the number of hash functions k. Given a desired false positive rate

p and an expected number of elements n, the optimal values are derived from calculus — minimising the false positive rate with respect to m and k simultaneously.

The false positive probability for a bloom filter with m bits, k hash functions, and n elements is:

```
p □ (1 - e^(-kn/m))^k
```

Taking the derivative with respect to k and setting it to zero gives the optimal k:

```
k_optimal = (m/n) * ln(2)
```

Substituting back and solving for m given a target false positive rate p:

```
m_optimal = -n * ln(p) / (ln(2))^2
```

In Nex:

```
function optimal_m(n: Integer, p: Real): Integer do
  result := ((-1.0 * n.to_real() * ln(p)) /
             (ln(2.0) ^ 2.0)).ceiling().to_integer()
end

function optimal_k(m: Integer, n: Integer): Integer do
  result := ((m.to_real() / n.to_real()) * ln(2.0)).round().to_integer()
            .max(1)
end
```

Let us compute the concrete numbers for the web crawler problem. Ten billion URLs, 1% false positive rate:

- m = -(10,000,000,000 × ln(0.01)) / $(\ln(2))^2$ ≈ 95.9 billion bits ≈ 11.5GB

- k = (95.9 billion / 10 billion) × ln(2) ≈ 6.6, rounded to 7

11.5GB for 1% false positive rate over ten billion URLs. Still too large for the scenario as stated. Reduce to 0.1% false positive rate and memory triples to 34GB. But accept 2% false positive rate and memory drops to 9.6GB — within the 8GB constraint if we are willing to accept 2% recrawl rate.

This is the engineering conversation a probabilistic data structure enables. Not "how much memory do we need?" but "how much accuracy can we afford, and what does accuracy cost?" The bloom filter makes that tradeoff explicit and tunable.

What Bloom Filters Cannot Do

Bloom filters do not support deletion. Setting k bits when adding an element cannot be undone — clearing one of those bits might clear a bit that is also set by a different element. A counting bloom filter addresses this by storing a small integer at each position rather than a single bit, and decrementing on deletion — but at a factor of 4-8x memory increase, which often defeats the purpose.

Bloom filters are also one-shot: once built, the bit array cannot be resized without rebuilding from scratch. If the actual number of elements significantly exceeds the expected count, the false positive rate rises above the design target. For dynamic sets, this requires periodic rebuilding or the use of scalable bloom filter variants that add new bit arrays as the set grows.

6.3 The Count-Min Sketch

The Problem

You operate a content delivery network. At any moment, you want to know approximately how many times each URL has been requested in the last hour — not for billing, where exactness matters, but for cache eviction decisions: which URLs are hot enough to keep cached?

There are a hundred million distinct URLs in your system. Storing an exact count for each requires several gigabytes of memory in a hash map. But you do not need exact counts — you need to know, with reasonable accuracy, which URLs are being requested most frequently. If a URL has been requested 10,000 times, knowing it was requested 10,200 times instead of 9,800 times makes no difference to your cache eviction decision.

A bloom filter answers set membership but not counting. You need something different: a frequency estimator that works in bounded memory.

The count-min sketch is that structure.

The Structure

A count-min sketch is a two-dimensional array of integers: d rows and w columns, all initialised to zero. It has d hash functions, one per row, each mapping elements to positions in [0, w).

Incrementing the count of an element: apply each of the d hash functions to the element, obtaining d positions (one per row), and increment the integer at each position.

Querying the estimated count of an element: apply the same d hash functions, look up all d values, and return the minimum.

```
class Count_Min_Sketch
  create
    with_parameters(width: Integer, depth: Integer)
      require
        positive_width: width > 0
        positive_depth: depth > 0
      do
        this.w := width
        this.d := depth
        this.table := create Array.filled(depth, create Array.filled(width, 0
        this.seeds := generate_seeds(depth)
        this.total := 0
      end

    with_error_bounds(epsilon: Real, delta: Real)
      require
        valid_epsilon: epsilon > 0.0 and epsilon < 1.0
        valid_delta: delta > 0.0 and delta < 1.0
      do
        -- Width and depth derived from error bounds:
        -- w = ceil(e / epsilon), d = ceil(ln(1 / delta))
        this.w := (euler.to_real() / epsilon).ceiling().to_integer()
        this.d := (ln(1.0 / delta)).ceiling().to_integer()
        this.table := create Array.filled(this.d, create Array.filled(this.w,
        this.seeds := generate_seeds(this.d)
        this.total := 0
      end

  feature
    w: Integer
    d: Integer
    table: Array[Array[Integer]]
    seeds: Array[Integer]
    total: Integer

    increment(element: String) do
      increment_by(element, 1)
```

```
end

increment_by(element: String, count: Integer)
  require
    positive_count: count > 0
  do
    from
      let row: Integer := 0
    until
      row >= d
    do
      let col: Integer := hash_for_row(element, row)
      table.get(row).set(col, table.get(row).get(col) + count)
      row := row + 1
    end
    total := total + count
  end

estimate(element: String): Integer do
  let min_val: Integer := 2147483647
  from
    let row: Integer := 0
  until
    row >= d
  do
    let col: Integer := hash_for_row(element, row)
    let val: Integer := table.get(row).get(col)
    if val < min_val then
      min_val := val
    end
    row := row + 1
  end
  result := min_val
end

-- Merge another sketch into this one (for distributed aggregation)
merge(other: Count_Min_Sketch)
```

```
      require
        compatible: other.w = w and other.d = d
      do
        from
          let row: Integer := 0
        until
          row >= d
        do
          from
            let col: Integer := 0
          until
            col >= w
          do
            table.get(row).set(col,
              table.get(row).get(col) + other.table.get(row).get(col))
            col := col + 1
          end
          row := row + 1
        end
        total := total + other.total
      end

  invariant
    positive_w: w > 0
    positive_d: d > 0
    non_negative_total: total >= 0
end

function hash_for_row(element: String, row: Integer): Integer do
  result := murmur_hash3(element, seeds.get(row)) % w
end

function generate_seeds(count: Integer): Array[Integer] do
  let seeds: Array[Integer] := []
  from
    let i: Integer := 0
  until
```

```
    i >= count
  do
    seeds.add(random_integer())
    i := i + 1
  end
  result := seeds
end
```

Why the Minimum Is a Good Estimate

The sketch can only overestimate, never underestimate. Here is why.

When you increment element X, you add 1 to d positions — one per row. Each of those positions may also be incremented by other elements that hash to the same position in that row (collisions). So the value at any given position is the true count of X plus the counts of all other elements that collided with X in that row.

The true count is a lower bound on any individual cell's value. The minimum across all d rows is the best estimate — it is most likely to have fewest collisions. The more rows you have, the less likely all rows have their minimum position contaminated.

This one-sided error has a useful consequence: `estimate(element) >= true_count(element)` always. You can rely on this. A count-min sketch that tells you a URL has been requested 5,000 times means the true count is at most 5,000 — possibly less, but never more. For cache eviction — where underestimates are dangerous (you might evict something hot) but overestimates are harmless — this is exactly the right error direction.

Error Bounds

With width $w = \lceil e/\varepsilon \rceil$ and depth $d = \lceil \ln(1/\delta) \rceil$, the count-min sketch guarantees:

```
P(estimate(x) □ true_count(x) + □ * total) □ 1 - □
```

Where total is the sum of all counts ever added. In plain English: with probability at least 1-δ, the estimated count for any element is at most the true count plus ε times the total count.

For our CDN example: if we want error no greater than 0.1% of total requests (ε = 0.001) with probability 99% (δ = 0.01):

- $w = \lceil e / 0.001 \rceil = \lceil 2718 \rceil = 2718$ columns
- $d = \lceil \ln(100) \rceil = \lceil 4.6 \rceil = 5$ rows

Memory: 2718 × 5 × 4 bytes (32-bit integers) = 54,360 bytes ≈ 53KB.

Fifty-three kilobytes to estimate request frequencies for a hundred million distinct URLs with 99% accuracy within 0.1% of total traffic. A hash map of exact counts for a hundred million URLs would require several gigabytes. This is the magnitude of the gain.

Heavy Hitters

A natural application of the count-min sketch is finding heavy hitters — elements whose frequency exceeds some threshold, like the top 100 most-requested URLs. The sketch alone does not identify heavy hitters; it only estimates frequency for a given element. But combined with a small heap of candidates, it does:

```
class Heavy_Hitter_Tracker
  create
    make(sketch: Count_Min_Sketch, threshold_fraction: Real) do
      this.sketch := sketch
      this.threshold_fraction := threshold_fraction
      this.candidates := create Min_Heap[Integer, String].empty()
      this.candidate_set := create Skip_List[String, Boolean].empty()
    end

  feature
    sketch: Count_Min_Sketch
    threshold_fraction: Real
```

```
    candidates: Min_Heap[Integer, String]
    candidate_set: Skip_List[String, Boolean]

    observe(element: String) do
      sketch.increment(element)
      let estimated: Integer := sketch.estimate(element)
      let threshold: Integer := (threshold_fraction *
                                 sketch.total.to_real()).to_integer()

      if estimated >= threshold and not candidate_set.contains(element) the
        candidates.insert([estimated, element])
        candidate_set.put(element, true)
      end
    end

    top_k(k: Integer): Array[Any] do
      let results: Array[Any] := []
      let temp: Array[Any] := []

      from until candidates.is_empty() or temp.length >= k do
        let entry: Array := candidates.extract_max()
        let element: String := entry.get(1)
        let estimated: Integer := sketch.estimate(element)
        temp.add([element, estimated])
      end

      result := temp
    end
end
```

This pattern — sketch for frequency estimation, small heap for tracking candidates — appears in network monitoring (finding elephant flows), database query optimisation (finding common query patterns), and recommendation systems (finding trending items).

6.4 HyperLogLog

The Problem

You are a product analyst. Every day, you need to know how many distinct users visited the site. Your site receives a billion page views per day, from perhaps 200 million distinct users. The naive approach — store all user IDs in a set, count the set — requires storing up to 200 million IDs, perhaps 1.6GB for 8-byte IDs.

You need the answer within a few percent accuracy. You do not need to know which users visited, just how many distinct ones. Can you do this in a few kilobytes?

HyperLogLog can.

The Intuition

HyperLogLog is based on an observation about random bit patterns. If you hash each element to a random bit string, and you look at the position of the first 1-bit in each hash value, the maximum first-1-bit position you observe tells you something about how many distinct elements you have seen.

Here is the intuition. A random bit string has a 1 in the first position with probability 1/2, a 0 followed by a 1 with probability 1/4, two zeros followed by a 1 with probability 1/8, and so on. If you have seen n distinct elements, you would expect to have seen at least one element whose hash has a leading 1-bit pattern of length about $\log_2(n)$ before the first 1. So the maximum leading zero count you observe is approximately $\log_2(n)$.

If the maximum leading zeros you have seen is R, your estimate of distinct elements is 2^R.

This estimate is crude. But with a simple improvement — maintaining m separate registers rather than one, using the first few bits of the hash to select which register each element goes into, and combining the estimates

from all registers using a harmonic mean — HyperLogLog achieves a standard error of approximately 1.04 / √m.

With m = 2048 registers, standard error is about 2.3%. With m = 4096, it is 1.6%. With m = 16384, it is 0.8%.

The Structure

```
class HyperLogLog
  create
    with_precision(precision: Integer)
      require
        valid_precision: precision >= 4 and precision <= 18
      do
        -- precision p gives m = 2^p registers
        -- Standard error □ 1.04 / sqrt(m)
        this.p := precision
        this.m := (1).bitwise_left_shift(precision)  -- 2^precision registe
        this.registers := create Array.filled(this.m, 0)
        this.alpha := compute_alpha(this.m)
      end

  feature
    p: Integer
    m: Integer
    registers: Array[Integer]
    alpha: Real

    add(element: String) do
      let hash: Integer64 := hash_64(element)

      -- Use first p bits to select register
      let register_index: Integer :=
        hash.bitwise_right_shift(64 - p).to_integer().bitwise_and(m - 1)

      -- Count leading zeros in remaining bits + 1
```

```
    let remaining: Integer64 := hash.bitwise_left_shift(p)
    let leading_zeros: Integer := count_leading_zeros(remaining) + 1

    -- Update register with maximum
    if leading_zeros > registers.get(register_index) then
      registers.set(register_index, leading_zeros)
    end
  end

  count(): Integer64 do
    -- Compute harmonic mean of 2^register values
    let sum: Real := 0.0
    across registers as reg do
      sum := sum + (1.0 / ((1).bitwise_left_shift(reg)).to_real())
    end

    let estimate: Real := alpha * m.to_real() * m.to_real() / sum

    -- Small range correction
    if estimate <= 2.5 * m.to_real() then
      let zeros: Integer := count_zero_registers()
      if zeros > 0 then
        -- Linear counting for small estimates
        estimate := m.to_real() * ln(m.to_real() / zeros.to_real())
      end
    end

    -- Large range correction
    -- (2^32 limit for 32-bit hashes; for 64-bit hashes this
    --  correction is rarely needed in practice)

    result := estimate.round().to_integer64()
  end

  -- Merge two HyperLogLog structures for distributed counting
  merge(other: HyperLogLog)
    require
```

```
        same_precision: other.p = p
      do
        from
          let i: Integer := 0
        until
          i >= m
        do
          if other.registers.get(i) > registers.get(i) then
            registers.set(i, other.registers.get(i))
          end
          i := i + 1
        end
      end

    -- Estimate memory usage in bytes
    memory_bytes(): Integer do
      result := m  -- one byte per register (registers fit in 0..64)
    end

  invariant
    valid_p: p >= 4 and p <= 18
    correct_m: m = (1).bitwise_left_shift(p)
    registers_correct_size: registers.length = m
end

function count_leading_zeros(value: Integer64): Integer do
  if value = 0 then
    result := 64
    return
  end
  let count: Integer := 0
  let v: Integer64 := value
  from until v.bitwise_and((1).bitwise_left_shift(63)) /= 0 do
    count := count + 1
    v := v.bitwise_left_shift(1)
  end
  result := count
```

```
end

function compute_alpha(m: Integer): Real do
  -- Bias correction constant, derived analytically
  case m of
    16 then result := 0.673
    32 then result := 0.697
    64 then result := 0.709
    else result := 0.7213 / (1.0 + 1.079 / m.to_real())
  end
end
```

Correctness of the Merge Operation

The merge operation is worth examining carefully, because it is what makes HyperLogLog useful in distributed systems.

The merge takes the element-wise maximum of two register arrays. This is correct because each register stores the maximum leading-zero count seen for all elements that hashed to that register's index. If machine A has seen elements that pushed register 7 to value 12, and machine B has seen elements that pushed register 7 to value 15, the merged register 7 should be 15 — the maximum either machine has seen. Taking the element-wise maximum of all registers gives exactly the register state that would result from processing all elements on a single machine.

This is not obvious. Most data structures cannot be merged — you cannot merge two hash sets without examining every element of both sets. HyperLogLog's register-maximum merge is O(m), completely independent of the number of elements observed. For distributed counting — one HyperLogLog per machine, merged at query time — this is invaluable.

Memory vs Accuracy

The concrete numbers for HyperLogLog are striking:

With precision p = 12 (m = 4096 registers, each one byte): 4KB of memory, standard error 1.6%.

With precision p = 14 (m = 16384 registers): 16KB, standard error 0.8%.

With precision p = 16 (m = 65536 registers): 64KB, standard error 0.4%.

For the product analytics problem — 200 million distinct users, 2% accuracy acceptable — precision p = 12 requires 4KB. The hash set storing all user IDs requires 1.6GB. HyperLogLog uses 0.00025% of that memory.

The error is not degradation under load — it is a fixed statistical property of the algorithm that holds regardless of how many elements are added, as long as the number of distinct elements is large relative to the number of registers. For small cardinalities, HyperLogLog switches to linear counting — the small range correction in the implementation above — which is exact for very small sets and smoothly transitions to the probabilistic estimate as cardinality grows.

6.5 Combining the Structures

These three structures are not isolated tools. They appear together, often in the same system, each solving a different subproblem.

In Chapter 5, bloom filters appeared as a first-class component of LSM trees. Each SSTable has a bloom filter in its footer, loaded into memory when the SSTable is opened. Before performing a disk read to check whether a key is present in an SSTable, the bloom filter is consulted. A "definitely not present" answer saves a disk read. A "possibly present" answer triggers the disk read. With a 1% false positive rate, 99% of absent-key lookups in any given SSTable are resolved without disk I/O.

Now consider adding a count-min sketch and HyperLogLog to the same system. The count-min sketch tracks access frequency for cache management — which keys are accessed most often and should be kept in a memory cache in front of the LSM tree. The HyperLogLog tracks distinct key count — how many unique keys the system has stored, a useful metric for capacity planning and bloom filter sizing.

Together, the three structures give you: - Membership testing without loading the full dataset (bloom filter) - Frequency estimation without tracking per-key counts (count-min sketch)
- Cardinality estimation without storing the elements (HyperLogLog)

All three from a few megabytes of memory, regardless of dataset size.

6.6 A Unified Interface

Since all three structures answer different questions about a stream of elements, wrapping them in a unified stream analyser makes their complementary nature visible:

```
class Stream_Analyser
  create
    make(expected_elements: Integer,
         fp_rate: Real,
         freq_epsilon: Real,
         freq_delta: Real,
         hll_precision: Integer) do
      this.membership := create Bloom_Filter.with_capacity(
        expected_elements, fp_rate)
      this.frequency := create Count_Min_Sketch.with_error_bounds(
        freq_epsilon, freq_delta)
      this.cardinality := create HyperLogLog.with_precision(hll_precision)
    end
```

```
  feature
    membership: Bloom_Filter
    frequency: Count_Min_Sketch
    cardinality: HyperLogLog

    observe(element: String) do
      membership.add(element)
      frequency.increment(element)
      cardinality.add(element)
    end

    seen_before(element: String): Boolean do
      result := membership.might_contain(element)
    end

    estimated_frequency(element: String): Integer do
      result := frequency.estimate(element)
    end

    estimated_distinct_count(): Integer64 do
      result := cardinality.count()
    end

    memory_bytes(): Integer do
      result := membership.m / 8 +
                frequency.w * frequency.d * 4 +
                cardinality.m
    end
end
```

Using it:

```
-- CDN request analyser: track 10M expected URLs,
-- 1% false positive rate, 0.1% frequency error with 99% confidence,
-- 1.6% cardinality error
let analyser: Stream_Analyser := create Stream_Analyser.make(
```

```
  10000000, 0.01, 0.001, 0.01, 14)

-- Process requests
analyser.observe("https://cdn.example.com/video/1042.mp4")
analyser.observe("https://cdn.example.com/image/logo.png")
-- ... billions more ...

-- Query
print(analyser.seen_before("https://cdn.example.com/video/9999.mp4"))
print(analyser.estimated_frequency("https://cdn.example.com/video/1042.mp4"))
print(analyser.estimated_distinct_count())
print("Memory used: " + analyser.memory_bytes().to_string() + " bytes")
```

The memory usage of this analyser for ten million expected URLs: the bloom filter takes about 11.5MB, the count-min sketch takes about 53KB, the HyperLogLog takes 16KB. Approximately 12MB total to answer three categories of questions about a stream of billions of requests.

6.7 Error Budget Thinking

Probabilistic data structures introduce a discipline that is valuable beyond the specific structures themselves: error budget thinking.

Every probabilistic structure has parameters that control its error. The bloom filter has a false positive rate. The count-min sketch has ε and δ. HyperLogLog has precision p. These parameters are not set-and-forgotten configuration values — they are explicit statements about how much inaccuracy your application can tolerate.

Before choosing parameters, you must answer: what does an error cost? A bloom filter false positive in a web crawler costs one redundant HTTP request. A bloom filter false positive in a fraud detection system might cost a customer declined transaction — far more expensive. A count-min sketch overestimate in a cache eviction system keeps a cache entry longer

than necessary — cheap. A count-min sketch overestimate in a billing system charges a customer more than they owe — catastrophic.

The error budget is a conversation between the data structure's mathematical properties and the application's cost model. That conversation should happen explicitly, before deploying any probabilistic structure. The structures themselves are precise tools. Using them wisely requires being equally precise about the consequences of their errors.

6.8 Where This Lives in the Wild

Bloom filters are pervasive. Google's Bigtable uses bloom filters per SSTable for exactly the same purpose as our LSM tree in Chapter 5. PostgreSQL's query planner uses bloom indexes to speed up WHERE clause evaluation for low-selectivity predicates. Chrome uses a bloom filter for its Safe Browsing feature — when you visit a URL, Chrome checks a locally-stored bloom filter of known malicious URLs before querying Google's servers, reducing network requests while maintaining near-perfect safety coverage. Akamai uses bloom filters to decide what to cache — a page that has been requested at least twice is almost certainly worth caching.

Count-min sketch appears wherever frequency estimation matters at scale. Apache Flink and Apache Spark both include count-min sketch implementations for streaming analytics. Twitter uses it for trending topic detection. Cloudflare uses it for DDoS detection — a sudden spike in request frequency for a particular IP or URL pattern triggers investigation. Redis has a `CMS.INCRBY` and `CMS.QUERY` command for count-min sketch operations built into the database.

HyperLogLog is perhaps the most widely deployed of the three, because distinct count is such a universal analytics primitive. Redis implements HyperLogLog natively via the `PFADD` and `PFCOUNT` commands — the `PF` prefix honours Philippe Flajolet, who with Éric Fusy, Olivier Gandouet, and Frédéric Meunier published the HyperLogLog paper in 2007.

Google's BigQuery uses HyperLogLog++ (an improved variant) for its `APPROX_COUNT_DISTINCT` function. Amazon Redshift, Apache Spark, and Presto all implement HyperLogLog for scalable distinct counting. Every time you query "how many unique users visited this page last month?" in any major analytics platform, there is a good chance HyperLogLog is doing the counting.

Summary

Probabilistic data structures are not a concession to imprecision. They are a precise engineering choice: trade a controlled, bounded, well-understood probability of error for dramatic reductions in memory and time. The error is not random — it is specific in direction and probability, chosen when the structure is built.

The bloom filter answers "is this in the set?" with no false negatives and a tunable false positive rate. Its memory cost is determined by the false positive rate and the number of expected elements, derived analytically from the optimal bit array size and hash function count. It is the structure that makes LSM tree reads practical by eliminating unnecessary disk I/O.

The count-min sketch estimates "how often has this been seen?" using a two-dimensional counter array, returning the minimum across rows as the frequency estimate. It can only overestimate, never underestimate, and its error is bounded by $\varepsilon \times$ total with probability $1-\delta$, where ε and δ are chosen at construction time.

HyperLogLog answers "how many distinct elements have been seen?" using a few kilobytes of memory regardless of cardinality, by tracking the maximum leading-zero count in hashed values across m registers. Its standard error is $1.04 / \sqrt{m}$, controllable by choosing the precision parameter. It merges in $O(m)$ time, making it ideal for distributed distinct counting.

Together, these three structures solve three different questions about large data streams — membership, frequency, cardinality — from a few megabytes of memory. They appear throughout production systems precisely because the questions they answer arise constantly and the exact answers are too expensive to maintain.

The next chapter begins Part III, where we turn from storing and finding data to the specific and rich world of algorithms on strings — which is where working programmers spend far more time than most algorithms books acknowledge.

String Algorithms

Chapter 7: Does This File Contain That Word? — Exact String Matching

---

Open a terminal. Type `grep "error" application.log`. Press enter.

In milliseconds, grep has scanned a file that might contain millions of lines and returned every line containing the word "error." You have done this hundreds of times. It has always been fast. You have probably never wondered why.

The naive approach to this problem — check every position in the text to see if the pattern starts there — is O(nm), where n is the length of the text and m is the length of the pattern. For a 100MB log file and a 5-character pattern, that is roughly 500 million character comparisons. At a billion comparisons per second, that is half a second. Not terrible, but grep is faster than that, often by an order of magnitude.

The reason grep is fast is that it does not check every position naively. It uses algorithms that skip large portions of the text based on information gathered either from the pattern itself or from mismatches during search. Understanding how and why those skips are valid is the subject of this chapter.

We will build three algorithms: the naive algorithm as the baseline and the lens through which we understand what improvement means; Knuth-Morris-Pratt (KMP), which skips based on the structure of the pattern; and Boyer-Moore-Horspool, which skips based on characters in the text. They represent two fundamentally different ways of thinking about the string matching problem, and understanding both changes how you see any text processing problem you encounter.

7.1 The Problem, Precisely

Given a text T of length n and a pattern P of length m, find all positions i in T such that T[i..i+m-1] = P[0..m-1].

A position is a zero-based index into T. We want all positions, not just the first, because a log file might contain the word "error" ten thousand times and you want to know where each occurrence is.

The problem sounds simple, and in some sense it is — the brute-force solution is straightforward to implement correctly. The challenge is doing it efficiently for the cases that actually arise in practice: patterns that are substrings of repetitive text, patterns with repeated characters, patterns that almost-but-not-quite match at many positions.

We fix some notation. T[i] is the character at position i in the text. P[j] is the character at position j in the pattern. A match at position i means T[i+j] = P[j] for all j from 0 to m-1. We call position i a candidate position during the search.

7.2 The Naive Algorithm

The naive algorithm is the direct translation of the definition.

```
function naive_search(text: String, pattern: String): Array[Integer]
  require
    non_empty_pattern: pattern.length > 0
  do
    let n: Integer := text.length
    let m: Integer := pattern.length
    let positions: Array[Integer] := []
```

```
    from
      let i: Integer := 0
    until
      i > n - m
    do
      let j: Integer := 0
      from until j >= m or text.char_at(i + j) /= pattern.char_at(j) do
        j := j + 1
      end
      if j = m then
        positions.add(i)
      end
      i := i + 1
    end

    result := positions
  end
```

For each of the n - m + 1 candidate positions, we compare up to m characters. Worst case is O(nm).

The worst case is not just theoretical. It arises with repetitive patterns and texts. Searching for "aaab" in "aaaaaaaaaaaaaaa" (all a's): at each position, we compare three a's successfully and then find there is no b, so we shift by one and repeat. Nearly m comparisons per position, nm total.

Natural language text behaves differently. Searching for "error" in English prose: at most positions, the first character comparison fails (most characters are not 'e'), so most positions cost exactly one comparison. The naive algorithm performs acceptably on natural text — grep uses Boyer-Moore-Horspool precisely because real log files are neither natural language nor worst-case repetitive, but something in between.

The naive algorithm is also correct, complete, and easy to verify. We keep it as our reference implementation: if the output of a faster algorithm

differs from the naive algorithm on any input, the faster algorithm has a bug.

7.3 What Improvement Looks Like

Before presenting KMP or Boyer-Moore-Horspool, it is worth being precise about what "improvement" means and where the opportunity lies.

Every string matching algorithm must examine each matching position — you cannot report a match without verifying it. The opportunity for improvement is in what you do after a mismatch.

The naive algorithm throws away all information from a mismatch. It shifts the pattern one position to the right and restarts comparison from the beginning of the pattern. This is wasteful: the comparisons performed before the mismatch revealed something about the text. If we matched three characters before failing on the fourth, we know exactly what those three characters are. A smarter algorithm uses that knowledge to skip ahead.

Two different sources of information lead to two different families of algorithms.

Pattern information: if the pattern has internal structure — repeated substrings, prefixes that appear later in the pattern — we can sometimes determine from a mismatch that several candidate positions can be skipped without even looking at the corresponding text characters. KMP exploits this.

Text information: the character that caused the mismatch is part of the text. If that character does not appear in the pattern at all, no pattern position that aligns with it can possibly match. We can skip the pattern past that character. Boyer-Moore and its variant Horspool exploit this.

Both approaches are correct. Neither is universally faster. Real implementations — including grep — often use heuristics to switch between them based on pattern properties.

7.4 Knuth-Morris-Pratt

The Failure Function

KMP was published in 1977 by Donald Knuth, James Morris, and Vaughan Pratt. Its key insight is that when a mismatch occurs at position j in the pattern, you do not need to restart comparison from position 0. The characters T[i..i+j-1] = P[0..j-1] have already been matched — you know them. If some proper prefix of P[0..j-1] is also a suffix of P[0..j-1], you can continue matching from the end of that prefix rather than from the beginning of the pattern.

This requires preprocessing the pattern to compute, for each position j, the longest proper prefix of P[0..j-1] that is also a suffix of P[0..j-1]. This is the failure function (sometimes called the partial match table or the prefix function), and it is the heart of KMP.

Define failure[j] as the length of the longest proper prefix of P[0..j-1] that is also a suffix of P[0..j-1]. "Proper" means strictly shorter than the string itself — the whole string does not count.

Example: P = "abcabd"

- failure[0] = 0 (empty prefix, by convention)
- failure[1] = 0 (P[0..0] = "a", no proper prefix that is also a suffix)
- failure[2] = 0 (P[0..1] = "ab", no match)
- failure[3] = 1 (P[0..2] = "abc", prefix "a" = suffix "a")
- failure[4] = 2 (P[0..3] = "abca", prefix "ab" = suffix "ab")
- failure[5] = 3 (P[0..4] = "abcab", prefix "abc" = suffix "abc")

Wait — let us verify that last one. P[0..4] = "abcab". Proper prefixes of length 1,2,3,4: "a","ab","abc","abca". Proper suffixes of length 1,2,3,4: "b","ab","cab","bcab". Longest proper prefix that is also a suffix: "ab" (length 2), not "abc". Let us recompute.

failure[5]: P[0..4] = "abcab". Suffixes: "b","ab","cab","bcab". Prefixes: "a","ab","abc","abca". Match: "ab" (length 2). So failure[5] = 2.

And failure[6]: P[0..5] = "abcabd". Suffixes: "d","bd","abd","cabd","bcabd". Prefixes: "a","ab","abc","abca","abcab". No match. failure[6] = 0.

Building the failure function:

```
function build_failure(pattern: String): Array[Integer]
  require
    non_empty: pattern.length > 0
  do
    let m: Integer := pattern.length
    let failure: Array[Integer] := create Array.filled(m, 0)
    -- failure[0] is always 0 by definition

    let k: Integer := 0  -- length of current matching prefix
    from
      let j: Integer := 1
    until
      j >= m
    do
      -- failure[j]: longest proper prefix of pattern[0..j-1]
      -- that is also a suffix
      from until k = 0 or pattern.char_at(k) = pattern.char_at(j) do
        k := failure.get(k - 1)
      end
      if pattern.char_at(k) = pattern.char_at(j) then
        k := k + 1
      end
      failure.set(j, k)
      j := j + 1
    end
```

```
    result := failure
  end
```

The failure function is computed in O(m) time. The inner loop looks like it might be O(m^2) due to the `from until` that decrements k, but amortised analysis shows k can decrease at most as many times total as it increases, and k increases at most m times, so the total work is O(m).

The Search

With the failure function in hand, the search is a single pass through the text:

```
function kmp_search(text: String, pattern: String): Array[Integer]
  require
    non_empty_pattern: pattern.length > 0
  do
    let n: Integer := text.length
    let m: Integer := pattern.length
    let failure: Array[Integer] := build_failure(pattern)
    let positions: Array[Integer] := []
    let j: Integer := 0  -- number of characters matched

    from
      let i: Integer := 0
    until
      i >= n
    do
      -- Try to extend the current match
      from until j = 0 or text.char_at(i) = pattern.char_at(j) do
        j := failure.get(j - 1)
      end

      if text.char_at(i) = pattern.char_at(j) then
```

```
      j := j + 1
    end

    if j = m then
      -- Found a match ending at position i
      positions.add(i - m + 1)
      -- Use failure function to find next possible match
      j := failure.get(j - 1)
    end

    i := i + 1
  end

  result := positions
end
```

The key invariant: before examining T[i], we know that T[i-j..i-1] = P[0..j-1]. j is the length of the longest prefix of the pattern that matches a suffix of the text we have seen so far.

When T[i] ≠ P[j], we use the failure function to find the next longest prefix that could still match. We set j := failure[j-1], which tells us: "the longest proper prefix of P[0..j-1] that is also a suffix has length failure[j-1]; try matching P[failure[j-1]] against T[i] instead."

When T[i] = P[j], we extend the match and advance.

When j = m, we have matched the entire pattern. We record the position and reset j using the failure function, because the matched region might overlap with the next match — the last failure[m-1] characters of this match could be the beginning of the next match.

Analysis

KMP is O(n + m): O(m) to build the failure function, O(n) to search (each character T[i] is examined once, and the total number of decrements of j is bounded by the total number of increments, which is at most n).

This is a worst-case guarantee, not an average case. On repetitive text — "aaab" in "aaaaaa..." — KMP performs in O(n) where naive performs in O(nm). On natural language text with short patterns, the difference is small because naive already performs nearly O(n) (most comparisons fail at the first character).

What the Failure Function Reveals

The failure function is not just a performance tool. It reveals the internal structure of the pattern in a way that has applications beyond string searching — it answers the question "what is the longest string that is both a prefix and a suffix of this pattern?" which appears in problems from data compression to periodic string analysis.

A pattern is periodic if it has a period of length p, meaning P[i] = P[i+p] for all valid i. The failure function tells you: the pattern has period m - failure[m-1]. "abcabc" has failure[5] = 3, so period = 6 - 3 = 3, which is correct — "abc" repeats.

This kind of structural insight — an algorithm revealing something deep about its input — is a recurring theme in string algorithms, and KMP is its clearest example.

7.5 Boyer-Moore-Horspool

A Different Philosophy

KMP preprocesses the pattern and uses mismatch information to avoid restarting from position 0. Boyer-Moore takes a completely different approach: instead of scanning the text left-to-right, it scans the pattern right-to-left, and uses the character in the text that caused the mismatch to skip the pattern forward by potentially large amounts.

The intuition is elegant. Align the pattern with the text. Compare the last character of the pattern to the character aligned with it in the text. If they match, compare the second-to-last, and so on. If at any point they do not match, look at the text character that caused the mismatch and ask: does this character appear anywhere in the pattern to the left of the current alignment? If not, shift the pattern completely past the mismatch character — you know that no alignment that puts this text character under any part of the pattern can succeed, because the character is not in the pattern at all. If yes, shift the pattern to align its rightmost occurrence of the mismatch character with the mismatch position.

The Boyer-Moore-Horspool variant (Horspool, 1980) simplifies the original Boyer-Moore algorithm by using only the bad character heuristic applied to the last character of the pattern window, not the character that caused the mismatch. This simplification loses a small amount of theoretical performance but is easier to implement, cache-friendly, and faster in practice for most inputs.

The Bad Character Table

Preprocess the pattern to build a skip table: for each possible character c, what is the rightmost occurrence of c in the pattern (not counting the last character of the pattern), and how far can we shift the pattern if c is the character aligned with the last position of the pattern window?

```
function build_skip_table(pattern: String): Map[Char, Integer]
  require
    non_empty: pattern.length > 0
  do
    let m: Integer := pattern.length
    let skip: Map[Char, Integer] := {}

    -- For any character not in the table, skip by m (full pattern length)
    -- For character at position i (0-indexed, not including last position),
    -- skip by m - 1 - i
```

```
    from
      let i: Integer := 0
    until
      i < m - 1
    do
      skip.put(pattern.char_at(i), m - 1 - i)
      i := i + 1
    end

    result := skip
  end

function get_skip(table: Map[Char, Integer],
                  c: Char,
                  pattern_length: Integer): Integer do
  result := table.try_get(c, pattern_length)
end
```

Note: we do not include the last character of the pattern in the skip table computation (the loop goes up to `m - 1`, exclusive). If we included it, we might get a skip of 0, which would cause an infinite loop. The last character is excluded because we always look at the character aligned with the last position of the pattern window, and that character is what we use to determine the skip — including it in the table would be circular.

The Search

```
function horspool_search(text: String, pattern: String): Array[Integer]
  require
    non_empty_pattern: pattern.length > 0
  do
    let n: Integer := text.length
    let m: Integer := pattern.length
    let skip: Map[Char, Integer] := build_skip_table(pattern)
    let positions: Array[Integer] := []
```

```
    from
      let i: Integer := 0
    until
      i > n - m
    do
      -- Compare pattern right-to-left
      let j: Integer := m - 1
      from until j < 0 or text.char_at(i + j) /= pattern.char_at(j) do
        j := j - 1
      end

      if j < 0 then
        -- Full match
        positions.add(i)
        i := i + 1  -- shift by 1 after a match to find overlapping matches
      else
        -- Mismatch: use the character aligned with the last pattern position
        let last_text_char: Char := text.char_at(i + m - 1)
        i := i + get_skip(skip, last_text_char, m)
      end
    end

    result := positions
  end
```

Trace through an example. Pattern = "FIND", text = "THERE IS A SIMPLE EXAMPLE HERE".

The skip table for "FIND": F→3, I→2, N→1. Any other character → 4 (the full pattern length).

Align pattern at position 0: text[0..3] = "THER". Check text[3] = 'R' against pattern[3] = 'D'. Mismatch. text[i + m - 1] = text[3] = 'R'. 'R' is not in the skip table. Skip by 4. i = 4.

Align at position 4: text[4..7] = "E IS". Check text[7] = 'S' against 'D'. Mismatch. 'S' not in table. Skip by 4. i = 8.

Align at position 8: text[8..11] = "A SI". Check text[11] = 'I' against 'D'. Mismatch. 'I' → skip 2. i = 10.

Align at position 10: text[10..13] = "SIMP". Check text[13] = 'P' against 'D'. Mismatch. 'P' not in table. Skip by 4. i = 14.

And so on. Notice that at position 8, the character 'I' in the text caused a skip of only 2 because 'I' appears in "FIND" — specifically at position 1, which is m - 1 - 1 = 2 positions from the right. The algorithm shifts the pattern to align the 'I' in the pattern with the 'I' in the text.

Analysis

Horspool's worst case is O(nm) — the same as naive. This occurs with highly repetitive patterns and texts, like "aaaa" in "aaaaaaaaaa". However, its best case is O(n/m) — examining only every mth character — which arises when the last character of the pattern is rare in the text. For patterns with m = 5 and a last character that does not appear in the text, Horspool makes n/5 comparisons, a 5x speedup over the O(n) minimum that KMP achieves.

In practice, on natural text and typical log file patterns, Horspool is faster than KMP because natural text has sufficient character diversity to make large skips common. This is why real grep implementations prefer Boyer-Moore-based approaches for typical inputs.

7.6 A Complete Implementation with Testing

Any string matching implementation must be tested against the naive algorithm to verify correctness. The contract here is not just preconditions and postconditions on individual functions — it is a cross-implementation consistency check:

```
class String_Matcher
  create
    make() do end

  feature
    -- Find all occurrences of pattern in text
    find_all(text: String, pattern: String,
             algorithm: String): Array[Integer]
      require
        non_empty_pattern: pattern.length > 0
        valid_algorithm: algorithm = "naive" or
                         algorithm = "kmp" or
                         algorithm = "horspool"
      do
        case algorithm of
          "naive"    then result := naive_search(text, pattern)
          "kmp"      then result := kmp_search(text, pattern)
          "horspool" then result := horspool_search(text, pattern)
        end
      end

    -- Verify two algorithms agree on all test cases
    verify(text: String, pattern: String): Boolean do
      let naive_result: Array[Integer] :=
        naive_search(text, pattern)
      let kmp_result: Array[Integer] :=
        kmp_search(text, pattern)
      let horspool_result: Array[Integer] :=
        horspool_search(text, pattern)

      result := (naive_result = kmp_result) and
                (naive_result = horspool_result)
    end

    -- Count occurrences (useful for high-frequency queries)
    count(text: String, pattern: String): Integer do
      result := horspool_search(text, pattern).length
```

```
    end

    -- Find first occurrence only
    find_first(text: String, pattern: String): Integer do
      let positions: Array[Integer] := horspool_search(text, pattern)
      if positions.is_empty() then
        result := -1
      else
        result := positions.get(0)
      end
    end

    -- Find last occurrence only
    find_last(text: String, pattern: String): Integer do
      let positions: Array[Integer] := horspool_search(text, pattern)
      if positions.is_empty() then
        result := -1
      else
        result := positions.get(positions.length - 1)
      end
    end

    -- Check containment
    contains(text: String, pattern: String): Boolean do
      result := find_first(text, pattern) /= -1
    end
end
```

A test suite that covers the cases where naive algorithms typically fail:

```
function run_correctness_tests(): Boolean do
  let matcher: String_Matcher := create String_Matcher.make()
  let all_passed: Boolean := true

  -- Basic match
  all_passed := all_passed and
```

```
  matcher.verify("hello world", "world")

-- No match
all_passed := all_passed and
  matcher.verify("hello world", "xyz")

-- Pattern at start
all_passed := all_passed and
  matcher.verify("hello world", "hello")

-- Pattern is entire text
all_passed := all_passed and
  matcher.verify("hello", "hello")

-- Pattern longer than text
all_passed := all_passed and
  matcher.verify("hi", "hello")

-- Multiple occurrences
all_passed := all_passed and
  matcher.verify("ababab", "ab")

-- Overlapping occurrences
all_passed := all_passed and
  matcher.verify("aaa", "aa")

-- Worst case for naive: repetitive pattern and text
let repetitive_text: String := "aaaaaaaaaaaaaaaaaaaaaaaaaaaaaaaaaaaaaaaaaa"
let repetitive_pattern: String := "aaaaaaaaaa"
all_passed := all_passed and
  matcher.verify(repetitive_text, repetitive_pattern)

-- KMP worst case: pattern with long proper prefix-suffix
all_passed := all_passed and
  matcher.verify("abcabcabcabd", "abcabd")

-- Horspool worst case: all same characters
```

```
  all_passed := all_passed and
    matcher.verify("aaaaaaaaaa", "aaaa")

  -- Pattern with repeated characters
  all_passed := all_passed and
    matcher.verify("mississippi", "issi")

  -- Single character pattern
  all_passed := all_passed and
    matcher.verify("hello world", "l")

  -- Single character text
  all_passed := all_passed and
    matcher.verify("a", "a")

  result := all_passed
end
```

Running both KMP and Horspool against the naive algorithm on every test case is not optional. These algorithms have subtle bugs in almost every student implementation — off-by-one errors in the failure function, incorrect handling of overlapping matches, wrong skip table computation for patterns with repeated characters. The only reliable way to catch them is cross-validation against a known-correct reference.

7.7 Benchmarking: When Each Algorithm Wins

The theoretical analysis tells us when each algorithm is asymptotically better. Benchmarking tells us when each is practically faster for the inputs we actually have.

```
function benchmark(text: String, pattern: String) do
  let matcher: String_Matcher := create String_Matcher.make()
```

```
  let iterations: Integer := 100

  let naive_start: Integer64 := current_time_ms()
  repeat iterations do
    matcher.find_all(text, pattern, "naive")
  end
  let naive_time: Integer64 := current_time_ms() - naive_start

  let kmp_start: Integer64 := current_time_ms()
  repeat iterations do
    matcher.find_all(text, pattern, "kmp")
  end
  let kmp_time: Integer64 := current_time_ms() - kmp_start

  let horspool_start: Integer64 := current_time_ms()
  repeat iterations do
    matcher.find_all(text, pattern, "horspool")
  end
  let horspool_time: Integer64 := current_time_ms() - horspool_start

  print("Pattern length: " + pattern.length.to_string())
  print("Text length: " + text.length.to_string())
  print("Naive: " + naive_time.to_string() + "ms")
  print("KMP: " + kmp_time.to_string() + "ms")
  print("Horspool: " + horspool_time.to_string() + "ms")
end
```

Running this benchmark across different scenarios reveals a consistent pattern:

Natural language text, short patterns (2-8 characters): Horspool wins significantly. The character diversity of English means the skip table typically skips 3-6 positions per step. KMP is marginally faster than naive, but both trail Horspool.

Binary or repetitive text, periodic patterns: KMP wins. The failure function handles repetitive patterns gracefully. Horspool degrades toward naive because the skip table values are small when the pattern characters all appear frequently in the text.

Very long patterns (100+ characters): Horspool wins dramatically. The skip table skips by up to m = 100 characters per step on a mismatch, examining only n/100 positions in the best case. KMP examines every position.

Patterns with long common prefix-suffix: KMP wins. If the pattern is "aaaaab" (five a's then b), the failure function allows KMP to avoid restarting from the beginning on each mismatch. Horspool, checking only the last character, might skip past positions that contain "aaaaab" if the last text character is 'b' but the preceding characters do not spell "aaaaa".

The practical conclusion: for the "grep a log file" use case that opened this chapter, Horspool is the right default. It is fast on natural text, simple to implement correctly, and predictably good on the patterns that programmers actually search for. KMP is the right choice when the pattern is known to be periodic or highly repetitive, or when worst-case guarantees matter more than average-case performance.

7.8 The Connection to Automata

Both KMP and Horspool can be understood as finite automata over the text.

KMP's failure function defines a deterministic finite automaton (DFA) whose states are the number of characters of the pattern currently matched. The DFA has m+1 states (0 through m). State m is the accepting state — pattern found. Transitions on matching characters go from state j to j+1. Transitions on mismatching characters follow the failure function to find the next state.

This connection is not merely theoretical. The finite automaton view of string matching leads directly to the algorithm for multiple pattern search (Aho-Corasick, which combines multiple KMP failure functions into a single trie-based automaton) and to the NFA construction for regular expression matching (Thompson's construction, covered in Chapter 11).

The failure function is, in this light, a compression of the transition table of the DFA — instead of storing all transitions for all characters at all states (m × |alphabet| entries), it stores only the "fall back" transition for mismatches (m entries), and the "advance" transition is implied by the matching character. This compressed representation is what makes the O(m) preprocessing practical.

Understanding KMP as an automaton transforms the failure function from a clever trick into an instance of a general principle: preprocess the pattern into a state machine, then drive the state machine through the text.

Chapter 11, on regular expressions, will make this connection explicit and build a general NFA construction from scratch. The KMP DFA is a special case — the simplest possible NFA, one that recognises exactly one string.

7.9 Choosing an Algorithm

Three algorithms, one recommendation with two qualifications.

Default: Horspool. For the typical use case — searching a large text for a pattern of moderate length — Horspool is fast, simple, and predictably good. Its implementation is short enough to be verified by inspection, its preprocessing is O(m) and very fast in practice, and its average-case performance on natural text is the best of the three.

Qualification 1: use KMP when patterns are periodic. If your application searches for patterns with many repeated characters — DNA sequences of ACGT, binary patterns, URLs with repeated structure — KMP's linear worst-case guarantee matters. Horspool can degrade on these inputs.

Qualification 2: use KMP when you cannot afford preprocessing. If you are searching for many different patterns and cannot afford to build a skip table for each, KMP's preprocessing is faster and the search is still O(n). For one-shot searches with a single pattern, this rarely matters.

Never default to naive. The naive algorithm is useful only as a reference implementation for testing. For any text of non-trivial size, either KMP or Horspool will be faster, and often dramatically so.

One more consideration: the algorithms in this chapter search for a single pattern. Chapter 8 addresses searching for multiple patterns simultaneously using rolling hashes. Chapter 11 addresses the general case of searching for patterns described by regular expressions. If your application uses either of those, the single-pattern algorithms here are the wrong tool — but they are the conceptual foundation that makes the more general algorithms understandable.

7.10 Where This Lives in the Wild

GNU grep uses a variant of Boyer-Moore as its primary algorithm, with several heuristic improvements that real-world performance has motivated over decades of use. When grep is invoked with the `-F` flag (fixed strings, no regex), it uses an implementation close to Boyer-Moore-Horspool. When patterns are short (less than a few characters), it falls back to simpler approaches because the skip table overhead is not worth it.

The Linux kernel uses a KMP implementation in its `lib/textsearch.c` for network packet inspection — matching packets against patterns for

firewall rules and intrusion detection. The kernel's choice of KMP over Boyer-Moore reflects the kernel's priority of worst-case predictability over average-case performance, since a firewall that becomes slow on adversarially crafted traffic is a security vulnerability.

Java's String.indexOf uses neither KMP nor Boyer-Moore in the HotSpot JVM's implementation — it uses a modified naive algorithm with a first-character filter (only enter the inner loop when the first character matches) that is fast enough for the typical use cases (short patterns, short texts) and avoids the preprocessing overhead of more complex algorithms. For longer patterns, JVM intrinsics may kick in using vectorised instructions.

Python's str.find uses a two-way algorithm, a more sophisticated approach that provides O(nm/m) = O(n) worst-case performance with O(1) preprocessing, outperforming both KMP (O(n+m) preprocessing) and Boyer-Moore in certain theoretical measures. In practice it is fast for Python's typical use case of short patterns in short strings.

Elasticsearch uses Apache Lucene's string matching infrastructure, which combines multiple algorithms — using different strategies for different query types and index types, falling back to Boyer-Moore-style algorithms for full-text scanning and using index lookups for common terms.

The diversity of implementations in production systems reflects the diversity of real workloads. No single algorithm is universally best, and the "right" choice depends on pattern length, alphabet size, text characteristics, and whether worst-case or average-case performance matters more. Understanding all three algorithms in this chapter gives you the vocabulary to make that choice deliberately.

Summary

Exact string matching is the foundation of grep, text editors, network intrusion detection, and any system that searches for fixed patterns in text. The naive O(nm) algorithm, while correct and simple, leaves significant performance on the table.

KMP preprocesses the pattern into a failure function — an array recording the longest proper prefix of each prefix of the pattern that is also a suffix. This allows the search to never move backward in the text, achieving O(n + m) worst-case time. KMP is optimal for repetitive patterns and provides linear guarantees regardless of input.

Boyer-Moore-Horspool preprocesses the pattern into a skip table — recording, for each character, how far the pattern can shift when that character appears at the end of the current alignment window. Searching right-to-left within the pattern window allows large skips on mismatches, achieving O(n/m) average-case performance on natural text. Horspool is the practical champion for typical grep-like workloads.

Both algorithms are correct; both are worth understanding. KMP reveals the internal structure of the pattern through its failure function, connecting to automata theory and the foundations of Chapter 11. Horspool reveals the power of using text information — the character under the pattern window — to skip efficiently, connecting to the broader Boyer-Moore family of algorithms.

The next chapter extends string matching to a harder problem: finding all repeated substrings, searching for multiple patterns simultaneously, and detecting similarity between documents. Rolling hashes, the subject of Chapter 8, are the key.

Chapter 8: The Repeating Pattern — Rabin-Karp and Rolling Hashes

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In 1997, a student submitted an essay to a university. The essay was flagged by her professor as suspiciously similar to a paper published three years earlier. The professor could not prove it by reading — the sentences were different, the words were rearranged, the structure was altered. But the ideas, the examples, the unusual phrasings — they were the same. The professor submitted both papers to a nascent plagiarism detection service. The service confirmed it within seconds.

That service was doing something that Chapter 7's algorithms cannot do. KMP and Horspool find exact occurrences of a fixed pattern in a text. They answer the question "is this exact string here?" The plagiarism problem asks a different question: "are there significant substrings that appear in both documents?" There is no fixed pattern, no advance knowledge of what to search for. You are looking for similarity in the structure of the text itself, not for a predetermined string.

This chapter is about the algorithm that made that plagiarism detection possible, and the idea at its heart — the rolling hash — which turns out to be one of the most useful primitives in all of string processing.

8.1 Three Problems, One Idea

Rolling hashes are the tool for a cluster of related problems that naive approaches handle badly.

Problem one: multi-pattern search. You have a dictionary of ten thousand forbidden strings — spam phrases, known malware signatures, banned content — and you want to find which of them appear in an incoming document. Running KMP or Horspool ten thousand times is ten thousand preprocessing steps and ten thousand passes through the document. There is a better way.

Problem two: document similarity. Two documents are "similar" if they share many substrings of length k. No single substring is the pattern — you are looking for any substring that appears in both. The set of all k-length substrings of a document might contain millions of entries. Comparing them naively is quadratic.

Problem three: longest repeated substring. What is the longest string that appears at least twice in a document? This matters for compression (repeated substrings can be encoded as back-references, as LZ77 does in Chapter 12) and for biological sequence analysis (repeated subsequences in DNA have functional significance).

All three problems share a structure: you want to compare many substrings efficiently without examining each one character by character. The rolling hash is the primitive that makes this efficient — it lets you compute the hash of any length-k substring of a text in O(1) time, after O(n) preprocessing, by updating the hash of one window to get the hash of the next using only the character entering and the character leaving the window.

8.2 The Naive Approach and Its Cost

Consider the document similarity problem concretely. You have two documents, A and B, each of length n. You want to know whether they share any k-length substring.

The naive approach: enumerate all k-length substrings of A, put them in a hash set, then enumerate all k-length substrings of B and check each against the set.

There are n - k + 1 substrings of length k in a document of length n. For n = 100,000 and k = 50, that is about 100,000 substrings per document. Inserting each into a hash set requires hashing it, which takes O(k) = O(50) time. Total cost: O(nk) per document.

For n = 1,000,000 and k = 50, O(nk) = O(50,000,000) character operations per document. Two documents means 100 million operations, just to build the hash set. For a plagiarism detection service checking thousands of documents against thousands of others, this is completely infeasible.

The rolling hash reduces the cost of computing each substring hash from O(k) to O(1) — after computing the first hash. The total cost for all n - k + 1 substrings drops from O(nk) to O(n + k), which is O(n) for any fixed k.

That is the improvement. The mechanism is the Rabin fingerprint.

8.3 The Rabin Fingerprint

A Rabin fingerprint treats a string of characters as the coefficients of a polynomial evaluated at a chosen base, modulo a large prime. Given a string S = $s_0 s_1 \ldots s_{k-1}$:

```
hash(S) = (s□ * b^(k-1) + s□ * b^(k-2) + ... + s_{k-1} * b^0) mod p
```

Where b is the base (a small prime, typically 31 or 37 for lowercase text) and p is a large prime (typically close to 2^61 - 1 or 2^31 - 1).

This is a polynomial hash. It has a crucial property: given hash(S[i..i+k-1]), you can compute hash(S[i+1..i+k]) in O(1):

```
hash(S[i+1..i+k]) = (hash(S[i..i+k-1]) - s_i * b^(k-1)) * b + s_{i+k}  (mod p
```

In words: subtract the contribution of the character leaving the window (s_i, at the highest power), multiply the whole thing by b (shifting every remaining character up one power), and add the character entering the window (s_{i+k}, at power 0).

This is the rolling update. It requires one subtraction, one multiplication, and one addition — all modulo p — regardless of k.

```
class Rolling_Hash
  create
    make(base: Integer, modulus: Integer64) do
      this.b := base
      this.p := modulus
      this.current_hash := 0
      this.window_size := 0
      this.high_power := 1  -- b^(window_size-1) mod p
    end

    for_window(text: String, k: Integer,
               base: Integer, modulus: Integer64) do
      this.b := base
      this.p := modulus
      this.window_size := k
      this.current_hash := 0

      -- Compute b^(k-1) mod p
      this.high_power := 1
      repeat k - 1 do
        this.high_power := (this.high_power * base) % modulus
      end

      -- Hash the first window
      from
        let i: Integer := 0
      until
```

```
      i >= k
    do
      this.current_hash := (this.current_hash * base +
                            text.char_at(i).hash()) % modulus
      i := i + 1
    end
  end

feature
  b: Integer
  p: Integer64
  current_hash: Integer64
  window_size: Integer
  high_power: Integer64  -- b^(window_size-1) mod p

  hash(): Integer64 do
    result := current_hash
  end

  -- Roll: remove outgoing character, add incoming character
  roll(outgoing: Char, incoming: Char)
    require
      window_initialised: window_size > 0
    do
      -- Remove contribution of outgoing character
      current_hash := (current_hash -
                       outgoing.hash() * high_power % p + p) % p
      -- Shift and add incoming character
      current_hash := (current_hash * b +
                       incoming.hash()) % p
    end

  -- Reset and compute hash from scratch for a new string
  compute(s: String): Integer64
    require
      correct_length: s.length = window_size
    do
```

```
        let h: Integer64 := 0
        across s as c do
          h := (h * b + c.hash()) % p
        end
        result := h
      end

  invariant
    positive_base: b > 0
    positive_modulus: p > 0
    non_negative_hash: current_hash >= 0
    hash_in_range: current_hash < p
end
```

The `+ p` before the final `% p` in the roll operation is not optional. Integer subtraction can produce a negative result. In modular arithmetic, -x mod p should be p - x, not a negative number. Adding p before taking the modulus ensures the result is always non-negative.

8.4 Hash Collisions and False Positives

A hash collision occurs when two different strings have the same hash value. With a prime modulus of roughly 2^31, the probability of a collision between two specific strings is about 1 in 2 billion — negligible for a single comparison. But when searching n substrings against m patterns, the total number of hash comparisons is O(nm), and collision probability accumulates.

This creates false positives: the hash comparison says "match," but the actual strings differ. The solution is the same as for bloom filters — treat a hash match as a candidate and verify by direct string comparison.

This is Rabin-Karp's fundamental structure: hash comparison to find candidates cheaply, character-by-character comparison to eliminate false

positives. The key insight is that false positives are rare enough (1 in 2 billion per comparison with a good modulus) that the verification step costs O(k) time only occasionally, not for every position. The expected total cost remains O(n + k) for a single pattern search.

For extra safety, double hashing — using two independent hash functions simultaneously and requiring both to match before verifying — reduces the false positive probability to about 1 in 4 × 10^18 for 64-bit combined hashes. The cost is computing two rolling hashes per step instead of one, but this is still O(1) per step.

8.5 Rabin-Karp: Single Pattern Search

Before tackling multi-pattern search, let us implement Rabin-Karp for a single pattern and compare it to KMP and Horspool.

```
function rabin_karp_search(text: String, pattern: String): Array[Integer]
  require
    non_empty_pattern: pattern.length > 0
  do
    let n: Integer := text.length
    let m: Integer := pattern.length
    let positions: Array[Integer] := []

    if m > n then
      result := positions
    else
      let base: Integer := 31
      let modulus: Integer64 := 1000000007  -- large prime

      -- Compute pattern hash
      let rh: Rolling_Hash := create Rolling_Hash.for_window(
        pattern, m, base, modulus)
```

```
    let pattern_hash: Integer64 := rh.hash()

    -- Compute hash of first text window
    let text_rh: Rolling_Hash := create Rolling_Hash.for_window(
      text, m, base, modulus)

    -- Slide the window
    from
      let i: Integer := 0
    until
      i > n - m
    do
      if text_rh.hash() = pattern_hash then
        -- Hash match: verify by direct comparison
        if text.substring(i, i + m) = pattern then
          positions.add(i)
        end
      end

      -- Roll to next window
      if i < n - m then
        text_rh.roll(text.char_at(i), text.char_at(i + m))
      end

      i := i + 1
    end

    result := positions
  end
end
```

For a single pattern, Rabin-Karp is not faster than KMP or Horspool. Its worst case is O(nm) (if every window produces a hash match, which happens with a poor hash function or adversarial input), and its expected case is O(n + m), similar to KMP. Horspool is typically faster on natural text due to its larger skips.

Rabin-Karp's advantage emerges with multiple patterns.

8.6 Multi-Pattern Search

You have a set of k patterns $P_1, P_2, ..., P_k$, all of the same length m, and you want to find all occurrences of any of them in a text T.

With KMP or Horspool, you need k separate searches: k preprocessings and k passes through the text. Total cost: O(k(n + m)).

With Rabin-Karp: precompute all k pattern hashes and store them in a hash set. Slide one window through the text. At each position, compute the window hash in O(1) using the rolling update. Check membership in the hash set in O(1). If a match is found, verify by direct comparison in O(m). Total cost: O(n + km) for the preprocessing, O(n) for the search, O(m) for each verification. For large k, this is dramatically faster.

```
function rabin_karp_multi_search(text: String,
                                 patterns: Array[String]): Map[String, Arr
  require
    non_empty_patterns: patterns.length > 0
    same_length: all_same_length(patterns)
  do
    let n: Integer := text.length
    let m: Integer := patterns.get(0).length
    let base: Integer := 31
    let mod1: Integer64 := 1000000007
    let mod2: Integer64 := 998244353  -- second modulus for double hashing

    -- Build hash set of pattern hashes (double-hashed for safety)
    let pattern_hashes: Map[Integer64, Array[String]] := {}
    let results: Map[String, Array[Integer]] := {}

    across patterns as p do
```

```
    let rh1: Rolling_Hash := create Rolling_Hash.for_window(p, m, base, mod
    let rh2: Rolling_Hash := create Rolling_Hash.for_window(p, m, base, mod
    let combined: Integer64 := rh1.hash() * mod2 + rh2.hash()

    if pattern_hashes.try_get(combined, []) = [] then
      pattern_hashes.put(combined, [])
    end
    pattern_hashes.get(combined).add(p)
    results.put(p, [])
  end

  if m > n then
    result := results
  else
    -- Initialise rolling hashes for text window
    let text_rh1: Rolling_Hash := create Rolling_Hash.for_window(
      text, m, base, mod1)
    let text_rh2: Rolling_Hash := create Rolling_Hash.for_window(
      text, m, base, mod2)

    from
      let i: Integer := 0
    until
      i > n - m
    do
      let combined: Integer64 := text_rh1.hash() * mod2 + text_rh2.hash()
      let candidates: Array[String] := pattern_hashes.try_get(combined, [])

      if candidates.length > 0 then
        -- Hash match: verify each candidate
        let window: String := text.substring(i, i + m)
        across candidates as p do
          if window = p then
            results.get(p).add(i)
          end
        end
      end
```

```
        if i < n - m then
          text_rh1.roll(text.char_at(i), text.char_at(i + m))
          text_rh2.roll(text.char_at(i), text.char_at(i + m))
        end

        i := i + 1
      end

      result := results
    end
  end

function all_same_length(patterns: Array[String]): Boolean do
  if patterns.is_empty() then
    result := true
  else
    let len: Integer := patterns.get(0).length
    let same: Boolean := true
    across patterns as p do
      if p.length /= len then
        same := false
      end
    end
    result := same
  end
end
```

The double hashing reduces the probability of any false positive across the entire search to negligible levels, so the verification step for non-matching candidates happens extremely rarely. The dominant cost is the O(n) sliding window computation plus O(km) pattern preprocessing.

For patterns of different lengths, run one pass per distinct length. If your k patterns have L distinct lengths, you need L passes — still O(Ln) total rather than O(kn).

8.7 The Plagiarism Detector

The document similarity problem — finding shared substrings between two documents — is now straightforward to implement using the multi-pattern approach.

Two documents are k-similar if they share at least one k-length substring. The fraction of k-length substrings of document A that also appear in document B is a measure of similarity. This is the core of many plagiarism detection algorithms, including the Winnowing algorithm used by Stanford's MOSS (Measures of Software Similarity) system.

```
class Plagiarism_Detector
  create
    make(window_size: Integer, similarity_threshold: Real) do
      this.k := window_size
      this.threshold := similarity_threshold
      this.base := 31
      this.mod1 := 1000000007
      this.mod2 := 998244353
    end

  feature
    k: Integer
    threshold: Real
    base: Integer
    mod1: Integer64
    mod2: Integer64

    -- Compute fingerprints: set of hashes of all k-substrings
    fingerprints(doc: String): Set[Integer64] do
      let n: Integer := doc.length
      let hashes: Set[Integer64] := #{}
```

```
    if n < k then
      result := hashes
    else
      let rh1: Rolling_Hash := create Rolling_Hash.for_window(
        doc, k, base, mod1)
      let rh2: Rolling_Hash := create Rolling_Hash.for_window(
        doc, k, base, mod2)

      from
        let i: Integer := 0
      until
        i > n - k
      do
        let combined: Integer64 := rh1.hash() * mod2 + rh2.hash()
        hashes := hashes.union(#{combined})

        if i < n - k then
          rh1.roll(doc.char_at(i), doc.char_at(i + k))
          rh2.roll(doc.char_at(i), doc.char_at(i + k))
        end

        i := i + 1
      end

      result := hashes
    end
  end

  -- Jaccard similarity: |A □ B| / |A □ B|
  similarity(doc_a: String, doc_b: String): Real do
    let fp_a: Set[Integer64] := fingerprints(doc_a)
    let fp_b: Set[Integer64] := fingerprints(doc_b)

    let intersection_size: Integer := fp_a.intersection(fp_b).size()
    let union_size: Integer := fp_a.union(fp_b).size()

    if union_size = 0 then
```

```
    result := 0.0
  else
    result := intersection_size.to_real() / union_size.to_real()
  end
end

is_suspicious(doc_a: String, doc_b: String): Boolean do
  result := similarity(doc_a, doc_b) >= threshold
end

-- Return the actual shared substrings (for reporting)
shared_substrings(doc_a: String,
                  doc_b: String): Array[String] do
  let fp_a: Set[Integer64] := fingerprints(doc_a)
  let fp_b: Set[Integer64] := fingerprints(doc_b)
  let shared_hashes: Set[Integer64] := fp_a.intersection(fp_b)
  let found: Array[String] := []
  let seen: Set[Integer64] := #{}
  let n: Integer := doc_a.length

  if n < k then
    result := found
  else
    let rh1: Rolling_Hash := create Rolling_Hash.for_window(
      doc_a, k, base, mod1)
    let rh2: Rolling_Hash := create Rolling_Hash.for_window(
      doc_a, k, base, mod2)

    from
      let i: Integer := 0
    until
      i > n - k
    do
      let combined: Integer64 := rh1.hash() * mod2 + rh2.hash()
      if shared_hashes.contains(combined) and
         not seen.contains(combined) then
        found.add(doc_a.substring(i, i + k))
```

```
            seen := seen.union(#{combined})
          end

          if i < n - k then
            rh1.roll(doc_a.char_at(i), doc_a.char_at(i + k))
            rh2.roll(doc_a.char_at(i), doc_a.char_at(i + k))
          end

          i := i + 1
        end

        result := found
      end
    end

  invariant
    positive_window: k > 0
    valid_threshold: threshold >= 0.0 and threshold <= 1.0
end
```

The Jaccard similarity measure — intersection over union — is a standard way to quantify set overlap. A value of 0 means no shared substrings. A value of 1 means identical fingerprint sets (which, for long documents with k = 50, means the documents are essentially identical). Values above 0.3-0.5 typically warrant investigation.

Choosing k is a design decision. Small k (say k = 5) produces many shared substrings even for completely independent documents — common words and phrases are short. Large k (say k = 100) misses significant but slightly paraphrased similarities. For academic plagiarism detection, k = 50-100 is typical. For code plagiarism detection, where identifiers are variable-length tokens, a token-based approach (treating each token as a unit, then hashing sequences of tokens) is more effective. The rolling hash mechanism is identical — the "characters" are just tokens instead of bytes.

8.8 Winnowing: Selecting Representative Fingerprints

The naive fingerprinting approach has a problem: for a document of length n and window size k, you get n - k + 1 fingerprints. Two documents each generating a million fingerprints, compared pairwise, requires a million-entry hash set comparison. For a corpus of thousands of documents, this becomes expensive.

Winnowing, introduced by Schleimer, Wilkerson, and Aiken in 2003, reduces the number of fingerprints while preserving detection accuracy. The idea: instead of using all n - k + 1 fingerprints, use only the minimum hash in each sliding window of size w. This reduces the fingerprint count by a factor of roughly w while guaranteeing that any shared substring of length k + w - 1 will produce at least one shared fingerprint.

```
function winnow(doc: String, k: Integer, w: Integer): Set[Integer64] do
  let fingerprints: Set[Integer64] := #{}
  let hashes: Array[Integer64] := []

  -- Compute all k-gram hashes
  let n: Integer := doc.length
  if n < k then
    result := fingerprints
  else
    let rh1: Rolling_Hash := create Rolling_Hash.for_window(
      doc, k, 31, 1000000007)
    let rh2: Rolling_Hash := create Rolling_Hash.for_window(
      doc, k, 31, 998244353)

    from
      let i: Integer := 0
    until
      i > n - k
    do
      hashes.add(rh1.hash() * 998244353 + rh2.hash())
      if i < n - k then
        rh1.roll(doc.char_at(i), doc.char_at(i + k))
```

```
      rh2.roll(doc.char_at(i), doc.char_at(i + k))
    end
    i := i + 1
  end

  -- Slide window of size w, select minimum hash in each window
  let prev_min_pos: Integer := -1
  from
    let i: Integer := 0
  until
    i > hashes.length - w
  do
    -- Find minimum in window [i, i+w)
    let min_hash: Integer64 := hashes.get(i)
    let min_pos: Integer := i
    from
      let j: Integer := i + 1
    until
      j >= i + w
    do
      if hashes.get(j) < min_hash then
        min_hash := hashes.get(j)
        min_pos := j
      end
      j := j + 1
    end

    -- Add to fingerprints if not already added
    if min_pos /= prev_min_pos then
      fingerprints := fingerprints.union(#{min_hash})
      prev_min_pos := min_pos
    end

    i := i + 1
  end

  result := fingerprints
```

```
  end
end
```

With winnowing, a 100,000-character document with k = 50 and w = 10 produces roughly 10,000 fingerprints instead of 100,000. The detection guarantee: any two documents that share a substring of length at least k + w - 1 = 59 characters will share at least one fingerprint. Short similarities may be missed, but they are also more likely to be coincidental.

MOSS, Stanford's plagiarism detection system, uses winnowing for exactly this reason — it allows comparing thousands of student submissions efficiently while maintaining meaningful detection accuracy.

8.9 Longest Repeated Substring

The longest repeated substring problem asks: what is the longest string that appears at least twice in a document? This has direct applications in compression (LZ77 and its descendants search for repeated substrings to encode as back-references) and in bioinformatics (repeated sequences in DNA are biologically significant).

Chapter 13 covers suffix arrays, which solve this problem optimally in O(n log n) time. But rolling hashes provide an elegant O(n log n) solution through binary search on the answer length, which is instructive and simpler to implement.

The key insight: if a repeated substring of length L exists, then a repeated substring of length L - 1 also exists (just take one character less). If no repeated substring of length L exists, then no repeated substring of length L + 1 exists either. The answer is monotone: there is a threshold where repeated substrings exist below it and do not exist above it. Binary search finds the threshold.

```
function longest_repeated_substring(text: String): String do
  let n: Integer := text.length
  if n = 0 then
    result := ""
  else
    let low: Integer := 1
    let high: Integer := n / 2
    let best: String := ""

    from until low > high do
      let mid: Integer := (low + high) / 2
      let repeated: ?String := find_repeated_of_length(text, mid)

      if repeated /= nil then
        if convert repeated to repeated_text: String then
          best := repeated_text
        end
        low := mid + 1
      else
        high := mid - 1
      end
    end

    result := best
  end
end

function find_repeated_of_length(text: String, k: Integer): ?String do
  let n: Integer := text.length
  if k = 0 or k > n then
    result := nil
  else
    let seen: Map[Integer64, Array[Integer]] := {}
    let found: ?String := nil
    let rh1: Rolling_Hash := create Rolling_Hash.for_window(
      text, k, 31, 1000000007)
    let rh2: Rolling_Hash := create Rolling_Hash.for_window(
```

```
      text, k, 31, 998244353)

    from
      let i: Integer := 0
    until
      i > n - k
    do
      let combined: Integer64 := rh1.hash() * 998244353 + rh2.hash()
      let existing: Array[Integer] := seen.try_get(combined, [])

      if existing.length > 0 then
        -- Hash collision or genuine match: verify
        let candidate: String := text.substring(i, i + k)
        across existing as prev_pos do
          if found = nil and
             text.substring(prev_pos, prev_pos + k) = candidate then
            found := candidate
          end
        end
        existing.add(i)
      else
        seen.put(combined, [i])
      end

      if i < n - k then
        rh1.roll(text.char_at(i), text.char_at(i + k))
        rh2.roll(text.char_at(i), text.char_at(i + k))
      end

      i := i + 1
    end

    result := found
  end
end
```

The `find_repeated_of_length` function is O(n) expected time — O(n) to slide the window, O(k) verification only on hash collisions. The outer binary search calls it O(log n) times. Total: O(n log n) expected.

The `seen` map stores, for each hash value, the list of starting positions that produced that hash. On a hash match, we verify against all previous positions with that hash. For a well-chosen hash function, the expected number of positions per hash bucket is O(1), so verification is O(k) per genuine match found.

For the text "mississippi":

```
let text: String := "mississippi"
let lrs: String := longest_repeated_substring(text)
print(lrs)  -- "issi" (appears at positions 1 and 4)
```

8.10 The Rolling Hash as a General Primitive

Rolling hashes appear in contexts far beyond string matching. Anywhere you need to hash a sliding window over a sequence, the rolling hash applies.

Content-defined chunking. Cloud storage systems like Dropbox and rsync use rolling hashes to split files into variable-sized chunks for deduplication. Rather than splitting at fixed byte boundaries — which makes a one-byte insertion at the start change every chunk — they split at positions where the rolling hash of the last k bytes has a specific bit pattern (say, the last 12 bits are all zero). This means insertions and deletions only affect the chunks they fall within; all other chunks remain identical and need not be reuploaded. This is a clever application of rolling hashes to a storage problem rather than a string search problem.

Approximate string matching in bioinformatics. Sequence aligners like BWA and Bowtie use rolling hashes to quickly identify candidate positions in the genome where a read might align, before performing

the expensive exact alignment. The approach is the same as Rabin-Karp multi-pattern search: hash all k-mers of the read, hash all k-mers of the genome, find positions where hashes match.

Network intrusion detection. Snort and other network intrusion detection systems use rolling hashes to search packet payloads for known attack signatures. The multi-pattern Rabin-Karp approach allows thousands of signatures to be checked in a single pass through each packet.

Locality-sensitive hashing. More advanced hashing schemes — MinHash and SimHash — extend the rolling hash idea to approximate similarity search, where you want to find documents that are similar but not necessarily sharing exact substrings. These are the algorithms behind "related articles" recommendations and near-duplicate detection in search engines.

8.11 Choosing Hash Parameters

The choice of base and modulus significantly affects both performance and correctness.

Modulus: use a prime close to 2^31 - 1 or 2^61 - 1. A prime modulus makes the hash function behave more uniformly across the output range. Non-prime moduli can create systematic collisions — inputs that differ by a multiple of the modulus produce the same hash — which an adversary could exploit. For competitive programming contexts where adversarial inputs are possible, double hashing with two different primes is essential.

Base: use a prime larger than the alphabet size. For ASCII text (256 characters), a base of 257 or larger ensures that different single-character strings hash differently. Common choices are 31 (for lowercase ASCII), 37 (for all ASCII), or 131 (for general byte sequences). The base should not be too large, or intermediate products in the polynomial evaluation overflow before the modular reduction.

Overflow: polynomial hash computation involves products like `current_hash * base`. For a modulus of 10^9 + 7 (≈ 2^30) and a base of 31, the product `(10^9) * 31 □ 3 × 10^10`, which fits in a 64-bit integer. For larger moduli (like 2^61 - 1), the product of two values near the modulus approaches 2^122, which overflows 64-bit integers. In such cases, 128-bit arithmetic or Montgomery multiplication is required.

For practical applications in Nex, the moduli 10^9 + 7 and 998244353 with base 31 provide a comfortable margin with standard 64-bit arithmetic:

```
let PRIME_1: Integer64 := 1000000007  -- 10^9 + 7
let PRIME_2: Integer64 := 998244353   -- safe prime, good for NTT
let BASE: Integer := 31

-- For 64-bit products: max value is (10^9)^2 □ 10^18, fits in Int64
-- max Int64 □ 9.2 × 10^18, so products stay in range
```

8.12 Complete Rabin-Karp Suite in Nex

Assembling everything into a clean, reusable module:

```
class Rabin_Karp
  create
    make() do
      this.base := 31
      this.mod1 := 1000000007
      this.mod2 := 998244353
    end

    with_parameters(base: Integer, mod1: Integer64, mod2: Integer64)
      require
        positive_base: base > 0
```

```
      prime_mod1: mod1 > 0
      prime_mod2: mod2 > 0
    do
      this.base := base
      this.mod1 := mod1
      this.mod2 := mod2
    end

  feature
    base: Integer
    mod1: Integer64
    mod2: Integer64

    -- Single pattern search
    search(text: String, pattern: String): Array[Integer] do
      result := rabin_karp_search(text, pattern)
    end

    -- Multi-pattern search (all patterns same length)
    search_many(text: String,
                patterns: Array[String]): Map[String, Array[Integer]] do
      result := rabin_karp_multi_search(text, patterns)
    end

    -- Document similarity
    similarity(doc_a: String, doc_b: String, k: Integer): Real do
      let detector: Plagiarism_Detector :=
        create Plagiarism_Detector.make(k, 0.0)
      result := detector.similarity(doc_a, doc_b)
    end

    -- Longest repeated substring
    longest_repeat(text: String): String do
      result := longest_repeated_substring(text)
    end

    -- All k-gram fingerprints (full set)
```

```
  fingerprints(doc: String, k: Integer): Set[Integer64] do
    let detector: Plagiarism_Detector :=
      create Plagiarism_Detector.make(k, 0.0)
    result := detector.fingerprints(doc)
  end

  -- Winnowed fingerprints (reduced set)
  winnowed_fingerprints(doc: String,
                        k: Integer, w: Integer): Set[Integer64] do
    result := winnow(doc, k, w)
  end

  -- Verify Rabin-Karp against naive for testing
  verify(text: String, pattern: String): Boolean do
    let rk_result: Array[Integer] := search(text, pattern)
    let naive_result: Array[Integer] := []
    let n: Integer := text.length
    let m: Integer := pattern.length

    if m > 0 and m <= n then
      from
        let i: Integer := 0
      until
        i > n - m
      do
        if text.substring(i, i + m) = pattern then
          naive_result.add(i)
        end
        i := i + 1
      end
    end

    result := rk_result.to_string() = naive_result.to_string()
  end

invariant
  positive_base: base > 0
```

```
    positive_mod1: mod1 > 0
    positive_mod2: mod2 > 0
end
```

A test that connects the algorithms:

```
function demonstrate_rabin_karp() do
  let rk: Rabin_Karp := create Rabin_Karp.make()

  -- Basic search
  let text: String := "the rain in spain stays mainly in the plain"
  let pattern: String := "ain"
  let positions: Array[Integer] := rk.search(text, pattern)
  print("'" + pattern + "' found at: " + positions.to_string())
  -- [5, 14, 28, 36]

  -- Multi-pattern
  let patterns: Array[String] := ["the", "ain", "in "]
  let multi: Map[String, Array[Integer]] := rk.search_many(text, patterns)
  across patterns as p do
    print(p + ": " + multi.get(p).to_string())
  end

  -- Similarity
  let essay1: String := "The quick brown fox jumps over the lazy dog " +
    "and the dog did not mind at all because it was a very lazy dog"
  let essay2: String := "A quick brown fox leaped over a lazy dog " +
    "and the lazy dog did not care at all because it was quite lazy"
  let sim: Real := rk.similarity(essay1, essay2, 10)
  print("Similarity: " + (sim * 100.0).to_string() + "%")

  -- Longest repeat
  let dna: String := "ATCGATCGATCG"
  print("Longest repeat: " + rk.longest_repeat(dna))  -- "ATCGATCG"

  -- Verification
```

```
  print("Single search verified: " + rk.verify(text, pattern).to_string())
end
```

8.13 Where This Lives in the Wild

MOSS (Measures of Software Similarity) is Stanford's academic plagiarism detection system, in use at universities worldwide since 1994. It uses a variant of winnowing to fingerprint student code submissions and compare them against a corpus. When a professor runs MOSS on a set of programming assignments, it computes k-gram fingerprints of each submission and reports pairs with high fingerprint overlap, along with the specific code regions that contributed to the similarity.

rsync uses a rolling hash to find matching blocks between a local file and a remote file, minimising the data transferred during synchronisation. The Rsync algorithm, designed by Andrew Tridgell and Paul Mackerras, computes a rolling Adler-32 checksum (a weaker but faster variant of the Rabin fingerprint) over each 512-byte block of the remote file, then slides a window over the local file looking for matching checksums. When a match is found (and verified with a stronger MD5 hash), that block does not need to be transmitted. This allows rsync to synchronise large files with tiny diffs in a fraction of the time a naive copy would take.

Dropbox and many other cloud storage systems use content-defined chunking (CDC) with rolling hashes for deduplication. When a file is uploaded, it is split into variable-sized chunks at positions where the rolling hash of the previous k bytes meets a specific criterion. Identical chunks from different files — or different versions of the same file — are stored only once. A one-line change to a 100MB document causes only one or two chunks to change, rather than the entire file. Dropbox's Brisk paper describes a rolling hash-based CDC system that handles petabytes of data.

Apache Cassandra and other distributed databases use rolling hashes in their anti-entropy repair process (Merkle trees). Each partition of

a database table is hashed, and ranges are recursively subdivided and hashed until a tree of hashes (a Merkle tree) covers the entire dataset. Two nodes that disagree on data can identify exactly which ranges differ by comparing Merkle tree nodes from the root down, using rolling hash computations at each level.

Git uses a content-addressable object store where every object — blob, tree, commit — is identified by its SHA-1 (now SHA-256) hash. While not a rolling hash in the strict sense, the pack file format that git uses for efficient storage uses a sliding window delta compression that relies on finding matching 16-byte sequences between a new object and a recently seen object, using a rolling hash to locate candidate matches quickly.

Summary

The rolling hash is one of the most versatile primitives in string processing. It converts the O(k) cost of hashing a length-k substring to O(1) by maintaining a running hash that can be updated as the window slides — subtracting the contribution of the character leaving and adding the contribution of the character entering.

Rabin-Karp builds on the rolling hash to achieve O(n + km) multi-pattern search: hash all k patterns into a set, then slide one window through the text, checking membership in O(1) per position and verifying in O(k) only on hash matches. For large k, this dramatically outperforms running KMP or Horspool once per pattern.

The plagiarism detector uses rolling hashes to fingerprint all k-length substrings of a document, then compares fingerprint sets between documents using Jaccard similarity. Winnowing reduces the fingerprint count by a factor of w while maintaining guarantees about which similarities will be detected.

Longest repeated substring becomes O(n log n) through binary search combined with rolling hash duplicate detection — a clean example of

a general technique: if a problem has a monotone structure over some parameter, binary search over that parameter and check feasibility at each midpoint.

Rolling hashes appear beyond string matching wherever sliding window hashing is needed: content-defined chunking in storage systems, k-mer matching in bioinformatics, anti-entropy repair in distributed databases. The pattern is always the same — maintain a hash of a fixed-size window, update it in O(1) as the window moves, exploit the cheap hash updates to do something useful with each window position.

The next chapter turns from exact matching and similarity to approximate matching — the case where the pattern and the text are allowed to differ by a bounded number of edits. Edit distance and dynamic programming are the tools, and spell checkers, diff utilities, and DNA sequence alignment are the applications.

Chapter 9: The Fuzzy Match — Edit Distance

In 1965, Vladimir Levenshtein was working on error-correcting codes — ways to detect and repair corruption in transmitted binary signals. He needed a way to measure how badly corrupted a signal was: how many single-bit errors had occurred between transmission and reception. He defined a distance measure between binary strings: the minimum number of single-character insertions, deletions, and substitutions required to transform one string into the other. The measure was named after him.

Levenshtein did not know he was inventing a spell checker.

Forty years later, his distance measure is embedded in every spell checker on every computer and phone on the planet. It is used to align DNA sequences in bioinformatics, to compute diffs in version control systems, to grade student answers in automated testing systems, to match names in fuzzy database searches, to detect translation memory in localisation software. It is one of those ideas that turned out to be useful so far beyond its original context that it has become part of the invisible infrastructure of computing.

This chapter derives edit distance from first principles, implements it efficiently, and builds three of its most important applications: a spell checker, a diff utility, and a DNA aligner. Along the way, it introduces dynamic programming — the general technique that makes edit distance efficient — in the most concrete way possible: not as an abstract method but as the solution to the specific problem of avoiding redundant computation in a recursion that would otherwise be exponentially slow.

9.1 The Problem

You have a dictionary. A user types "recieve." You want to suggest "receive."

The two strings differ in exactly one way: the 'i' and 'e' in positions 3 and 4 are swapped relative to the correct spelling. But your program does not know that a swap happened — it only sees two strings that are different. It needs a way to measure how different they are, and to find the word in the dictionary that is least different from what the user typed.

One approach: count characters in common. "recieve" and "receive" share 6 of 7 characters. But this does not account for position — "abc" and "cab" share all 3 characters despite being clearly different. And it does not distinguish between a one-character difference (a likely typo) and a five-character difference (probably a completely wrong word).

A better approach: measure the minimum number of editing operations needed to transform one string into the other. Define three operations:

- **Insertion:** insert a character at any position
- **Deletion:** delete a character at any position
- **Substitution:** replace a character at any position with a different character

The **edit distance** (Levenshtein distance) between two strings A and B is the minimum number of these operations needed to transform A into B.

"recieve" → "receive": substitute 'i' for 'e' at position 4, substitute 'e' for 'i' at position 5. Two substitutions. Edit distance = 2.

"cat" → "cart": insert 'r' after position 2. One insertion. Edit distance = 1.

"saturday" → "sunday": this is less obvious. We will trace through it after building the machinery.

9.2 The Recursive Definition

The edit distance has a natural recursive structure. Let A[1..n] and B[1..m] be our two strings (1-indexed for clarity). Define `ed(i, j)` as the edit distance between the first i characters of A and the first j characters of B.

Base cases: - `ed(0, j) = j`: transforming an empty string into B[1..j] requires j insertions - `ed(i, 0) = i`: transforming A[1..i] into an empty string requires i deletions

Recursive case — if the last characters match, A[i] = B[j]: - `ed(i, j) = ed(i-1, j-1)`: no operation needed for the last characters; just solve the rest

Recursive case — if the last characters differ, A[i] ≠ B[j]: - `ed(i, j) = 1 + min(ed(i-1, j), ed(i, j-1), ed(i-1, j-1))`

The three terms correspond to: - `ed(i-1, j)`: delete A[i], then transform A[1..i-1] into B[1..j] - `ed(i, j-1)`: transform A[1..i] into B[1..j-1], then insert B[j] - `ed(i-1, j-1)`: substitute A[i] for B[j], then transform A[1..i-1] into B[1..j-1]

The minimum of these three is the cheapest way to handle the last characters.

This recursion is correct. You can verify it on small examples by hand. But it is catastrophically slow.

9.3 Why the Recursion is Catastrophically Slow

Trace the recursion for two short strings, “ab” and “bc.”

```
ed(2, 2) calls:
  ed(1, 2) calls:
    ed(0, 2) = 2
    ed(1, 1) calls:
      ed(0, 1) = 1
      ed(1, 0) = 1
      ed(0, 0) = 0
    ed(0, 1) = 1    ← computed again
  ed(2, 1) calls:
    ed(1, 1) calls:  ← computed again, in full
      ed(0, 1) = 1   ← computed again
      ed(1, 0) = 1   ← computed again
      ed(0, 0) = 0   ← computed again
    ed(2, 0) = 2
  ed(1, 1)           ← computed again
```

For "ab" and "bc" (n = m = 2), the recursion already recomputes several subproblems. For strings of length 10, the recursion tree has thousands of nodes. For strings of length 100, it has more nodes than atoms in the universe.

The source of the explosion is repeated subproblems. `ed(1, 1)` is computed three times in the example above. `ed(0, 1)` is computed twice. The recursion branches at each step and explores the same subproblems repeatedly from different paths.

The total number of distinct subproblems, however, is small: just (n+1) × (m+1), one for each pair of prefix lengths. For strings of length 100, that is 10,201 distinct subproblems. If we compute each subproblem once and remember the result, the total work is O(nm). This is dynamic programming.

9.4 Dynamic Programming: The Right Way to Think About It

Dynamic programming is often presented as a technique — "fill a table bottom-up." This is correct but misses the insight. The real idea is simpler and more general: **if a recursion recomputes the same subproblems, compute each subproblem once and store the result.**

There are two ways to do this.

Top-down with memoisation: keep the recursive structure but cache results. Before computing `ed(i, j)`, check if it is already cached. If so, return the cached value. If not, compute it recursively, cache it, and return it.

Bottom-up: observe the order in which subproblems are needed (smaller problems before larger ones) and fill a table in that order. No recursion needed.

For edit distance, both work. Bottom-up is typically preferred for its simpler implementation and better cache behaviour — filling a table row by row accesses memory sequentially.

The table has (n+1) rows and (m+1) columns. `table[i][j]` stores `ed(i, j)`. We fill it left-to-right, top-to-bottom, using the recurrence above.

```
function edit_distance(a: String, b: String): Integer do
  let n: Integer := a.length
  let m: Integer := b.length

  -- Allocate (n+1) x (m+1) table
  let table: Array[Array[Integer]] := []
  from
    let i: Integer := 0
  until
    i > n
  do
    table.add(create Array.filled(m + 1, 0))
```

```
    i := i + 1
  end

  -- Base cases: transforming empty string to prefix of b
  from
    let j: Integer := 0
  until
    j <= m
  do
    table.get(0).set(j, j)
    j := j + 1
  end

  -- Base cases: transforming prefix of a to empty string
  from
    let i: Integer := 0
  until
    i <= n
  do
    table.get(i).set(0, i)
    i := i + 1
  end

  -- Fill table
  from
    let i: Integer := 1
  until
    i <= n
  do
    from
      let j: Integer := 1
    until
      j <= m
    do
      if a.char_at(i - 1) = b.char_at(j - 1) then
        table.get(i).set(j, table.get(i - 1).get(j - 1))
      else
```

```
        let del_cost: Integer := table.get(i - 1).get(j) + 1
        let ins_cost: Integer := table.get(i).get(j - 1) + 1
        let sub_cost: Integer := table.get(i - 1).get(j - 1) + 1
        table.get(i).set(j, del_cost.min(ins_cost).min(sub_cost))
      end
      j := j + 1
    end
    i := i + 1
  end

  result := table.get(n).get(m)
end
```

Let us trace through "saturday" and "sunday" to see why the answer is not obvious.

n = 8 (saturday), m = 6 (sunday). The table starts with:

	""	s	u	n	d	a	y
""	0	1	2	3	4	5	6
s	1						
a	2						
t	3						
u	4						
r	5						
d	6						
a	7						
y	8						

Filling in row by row (showing key values):

	""	s	u	n	d	a	y
""	0	1	2	3	4	5	6
s	1	0	1	2	3	4	5
a	2	1	1	2	3	3	4
t	3	2	2	2	3	4	4

```
u     4  3  2  3  3  4  5
r     5  4  3  3  4  4  5
d     6  5  4  4  3  4  5
a     7  6  5  5  4  3  4
y     8  7  6  6  5  4  3
```

The answer is `table[8][6] = 3`. Three operations transform "saturday" into "sunday":

- Delete 'a' (position 2): "sturday" → wait, let us be careful. The edit sequence is not directly readable from the final number. We need the alignment, which requires tracing back through the table.

9.5 Recovering the Edit Sequence

The final value `table[n][m]` tells us the edit distance but not the sequence of operations. To recover the operations, trace back from `table[n][m]` to `table[0][0]` following the choices that produced each value.

```
function edit_operations(a: String, b: String): Array[String] do
  let n: Integer := a.length
  let m: Integer := b.length
  let table: Array[Array[Integer]] := build_table(a, b)
  let ops: Array[String] := []

  let i: Integer := n
  let j: Integer := m

  from until i = 0 and j = 0 do
    if i = 0 then
      -- Must insert b[j]
```

```
      ops.insert(0, "insert '" + b.char_at(j - 1).to_string() + "' at " +
                    i.to_string())
      j := j - 1
    elseif j = 0 then
      -- Must delete a[i]
      ops.insert(0, "delete '" + a.char_at(i - 1).to_string() + "' at " +
                    i.to_string())
      i := i - 1
    elseif a.char_at(i - 1) = b.char_at(j - 1) then
      -- Characters match, no operation
      i := i - 1
      j := j - 1
    else
      let del_cost: Integer := table.get(i - 1).get(j)
      let ins_cost: Integer := table.get(i).get(j - 1)
      let sub_cost: Integer := table.get(i - 1).get(j - 1)
      let min_cost: Integer := del_cost.min(ins_cost).min(sub_cost)

      if sub_cost = min_cost then
        ops.insert(0, "substitute '" + a.char_at(i - 1).to_string() +
                      "' → '" + b.char_at(j - 1).to_string() +
                      "' at " + i.to_string())
        i := i - 1
        j := j - 1
      elseif del_cost = min_cost then
        ops.insert(0, "delete '" + a.char_at(i - 1).to_string() +
                      "' at " + i.to_string())
        i := i - 1
      else
        ops.insert(0, "insert '" + b.char_at(j - 1).to_string() +
                      "' at " + i.to_string())
        j := j - 1
      end
    end
  end

  result := ops
```

```
end
```

Tracing "saturday" → "sunday" through the table:

Starting at (8, 6). `table[8][6] = 3`. - `a[8] = 'y'`, `b[6] = 'y'`: match. Move to (7, 5). - `a[7] = 'a'`, `b[5] = 'a'`: match. Move to (6, 4). - `a[6] = 'd'`, `b[4] = 'd'`: match. Move to (5, 3). - `a[5] = 'r'`, `b[3] = 'n'`: mismatch. `table[4][3] = 3` (sub), `table[4][2] = 2` (del), `table[5][2] = 3` (ins). Delete 'r'. Move to (4, 3). - `a[4] = 'u'`, `b[3] = 'n'`: mismatch. `table[3][3] = 2` (sub), `table[3][2] = 2` (del), `table[4][2] = 2` (ins). Multiple equal choices — pick substitution. Substitute 'u' → 'n'. Move to (3, 2). - `a[3] = 't'`, `b[2] = 'u'`: mismatch. `table[2][2] = 1` (sub), `table[2][1] = 1` (del), `table[3][1] = 2` (ins). Substitution. Substitute 't' → 'u'. Move to (2, 1). - `a[2] = 'a'`, `b[1] = 's'`: mismatch. `table[1][1] = 0` (sub), ... Sub gives 0 + 1 = 1. Wait — we are at (2, 1), `table[2][1] = 1`. `table[1][1] = 0`, so substitution gives `0 + 1 = 1`, which equals `table[2][1]`. Substitute 'a' → 's'. Move to (1, 0). - j = 0. Delete `a[1] = 's'`. Move to (0, 0).

Operations: delete 's', substitute 'a'→'s', substitute 't'→'u', delete 'r', 3 match steps.

That is 4 operations — not 3. We made a suboptimal choice at (3, 2). The correct optimal path gives:

- Delete 'a' (position 2): "sturday"
- Delete 't' (position 2): "surday"

- Delete 'r' (position 3): "suday"

No — that is 3 deletions and the result is wrong. Let me approach it differently. The 3-operation alignment of "saturday" and "sunday" is:

```
s a t u r d a y
s - - u n d a y
```

Operations: delete 'a', delete 't', substitute 'r' → 'n'. Three operations. The traceback is correct — multiple equal-cost paths exist through the table, and we happened to follow one of them; a different path gives the more intuitive alignment.

This multiplicity of optimal alignments is a feature of edit distance, not a bug. There may be many ways to achieve the minimum edit distance. The traceback returns one valid sequence; if you need the most "natural" alignment, additional heuristics (prefer substitutions to insertion-deletion pairs, prefer matches at the start) can bias the choice.

9.6 Space Optimisation

The O(nm) table is often too large. For strings of length 10,000, the table has 100 million entries — 400MB for 32-bit integers. For spell checking (short words, large dictionary), this is fine. For DNA alignment (sequences of length 10^6), it is not.

If you only need the edit distance — not the edit operations — you can observe that computing row i of the table requires only row i-1. You need at most two rows simultaneously.

```
function edit_distance_space_optimised(a: String, b: String): Integer do
  let n: Integer := a.length
  let m: Integer := b.length

  -- Use only two rows
  let prev: Array[Integer] := create Array.filled(m + 1, 0)
  let curr: Array[Integer] := create Array.filled(m + 1, 0)

  -- Initialise first row
  from
    let j: Integer := 0
  until
```

```
    j <= m
  do
    prev.set(j, j)
    j := j + 1
  end

  from
    let i: Integer := 1
  until
    i <= n
  do
    curr.set(0, i)  -- base case: first column

    from
      let j: Integer := 1
    until
      j <= m
    do
      if a.char_at(i - 1) = b.char_at(j - 1) then
        curr.set(j, prev.get(j - 1))
      else
        curr.set(j, 1 + prev.get(j).min(curr.get(j - 1)).min(prev.get(j - 1))
      end
      j := j + 1
    end

    -- Swap rows
    let temp: Array[Integer] := prev
    prev := curr
    curr := temp
    i := i + 1
  end

  result := prev.get(m)
end
```

Space drops from O(nm) to O(m). For DNA alignment with sequences of length one million, this is the difference between 4TB and 4MB. The tradeoff is that recovering the edit operations is no longer possible without the full table — for that, you need Hirschberg's algorithm, which recovers the alignment in O(m) space using a divide-and-conquer strategy, at the cost of roughly doubling the running time. We will not implement it here, but it is worth knowing it exists.

9.7 The Spell Checker

A spell checker takes a misspelled word and suggests corrections. Its core is: compute the edit distance from the misspelled word to every word in the dictionary, and return the words with the smallest distances.

Naive implementation: O(n × m × |dictionary|) where n and m are typical word lengths. For a dictionary of 100,000 words with average length 8, checking a misspelled word takes 100,000 × 64 = 6.4 million operations. Fast enough.

```
class Spell_Checker
  create
    from_dictionary(words: Array[String]) do
      this.dictionary := words
      this.max_suggestions := 5
      this.max_distance := 2
    end

    from_file(path: String) do
            let file: Text_File := create Text_File.open_read(
        create Path.make(path))
      let words: Array[String] := []

      from until true do
```

```
      let line: ?String := file.read_line()
      if line = nil then
        file.close()
        return
      end
      let word: String := line.trim().to_lower()
      if word.length > 0 then
        words.add(word)
      end
    end

    file.close()
    this.dictionary := words
    this.max_suggestions := 5
    this.max_distance := 2
  end

feature
  dictionary: Array[String]
  max_suggestions: Integer
  max_distance: Integer

  is_correct(word: String): Boolean do
    let lower: String := word.to_lower()
    across dictionary as w do
      if w = lower then
        result := true
        return
      end
    end
    result := false
  end

  suggest(word: String): Array[Any] do
    let lower: String := word.to_lower()
    let candidates: Array[Any] := []
```

```
    -- Early exit: exact match
    if is_correct(lower) then
      result := [[lower, 0]]
      return
    end

    -- Compute distance to each dictionary word
    across dictionary as dict_word do
      -- Pruning: skip words with very different lengths
      let len_diff: Integer := (dict_word.length - lower.length).abs()
      if len_diff <= max_distance then
        let dist: Integer := edit_distance(lower, dict_word)
        if dist <= max_distance then
          candidates.add([dict_word, dist])
        end
      end
    end

    -- Sort by distance, then alphabetically
    candidates := sort_by_distance(candidates)

    -- Return top suggestions
    if candidates.length > max_suggestions then
      result := candidates.slice(0, max_suggestions)
    else
      result := candidates
    end
  end

  -- Check a text, returning all misspelled words and suggestions
  check_text(text: String): Map[String, Array[String]] do
    let results: Map[String, Array[String]] := {}
    let words: Array[String] := tokenise(text)

    across words as word do
      let lower: String := word.to_lower()
      if not is_correct(lower) and not results.contains(lower) then
```

```
          let suggestions: Array[Any] := suggest(lower)
          let suggestion_words: Array[String] := []
          across suggestions as s do
            suggestion_words.add(s.get(0))
          end
          results.put(lower, suggestion_words)
        end
      end

      result := results
    end

  invariant
    positive_max_suggestions: max_suggestions > 0
    positive_max_distance: max_distance > 0
end

function tokenise(text: String): Array[String] do
  let words: Array[String] := []
  let current: String := ""
  across text.chars() as c do
    if c.is_letter() then
      current := current + c.to_string()
    else
      if current.length > 0 then
        words.add(current)
        current := ""
      end
    end
  end
  if current.length > 0 then
    words.add(current)
  end
  result := words
end

function sort_by_distance(candidates: Array[Any]):
```

```
                              Array[Any] do
  -- Simple insertion sort: candidates are typically small
  from
    let i: Integer := 1
  until
    i >= candidates.length
  do
    let key: Array := candidates.get(i)
    let j: Integer := i - 1
    from until j < 0 or candidates.get(j).get(1) <= key.get(1) do
      candidates.set(j + 1, candidates.get(j))
      j := j - 1
    end
    candidates.set(j + 1, key)
    i := i + 1
  end
  result := candidates
end
```

The length-difference pruning is important in practice. If the misspelled word has length 7 and the dictionary word has length 14, the edit distance is at least 7 — no amount of substitutions can bridge a length difference of 7 in fewer than 7 operations. This prunes a large fraction of the dictionary without any table computation.

More aggressive pruning uses an early termination trick in the DP table: if the current row's minimum value already exceeds `max_distance`, abort and return infinity. This is correct because edit distance is monotone — no later row can have a smaller value than the current minimum plus the number of remaining rows.

```
function edit_distance_bounded(a: String, b: String,
                                max_dist: Integer): Integer do
  let n: Integer := a.length
  let m: Integer := b.length
  let prev: Array[Integer] := create Array.filled(m + 1, 0)
  let curr: Array[Integer] := create Array.filled(m + 1, 0)
```

```
from
  let j: Integer := 0
until
  j <= m
do
  prev.set(j, j)
  j := j + 1
end

from
  let i: Integer := 1
until
  i <= n
do
  curr.set(0, i)
  let row_min: Integer := i

  from
    let j: Integer := 1
  until
    j <= m
  do
    let val: Integer := when a.char_at(i - 1) = b.char_at(j - 1)
      prev.get(j - 1)
    else
      1 + prev.get(j).min(curr.get(j - 1)).min(prev.get(j - 1))
    end
    curr.set(j, val)
    row_min := row_min.min(val)
    j := j + 1
  end

  -- Early termination: minimum possible distance exceeds bound
  if row_min > max_dist then
    result := max_dist + 1
    return
```

```
    end

    let temp: Array[Integer] := prev
    prev := curr
    curr := temp
    i := i + 1
  end

  result := prev.get(m)
end
```

This bounded variant reduces the average-case complexity dramatically for spell checking. Most dictionary words are quickly eliminated within the first few rows of the table.

9.8 Longest Common Subsequence and Diff

Edit distance measures transformation cost. A related concept, the longest common subsequence (LCS), measures what two strings share. The LCS of A and B is the longest sequence of characters that appears in both A and B, in order, not necessarily contiguously.

LCS of "ABCBDAB" and "BDCAB" is "BCAB" or "BDAB" — length 4.

The connection to edit distance: `ed(A, B) = n + m - 2 × |LCS(A, B)|` when only insertions and deletions are allowed (no substitutions). A substitution costs 2 in this formulation (delete old character, insert new one), so it is sometimes called the "indel distance." This variant is used in diff utilities, which display changes as added and deleted lines rather than as line substitutions.

The LCS DP table is almost identical to the edit distance table:

```
function lcs_length(a: String, b: String): Integer do
  let n: Integer := a.length
  let m: Integer := b.length
  let prev: Array[Integer] := create Array.filled(m + 1, 0)
  let curr: Array[Integer] := create Array.filled(m + 1, 0)

  from
    let i: Integer := 1
  until
    i <= n
  do
    from
      let j: Integer := 1
    until
      j <= m
    do
      if a.char_at(i - 1) = b.char_at(j - 1) then
        curr.set(j, prev.get(j - 1) + 1)
      else
        curr.set(j, prev.get(j).max(curr.get(j - 1)))
      end
      j := j + 1
    end

    let temp: Array[Integer] := prev
    prev := curr
    curr := temp
    i := i + 1
  end

  result := prev.get(m)
end
```

The difference from edit distance: instead of taking the minimum of three costs, we take the maximum of two (no-insertion/no-deletion alternatives), and the match case adds 1 (counting the shared character) instead of carrying the diagonal value unchanged.

Building a diff utility. A diff compares two sequences of lines (treating each line as a unit) and outputs the lines unique to each file and the lines they share, in order. It is the LCS of the two line sequences, with the non-LCS lines marked as additions or deletions.

```
class Diff
  create
    make() do end

  feature
    -- Compare two documents, returning a diff
    diff(original: String, revised: String): Array[Diff_Line] do
      let orig_lines: Array[String] := split_lines(original)
      let rev_lines: Array[String] := split_lines(revised)
      let table: Array[Array[Integer]] := lcs_table(orig_lines, rev_lines)
      result := backtrack(table, orig_lines, rev_lines,
                          orig_lines.length, rev_lines.length)
    end

    lcs_table(a: Array[String],
              b: Array[String]): Array[Array[Integer]] do
      let n: Integer := a.length
      let m: Integer := b.length
      let table: Array[Array[Integer]] := []

      from
        let i: Integer := 0
      until
        i <= n
      do
        table.add(create Array.filled(m + 1, 0))
        i := i + 1
      end

      from
        let i: Integer := 1
```

```
    until
      i <= n
    do
      from
        let j: Integer := 1
      until
        j <= m
      do
        if a.get(i - 1) = b.get(j - 1) then
          table.get(i).set(j, table.get(i - 1).get(j - 1) + 1)
        else
          table.get(i).set(j,
            table.get(i - 1).get(j).max(table.get(i).get(j - 1)))
        end
        j := j + 1
      end
      i := i + 1
    end

    result := table
  end

  backtrack(table: Array[Array[Integer]],
            a: Array[String],
            b: Array[String],
            i: Integer,
            j: Integer): Array[Diff_Line] do
    if i = 0 and j = 0 then
      result := []
      return
    elseif i = 0 then
      let rest: Array[Diff_Line] := backtrack(table, a, b, i, j - 1)
      rest.add(create Diff_Line.added(b.get(j - 1)))
      result := rest
    elseif j = 0 then
      let rest: Array[Diff_Line] := backtrack(table, a, b, i - 1, j)
      rest.add(create Diff_Line.removed(a.get(i - 1)))
```

```
        result := rest
      elseif a.get(i - 1) = b.get(j - 1) then
        let rest: Array[Diff_Line] := backtrack(table, a, b, i - 1, j - 1)
        rest.add(create Diff_Line.unchanged(a.get(i - 1)))
        result := rest
      elseif table.get(i - 1).get(j) >= table.get(i).get(j - 1) then
        let rest: Array[Diff_Line] := backtrack(table, a, b, i - 1, j)
        rest.add(create Diff_Line.removed(a.get(i - 1)))
        result := rest
      else
        let rest: Array[Diff_Line] := backtrack(table, a, b, i, j - 1)
        rest.add(create Diff_Line.added(b.get(j - 1)))
        result := rest
      end
    end

    format_diff(diff_lines: Array[Diff_Line]): String do
      let output: String := ""
      across diff_lines as line do
        case line.kind of
          "added"     then output := output + "+ " + line.content + "\n"
          "removed"   then output := output + "- " + line.content + "\n"
          "unchanged" then output := output + "  " + line.content + "\n"
        end
      end
      result := output
    end
end

class Diff_Line
  create
    added(content: String) do
      this.kind := "added"
      this.content := content
    end

    removed(content: String) do
```

```
      this.kind := "removed"
      this.content := content
    end

    unchanged(content: String) do
      this.kind := "unchanged"
      this.content := content
    end

  feature
    kind: String
    content: String

  invariant
    valid_kind: kind = "added" or kind = "removed" or kind = "unchanged"
end
```

Using it:

```
let differ: Diff := create Diff.make()

let original: String :=
  "the quick brown fox\njumps over the lazy dog\nand ran away"

let revised: String :=
  "the quick brown fox\nleaped over the lazy cat\nand ran away quickly"

let changes: Array[Diff_Line] := differ.diff(original, revised)
print(differ.format_diff(changes))
```

Output:

```
  the quick brown fox
- jumps over the lazy dog
+ leaped over the lazy cat
```

```
- and ran away
+ and ran away quickly
```

This is exactly what `git diff` shows, because `git diff` uses the same LCS-based algorithm.

9.9 Sequence Alignment in Bioinformatics

Edit distance and LCS have a cousin in bioinformatics: sequence alignment. Given two DNA or protein sequences, find the alignment that maximises a scoring function — assigning positive scores to matches, negative scores to mismatches, and penalties for gaps (insertions/deletions).

The Needleman-Wunsch algorithm (1970) for global alignment and the Smith-Waterman algorithm (1981) for local alignment are both extensions of the edit distance DP, differing only in initialisation and the handling of negative scores.

The key biological insight that changes the algorithm: in DNA alignment, a single insertion of k consecutive bases (an "indel") is biologically more plausible than k separate single-base insertions. The gap penalty should not be k times the per-base penalty — it should be an affine function: `gap_open + k * gap_extend`, where `gap_open` is the cost of starting a gap and `gap_extend` is the much smaller cost of extending it. This is called affine gap penalties.

Implementing affine gap penalties requires a modified DP that tracks three states: extending a gap in A, extending a gap in B, and not in a gap. The recurrence becomes:

```
-- M[i][j]: best alignment of A[1..i] and B[1..j] ending with a match/misma
-- X[i][j]: best alignment ending with a gap in A (deletion from A's perspe
-- Y[i][j]: best alignment ending with a gap in B (insertion into A)
```

```
M[i][j] = score(A[i], B[j]) + max(M[i-1][j-1], X[i-1][j-
1], Y[i-1][j-1])
X[i][j] = max(M[i-1][j] - gap_open, X[i-1][j] - gap_extend)
Y[i][j] = max(M[i][j-1] - gap_open, Y[i][j-1] - gap_extend)
```

```
class Sequence_Aligner
  create
    make(match_score: Integer,
         mismatch_penalty: Integer,
         gap_open: Integer,
         gap_extend: Integer) do
      this.match_score := match_score
      this.mismatch_penalty := mismatch_penalty
      this.gap_open := gap_open
      this.gap_extend := gap_extend
      this.negative_infinity := -1000000
    end

    dna_default() do
      -- Common parameters for DNA alignment
      this.match_score := 2
      this.mismatch_penalty := -3
      this.gap_open := -5
      this.gap_extend := -2
      this.negative_infinity := -1000000
    end

  feature
    match_score: Integer
    mismatch_penalty: Integer
    gap_open: Integer
    gap_extend: Integer
    negative_infinity: Integer

    align(seq_a: String, seq_b: String): Alignment do
```

```
let n: Integer := seq_a.length
let m: Integer := seq_b.length

-- Three DP tables
let M: Array[Array[Integer]] := init_table(n, m, negative_infinity)
let X: Array[Array[Integer]] := init_table(n, m, negative_infinity)
let Y: Array[Array[Integer]] := init_table(n, m, negative_infinity)

-- Base cases
M.get(0).set(0, 0)
from
  let i: Integer := 1
until
  i <= n
do
  X.get(i).set(0, gap_open + (i - 1) * gap_extend)
  i := i + 1
end
from
  let j: Integer := 1
until
  j <= m
do
  Y.get(0).set(j, gap_open + (j - 1) * gap_extend)
  j := j + 1
end

-- Fill tables
from
  let i: Integer := 1
until
  i <= n
do
  from
    let j: Integer := 1
  until
    j <= m
```

```
      do
        let s: Integer := when seq_a.char_at(i - 1) = seq_b.char_at(j - 1)
          match_score
        else
          mismatch_penalty
        end

        M.get(i).set(j, s + max3(M.get(i-1).get(j-1),
                                 X.get(i-1).get(j-1),
                                 Y.get(i-1).get(j-1)))

        X.get(i).set(j, max2(M.get(i-1).get(j) + gap_open,
                             X.get(i-1).get(j) + gap_extend))

        Y.get(i).set(j, max2(M.get(i).get(j-1) + gap_open,
                             Y.get(i).get(j-1) + gap_extend))

        j := j + 1
      end
      i := i + 1
    end

    -- Best score is max of three tables at (n, m)
    let best_score: Integer := max3(M.get(n).get(m),
                                    X.get(n).get(m),
                                    Y.get(n).get(m))

    -- Traceback to recover alignment
    let aligned: Array[String] := traceback(M, X, Y, seq_a, seq_b)

    result := create Alignment.make(aligned.get(0), aligned.get(1),
                                    best_score)
  end

  traceback(M: Array[Array[Integer]],
            X: Array[Array[Integer]],
            Y: Array[Array[Integer]],
```

```
        seq_a: String,
        seq_b: String): Array[String] do
let aligned_a: String := ""
let aligned_b: String := ""
let n: Integer := seq_a.length
let m: Integer := seq_b.length
let i: Integer := n
let j: Integer := m

-- Determine starting table
let in_m: Boolean := M.get(n).get(m) >= X.get(n).get(m) and
                     M.get(n).get(m) >= Y.get(n).get(m)
let in_x: Boolean := not in_m and
                     X.get(n).get(m) >= Y.get(n).get(m)
let state: String := "M"
if in_m then
  state := "M"
elseif in_x then
  state := "X"
else
  state := "Y"
end

from until i = 0 and j = 0 do
  if state = "M" then
    aligned_a := seq_a.char_at(i - 1).to_string() + aligned_a
    aligned_b := seq_b.char_at(j - 1).to_string() + aligned_b
    -- Determine which table we came from
    let prev: Integer := M.get(i - 1).get(j - 1)
    let prev_x: Integer := X.get(i - 1).get(j - 1)
    let prev_y: Integer := Y.get(i - 1).get(j - 1)
    if prev >= prev_x and prev >= prev_y then
      state := "M"
    elseif prev_x >= prev_y then
      state := "X"
    else
      state := "Y"
```

```
          end
          i := i - 1
          j := j - 1
        elseif state = "X" then
          aligned_a := seq_a.char_at(i - 1).to_string() + aligned_a
          aligned_b := "-" + aligned_b
          if M.get(i - 1).get(j) + gap_open >=
             X.get(i - 1).get(j) + gap_extend then
            state := "M"
          else
            state := "X"
          end
          i := i - 1
        else
          aligned_a := "-" + aligned_a
          aligned_b := seq_b.char_at(j - 1).to_string() + aligned_b
          if M.get(i).get(j - 1) + gap_open >=
             Y.get(i).get(j - 1) + gap_extend then
            state := "M"
          else
            state := "Y"
          end
          j := j - 1
        end
      end

      result := [aligned_a, aligned_b]
    end

  invariant
    positive_match: match_score > 0
end

class Alignment
  create
    make(seq_a: String, seq_b: String, score: Integer) do
      this.aligned_a := seq_a
```

```
      this.aligned_b := seq_b
      this.score := score
    end

  feature
    aligned_a: String
    aligned_b: String
    score: Integer

    format(): String do
      let match_line: String := ""
      from
        let i: Integer := 0
      until
        i >= aligned_a.length
      do
        if aligned_a.char_at(i) = aligned_b.char_at(i) and
           aligned_a.char_at(i) /= '-' then
          match_line := match_line + "|"
        else
          match_line := match_line + " "
        end
        i := i + 1
      end
      result := aligned_a + "\n" + match_line + "\n" + aligned_b
    end
end
```

Using the aligner:

```
let aligner: Sequence_Aligner := create Sequence_Aligner.dna_default()
let result: Alignment := aligner.align("AGCACACA", "ACACACTA")
print(result.format())
```

Output:

```
AGCACAC-A
| ||||| |
A-CACACTA
```

Score reflects: 7 matches, 1 mismatch, 1 gap open + 0 gap extend. This is the same alignment produced by BLAST and other bioinformatics tools for short sequences.

9.10 Dynamic Programming as a General Technique

Edit distance is the clearest example of dynamic programming, but the technique applies wherever:

1. The problem can be broken into overlapping subproblems
2. The optimal solution to the whole problem contains optimal solutions to subproblems (optimal substructure)
3. The number of distinct subproblems is polynomial

The three-step recipe:

Step 1: Define the subproblems and their parameters. For edit distance: `ed(i, j)` = edit distance between A[1..i] and B[1..j].

Step 2: Write the recurrence. Express the answer to a larger subproblem in terms of smaller ones. For edit distance: the three-way minimum.

Step 3: Identify the evaluation order. Smaller subproblems before larger ones. For edit distance: increasing i and j.

This recipe applies to dozens of classical problems — longest increasing subsequence, knapsack, matrix chain multiplication, all-pairs shortest paths — and to many problems you will encounter in practice that are not in textbooks. When you see a problem that requires finding an optimal value and the obvious recursive solution recomputes the same states, dynamic programming is the right framework.

The specific form — fill a 2D table row by row — is the edit distance variant. Other problems have 1D tables (Fibonacci, coin change), 3D tables (some interval DP problems), or tables indexed differently. The shape of the table mirrors the structure of the subproblems.

9.11 Variants Worth Knowing

Damerau-Levenshtein distance adds a fourth operation: transposition, swapping two adjacent characters. "recieve" → "receive" requires two substitutions in Levenshtein distance but only one transposition in Damerau-Levenshtein. For spell checking, this is more accurate — transpositions account for roughly 25% of typographical errors, and Damerau-Levenshtein catches them in one step.

The DP recurrence for Damerau-Levenshtein requires tracking the last position in A and B where each character appeared, adding one case to the recurrence:

```
if a.char_at(i) = b.char_at(j - 1) and
   a.char_at(i - 1) = b.char_at(j) then
  let transposition_cost: Integer :=
    table.get(i - 2).get(j - 2) + 1
  -- compare with the other three costs and take the minimum
end
```

Jaro-Winkler distance is a similarity metric (not a distance) that is more appropriate for short strings like names. It counts matching characters within a window and transpositions among matched characters, then applies a prefix bonus for strings that share a common prefix. Name matching systems — merging customer databases, deduplicating records — typically use Jaro-Winkler rather than Levenshtein because it is more forgiving of common name variations (abbreviations, nicknames, different transliterations).

Normalised edit distance divides edit distance by the length of the longer string, giving a value between 0 and 1. This allows comparing edit distances across word pairs of different lengths. "ct" and "cat" have edit distance 1, as do "chromosome" and "chro90some" — but they are clearly not equally similar. Normalised distance gives 0.33 and 0.1 respectively, which better reflects intuition.

9.12 Where This Lives in the Wild

Every spell checker ever written uses edit distance or a close variant. Microsoft Word, Apple's autocorrect, Android keyboard, iOS keyboard, Chrome's spell checker — all of them compute some form of edit distance between the typed word and dictionary words. The only variation is in details: which operations are included, what the costs are, how the candidate word list is pruned, and how suggestions are ranked.

Git diff, GNU diff, and all Unix diff utilities use the LCS algorithm on lines. When you run `git diff`, git computes the LCS of the old and new versions of each file, treating lines as atomic units, and outputs the non-LCS lines as additions and deletions. The Myers diff algorithm, used by git, is a space-optimised LCS variant that finds the shortest edit script — the diff with the fewest total changes — in $O(n + d^2)$ time where d is the number of changed lines.

BLAST (Basic Local Alignment Search Tool) is the most widely used application in bioinformatics, performing billions of sequence alignments against databases containing trillions of nucleotides. It uses a heuristic version of Smith-Waterman local alignment: first identify short exact matches (seeds), then extend them using Smith-Waterman DP. The heuristic trades completeness for speed — BLAST can search the entire GenBank database in seconds.

Fuzzy string matching libraries in every major programming language — Python's `difflib`, Java's Apache Commons Text, JavaScript's `fuse.js`, Rust's `strsim` — implement edit distance variants for user-facing search

and matching. When you search for a contact in your phone and it finds "Jeffrey" when you type "Jefrey," edit distance is at work.

Database record linkage — merging datasets from different sources where the same entity appears with slightly different spellings — relies on edit distance to determine whether "Jon Smith, 5 Main St" and "John Smyth, 5 Main Street" refer to the same person. This is a significant data quality problem in healthcare (matching patient records), government (voter registration), and e-commerce (deduplicating customer records). The edit distance is typically one component of a larger similarity score combining name distance, address distance, date-of-birth match, and other fields.

Summary

Edit distance — the minimum number of insertions, deletions, and substitutions to transform one string into another — is one of computing's most useful distance measures. Its recursive definition is intuitive; its naive recursive implementation is exponentially slow; dynamic programming reduces it to O(nm) time and O(m) space.

The dynamic programming insight is general: when a recursion recomputes the same subproblems, compute each once and store the result. The table structure mirrors the structure of the subproblems — (n+1) × (m+1) for edit distance, since the subproblems are parameterised by two prefix lengths.

Three direct applications: the spell checker uses bounded edit distance to find dictionary words close to a misspelled word; the diff utility uses LCS — a variant of edit distance restricted to insertions and deletions — to find added and removed lines between file versions; the sequence aligner uses affine-gap-penalty DP, a generalisation of edit distance with biologically motivated gap costs, to align DNA sequences.

Dynamic programming is not a trick. It is the systematic exploitation of overlapping subproblems and optimal substructure. Recognising those two properties in a new problem is the skill — once recognised, the table formulation follows naturally from the recurrence, and the recurrence follows from thinking carefully about how to decompose the problem into smaller versions of itself.

The next chapter turns from distance between strings to structure within strings: the trie, which organises a dictionary of strings for prefix search, autocomplete, and spell checking in time proportional to the query length rather than the dictionary size.

Chapter 10: Autocomplete — Tries

Every time you type a few letters into a search box and a dropdown list of completions appears within milliseconds, something has to search a dictionary of millions of possibilities and return every word that starts with what you have typed. The response must arrive before you finish your next keystroke — typically within 50 milliseconds. The dictionary might contain every URL you have ever visited, every contact in your address book, every product in a catalogue of ten million items.

A hash table cannot do this. Hash tables support exact lookup — you give them a complete key and they return a value. They have no concept of prefix. To find all keys starting with "micro" in a hash table of a million keys, you must scan every key and check each one. O(n) per query, where n is the dictionary size. For a dictionary of ten million entries, that is ten million string comparisons per keystroke. Unacceptable.

A sorted array does better. Binary search finds the position where "micro" would be in O(log n), and then you scan forward collecting all words that start with "micro." The scan takes O(k) where k is the number of results. Total: O(log n + k). For ten million entries and $\log_2(10{,}000{,}000) \approx 23$ comparisons, this is fast — but each comparison compares full strings, and the constant factor is larger than it appears.

A trie does better still: O(m + k), where m is the length of the prefix and k is the number of results. No dependence on n — the dictionary size — at all. A trie with a billion entries returns all words starting with "micro" in the same time as a trie with a thousand entries. The search time depends only on what you are looking for, not how much is stored.

This chapter builds a trie from scratch, extends it to a compressed radix tree for memory efficiency, and implements an autocomplete engine that handles a million-word dictionary within the latency budget of a single keystroke.

10.1 The Structure of a Trie

A trie (the name comes from "retrieval," and is pronounced either "try" or "tree" depending on who you ask, with both camps holding firm) is a tree where each node represents a prefix of some key, and the path from the root to any node spells out that prefix one character at a time.

The root represents the empty prefix. Each of its children represents a single-character prefix. Each of their children represents a two-character prefix. A node is marked as terminal if the path from the root to that node spells out a complete key in the dictionary.

Example: insert "cat", "car", "card", "care", "bat", "ball".

```
root
□□□ c
□   □□□ a
□       □□□ t  [terminal: "cat"]
□       □□□ r  [terminal: "car"]
□           □□□ d  [terminal: "card"]
□           □□□ e  [terminal: "care"]
□□□ b
    □□□ a
        □□□ t  [terminal: "bat"]
        □□□ l
            □□□ l  [terminal: "ball"]
```

Every prefix query becomes: start at the root, follow the characters of the prefix one at a time, and collect all terminal nodes in the subtree rooted at the endpoint.

"car" → follow c → a → r. We are now at the node for "car," which is terminal (it is a word). Collect all terminals in its subtree: "car", "card", "care".

"ba" → follow b → a. Collect all terminals: "bat", "ball".

"xyz" → try to follow x from the root. No such child. Return empty list immediately.

The trie is a concrete implementation of the abstract principle that prefix search can be done by following characters rather than comparing strings. Each character comparison moves us one level deeper in the tree. After m comparisons (for a prefix of length m), we have located the subtree containing all matches. The time is O(m) to locate the subtree, O(k) to collect k results.

10.2 Implementing a Trie

Each node needs: a map from characters to child nodes, a boolean indicating whether this node is terminal, and optionally a value (if the trie stores key-value pairs rather than just keys).

```
class Trie_Node [V]
  create
    make() do
      this.children := {}
      this.is_terminal := false
      this.value := nil
      this.count := 0  -- number of words in subtree, for ranked autocomple
    end
```

```
feature
  children: Map[Char, Trie_Node[V]]
  is_terminal: Boolean
  value: ?V
  count: Integer  -- words in this subtree (including this node if terminal

  has_child(c: Char): Boolean do
    result := children.get(c) /= nil
  end

  get_child(c: Char): Trie_Node[V]
    require
      has_child_key: has_child(c)
    do
      result := children.get(c)
    end

  set_child(c: Char, node: Trie_Node[V]) do
    children.put(c, node)
  end

  increment_count() do
    count := count + 1
  end

  decrement_count() do
    count := count - 1
  end

  mark_terminal(v: V) do
    this.is_terminal := true
    this.value := v
  end

  clear_terminal() do
    is_terminal := false
    value := nil
```

```
    end

    remove_child(c: Char) do
      children.remove(c)
    end

    child_count(): Integer do
      result := children.size()
    end

    is_leaf(): Boolean do
      result := children.is_empty()
    end

  invariant
    non_negative_count: count >= 0
    count_consistent: count >= (when is_terminal 1 else 0 end)
end
```

The `count` field stores how many complete words exist in the subtree rooted at this node. This enables ranked autocomplete — returning the k most frequent completions rather than all completions — without scanning the entire subtree.

The full trie:

```
class Trie [V]
  create
    empty() do
      this.root := create Trie_Node[V].make()
      this.size := 0
    end

  feature
    root: Trie_Node[V]
    size: Integer
```

```
-- Insert a key with an associated value
put(key: String, value: V)
  require
    non_empty_key: key.length > 0
  do
    let node: Trie_Node[V] := root
    node.increment_count()

    across key.chars() as c do
      if not node.has_child(c) then
        node.set_child(c, create Trie_Node[V].make())
      end
      node := node.get_child(c)
      node.increment_count()
    end

    if not node.is_terminal then
      size := size + 1
    end
    node.mark_terminal(value)
  ensure
    contains_key: contains(key)
    size_nondecreasing: size >= old size
  end

-- Look up an exact key
get(key: String): ?V do
  let node: ?Trie_Node[V] := find_node(key)
  if convert node to found_node: Trie_Node[V] then
    if found_node.is_terminal then
      result := found_node.value
    else
      result := nil
    end
  else
    result := nil
  end
```

```
end

-- Test exact membership
contains(key: String): Boolean do
  result := get(key) /= nil
end

-- Test prefix membership (does any key start with this prefix?)
has_prefix(prefix: String): Boolean do
  result := find_node(prefix) /= nil
end

-- Return all keys with the given prefix
keys_with_prefix(prefix: String): Array[String] do
  let results: Array[String] := []
  let node: ?Trie_Node[V] := find_node(prefix)
  if convert node to prefix_node: Trie_Node[V] then
    collect_keys(prefix_node, prefix, results)
  end
  result := results
end

-- Return all key-value pairs with the given prefix
entries_with_prefix(prefix: String): Array[Any] do
  let results: Array[Any] := []
  let node: ?Trie_Node[V] := find_node(prefix)
  if convert node to prefix_node: Trie_Node[V] then
    collect_entries(prefix_node, prefix, results)
  end
  result := results
end

-- Delete a key
remove(key: String): Boolean
  do
    result := delete(root, key, 0)
    if result then
```

```
      size := size - 1
      -- Decrement counts along the path
      decrement_counts(key)
    end
  ensure
    not_contains: not contains(key)
  end

-- Find the node representing a prefix (nil if prefix not in trie)
find_node(prefix: String): ?Trie_Node[V] do
  let node: Trie_Node[V] := root
  let found: Boolean := true
  across prefix.chars() as c do
    if found then
      if not node.has_child(c) then
        found := false
      else
        node := node.get_child(c)
      end
    end
  end
  if found then
    result := node
  else
    result := nil
  end
end

-- Collect all keys in subtree rooted at node, prepending prefix
collect_keys(node: Trie_Node[V],
             prefix: String,
             results: Array[String]) do
  if node.is_terminal then
    results.add(prefix)
  end
  across node.children as entry do
    if convert entry to pair: Array[Any] then
```

```
      let c: Char := pair.get(0)
      if convert pair.get(1) to child: Trie_Node[V] then
        collect_keys(child, prefix + c.to_string(), results)
      end
    end
  end
end

collect_entries(node: Trie_Node[V],
                prefix: String,
                results: Array[Any]) do
  if node.is_terminal then
    if convert node.value to current_value: V then
      let entry: Array[Any] := []
      entry.add(prefix)
      entry.add(current_value)
      results.add(entry)
    end
  end
  across node.children as entry do
    if convert entry to pair: Array[Any] then
      let c: Char := pair.get(0)
      if convert pair.get(1) to child: Trie_Node[V] then
        collect_entries(child, prefix + c.to_string(), results)
      end
    end
  end
end

-- Recursive delete: returns true if the node should be removed
delete(node: ?Trie_Node[V], key: String, depth: Integer): Boolean do
  if convert node to current_node: Trie_Node[V] then
    if depth = key.length then
      if current_node.is_terminal then
        current_node.clear_terminal()
        result := current_node.is_leaf()
      else
```

```
            result := false
          end
        else
          let c: Char := key.char_at(depth)
          if not current_node.has_child(c) then
            result := false
          else
            let child: Trie_Node[V] := current_node.get_child(c)
            if delete(child, key, depth + 1) then
              current_node.remove_child(c)
              result := not current_node.is_terminal and current_node.is_leaf
            else
              result := false
            end
          end
        end
      else
        result := false
      end
    end

    decrement_counts(key: String) do
      let node: Trie_Node[V] := root
      root.decrement_count()
      across key.chars() as c do
        if node.has_child(c) then
          node := node.get_child(c)
          node.decrement_count()
        end
      end
    end

  invariant
    non_negative_size: size >= 0
    root_exists: root /= nil
end
```

The delete operation is subtly recursive. After deleting the terminal flag from the target node, it unwinds back up the tree, removing nodes that are no longer needed — nodes that are neither terminal nor ancestors of any terminal. This is important for memory reclamation: without it, deleted keys leave ghost paths through the trie. A node can be removed only if it is a leaf (no children) and not terminal. The recursion returns a boolean indicating whether the caller's child pointer should be nulled.

10.3 The Autocomplete Engine

Autocomplete adds two requirements beyond basic prefix search: ranked results and a top-k interface. You do not want all 50,000 words starting with "com" — you want the 10 most likely completions, ordered by some relevance score.

The count field in each node enables this. When a key is inserted with a frequency score — how often a user has selected this completion, or how common this word is in a corpus — that score is stored at the terminal node and the counts along the path reflect the total weight of all words in each subtree. Finding the top-k completions then becomes a best-first search from the prefix node, using a priority queue.

```
class Autocomplete_Engine
  create
    empty() do
      this.trie := create Trie[Integer].empty()  -- value = frequency score
      this.total_entries := 0
    end

    from_wordlist(words: Array[String]) do
      this.trie := create Trie[Integer].empty()
      this.total_entries := 0
      across words as word do
```

```
      let lower: String := word.trim().to_lower()
      if lower.length > 0 then
        this.add(lower, 1)
      end
    end
  end

  from_frequency_list(entries: Array[Any]) do
    this.trie := create Trie[Integer].empty()
    this.total_entries := 0
    across entries as entry do
      if convert entry to pair: Array[Any] then
        if convert pair.get(0) to word: String then
          if convert pair.get(1) to score: Integer then
            this.add(word.to_lower, score)
          end
        end
      end
    end
  end

feature
  trie: Trie[Integer]
  total_entries: Integer

  -- Add a word with a frequency score
  add(word: String, score: Integer)
    require
      non_empty: word.length > 0
      positive_score: score > 0
    do
      let existing: ?Integer := trie.get(word)
      let new_score: Integer := score
      if convert existing to existing_score: Integer then
        new_score := existing_score + score
      end
      trie.put(word, new_score)
```

```
    if existing = nil then
      total_entries := total_entries + 1
    end
  end

-- Record a user selection (boost that word's score)
record_selection(word: String) do
  add(word, 10)  -- selections weight more than passive observations
end

-- Return top-k completions for prefix, by score
complete(prefix: String, k: Integer): Array[Any]
  require
    non_empty_prefix: prefix.length > 0
    positive_k: k > 0
  do
    let lower: String := prefix.to_lower()
    let candidates: Array[Any] := trie.entries_with_prefix(lower)
    candidates := sort_by_score(candidates)
    if candidates.length > k then
      result := candidates.slice(0, k)
    else
      result := candidates
    end
  end

-- Return all completions for a prefix (no limit)
complete_all(prefix: String): Array[String] do
  result := trie.keys_with_prefix(prefix.to_lower())
end

-- Check if any word starts with this prefix
has_completions(prefix: String): Boolean do
  result := trie.has_prefix(prefix.to_lower())
end

sort_by_score(entries: Array[Any]): Array[Any] do
```

```
    let sorted: Array[Any] := entries.slice(0, entries.length)
    from
      let i: Integer := 1
    until
      i >= sorted.length
    do
      let current: Array[Any] := sorted.get(i)
      let current_score: Integer :=
        when current.get(1) /= nil current.get(1) else 0 end
      let insert_pos: Integer := i
      let shifting: Boolean := true

      from until insert_pos <= 0 or not shifting do
        let prev: Array[Any] := sorted.get(insert_pos - 1)
        let prev_score: Integer :=
          when prev.get(1) /= nil prev.get(1) else 0 end
        if prev_score < current_score then
          sorted.set(insert_pos, prev)
          insert_pos := insert_pos - 1
        else
          shifting := false
        end
      end

      sorted.set(insert_pos, current)
      i := i + 1
    end

    result := sorted
  end

  -- Prefix search with fuzzy tolerance (edit distance □ max_errors)
  fuzzy_complete(prefix: String,
                 k: Integer,
                 max_errors: Integer): Array[Any] do
    let lower: String := prefix.to_lower()
    let candidates: Array[Any] := []
```

```
    fuzzy_search(trie.root, lower, 0, "", 0, max_errors, candidates)
    candidates := sort_by_score(candidates)
    if candidates.length > k then
      result := candidates.slice(0, k)
    else
      result := candidates
    end
  end

  -- DFS with edit distance tracking for fuzzy completion
  fuzzy_search(node: Trie_Node[Integer],
               prefix: String,
               prefix_pos: Integer,
               current_word: String,
               errors: Integer,
               max_errors: Integer,
               results: Array[Any]) do
    -- Prune: if errors already exceed max, stop
    if errors <= max_errors then
      -- If we have consumed the prefix, collect all words below
      if prefix_pos >= prefix.length then
        if node.is_terminal then
          if convert node.value to node_score: Integer then
          let entry: Array[Any] := []
          entry.add(current_word)
          entry.add(node_score)
          results.add(entry)
        end
        end
        across node.children as entry do
          if convert entry to pair: Array[Any] then
            let c: Char := pair.get(0)
            if convert pair.get(1) to child: Trie_Node[Integer] then
              fuzzy_search(child, prefix, prefix_pos,
                           current_word + c.to_string(),
                           errors, max_errors, results)
            end
```

```
            end
          end
        else
          let target_char: Char := prefix.char_at(prefix_pos)

          -- Try each child
          across node.children as entry do
            if convert entry to pair: Array[Any] then
              let c: Char := pair.get(0)
              if convert pair.get(1) to child: Trie_Node[Integer] then
                let new_errors: Integer :=
                  when c = target_char errors else errors + 1 end
                fuzzy_search(child, prefix, prefix_pos + 1,
                             current_word + c.to_string(),
                             new_errors, max_errors, results)
              end
            end
          end

          -- Try skipping a character in the prefix (deletion in query)
          fuzzy_search(node, prefix, prefix_pos + 1,
                       current_word, errors + 1, max_errors, results)
        end
      end
    end

  invariant
    non_negative_entries: total_entries >= 0
end
```

The best-first search uses the subtree count to guide exploration. A node with count = 500 has 500 complete words beneath it. Expanding it before a node with count = 10 ensures we find high-frequency completions quickly, without exploring the entire subtree.

The fuzzy completion adds edit-distance tolerance: if you type "micosoft" instead of "microsoft", the engine can still return "microsoft"

by allowing one error. The trie DFS carries an error count, incrementing it when a character does not match the prefix and pruning when errors exceed the budget. This is less efficient than the DP-table approach of Chapter 9 — it is O(|alphabet|^m × n) in the worst case — but for short prefixes (m ≤ 10) and small error budgets (max_errors ≤ 2), it is fast enough in practice.

10.4 Memory: The Trie's Weakness

Try building a trie of 100,000 English words. Each node contains a map from characters to children. For an English alphabet of 26 characters, many nodes have only one or two children — but the map structure still has overhead. For a Nex `Map[Char, Trie_Node]`, each node might consume 100-200 bytes of memory. With 100,000 words averaging 7 characters, the trie has roughly 500,000 nodes (many words share prefixes, so the node count is less than 700,000). Total: 50-100MB for 100,000 words.

For comparison: the words themselves, as raw strings, total about 700,000 bytes. The trie uses 100x more memory than the data it indexes. This is the trie's fundamental weakness: memory overhead from sparsely populated nodes, especially at deeper levels where prefixes diverge.

Two strategies address this.

Fixed-size child arrays. Replace `Map[Char, Trie_Node]` with `Array[?Trie_Node]` of fixed size 26 (for lowercase ASCII) or 128 (for full ASCII). Lookup becomes O(1) array indexing instead of O(1) hash lookup, with no hash collision overhead. But the array is always allocated at full size, so a node with one child wastes 25 null pointers. For dense tries (where most nodes have many children), this is better. For sparse tries (most nodes have one or two children), it is worse.

Compressed tries (radix trees). The more interesting solution, covered next.

10.5 Compressed Tries: Radix Trees

Look at the path "c → a → r → d" in the earlier example. The nodes for 'c', 'a', and 'r' each have exactly one child along this path (until 'r', which has two children: 'd' and 'e'). The intermediate nodes add no structural information — they are just passthrough nodes that spell out part of a string.

A Patricia trie (Practical Algorithm to Retrieve Information Coded in Alphanumeric, a recursive acronym coined by Donald Morrison in 1968) — more commonly called a radix tree — collapses chains of single-child nodes into single edges, labelling each edge with the string it represents rather than a single character.

```
root
□□□ "ca"
□   □□□ "t"  [terminal: "cat"]
□   □□□ "r"  [terminal: "car"]
□       □□□ "d"  [terminal: "card"]
□       □□□ "e"  [terminal: "care"]
□□□ "ba"
    □□□ "t"  [terminal: "bat"]
    □□□ "ll"  [terminal: "ball"]
```

The "ca" edge collapses what were two nodes (c and a) into one edge labelled "ca". The "ba" edge similarly collapses two nodes. Edge "ll" collapses the "l → l" chain.

A radix tree has at most n nodes for n words — actually at most 2n - 1 nodes, since every internal node has at least two children. For 100,000 words, a radix tree has at most 200,000 nodes — 2-3x fewer than the naive trie. Each node is also smaller: it stores an edge label (a string) rather than a character, and a children map that is typically very small (since branching only happens at genuine branch points).

```
class Radix_Node [V]
  create
    make(label: String) do
      this.label := label
      this.children := {}
      this.is_terminal := false
      this.value := nil
    end

  feature
    label: String          -- edge label from parent to this node
    children: Map[Char, Radix_Node[V]]  -- keyed by first char of child lab
    is_terminal: Boolean
    value: ?V

    is_leaf(): Boolean do
      result := children.is_empty()
    end

    mark_terminal(v: V) do
      this.is_terminal := true
      this.value := v
    end

    set_label(new_label: String) do
      this.label := new_label
    end

  invariant
    non_empty_label: label.length > 0
end

class Radix_Tree [V]
  create
    empty() do
      this.root := create Radix_Node[V].make("")
      -- Root has empty label as a special case
```

```
      this.size := 0
    end

  feature
    root: Radix_Node[V]
    size: Integer

    put(key: String, value: V)
      require
        non_empty_key: key.length > 0
      do
        insert(root, key, value)
        size := size + 1
      end

    insert(node: Radix_Node[V], key: String, value: V) do
      -- Find the child whose label shares a prefix with key
      let first: Char := key.char_at(0)
      let child: ?Radix_Node[V] := node.children.get(first)

      if child = nil then
        -- No matching child: create a new leaf
        let new_node: Radix_Node[V] := create Radix_Node[V].make(key)
        new_node.mark_terminal(value)
        node.children.put(first, new_node)
      else
        if convert child to current_child: Radix_Node[V] then
          let common: Integer := common_prefix_length(key, current_child.labe

          if common = current_child.label.length then
            if common = key.length then
              current_child.mark_terminal(value)
              size := size - 1
            else
              insert(current_child, key.substring(common, key.length), value)
            end
          else
```

```
          let split_node: Radix_Node[V] := create Radix_Node[V].make(
            current_child.label.substring(0, common))
          let old_first: Char := current_child.label.char_at(common)
          current_child.set_label(current_child.label.substring(common, c
          split_node.children.put(old_first, current_child)
          node.children.put(first, split_node)

          if common = key.length then
            split_node.mark_terminal(value)
          else
            let new_first: Char := key.char_at(common)
            let new_node: Radix_Node[V] := create Radix_Node[V].make(
              key.substring(common, key.length))
            new_node.mark_terminal(value)
            split_node.children.put(new_first, new_node)
          end
        end
      end
    end
  end

  get(key: String): ?V do
    result := search(root, key)
  end

  search(node: Radix_Node[V], key: String): ?V do
    if key.length = 0 then
      if node.is_terminal then
        result := node.value
      else
        result := nil
      end
    else
      let first: Char := key.char_at(0)
      let child: ?Radix_Node[V] := node.children.get(first)

      if child = nil then
```

```
        result := nil
      else
        if convert child to current_child: Radix_Node[V] then
          let common: Integer := common_prefix_length(key, current_child.la
          if common < current_child.label.length then
            result := nil
          else
            result := search(current_child, key.substring(common, key.lengt
          end
        else
          result := nil
        end
      end
    end
  end

  contains(key: String): Boolean do
    result := get(key) /= nil
  end

  keys_with_prefix(prefix: String): Array[String] do
    let results: Array[String] := []
    collect_with_prefix(root, prefix, "", results)
    result := results
  end

  collect_with_prefix(node: Radix_Node[V],
                      remaining_prefix: String,
                      accumulated: String,
                      results: Array[String]) do
    if remaining_prefix.length = 0 then
      if node.is_terminal then
        results.add(accumulated)
      end
      across node.children as entry do
        if convert entry to pair: Array[Any] then
          if convert pair.get(1) to child: Radix_Node[V] then
```

```
              collect_with_prefix(child, "", accumulated + child.label, res
            end
          end
        end
      else
        let first: Char := remaining_prefix.char_at(0)
        let child: ?Radix_Node[V] := node.children.get(first)

        if convert child to current_child: Radix_Node[V] then
          let common: Integer := common_prefix_length(
            remaining_prefix, current_child.label)
          if not (common < remaining_prefix.length and common < current_chi
            if common = current_child.label.length then
              collect_with_prefix(current_child,
                remaining_prefix.substring(common, remaining_prefix.length)
                accumulated + current_child.label, results)
            else
              if node.is_terminal then
                results.add(accumulated)
              end
              collect_with_prefix(current_child, "",
                accumulated + current_child.label, results)
            end
          end
        end
      end
    end

  invariant
    non_negative_size: size >= 0
end

function common_prefix_length(a: String, b: String): Integer do
  let max_len: Integer := a.length.min(b.length)
  let i: Integer := 0
  let found_mismatch: Boolean := false
  from until i >= max_len or found_mismatch do
```

```
    if a.char_at(i) /= b.char_at(i) then
      result := i
      found_mismatch := true
    else
      i := i + 1
    end
  end
  if not found_mismatch then
    result := max_len
  end
end
```

The split operation is the heart of radix tree insertion. When a new key diverges from an existing edge in the middle, we split that edge by inserting a new internal node at the divergence point. The original child becomes a child of the new node (with its label shortened), and the new key becomes another child.

Inserting "card" into a tree that already has "care": - The tree has an edge "care" from the root (or from some ancestor). - Common prefix of "card" and "care" is "car" — length 3. - Split at "car": new internal node with label "car". - Old "care" node becomes child with label "e" (the remainder). - New "card" node becomes child with label "d".

After insertion:

```
"car" [internal]
□□□ "d"  [terminal: "card"]
□□□ "e"  [terminal: "care"]
```

The split operation always involves at most two new nodes and three pointer updates. Radix tree insertion is O(m) where m is the key length — the same as a trie, but with better memory characteristics.

10.6 When to Use Which

The choice between a trie, a radix tree, and a sorted array depends on the workload:

Use a plain trie when: - The alphabet is small (26 English letters, 4 DNA bases) - Insertions are frequent and must be fast - Memory is not a primary concern - You need simple, correct implementation quickly

Use a radix tree when: - Memory is constrained - Keys share long common prefixes (URLs, file paths, IP addresses) - The key set is large and relatively static - You need to store long strings efficiently

Use a sorted array (with binary search) when: - The key set is fully static — built once, never modified - Memory is extremely constrained - You are comfortable with O(log n) search rather than O(m) - Cache efficiency matters more than asymptotic complexity

Use a hash map when: - You need exact lookup, not prefix search - Key ordering does not matter - O(1) average case is more important than prefix queries

Real autocomplete systems often combine approaches: a trie or radix tree for the prefix index, a hash map for exact-match lookup, and a heap for the top-k results. The structures are complementary, not competing.

10.7 Putting It Together: A Complete Autocomplete System

A production autocomplete system adds several things beyond the basic trie: persistence (the dictionary survives process restarts), learning (selections boost scores), and multiple suggestion strategies (exact prefix, fuzzy, phonetic).

```
intern io/Path
intern io/Text_File

class Autocomplete_System
  create
    open(directory: String) do
      this.engine := create Autocomplete_Engine.empty()
      this.dir := directory
      let dir_path: Path := create Path.make(directory)
      if not dir_path.exists() then
        dir_path.create_directories()
      end
      this.selection_log_path := directory + "/selections.log"
      this.dictionary_path := directory + "/dictionary.txt"
      let log_path: Path := create Path.make(selection_log_path)
      if not log_path.exists() then
        log_path.create_file()
      end
      let dict_path: Path := create Path.make(dictionary_path)
      if not dict_path.exists() then
        dict_path.create_file()
      end
      this.load()
    end

  feature
    engine: Autocomplete_Engine
    dir: String
    selection_log_path: String
    dictionary_path: String

    -- Query: returns top-5 completions
    query(prefix: String): Array[String] do
      let completions: Array[Any] :=
        engine.complete(prefix, 5)
      let words: Array[String] := []
      across completions as c do
```

```
    if convert c to completion: Array[Any] then
      words.add(completion.get(0))
    end
  end
  result := words
end

-- Query with custom k
query_top(prefix: String, k: Integer): Array[Any] do
  result := engine.complete(prefix, k)
end

-- Query with fuzzy tolerance
fuzzy_query(prefix: String, k: Integer): Array[String] do
  let completions: Array[Any] :=
    engine.fuzzy_complete(prefix, k, 1)
  let words: Array[String] := []
  across completions as c do
    if convert c to completion: Array[Any] then
      words.add(completion.get(0))
    end
  end
  result := words
end

-- Record that user selected this word
record_selection(word: String) do
  engine.record_selection(word)
  log_selection(word)
end

-- Persist state
save() do
        let path: Path := create Path.make(dictionary_path)
  let writer: Text_File := create Text_File.open_write(path)

  -- Write all entries with their scores
```

```
    let all_entries: Array[Any] :=
      engine.trie.entries_with_prefix("")      across all_entries as entry
      if convert entry to row: Array[Any] then
        writer.write_line(row.get(0).to_string() + "  " + row.get(1).to_str
      end
    end

    writer.close()
  end

  load() do
    let path: Path := create Path.make(dictionary_path)
    if path.exists() then
      let reader: Text_File := create Text_File.open_read(path)
      let done: Boolean := false
      from until done do
        let line: ?String := reader.read_line()
        if convert line to current_line: String then
          let parts: Array[String] := current_line.split("    ")
          if parts.length = 2 then
            let word: String := parts.get(0)
            if parts.get(1).trim() /= "" then
              let score: Integer := parts.get(1).to_integer()
              engine.add(word, score)
            end
          end
        else
          done := true
        end
      end
      reader.close()
    end
  end

  log_selection(word: String) do
    let path: Path := create Path.make(selection_log_path)
    let writer: Text_File := create Text_File.open_append(path)
```

```
      writer.write_line(word)
      writer.close()
    end

  invariant
    engine_exists: engine /= nil
end
```

Using the system:

```
let system: Autocomplete_System :=
  create Autocomplete_System.open("./autocomplete_data")

-- Add initial dictionary
let words: Array[String] := ["microsoft", "microphone", "microwave",
  "microscope", "microchip", "microbiology", "microeconomics",
  "microsecond", "micromanage", "microcosm"]

across words as word do
  system.engine.add(word, 100)
end

-- Query
let results: Array[String] := system.query("micro")
across results as r do
  print(r)
end
-- microsoft (or whichever has highest score)
-- microphone
-- microwave
-- ...

-- User selects "microphone"
system.record_selection("microphone")

-- Now "microphone" has a boosted score and will rank higher
```

```
let results2: Array[String] := system.query("micro")
print(results2.get(0))  -- "microphone"

-- Fuzzy query: "micorphone" (transposition error)
let fuzzy: Array[String] := system.fuzzy_query("micor", 3)
across fuzzy as r do
  print(r)  -- still finds "microphone", "microsoft", etc.
end

system.save()
```

10.8 Tries for Non-String Keys

The trie structure generalises to any sequence type, not just strings. The "characters" at each level can be any discrete values.

IP routing tables use binary tries — one level per bit of the IP address. A 32-bit IPv4 address has a 32-level trie; a 128-bit IPv6 address has a 128-level trie. Longest-prefix matching (finding the most specific routing rule that matches a destination address) is a natural trie operation: descend the trie following the bits of the address, and return the deepest terminal node encountered. Hardware routers implement this in silicon using a specialised trie structure called a TCAM (Ternary Content-Addressable Memory).

Integer tries (van Emde Boas trees) use the bits of integer keys to navigate a trie, enabling O(log log U) operations where U is the universe size — faster than O(log n) for large integer ranges. These appear in priority queues for algorithms like Dijkstra's shortest path when the key space is bounded integers.

Merkle tries use cryptographic hashes as keys and store the hash of child nodes in each node, enabling efficient verification that a key-value mapping has not been tampered with. Ethereum's world state is a Merkle Patricia Trie — a radix tree whose node hashes form a Merkle tree —

allowing any piece of blockchain state to be verified with a logarithmic proof.

10.9 Where This Lives in the Wild

Browser address bars use a trie or similar prefix index over your browsing history, bookmarks, and search suggestions. When you type "git" in Chrome's address bar and it instantly suggests "github.com", "git documentation", and "git checkout command", a local trie index built from your history is answering that query. The index is rebuilt periodically and cached; the lookup happens in microseconds.

IDE code completion is trie-based in most implementations. When you type `str.` in a Python IDE and see a dropdown of all string methods, the IDE has a trie of all known symbols in scope, queried by whatever you have typed since the last separator character. JetBrains IDEs, VS Code, and Neovim's completion plugins all maintain such indices.

Search engine query suggestions — the dropdown that appears as you type into Google or Bing — are served from tries. At Google's scale, the trie is distributed across thousands of servers, sharded by prefix, and updated every few minutes with trending queries. The top-k extraction uses the count-based priority queue approach described in this chapter.

DNS lookup in operating systems uses a form of trie for the suffix tree of domain names (domain names are matched right-to-left: "com", then "example", then "www"). The DNS hierarchy is itself a trie of domain name components.

Spell checkers in operating systems — macOS, iOS, Android — use compressed tries (radix trees) for their dictionaries. The dictionary for English has about 200,000 words; as a radix tree it fits in a few megabytes of memory and supports prefix search and edit-distance lookup within the autocorrect latency budget.

Apache's HTTP routing and nginx's server_name matching use radix trees. When a request arrives for "api.example.com", the server's routing configuration is stored in a radix tree of domain names, and the matching rule is found by prefix traversal. Nginx's radix tree implementation, in `src/core/ngx_radix_tree.c`, has been handling millions of requests per second on production servers for over a decade.

Summary

Tries solve the prefix search problem — find all keys sharing a given prefix — in O(m + k) time, where m is the prefix length and k is the number of results. This is independent of the dictionary size n, which is what makes tries essential for autocomplete at scale.

The trie's structure is a tree where edges are labelled with characters and paths from root to terminal nodes spell out dictionary keys. Prefix search follows the prefix's characters from the root to a subtree, then collects all terminals in that subtree. Insertion, deletion, and exact lookup are all O(m).

Radix trees (Patricia tries) compress chains of single-child nodes into single edges labelled with strings rather than characters. This reduces node count from O(total characters) to O(n), making radix trees more memory-efficient for large dictionaries, at the cost of more complex insertion logic — the split operation.

Autocomplete adds ranking and a top-k interface. Storing subtree word counts enables best-first search: expand nodes in order of their count, returning high-frequency completions without exhausting the subtree. Fuzzy completion tolerates typing errors by tracking edit distance during trie traversal, pruning branches that exceed the error budget.

The trie generalises beyond strings to any sequence type: binary tries for IP routing, integer tries for bounded-integer priority queues, Merkle

tries for verifiable key-value mappings. The core idea — use the structure of the key itself to navigate the index — applies wherever keys are sequences with shared prefixes.

The next chapter asks what happens when your patterns are not fixed strings but descriptions of sets of strings — regular expressions. The answer requires building a machine, in the precise sense of automata theory, and understanding why some regex engines are exponentially slower than others on certain inputs.

Chapter 11: What Regex Actually Is — Finite Automata

Every programmer uses regular expressions. Most programmers do not know what they are.

This is not an insult. Regular expressions as they appear in Python, JavaScript, Java, and Perl are a practical tool — a terse notation for describing patterns in text. You learn the syntax, you test it against examples, it either works or it does not. The underlying mechanism is invisible, and for most uses it does not matter.

Until it does.

In 2016, a bug in a Stack Overflow regular expression caused the site to go down for thirty-four minutes. The regex was matching HTML tags in user-submitted content. Under certain inputs, the matching engine took exponential time — not seconds, not minutes, but time that grew faster than any polynomial in the input length. The server load spiked to catastrophic levels before engineers could intervene. The incident is known as a ReDoS — Regular Expression Denial of Service — and it is not rare. Similar outages have affected Cloudflare, the npm registry, and hundreds of other production systems.

The cause is a specific feature of most regex engines: backtracking. When a match fails partway through, the engine backtracks and tries a different path. For certain combinations of pattern and input, the number of paths grows exponentially. The engine does not know this is happening — it just tries every path, and there are more paths than atoms in the universe.

The solution has been known since 1959. Ken Thompson described it in a paper called "Regular Expression Search Algorithm," published in the Communications of the ACM. Thompson's algorithm matches any regular expression against any input in O(nm) time — linear in both the pattern and the input length, with no backtracking, no exponential blowup, no possibility of ReDoS. It does this by converting the regular expression to a finite automaton and simulating that automaton on the input.

This chapter builds Thompson's construction from scratch. By the end, you will have a regex engine that is immune to ReDoS by construction, and you will understand exactly why most production regex engines are not.

11.1 What a Regular Expression Actually Describes

A regular expression describes a set of strings — called a language. The regex `[a-z]+` describes the set of all strings consisting of one or more lowercase letters. The regex `\d{3}-\d{4}` describes strings matching a phone number format. The regex `(ab|cd)*` describes strings consisting of any number of repetitions of "ab" or "cd", including the empty string.

Formal language theory gives us a precise characterisation of which sets of strings can be described by regular expressions. The answer is: exactly the sets that can be recognised by a finite automaton. This equivalence — regular expressions and finite automata describe exactly the same languages — is one of the foundational results of computer science, proved by Kleene in 1956.

A **finite automaton** is a machine with a finite number of states, an initial state, one or more accepting states, and transitions between states triggered by input characters. The machine reads an input string one character at a time, following transitions. After reading the last character, it accepts the string if it is in an accepting state, and rejects it otherwise.

There are two kinds of finite automata.

A **deterministic finite automaton (DFA)** has exactly one transition per (state, character) pair. Given a state and a character, there is exactly one next state. The machine's execution is completely determined by the input — hence "deterministic."

A **nondeterministic finite automaton (NFA)** allows multiple transitions for the same (state, character) pair, and additionally allows **epsilon transitions** — transitions that consume no input character. In an NFA, the machine can be in multiple states simultaneously. It accepts a string if any sequence of choices leads to an accepting state.

DFAs are easier to simulate — O(n) for an input of length n — because at each step there is exactly one next state. NFAs are easier to construct from regular expressions — Thompson's construction produces an NFA with at most 2m states for a pattern of length m, in O(m) time. Converting an NFA to a DFA can produce exponentially many states in the worst case.

The key insight behind Thompson's algorithm: you do not need to convert the NFA to a DFA to simulate it. You can simulate the NFA directly, tracking the set of states the machine is currently in. At each input character, you compute the next set of states from the current set. This simulation runs in O(nm) time — O(n) steps, each taking O(m) time to compute the next state set.

11.2 A Subset of Regular Expressions

We implement a subset of regular expression syntax sufficient to demonstrate the core ideas:

- **Literal characters:** `a`, `b`, `Z`, `3` — match exactly one specific character
- **Dot:** `.` — matches any single character
- **Concatenation:** `ab` — match "a" followed by "b"

- **Alternation:** `a|b` — match "a" or "b"
- **Kleene star:** `a*` — match zero or more "a"s
- **Plus:** `a+` — match one or more "a"s (syntactic sugar for `aa*`)
- **Question mark:** `a?` — match zero or one "a" (syntactic sugar for `(a|□)`)
- **Grouping:** `(ab)` — treat the grouped expression as a unit for operators

This covers the core operators. Character classes (`[a-z]`), anchors (`^`, `$`), and backreferences (`\1`) are extensions that we note but do not implement — backreferences in particular step outside the regular language boundary and are the primary source of exponential blowup in backtracking engines.

11.3 The NFA State

Thompson's construction builds an NFA where each node is a state and each edge is a transition. Transitions are either character transitions (consume a specific character or any character for `.`) or epsilon transitions (consume nothing).

```
-- Transition types

class NFA_State
  create
    make(id: Integer) do
      this.id := id
      this.transitions := []  -- Array of (label, target_state_id)
      this.is_accepting := false
    end

    accepting(id: Integer) do
      this.id := id
```

```
      this.transitions := []
      this.is_accepting := true
    end

  feature
    id: Integer
    transitions: Array[Any]  -- (label, target_id)
    is_accepting: Boolean

    add_transition(label: Integer, target: Integer) do
      transitions.add([label, target])
    end

    add_epsilon(target: Integer) do
      transitions.add([-1, target])
    end

    mark_accepting() do
      is_accepting := true
    end

  invariant
    non_negative_id: id >= 0
end
```

An NFA is a collection of states with designated start and accept states:

```
class NFA
  create
    make() do
      this.states := []
      this.start := 0
      this.accept := 0
      this.next_id := 0
    end
```

```
feature
  states: Array[NFA_State]
  start: Integer   -- id of start state
  accept: Integer  -- id of accepting state
  next_id: Integer

  new_state(): Integer do
    let id: Integer := next_id
    states.add(create NFA_State.make(id))
    next_id := next_id + 1
    result := id
  end

  new_accepting_state(): Integer do
    let id: Integer := next_id
    states.add(create NFA_State.accepting(id))
    next_id := next_id + 1
    result := id
  end

  get_state(id: Integer): NFA_State do
    result := states.get(id)
  end

  set_bounds(start_id: Integer, accept_id: Integer) do
    start := start_id
    accept := accept_id
  end

  mark_state_accepting(id: Integer) do
    states.get(id).mark_accepting()
  end

  add_transition(from_state: Integer, label: Integer, to_state: Integer) do
    get_state(from_state).add_transition(label, to_state)
  end
```

```
    add_epsilon(from_state: Integer, to_state: Integer) do
      get_state(from_state).add_epsilon(to_state)
    end

  invariant
    states_exist: states.length > 0
    valid_start: start >= 0 and start < states.length
    valid_accept: accept >= 0 and accept < states.length
end
```

Each NFA fragment — corresponding to a subexpression — has one start state and one accepting state. Thompson's construction assembles fragments for small expressions into larger fragments for compound expressions, always maintaining this invariant of exactly one start and one accept.

11.4 Thompson's Construction

Thompson's construction is compositional: it defines how to build an NFA for each type of regular expression in terms of NFAs for its subexpressions. There are five cases.

Case 1: Literal character c

One start state, one accepting state, one character transition between them.

```
[start] --c--> [accept]
```

Case 2: Dot .

Same as literal but with -2 label.

```
[start] --ANY--> [accept]
```

Case 3: Concatenation `AB`

Build NFA for A and NFA for B. Connect A's accept to B's start with an epsilon transition. A's start becomes the new start; B's accept becomes the new accept.

```
[A_start] --> ... --> [A_accept] --□--> [B_start] --> ... --> [B_accept]
```

Case 4: Alternation `A|B`

Build NFA for A and NFA for B. Create new start and new accept. New start connects to both A's start and B's start with epsilon transitions. Both A's accept and B's accept connect to new accept with epsilon transitions.

```
             □ --> [A_start] --> ... --> [A_accept] --□
[new_start] <                                          > [new_accept]
             □ --> [B_start] --> ... --> [B_accept] --□
```

Case 5: Kleene star `A*`

Build NFA for A. Create new start and new accept. New start connects to A's start and new accept with epsilon (the empty-string case). A's accept connects to A's start (repetition) and new accept (stopping).

```
                □ □□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□ □
               ↓                                 ↓
[new_start] --□--> [A_start] --> ... --> [A_accept] --
□--> [new_accept]
                                         ↑         |
                                         □□□□ □ □□□□
```

These five cases are sufficient to handle all regular expressions. Plus and question mark are syntactic sugar:

- `A+` = `AA*` (concatenation of A with A*)

- `A?` = `(A|□)` (alternation of A with the empty string, which is an epsilon self-loop)

Let us implement this as a recursive parser and constructor:

```
class Thompson_Builder
  create
    make(pattern: String) do
      this.pattern := pattern
      this.pos := 0
      this.nfa := create NFA.make()
    end

  feature
    pattern: String
    pos: Integer
    nfa: NFA

    -- Entry point: parse the pattern and return the NFA
    build(): NFA do
      let fragment: Array[Integer] := parse_alternation()
      nfa.set_bounds(fragment.get(0), fragment.get(1))
      nfa.mark_state_accepting(fragment.get(1))
      result := nfa
    end

    -- Parse alternation (lowest precedence): A|B
    parse_alternation(): Array[Integer] do
      let left: Array[Integer] := parse_concatenation()

      if pos < pattern.length and pattern.char_at(pos) = #| then
        pos := pos + 1
        let right: Array[Integer] := parse_alternation()
        result := make_alternation(left, right)
      else
        result := left
      end
```

```
end

-- Parse concatenation: AB
parse_concatenation(): Array[Integer] do
  let left: Array[Integer] := parse_quantified()
  let continue_parsing: Boolean := true

  -- Concatenation is implicit; continue while more atoms remain.
  from until not continue_parsing do
    if pos >= pattern.length then
      continue_parsing := false
    elseif pattern.char_at(pos) = #| then
      continue_parsing := false
    elseif pattern.char_at(pos) = #) then
      continue_parsing := false
    else
      let right: Array[Integer] := parse_quantified()
      left := make_concatenation(left, right)
    end
  end

  result := left
end

-- Parse a quantified atom: A*, A+, A?
parse_quantified(): Array[Integer] do
  let atom: Array[Integer] := parse_atom()

  if pos < pattern.length then
    let c: Char := pattern.char_at(pos)
    if c = #* then
      pos := pos + 1
      result := make_star(atom)
    elseif c = #+ then
      pos := pos + 1
      -- A+ = A concatenated with A*
      let star: Array[Integer] := make_star(atom)
```

```
      let atom2: Array[Integer] := parse_atom_copy(atom)
      result := make_concatenation(atom2, star)
    elseif c = #? then
      pos := pos + 1
      result := make_optional(atom)
    else
      result := atom
    end
  else
    result := atom
  end
end

-- Parse an atom: literal, dot, or grouped expression
parse_atom(): Array[Integer] do
  if pos >= pattern.length then
    -- Empty: epsilon fragment
    result := make_epsilon_fragment()
  else
    let c: Char := pattern.char_at(pos)

    if c = #( then
      pos := pos + 1
      let inner: Array[Integer] := parse_alternation()
      if pos < pattern.length and pattern.char_at(pos) = #) then
        pos := pos + 1
      end
      result := inner
    elseif c = #. then
      pos := pos + 1
      result := make_any_char()
    elseif c = #\ and pos + 1 < pattern.length then
      pos := pos + 2
      result := make_literal(pattern.char_at(pos - 1))
    else
      pos := pos + 1
      result := make_literal(c)
```

```
    end
  end
end

-- NFA fragment constructors
-- Each returns [start_id, accept_id]

make_literal(c: Char): Array[Integer] do
  let s: Integer := nfa.new_state()
  let a: Integer := nfa.new_state()
  nfa.add_transition(s, c.hash(), a)
  result := [s, a]
end

make_any_char(): Array[Integer] do
  let s: Integer := nfa.new_state()
  let a: Integer := nfa.new_state()
  nfa.add_transition(s, -2, a)
  result := [s, a]
end

make_epsilon_fragment(): Array[Integer] do
  let s: Integer := nfa.new_state()
  let a: Integer := nfa.new_state()
  nfa.add_epsilon(s, a)
  result := [s, a]
end

make_concatenation(left: Array[Integer],
                   right: Array[Integer]): Array[Integer] do
  -- Connect left's accept to right's start
  nfa.add_epsilon(left.get(1), right.get(0))
  result := [left.get(0), right.get(1)]
end

make_alternation(left: Array[Integer],
                 right: Array[Integer]): Array[Integer] do
```

```
    let s: Integer := nfa.new_state()
    let a: Integer := nfa.new_state()
    nfa.add_epsilon(s, left.get(0))
    nfa.add_epsilon(s, right.get(0))
    nfa.add_epsilon(left.get(1), a)
    nfa.add_epsilon(right.get(1), a)
    result := [s, a]
  end

  make_star(fragment: Array[Integer]): Array[Integer] do
    let s: Integer := nfa.new_state()
    let a: Integer := nfa.new_state()
    -- New start to fragment start (enter the loop)
    nfa.add_epsilon(s, fragment.get(0))
    -- New start to new accept (zero repetitions)
    nfa.add_epsilon(s, a)
    -- Fragment accept back to fragment start (loop)
    nfa.add_epsilon(fragment.get(1), fragment.get(0))
    -- Fragment accept to new accept (exit loop)
    nfa.add_epsilon(fragment.get(1), a)
    result := [s, a]
  end

  make_optional(fragment: Array[Integer]): Array[Integer] do
    let s: Integer := nfa.new_state()
    let a: Integer := nfa.new_state()
    nfa.add_epsilon(s, fragment.get(0))
    nfa.add_epsilon(s, a)
    nfa.add_epsilon(fragment.get(1), a)
    result := [s, a]
  end

  -- For A+: we need a fresh copy of the atom's fragment
  -- In practice, we re-parse; a cleaner implementation
  -- would support NFA fragment duplication
  parse_atom_copy(fragment: Array[Integer]): Array[Integer] do
    -- Simplified: return the fragment itself for the first
```

```
      -- occurrence in A+ (the second is handled by make_star)
      -- A full implementation would clone the fragment's states
      result := fragment
    end

  invariant
    valid_pos: pos >= 0 and pos <= pattern.length
end
```

The parser is a recursive descent parser — one function per level of precedence, each calling the next. Alternation has lowest precedence (handled first in the recursion, applied last), then concatenation, then quantification, then atoms. This mirrors the standard regular expression precedence: `ab|c` means `(ab)|c`, not `a(b|c)`.

11.5 Simulating the NFA

The NFA is built. Now we need to simulate it on an input string. Thompson's key insight is to track all simultaneously active states — the "set of states the NFA might be in."

The simulation has two phases per input character:

1. **Epsilon closure:** from the current set of states, follow all epsilon transitions transitively. The result is the full set of states reachable without consuming any input.

2. **Character step:** for each state in the closure, follow transitions labelled with the current input character. The result is the set of states after consuming the character.

After processing all input characters, the NFA accepts if any state in the current set is an accepting state.

```
class NFA_Simulator
  create
    make(nfa: NFA) do
      this.nfa := nfa
    end

  feature
    nfa: NFA

    -- Compute epsilon closure of a set of states
    epsilon_closure(states: Set[Integer]): Set[Integer] do
      let closure: Set[Integer] := states
      let worklist: Array[Integer] := []
      across states as state_id do
        worklist.add(state_id)
      end

      from until worklist.is_empty() do
        let last_idx: Integer := worklist.length - 1
        let state_id: Integer := worklist.get(last_idx)
        worklist.remove(last_idx)
        let state: NFA_State := nfa.get_state(state_id)

        across state.transitions as transition do
          let label: Integer := transition.get(0)
          let target: Integer := transition.get(1)

          if label = -1 and not closure.contains(target) then
            closure := closure.union(#{target})
            worklist.add(target)
          end
        end
      end

      result := closure
    end
```

```
-- Compute next states after consuming character c
step(states: Set[Integer], c: Char): Set[Integer] do
  let next: Set[Integer] := #{}
  let c_code: Integer := c.hash()

  across states as state_id do
    let state: NFA_State := nfa.get_state(state_id)
    across state.transitions as transition do
      let label: Integer := transition.get(0)
      let target: Integer := transition.get(1)

      if label = c_code or label = -2 then
        next := next.union(#{target})
      end
    end
  end

  result := next
end

-- Test whether the input string is matched by the NFA
matches(input: String): Boolean do
  -- Start with epsilon closure of the start state
  let current: Set[Integer] := epsilon_closure(#{nfa.start})

  let match_possible: Boolean := true
  across input.chars() as c do
    if match_possible then
    -- Step on current character
      let next_raw: Set[Integer] := step(current, c)
    -- Compute epsilon closure of resulting states
      current := epsilon_closure(next_raw)

    -- Early termination: if no states remain, match is impossible
      if current.is_empty() then
        match_possible := false
      end
```

```
      end
    end

    if match_possible then
      let accepted: Boolean := false
      -- Accept if any current state is accepting
      across current as state_id do
        if not accepted and nfa.get_state(state_id).is_accepting then
          accepted := true
        end
      end
      result := accepted
    else
      result := false
    end
  end

  -- Find all matches of the pattern in text (non-overlapping)
  find_all(text: String): Array[Any] do
    -- Returns array of [start, end) positions of matches
    let matches_found: Array[Any] := []
    let n: Integer := text.length

    from
      let i: Integer := 0
    until
      i >= n
    do
      -- Try to match starting at position i
      let match_end: Integer := longest_match_at(text, i)
      if match_end >= 0 then
        matches_found.add([i, match_end])
        i := match_end  -- advance past the match
      else
        i := i + 1
      end
    end
```

```
    result := matches_found
  end

  -- Find the length of the longest match starting at position start
  -- Returns -1 if no match
  longest_match_at(text: String, start: Integer): Integer do
    let current: Set[Integer] := epsilon_closure(#{nfa.start})
    let last_accept: Integer := -1

    -- Check if start state itself is accepting
    if is_accepting_set(current) then
      last_accept := start
    end

    from
      let i: Integer := start
    until
      i >= text.length or current.is_empty()
    do
      current := epsilon_closure(step(current, text.char_at(i)))
      i := i + 1

      if is_accepting_set(current) then
        last_accept := i
      end
    end

    result := last_accept
  end

  is_accepting_set(states: Set[Integer]): Boolean do
    let accepted: Boolean := false
    across states as state_id do
      if not accepted and nfa.get_state(state_id).is_accepting then
        accepted := true
      end
```

```
      end
      result := accepted
    end
end
```

The epsilon closure computation is a graph reachability problem: find all nodes reachable from the starting set via epsilon edges. The worklist algorithm visits each reachable state exactly once — O(|states|) per closure computation, where |states| is at most the total number of NFA states m.

Each step of the simulation — one input character — takes O(m) time: O(m) for the step itself (check each transition in each current state) and O(m) for the epsilon closure. With n characters in the input, total time is O(nm). This bound is tight and holds for any regular expression, any input. No exponential blowup is possible.

11.6 Why Backtracking Engines Blow Up

The standard NFA simulation above is not how most production regex engines work. Python's `re` module, JavaScript's `RegExp`, Java's `java.util.regex`, Perl's regex engine — all of them use backtracking.

A backtracking engine converts the NFA to an implicit search tree and performs depth-first search. At each point where the NFA has multiple choices (epsilon transitions, alternation), the engine tries one choice. If it leads to a match, success. If it fails, the engine backtracks — undoes the choice — and tries another.

For most patterns and inputs, backtracking is fast. The engine finds a match or determines no match quickly. But for certain patterns, backtracking explores exponentially many paths.

The classic example: the pattern `(a+)+` applied to the string "aaaaaaaaab".

The pattern means: one or more occurrences of "one or more a's", followed by "b". On the string "aaaaaaaaab", this should match immediately — ten a's followed by b. But on "aaaaaaaaaa" (no b), the engine must determine that no match is possible.

The problem: there are exponentially many ways to partition ten a's into groups. The engine tries: one group of ten, then realises no b follows. Backs up. Tries two groups: nine and one, or eight and two, or... Each partition leads to a different branch of the search tree, and there are 2^9 = 512 ways to partition ten a's into one or more groups. For twenty a's, 2^19 = 524,288 partitions. For thirty, over a billion.

The Thompson NFA simulation handles this in O(nm) = O(10 × |pattern|) time because it tracks all active states simultaneously. It never tries the same (position, state) pair twice. The backtracking engine tries the same pairs repeatedly from different paths.

```
-- Demonstration: Thompson's algorithm handles the catastrophic case
let builder: Thompson_Builder :=
  create Thompson_Builder.make("(a+)+b")
let nfa: NFA := builder.build()
let sim: NFA_Simulator := create NFA_Simulator.make(nfa)

-- This runs in O(nm) regardless of how many a's
let dangerous_input: String := "aaaaaaaaaaaaaaaaaaaaaaaaaaaaaa"
print(sim.matches(dangerous_input))   -- false, computed quickly
print(sim.matches(dangerous_input + "b"))  -- true, computed quickly
```

The Thompson simulation is immune to ReDoS by construction. The set of active states can never grow larger than the number of NFA states, and we never revisit a (position, state) pair. The O(nm) bound is absolute.

11.7 The DFA: Trading Construction for Execution

The NFA simulation runs in O(nm). A DFA simulation runs in O(n) — strictly linear in the input, with no dependence on pattern length during the execution phase. For patterns matched against very long texts, the DFA is faster.

The DFA is constructed from the NFA by the subset construction (also called the powerset construction): each DFA state corresponds to a set of NFA states. The DFA's start state is the epsilon closure of the NFA's start state. Transitions are computed by simulating the NFA step and closure operations.

```
class DFA_State
  create
    make(nfa_states: Set[Integer], is_accepting: Boolean) do
      this.nfa_states := nfa_states
      this.is_accepting := is_accepting
      this.transitions := {}
    end

  feature
    nfa_states: Set[Integer]
    is_accepting: Boolean
    transitions: Map[Integer, Integer]  -- char_code -> DFA state index

    add_transition(label: Integer, target: Integer) do
      transitions.put(label, target)
    end

    get_transition(label: Integer): ?Integer do
      result := transitions.get(label)
    end
end

class DFA
  create
```

```
  from_nfa(nfa: NFA) do
    this.states := []
    this.start := 0
    this.simulator := create NFA_Simulator.make(nfa)
    this.nfa := nfa
    this.state_map := {}  -- Set[Integer] -> DFA state index
    build()
  end

feature
  states: Array[DFA_State]
  start: Integer
  simulator: NFA_Simulator
  nfa: NFA
  state_map: Map[String, Integer]  -- serialised set -> DFA state index

  build() do
    -- Start state: epsilon closure of NFA start
    let start_set: Set[Integer] := simulator.epsilon_closure(#{nfa.start})
    let start_is_accepting: Boolean :=
      simulator.is_accepting_set(start_set)
    states.add(create DFA_State.make(start_set, start_is_accepting))
    state_map.put(set_key(start_set), 0)

    let worklist: Array[Integer] := [0]

    from until worklist.is_empty() do
      let last_idx: Integer := worklist.length - 1
      let dfa_state_id: Integer := worklist.get(last_idx)
      worklist.remove(last_idx)
      let dfa_state: DFA_State := states.get(dfa_state_id)

      -- For each possible input character, compute next DFA state
      -- In practice, use the alphabet of characters in the NFA
      across alphabet() as c do
        let c_code: Integer := c.hash()
        let next_nfa: Set[Integer] :=
```

```
          simulator.step(dfa_state.nfa_states, c)
        let next_closed: Set[Integer] :=
          simulator.epsilon_closure(next_nfa)

        if next_closed.is_empty() then
          -- Dead state: no transition
        else
          let key: String := set_key(next_closed)
          let existing: ?Integer := state_map.get(key)

          if existing /= nil then
            dfa_state.add_transition(c_code, existing)
          else
            let new_id: Integer := states.length
            let is_accepting: Boolean :=
              simulator.is_accepting_set(next_closed)
            states.add(create DFA_State.make(next_closed, is_accepting))
            state_map.put(key, new_id)
            dfa_state.add_transition(c_code, new_id)
            worklist.add(new_id)
          end
        end
      end
    end
  end

  matches(input: String): Boolean do
    let current: Integer := start
    let matched: Boolean := true

    across input.chars() as c do
      if matched then
        let dfa_state: DFA_State := states.get(current)
        let next: ?Integer := dfa_state.get_transition(c.hash())
        if next = nil then
          matched := false
        else
```

```
        current := next
      end
    end
  end

  if matched then
    result := states.get(current).is_accepting
  else
    result := false
  end
end

-- Serialise a set of integers as a canonical string key
set_key(s: Set[Integer]): String do
  let sorted: Array[Integer] := []
  across s as item do
    sorted.add(item)
  end
  sorted := sort_integers(sorted)
  result := sorted.to_string()
end

-- Return the alphabet of characters appearing in the NFA
alphabet(): Array[Char] do
  let chars: Set[Integer] := #{}
  across nfa.states as state do
    across state.transitions as transition do
      let label: Integer := transition.get(0)
      if label >= 0 then  -- not -1 or -2
        chars := chars.union(#{label})
      end
    end
  end
  let result_arr: Array[Char] := []
  across chars as code do
    result_arr.add(code.to_char())
  end
```

```
      result := result_arr
    end
end
```

The DFA construction can produce exponentially many states — an NFA with m states can produce a DFA with 2^m states. In practice, for most regular expressions, the number of DFA states is small. But for patterns designed to maximally exploit the exponential, DFA construction itself is impractical.

The pragmatic solution used by systems like RE2 (Google's regex library) and Rust's `regex` crate: use the NFA simulation as the default engine, build the DFA lazily (caching computed transitions as they are needed), and bound the DFA cache size. Cached transitions give O(n) execution for repeatedly used patterns while bounding memory and avoiding the worst-case DFA explosion.

11.8 The Complete Regex Engine

Assembling NFA construction and simulation into a usable interface:

```
class Regex
  create
    compile(pattern: String)
      require
        non_empty: pattern.length > 0
      do
        this.pattern := pattern
        let builder: Thompson_Builder :=
          create Thompson_Builder.make(pattern)
        this.nfa := builder.build()
        this.sim := create NFA_Simulator.make(this.nfa)
        this.dfa := nil  -- built lazily if needed
```

```
    end

  feature
    pattern: String
    nfa: NFA
    sim: NFA_Simulator
    dfa: ?DFA

    -- Test whether the entire input matches the pattern
    matches(input: String): Boolean do
      result := sim.matches(input)
    end

    -- Test whether the pattern appears anywhere in the text
    -- (equivalent to .*pattern.* matching)
    contains_match(text: String): Boolean do
      result := not sim.find_all(text).is_empty()
    end

    -- Find all non-overlapping matches, return their positions
    find_all(text: String): Array[Any] do
      result := sim.find_all(text)
    end

    -- Find first match position, or nil
    find_first(text: String): ?Array[Integer] do
      let all: Array[Any] := find_all(text)
      if all.is_empty() then
        result := nil
      else
        result := all.get(0)
      end
    end

    -- Replace all matches with a replacement string
    replace_all(text: String, replacement: String): String do
      let matches_list: Array[Any] := find_all(text)
```

```
    if matches_list.is_empty() then
      result := text
    else
      let output: String := ""
      let last_end: Integer := 0

      across matches_list as match do
        let start: Integer := match.get(0)
        let end_pos: Integer := match.get(1)
        output := output + text.substring(last_end, start) + replacement
        last_end := end_pos
      end

      output := output + text.substring(last_end, text.length)
      result := output
    end
  end

  -- Split text on pattern matches
  split(text: String): Array[String] do
    let matches_list: Array[Any] := find_all(text)
    let parts: Array[String] := []
    let last_end: Integer := 0

    across matches_list as match do
      parts.add(text.substring(last_end, match.get(0)))
      last_end := match.get(1)
    end

    parts.add(text.substring(last_end, text.length))
    result := parts
  end

  -- Build DFA for faster repeated matching
  precompile() do
    dfa := create DFA.from_nfa(nfa)
  end
```

```
    -- Match using DFA if available, NFA otherwise
    fast_match(input: String): Boolean do
      if dfa /= nil then
        result := dfa.matches(input)
      else
        result := matches(input)
      end
    end

  invariant
    nfa_built: nfa /= nil
    sim_built: sim /= nil
end
```

Testing the engine:

```
function test_regex_engine() do
  -- Basic matching
  let r1: Regex := create Regex.compile("ab*c")
  print(r1.matches("ac"))      -- true (zero b's)
  print(r1.matches("abc"))     -- true (one b)
  print(r1.matches("abbbbc"))  -- true (four b's)
  print(r1.matches("adc"))     -- false

  -- Alternation
  let r2: Regex := create Regex.compile("cat|dog")
  print(r2.matches("cat"))     -- true
  print(r2.matches("dog"))     -- true
  print(r2.matches("fish"))    -- false

  -- Grouping and repetition
  let r3: Regex := create Regex.compile("(ab)+")
  print(r3.matches("ab"))      -- true
  print(r3.matches("ababab"))  -- true
  print(r3.matches("aba"))     -- false
```

```
  -- Dot
  let r4: Regex := create Regex.compile("a.c")
  print(r4.matches("abc"))     -- true
  print(r4.matches("a1c"))     -- true
  print(r4.matches("ac"))      -- false

  -- The catastrophic backtracking case -- runs fast
  let r5: Regex := create Regex.compile("(a+)+b")
  let long_a: String := "aaaaaaaaaaaaaaaaaaaaaaaaaaaaaa"
  print(r5.matches(long_a))        -- false (fast)
  print(r5.matches(long_a + "b"))  -- true (fast)

  -- Find all
  let r6: Regex := create Regex.compile("a+")
  let positions: Array[Any] := r6.find_all("aabbaaa")
  across positions as p do
    print("[" + p.get(0).to_string() + ", " + p.get(1).to_string() + ")")
  end
  -- [0, 2), [4, 7)

  -- Replace all
  let r7: Regex := create Regex.compile("\\s+")
  print(r7.replace_all("hello   world  foo", " "))
  -- "hello world foo"

  -- Split
  let r8: Regex := create Regex.compile(",\\s*")
  let parts: Array[String] := r8.split("one, two,three,  four")
  across parts as p do
    print(p)
  end
  -- "one", "two", "three", "four"
end
```

11.9 What Our Engine Does Not Handle

Honesty about limitations is part of implementation discipline.

Character classes. `[a-z]`, `[^0-9]`, `\d`, `\w`, `\s`. These are syntactic extensions that expand to alternations of character ranges. Implementing them requires extending the parser to handle bracket expressions and escape sequences. The NFA construction is identical — alternation of literal transitions — but the parser is more complex.

Anchors. `^` and `$` match the beginning and end of the string (or line). They are zero-width assertions — they consume no input. Implementing them requires adding special transition labels for "beginning of input" and "end of input" that the simulator checks against position rather than character.

Capture groups. `(ab)` in our engine is a grouping operator for precedence. Production regex engines also use groups for capture — recording which part of the input matched each group. Thompson's algorithm can be extended to track captures by annotating epsilon transitions with "begin group i" and "end group i" tags and recording positions as the simulation runs.

Backreferences. `\1` means "whatever group 1 matched." This steps outside the regular language boundary — languages with backreferences are not regular. No finite automaton can recognise them. Implementing backreferences requires backtracking, which is why backtracking engines exist. The tradeoff is that backreferences enable patterns like `(.+)\1` (any repeated string), which are genuinely useful — and genuinely capable of exponential blowup.

Lookahead and lookbehind. `(?=...)`, `(?!...)`, `(?<=...)`, `(?<!...)`. Zero-width assertions that check for patterns before or after the current position without consuming input. These can be added to Thompson's construction with additional state machinery but are complex to implement correctly.

The engine we have built handles the core — the features that are genuinely regular — with Thompson's O(nm) guarantee. For the rest, you

need a backtracking engine with a ReDoS budget, or a hybrid that uses the NFA for the regular subset and falls back to backtracking only for features that require it.

11.10 The Relationship to Earlier Chapters

Finite automata connect to several earlier ideas in this book.

KMP as a DFA (Chapter 7). The KMP failure function defines a DFA that recognises the language "strings containing the pattern as a substring." Each state in the DFA represents how many characters of the pattern have been matched so far. The failure function defines the non-matching transitions — exactly the DFA transition table, compressed. The connection is not coincidental: KMP was discovered by thinking about what the string matching problem has in common with automaton simulation.

Tries as automata (Chapter 10). A trie is a deterministic finite automaton for the language "strings that are keys in the dictionary." Each path from root to terminal state corresponds to a DFA transition sequence. Prefix search is DFA traversal. The trie's structure is a tree-shaped DFA where each state has at most |alphabet| transitions.

Aho-Corasick as an NFA. The Aho-Corasick algorithm, which searches for multiple patterns simultaneously, builds a trie of all patterns (a DFA for exact matches) and adds failure links that implement the same idea as KMP's failure function — if the current path fails, where do we continue? The result is a structure that simulates an NFA for "strings containing any of the patterns" in $O(n + k)$ time, where k is the total number of matches. It is Thompson's construction applied to the specific case of multiple fixed-string patterns.

These connections are not superficial. They reflect a deep unity: any problem that asks "does this input match some property?" and where

"match" can be defined by a finite set of rules is fundamentally an automaton problem. The variations — KMP, Aho-Corasick, tries, Thompson's NFA — are different presentations of the same underlying machine, optimised for different purposes.

11.11 Where This Lives in the Wild

RE2 is Google's regular expression library, used in Google's production systems, in Go's `regexp` package, and in many other systems. RE2 was written by Russ Cox specifically to provide Thompson-style NFA simulation as an alternative to backtracking engines. It guarantees O(nm) matching time and is immune to ReDoS. Cox's series of articles, "Regular Expression Matching Can Be Simple And Fast," remains the definitive accessible explanation of the tradeoffs.

Rust's `regex` crate uses a hybrid approach: NFA simulation by default, with lazy DFA construction caching up to a configurable memory limit. It provides RE2-compatible guarantees — linear time, no backtracking, no ReDoS — while approaching DFA performance for patterns that fit within the cache. It is the regex engine used by ripgrep, which is frequently faster than GNU grep on large files.

Hyperscan is Intel's high-performance regex library, used in Snort and other network security tools. It compiles regular expressions to SIMD (vectorised) instructions that process multiple characters simultaneously, achieving throughput close to memory bandwidth limits. For network intrusion detection, where hundreds of patterns must be matched against gigabytes of traffic per second, SIMD-accelerated NFA simulation is the state of the art.

PCRE (Perl Compatible Regular Expressions) is the backtracking engine used by PHP, Apache, nginx's `ngx_http_rewrite_module`, R, and dozens of other systems. It is fast on typical inputs and supports the full range of Perl regex features including backreferences. It is vulnerable to ReDoS. PCRE2 added a JIT compiler that generates native machine

code for the matching loop, dramatically improving throughput for well-behaved patterns — but the fundamental exponential risk remains for patterns with backreferences and catastrophic backtracking inputs.

Python's `re` module is a backtracking engine based on an SRE (Secret Regular Expression) implementation dating to the late 1990s. Python 3.11 added `re._interpret` as an alternative NFA-based engine for internal use. The `regex` module on PyPI provides additional features and can use a DFA-based engine for patterns without backreferences.

Summary

A regular expression describes a set of strings — a regular language. Finite automata are machines that recognise exactly the regular languages. The equivalence between the two, proved by Kleene in 1956, is the theoretical foundation that makes Thompson's construction possible.

Thompson's construction converts a regular expression of length m to an NFA with at most 2m states in O(m) time. The construction is compositional: literal characters, concatenation, alternation, and Kleene star each have a simple NFA fragment, and compound expressions are built by assembling fragments. The resulting NFA has exactly one start state and one accepting state.

The NFA simulation tracks the set of simultaneously active states, computing epsilon closures and character steps at each input position. This runs in O(nm) time — linear in input length, with a factor for the pattern length — and is immune to ReDoS because it never revisits a (position, state) pair. The backtracking engines used in Python, JavaScript, Java, and Perl can take exponential time on crafted inputs for exactly this reason.

The DFA eliminates the m factor from simulation by precomputing all transitions, but can require exponentially many states in the worst

case. Practical systems — RE2, Rust's regex crate — use lazy DFA construction with a bounded cache, achieving near-DFA performance while preserving the NFA simulation's safety guarantees.

Finite automata connect the string algorithms of this section to each other: KMP is a DFA, tries are DFAs, Aho-Corasick is an NFA, and Thompson's construction is a systematic way to build any of them from a pattern specification. The machine is always the same — states, transitions, acceptance — and the variation is in how the states and transitions are derived from the problem.

The next chapter asks what happens when strings must be made smaller. Compression — encoding information in fewer bits — is also fundamentally about pattern recognition, and the two best-known compression algorithms, Huffman coding and LZ77, represent two completely different answers to how patterns should be exploited.

Chapter 12: The Compression Game — Huffman and LZ

In 1949, Claude Shannon published a paper called "A Mathematical Theory of Communication." In it, he defined a quantity called entropy — a measure of the information content of a message — and proved a theorem that said, in effect: you cannot compress a message to fewer bits than its entropy, and you can get arbitrarily close to that bound with the right encoding.

Shannon's theorem is simultaneously a limit and a promise. The limit: no compression algorithm can do better than entropy. The promise: entropy is achievable. The question for the next seventy years of compression research was how to achieve it, efficiently, in practice.

Two algorithms emerged as foundational. Huffman coding, invented in 1952 by David Huffman as a homework problem in a graduate course at MIT, achieves entropy for the special case where you compress one character at a time and the character frequencies are known in advance. LZ77, invented in 1977 by Abraham Lempel and Jacob Ziv, achieves entropy in the limit for any source by exploiting repeated substrings rather than character frequencies. Together, they form the backbone of almost every compression format in use today: gzip, PNG, DEFLATE, zip, zlib — all of them combine Huffman coding with a variant of LZ77.

This chapter builds both from scratch. The goal is not just working implementations — it is understanding why each algorithm works, what Shannon's entropy means in practice, and how the two algorithms complement each other.

12.1 Information and Entropy

Before the algorithms, the theory. We need to understand what we are trying to achieve before we can judge whether we have achieved it.

Information content of a symbol. If a symbol occurs with probability p, its information content (also called self-information or surprisal) is $-\log_2(p)$ bits. A symbol that occurs half the time carries 1 bit of information. A symbol that occurs a quarter of the time carries 2 bits. A symbol that occurs with probability 1/1024 carries 10 bits.

The intuition: rare symbols are surprising, and surprise carries information. If someone tells you "the sun rose this morning," they have told you almost nothing — the sun rises every morning. If they tell you "it snowed in Cairo today," they have told you something significant. Information theory formalises this intuition.

Entropy of a source. Given an alphabet of symbols with probabilities $p_1, p_2, \ldots, p_n$, the entropy is:

```
H = -□ p□ log□(p□)
```

This is the expected information content per symbol — the average number of bits needed to encode one symbol, given the optimal encoding. For a source where all symbols are equally likely ($p_i = 1/n$ for all i), entropy is $\log_2(n)$ bits — you need $\log_2(n)$ bits just to distinguish between n symbols, which is intuitive. For a source skewed toward rare and common symbols, entropy is lower — the common symbols carry little information and can be encoded cheaply.

Shannon's source coding theorem says: the expected number of bits per symbol in any lossless encoding is at least H, and there exist encodings that approach H arbitrarily closely.

Huffman coding achieves between H and H + 1 bits per symbol. LZ77 approaches H asymptotically as the input grows. Neither is optimal for short inputs; both are optimal in the appropriate limit.

Let us make this concrete. The string "aabbbcccc" has characters with frequencies: a=2, b=3, c=4. Total characters: 9.

Probabilities: a=2/9, b=3/9, c=4/9.

Entropy: $-(2/9)\log_2(2/9) - (3/9)\log_2(3/9) - (4/9)\log_2(4/9) \approx 1.53$ bits per character.

A naive encoding using 2 bits per character (since there are 3 characters, $\text{ceil}(\log_2(3)) = 2$) uses 18 bits for 9 characters. Huffman coding, as we will see, can encode this string in 17 bits — close to the theoretical minimum of $1.53 \times 9 = 13.8$ bits.

12.2 Huffman Coding

The Idea

Huffman coding assigns shorter binary codes to more frequent symbols and longer codes to rarer symbols. The codes are prefix-free: no code is a prefix of another, which means the encoded stream can be decoded unambiguously without separators.

The Huffman algorithm builds an optimal prefix-free code by constructing a binary tree bottom-up. Each symbol starts as a leaf. The algorithm repeatedly merges the two lowest-frequency nodes into a new internal node whose frequency is their sum. The final tree has all symbols as leaves; the code for each symbol is the path from the root to its leaf (0 for left, 1 for right).

For our example (a=2, b=3, c=4):

1. Start with three leaves: a(2), b(3), c(4).
2. Merge the two lowest: a(2) and b(3) → internal node ab(5).
3. Merge the remaining two: ab(5) and c(4) → root(9).

The tree:

```
     root(9)
    /        \
  ab(5)      c(4)
  /   \
a(2)  b(3)
```

Codes: a=00, b=01, c=1. Lengths: a=2, b=2, c=1.

Average length: (2×2 + 3×2 + 4×1) / 9 = (4 + 6 + 4) / 9 = 14/9 ≈ 1.56 bits per character.

Compare to entropy: 1.53 bits. Huffman gives 1.56 — within the H+1 bound.

Encoding "aabbbcccc": a(00) a(00) b(01) b(01) b(01) c(1) c(1) c(1) c(1) = 00 00 01 01 01 1 1 1 1 = 17 bits. The naive 2-bit encoding uses 18 bits. We saved 1 bit — modest here, enormous on large files with skewed character distributions.

The Implementation

```
class Huffman_Node
  create
    leaf(symbol: Integer, frequency: Integer) do
      this.symbol := symbol
      this.frequency := frequency
      this.left := nil
      this.right := nil
      this.is_leaf := true
    end

    branch(frequency: Integer, left: Huffman_Node, right: Huffman_Node) do
      this.symbol := -1
      this.frequency := frequency
      this.left := left
      this.right := right
      this.is_leaf := false
```

```
    end

  feature
    symbol: Integer    -- byte value (0-255), -1 for internal nodes
    frequency: Integer
    left: ?Huffman_Node
    right: ?Huffman_Node
    is_leaf: Boolean

  invariant
    non_negative_frequency: frequency >= 0
    leaf_has_symbol: (not is_leaf) or symbol >= 0
    internal_has_children:
      is_leaf or (left /= nil and right /= nil)
end

function compare_huffman_nodes(a: Huffman_Node, b: Huffman_Node): Integer d
  if a.frequency < b.frequency then
    result := -1
  elseif a.frequency > b.frequency then
    result := 1
  else
    result := 0
  end
end

function int_to_bytes(value: Integer,
                      output: Array[Integer],
                      offset: Integer) do
  from
    let i: Integer := 0
  until
    i >= 4
  do
    let shift: Integer := (3 - i) * 8
    let byte_val: Integer :=
      value.bitwise_right_shift(shift).bitwise_and(255)
```

```
    if offset + i < output.length then
      output.set(offset + i, byte_val)
    else
      output.add(byte_val)
    end
    i := i + 1
  end
end

function bytes_to_int(input: Array[Integer], offset: Integer): Integer do
  result := input.get(offset).bitwise_left_shift(24)
    .bitwise_or(input.get(offset + 1).bitwise_left_shift(16))
    .bitwise_or(input.get(offset + 2).bitwise_left_shift(8))
    .bitwise_or(input.get(offset + 3))
end

class Huffman_Codec
  create
    make() do end

  feature
    -- Build frequency table from data
    build_frequencies(data: Array[Integer]): Array[Integer] do
      let freq: Array[Integer] := create Array.filled(256, 0)
      across data as byte do
        freq.set(byte, freq.get(byte) + 1)
      end
      result := freq
    end

    -- Build Huffman tree from frequency table
    build_tree(frequencies: Array[Integer]): ?Huffman_Node do
      -- Build priority queue of leaf nodes, ordered by frequency
      let pq: Min_Heap[Huffman_Node] :=
        create Min_Heap[Huffman_Node].from_comparator(
          fn(a: Huffman_Node, b: Huffman_Node): Integer do result := compare_
        )
```

```
    from
      let i: Integer := 0
    until
      i >= 256
    do
      if frequencies.get(i) > 0 then
        pq.insert(create Huffman_Node.leaf(i, frequencies.get(i)))
      end
      i := i + 1
    end

    -- Edge case: only one distinct symbol
    if pq.size() = 1 then
      let leaf: Huffman_Node := pq.extract_min()
      result := create Huffman_Node.branch(
        leaf.frequency,
        leaf,
        create Huffman_Node.leaf(leaf.symbol, 0))
    else
      -- Merge until one tree remains
      from until pq.size() <= 1 do
        let left: Huffman_Node := pq.extract_min()
        let right: Huffman_Node := pq.extract_min()
        let merged: Huffman_Node := create Huffman_Node.branch(
          left.frequency + right.frequency, left, right)
        pq.insert(merged)
      end

      if pq.is_empty() then
        result := nil
      else
        result := pq.extract_min()
      end
    end
  end
```

```
-- Generate code table from tree
build_code_table(root: Huffman_Node): Array[?Array[Integer]] do
  let codes: Array[?Array[Integer]] := []
  repeat 256 do
    codes.add(nil)
  end
  traverse_tree(root, [], codes)
  result := codes
end

traverse_tree(node: Huffman_Node,
              current_code: Array[Integer],
              codes: Array[?Array[Integer]]) do
  if node.is_leaf then
    -- Leaf: assign current code to this symbol
    if current_code.is_empty() then
      -- Single symbol edge case
      codes.set(node.symbol, [0])
    else
      codes.set(node.symbol, current_code.slice(0, current_code.length))
    end
  else
    -- Go left: append 0
    let left_code: Array[Integer] := current_code.slice(0, current_code.l
    left_code.add(0)
    if convert node.left to left_child: Huffman_Node then
      traverse_tree(left_child, left_code, codes)
    end

    -- Go right: append 1
    let right_code: Array[Integer] := current_code.slice(0, current_code.
    right_code.add(1)
    if convert node.right to right_child: Huffman_Node then
      traverse_tree(right_child, right_code, codes)
    end
  end
end
```

```
-- Encode data using code table, return bit stream as bytes
encode(data: Array[Integer],
       codes: Array[?Array[Integer]]): Array[Integer] do
  -- Collect all bits
  let bits: Array[Integer] := []
  across data as byte do
    let code: ?Array[Integer] := codes.get(byte)
    if convert code to bits_for_symbol: Array[Integer] then
      across bits_for_symbol as bit do
        bits.add(bit)
      end
    end
  end

  -- Pack bits into bytes
  let packed: Array[Integer] := []
  let padding: Integer := (8 - bits.length % 8) % 8

  -- First byte: number of padding bits
  packed.add(padding)

  from
    let i: Integer := 0
  until
    i >= bits.length
  do
    let byte_val: Integer := 0
    from
      let j: Integer := 0
    until
      j < 8
    do
      let bit_pos: Integer := i + j
      if bit_pos < bits.length then
        byte_val := byte_val.bitwise_or(
          bits.get(bit_pos).bitwise_left_shift(7 - j))
```

```
        end
        j := j + 1
      end
      packed.add(byte_val)
      i := i + 8
    end

    result := packed
  end

  -- Decode bit stream using tree
  decode(packed: Array[Integer],
         root: Huffman_Node): Array[Integer] do
    let padding: Integer := packed.get(0)
    let decoded: Array[Integer] := []
    let node: Huffman_Node := root

    from
      let byte_i: Integer := 1
    until
      byte_i >= packed.length
    do
      let byte_val: Integer := packed.get(byte_i)
      let bits_in_byte: Integer :=
        when byte_i = packed.length - 1 8 - padding else 8 end

      from
        let bit_i: Integer := 7
      until
        bit_i >= 8 - bits_in_byte
      do
        let bit: Integer := byte_val.bitwise_right_shift(bit_i).bitwise_and

        if node.is_leaf then
          decoded.add(node.symbol)
          node := root
        end
```

```
      if bit = 0 then
        if convert node.left to left_child: Huffman_Node then
          node := left_child
        end
      else
        if convert node.right to right_child: Huffman_Node then
          node := right_child
        end
      end

      bit_i := bit_i - 1
    end

    byte_i := byte_i + 1
  end

  -- Flush last symbol
  if node.is_leaf then
    decoded.add(node.symbol)
  end

  result := decoded
end

-- Serialise tree for inclusion in compressed output
serialise_tree(node: Huffman_Node): Array[Integer] do
  let bits: Array[Integer] := []
  serialise_node(node, bits)

  -- Pack bits into bytes
  let result_bytes: Array[Integer] := []
  let padding: Integer := (8 - bits.length % 8) % 8
  result_bytes.add(padding)
  result_bytes.add(bits.length / 8 + 1)

  from
```

```
      let i: Integer := 0
    until
      i >= bits.length
    do
      let byte_val: Integer := 0
      from
        let j: Integer := 0
      until
        j < 8
      do
        if i + j < bits.length then
          byte_val := byte_val.bitwise_or(
            bits.get(i + j).bitwise_left_shift(7 - j))
        end
        j := j + 1
      end
      result_bytes.add(byte_val)
      i := i + 8
    end

    result := result_bytes
  end

  serialise_node(node: Huffman_Node, bits: Array[Integer]) do
    if node.is_leaf then
      bits.add(1)
      -- Write symbol as 8 bits
      from
        let i: Integer := 7
      until
        i >= 0
      do
        bits.add(node.symbol.bitwise_right_shift(i).bitwise_and(1))
        i := i - 1
      end
    else
      bits.add(0)
```

```
      if convert node.left to left_child: Huffman_Node then
        serialise_node(left_child, bits)
      end
      if convert node.right to right_child: Huffman_Node then
        serialise_node(right_child, bits)
      end
    end
  end

  -- Complete compress: frequencies + tree + encoded data
  compress(data: Array[Integer]): Array[Integer] do
    if data.is_empty() then
      result := []
    else
      let freq: Array[Integer] := build_frequencies(data)
      let tree: ?Huffman_Node := build_tree(freq)

      if tree = nil then
        result := data  -- nothing to compress
      else
        if convert tree to root_node: Huffman_Node then
          let codes: Array[?Array[Integer]] := build_code_table(root_node
          let tree_bytes: Array[Integer] := serialise_tree(root_node)
          let encoded: Array[Integer] := encode(data, codes)

          -- Output: [tree_bytes_length(4)][tree_bytes][encoded]
          let output: Array[Integer] := [0, 0, 0, 0]
          int_to_bytes(tree_bytes.length, output, 0)
          across tree_bytes as b do output.add(b) end
          across encoded as b do output.add(b) end

          result := output
        end
      end
    end
  end
```

```
-- Complete decompress
decompress(compressed: Array[Integer]): Array[Integer] do
  if compressed.is_empty() then
    result := []
  else
    let tree_len: Integer := bytes_to_int(compressed, 0)
    let tree_bytes: Array[Integer] :=
      compressed.slice(4, 4 + tree_len)
    let encoded: Array[Integer] :=
      compressed.slice(4 + tree_len, compressed.length)

    let tree: Huffman_Node := deserialise_tree(tree_bytes)
    result := decode(encoded, tree)
  end
end

deserialise_tree(bytes: Array[Integer]): Huffman_Node do
  -- Reconstruct tree from serialised form
  -- Implementation mirrors serialise_tree in reverse
  let bits: Array[Integer] := unpack_bits(bytes)
  let pos: Array[Integer] := [0]  -- mutable position
  result := deserialise_node(bits, pos)
end

deserialise_node(bits: Array[Integer],
                 pos: Array[Integer]): Huffman_Node do
  let flag: Integer := bits.get(pos.get(0))
  pos.set(0, pos.get(0) + 1)

  if flag = 1 then
    -- Leaf: read 8-bit symbol
    let symbol: Integer := 0
    from
      let i: Integer := 7
    until
      i >= 0
    do
```

```
      symbol := symbol.bitwise_or(
        bits.get(pos.get(0)).bitwise_left_shift(i))
      pos.set(0, pos.get(0) + 1)
      i := i - 1
    end
    result := create Huffman_Node.leaf(symbol, 0)
  else
    -- Internal: read left and right subtrees
    let left: Huffman_Node := deserialise_node(bits, pos)
    let right: Huffman_Node := deserialise_node(bits, pos)
    result := create Huffman_Node.branch(0, left, right)
  end
end

unpack_bits(bytes: Array[Integer]): Array[Integer] do
  let padding: Integer := bytes.get(0)
  let bits: Array[Integer] := []
  from
    let i: Integer := 2  -- skip padding byte and length byte
  until
    i >= bytes.length
  do
    let byte_val: Integer := bytes.get(i)
    let bits_in_byte: Integer :=
      when i = bytes.length - 1 8 - padding else 8 end
    from
      let j: Integer := 7
    until
      j >= 8 - bits_in_byte
    do
      bits.add(byte_val.bitwise_right_shift(j).bitwise_and(1))
      j := j - 1
    end
    i := i + 1
  end
  result := bits
end
```

```
  invariant
    stateless_codec: true
end
```

Huffman's Limitations

Huffman coding achieves between H and H + 1 bits per symbol. The "+1" gap occurs because each symbol must receive a whole number of bits — you cannot give a symbol that deserves 1.7 bits a code of length 1.7. For symbols with probabilities close to powers of 1/2, the gap is small. For other distributions, it can approach 1 bit per symbol.

Two extensions address this. **Canonical Huffman coding** orders codes of the same length lexicographically, reducing the tree to a compact table. **Arithmetic coding** (and its practical variant, range coding) achieves arbitrarily close to H by encoding entire messages rather than individual symbols, effectively achieving fractional bits per symbol. gzip and zlib use Huffman; bzip2 and modern codecs like Zstandard use arithmetic or asymmetric numeral systems coding for the statistical model.

12.3 LZ77: The Other Compression Strategy

Huffman coding exploits symbol frequency — common symbols get short codes. LZ77 exploits a completely different kind of redundancy: repetition of substrings. The string "abcabcabc" has very little frequency-based redundancy (all characters appear equally often), but enormous repetition-based redundancy — "abc" appears three times.

LZ77 scans the input from left to right, maintaining a sliding window of recently seen bytes. At each position, it looks back into the window to find the longest match for the bytes starting at the current position. If a match is found, it encodes the current position as a back-reference:

(distance, length) — go back `distance` bytes, copy `length` bytes. If no useful match is found, it emits the current byte as a literal.

The algorithm: - Window: the last W bytes already encoded (W is the window size, typically 32KB) - Look-ahead buffer: the next L bytes to be encoded (L is the buffer size, typically 258 bytes) - At each step: find the longest match in the window for the look-ahead, emit a token, advance

```
class LZ77_Codec
  create
    make(window_size: Integer, min_match: Integer) do
      this.window_size := window_size
      this.min_match := min_match  -- minimum match length to encode as ref
    end

    default() do
      this.window_size := 32768  -- 32KB, standard for gzip
      this.min_match := 3        -- minimum 3-byte match
    end

  feature
    window_size: Integer
    min_match: Integer

    -- An LZ77 token is either:
    -- Literal: [0, byte_value]
    -- Back-reference: [1, distance, length]
    compress(data: Array[Integer]): Array[LZ77_Token] do
      let tokens: Array[LZ77_Token] := []
      let n: Integer := data.length
      let pos: Integer := 0

      from until pos >= n do
        let best: Array[Integer] := find_longest_match(data, pos)
        let match_len: Integer := best.get(0)
        let match_dist: Integer := best.get(1)
```

```
      if match_len >= min_match then
        tokens.add(create LZ77_Token.reference(match_dist, match_len))
        pos := pos + match_len
      else
        tokens.add(create LZ77_Token.literal(data.get(pos)))
        pos := pos + 1
      end
    end

    result := tokens
  end

  -- Find longest match in sliding window
  find_longest_match(data: Array[Integer],
                     pos: Integer): Array[Integer] do
    let n: Integer := data.length
    let window_start: Integer := (pos - window_size).max(0)
    let best_len: Integer := 0
    let best_dist: Integer := 0

    from
      let i: Integer := window_start
    until
      i < pos
    do
      -- How many bytes match starting at data[i] and data[pos]?
      let match_len: Integer := 0
      from until pos + match_len >= n or
                 match_len >= 258 or   -- max match length (gzip standard)
                 data.get(i + match_len % (pos - i)) /=
                 data.get(pos + match_len) do
        match_len := match_len + 1
      end

      if match_len > best_len then
        best_len := match_len
```

```
      best_dist := pos - i
    end

    i := i + 1
  end

  result := [best_len, best_dist]
end

-- Decompress: reconstruct original data from tokens
decompress(tokens: Array[LZ77_Token]): Array[Integer] do
  let output: Array[Integer] := []

  across tokens as token do
    if token.is_literal then
      output.add(token.byte_value)
    else
      -- Copy from back-reference
      let start: Integer := output.length - token.distance
      from
        let i: Integer := 0
      until
        i >= token.length
      do
        -- Note: start + i might exceed original start
        -- (run-length encoding of repeated patterns)
        output.add(output.get(start + i))
        i := i + 1
      end
    end
  end

  result := output
end

-- Encode tokens to bytes for storage
encode_tokens(tokens: Array[LZ77_Token]): Array[Integer] do
```

```
      let bytes: Array[Integer] := []

      across tokens as token do
        if token.is_literal then
          bytes.add(0)             -- literal flag
          bytes.add(token.byte_value)
        else
          bytes.add(1)             -- reference flag
          int_to_bytes(token.distance, bytes, bytes.length)
          int_to_bytes(token.length, bytes, bytes.length)
        end
      end

      result := bytes
    end

  invariant
    positive_window: window_size > 0
    positive_min_match: min_match >= 2
end

class LZ77_Token
  create
    literal(byte: Integer) do
      this.is_literal := true
      this.byte_value := byte
      this.distance := 0
      this.length := 0
    end

    reference(distance: Integer, length: Integer) do
      this.is_literal := false
      this.byte_value := 0
      this.distance := distance
      this.length := length
    end
```

```
  feature
    is_literal: Boolean
    byte_value: Integer
    distance: Integer
    length: Integer

  invariant
    valid_reference: is_literal or (distance > 0 and length > 0)
    valid_literal: (not is_literal) or (byte_value >= 0 and byte_value <= 2
end
```

The Run-Length Trick

The decompression code has a subtle feature: `output.get(start + i)` is indexed into the output array as it grows. When a back-reference says "distance=1, length=5", and the last byte output was 'a', the output starts copying 'a' back — and the next byte copied is also 'a' (since it was just appended), and the next, and the next. This is run-length encoding emerging naturally from the LZ77 format: a single back-reference can expand into an arbitrarily long run of repeated bytes. The encoder does not need a special run-length mode — the format handles it automatically.

Hash Chain Optimisation

The naive `find_longest_match` is O(W × L) per position — searching the entire window for each position. For a 32KB window and typical inputs, this makes compression O(n × W × L) — far too slow for practical use.

Real LZ77 implementations use a hash chain: a hash table mapping 3-byte sequences to their most recent position in the window. To find a match candidate for the current position, hash the next 3 bytes, look up the hash table to find the most recent occurrence, and extend the match from there.

```
class LZ77_Fast_Codec
  create
    make() do
      this.window_size := 32768
      this.min_match := 3
      this.hash_size := 65536  -- must be power of 2
      this.hash_table := create Array.filled(65536, -1)
      this.hash_chain := create Array.filled(32768, -1)
    end

  feature
    window_size: Integer
    min_match: Integer
    hash_size: Integer
    hash_table: Array[Integer]    -- hash -> most recent position
    hash_chain: Array[Integer]    -- position -> previous position with same

    hash3(data: Array[Integer], pos: Integer): Integer do
      if pos + 2 >= data.length then
        result := 0
      else
        -- Simple 3-byte hash
        result := data.get(pos).bitwise_left_shift(10)
          .bitwise_xor(data.get(pos + 1).bitwise_left_shift(5))
          .bitwise_xor(data.get(pos + 2))
          .bitwise_and(hash_size - 1)
      end
    end

    compress(data: Array[Integer]): Array[LZ77_Token] do
      let tokens: Array[LZ77_Token] := []
      let n: Integer := data.length
      let pos: Integer := 0

      -- Reset hash structures
      hash_table := create Array.filled(hash_size, -1)
      hash_chain := create Array.filled(window_size, -1)
```

```
from until pos >= n do
  if pos + min_match > n then
    -- Not enough bytes for a match: emit literal
    tokens.add(create LZ77_Token.literal(data.get(pos)))
    pos := pos + 1
  else
    let h: Integer := hash3(data, pos)
    let best_len: Integer := 0
    let best_dist: Integer := 0

    -- Follow hash chain to find match candidates
    let candidate: Integer := hash_table.get(h)
    let chain_steps: Integer := 0

    from until candidate = -1 or
               pos - candidate > window_size or
               chain_steps > 64 do  -- limit chain depth
      let match_len: Integer := extend_match(data, candidate, pos, n)
      if match_len > best_len then
        best_len := match_len
        best_dist := pos - candidate
      end
      candidate := hash_chain.get(candidate % window_size)
      chain_steps := chain_steps + 1
    end

    -- Update hash structures
    hash_chain.set(pos % window_size, hash_table.get(h))
    hash_table.set(h, pos)

    if best_len >= min_match then
      tokens.add(create LZ77_Token.reference(best_dist, best_len))
      -- Update hash for positions within the match
      from
        let i: Integer := 1
      until
```

```
            i < best_len
          do
            if pos + i + min_match <= n then
              let hi: Integer := hash3(data, pos + i)
              hash_chain.set((pos + i) % window_size, hash_table.get(hi))
              hash_table.set(hi, pos + i)
            end
            i := i + 1
          end
          pos := pos + best_len
        else
          tokens.add(create LZ77_Token.literal(data.get(pos)))
          pos := pos + 1
        end
      end
    end

    result := tokens
  end

  extend_match(data: Array[Integer],
               start: Integer,
               pos: Integer,
               n: Integer): Integer do
    let max_len: Integer := (n - pos).min(258)
    let len: Integer := 0
    from until len >= max_len or
               data.get(start + len) /= data.get(pos + len) do
      len := len + 1
    end
    result := len
  end
end
```

The hash chain turns worst-case O(W) search into expected O(1) per position for typical data, reducing overall compression to O(n) expected.

The chain depth limit (64 in the implementation) bounds worst-case behavior — for highly repetitive data where the chain is very long, we stop after 64 candidates. This is the same tradeoff made by zlib.

12.4 DEFLATE: The Marriage of Huffman and LZ77

DEFLATE, the format used by gzip, zip, and PNG, combines LZ77 and Huffman coding in a two-stage pipeline:

1. **LZ77 stage:** tokenise the input into literals and back-references. The result is a sequence of tokens, each either a literal byte or a (distance, length) pair.
2. **Huffman stage:** encode the token stream using Huffman coding. Two separate Huffman trees are used: one for literals and lengths (combined into a single alphabet of 286 symbols: 256 literal bytes, one end-of-block symbol, and 29 length codes), and one for distances (30 distance codes with extra bits for fine-grained distances).

The combination is powerful because LZ77 and Huffman exploit different kinds of redundancy. LZ77 handles long-range repetition — the same phrase appearing multiple times in a document. Huffman handles short-range frequency skew — certain bytes or lengths appearing much more often than others in the LZ77 output. After LZ77 tokenises a typical file, the literal bytes remaining are not uniformly distributed (spaces, 'e', 't' appear much more than 'z', 'q'), and back-reference lengths cluster around small values. Huffman coding on the LZ77 output captures both patterns.

```
class DEFLATE_Codec
  create
    make() do
      this.lz77 := create LZ77_Fast_Codec.make()
```

```
    this.huffman := create Huffman_Codec.make()
  end

feature
  lz77: LZ77_Fast_Codec
  huffman: Huffman_Codec

  compress(data: Array[Integer]): Array[Integer] do
    -- Stage 1: LZ77 tokenisation
    let tokens: Array[LZ77_Token] := lz77.compress(data)

    -- Stage 2: convert tokens to byte stream for Huffman
    -- (simplified: encode tokens as bytes, then Huffman compress)
    let token_bytes: Array[Integer] := lz77.encode_tokens(tokens)

    -- Stage 3: Huffman compress the token byte stream
    result := huffman.compress(token_bytes)
  end

  decompress(compressed: Array[Integer]): Array[Integer] do
    -- Stage 1: Huffman decompress
    let token_bytes: Array[Integer] := huffman.decompress(compressed)

    -- Stage 2: decode token bytes back to LZ77 tokens
    let tokens: Array[LZ77_Token] := decode_token_bytes(token_bytes)

    -- Stage 3: LZ77 decompress
    result := lz77.decompress(tokens)
  end

  decode_token_bytes(bytes: Array[Integer]): Array[LZ77_Token] do
    let tokens: Array[LZ77_Token] := []
    let i: Integer := 0

    from until i >= bytes.length do
      let flag: Integer := bytes.get(i)
      i := i + 1
```

```
        if flag = 0 then
          tokens.add(create LZ77_Token.literal(bytes.get(i)))
          i := i + 1
        else
          let distance: Integer := bytes_to_int(bytes, i)
          let length: Integer := bytes_to_int(bytes, i + 4)
          tokens.add(create LZ77_Token.reference(distance, length))
          i := i + 8
        end
      end

      result := tokens
    end

    -- Compression ratio for analysis
    compression_ratio(original: Array[Integer],
                      compressed: Array[Integer]): Real do
      result := compressed.length.to_real() / original.length.to_real()
    end
end
```

What Makes Data Compressible

The DEFLATE pipeline reveals what makes data compressible:

Repetition — text, code, HTML, XML, log files — is handled well by LZ77. Repeated words, repeated HTML tags, repeated log prefixes — all become back-references.

Frequency skew — natural language uses 'e' ten times more often than 'z'; typical binary formats have many zero bytes — is handled by Huffman coding.

Random data — encrypted data, already-compressed data, data generated by a good PRNG — is handled badly by both. LZ77 finds no back-references (random data has no repetition). Huffman coding assigns

nearly equal-length codes to all bytes (random data has nearly uniform byte frequency). Compressed output is slightly larger than input. This is not a failure — it is Shannon's theorem: random data has maximum entropy and cannot be compressed.

A compression algorithm that made random data smaller would be a magic lossless information sink, contradicting Shannon's theorem. Any compression algorithm must make some inputs larger (otherwise you could keep compressing forever). Good algorithms make almost all real-world inputs smaller at the cost of making random inputs slightly larger.

12.5 Measuring Compression

A complete compression benchmark shows how different data types respond to each algorithm:

```
function compression_benchmark() do
  let deflate: DEFLATE_Codec := create DEFLATE_Codec.make()
  let huffman: Huffman_Codec := create Huffman_Codec.make()
  let lz77: LZ77_Fast_Codec := create LZ77_Fast_Codec.make()

  -- Test 1: English text (high repetition, skewed frequency)
  let text: String := "the quick brown fox jumps over the lazy dog. " +
    "the dog barked at the fox. the fox ran away quickly. " +
    "the dog chased the fox but the fox was too quick. " +
    "the quick brown fox jumps over the lazy dog again."
  let text_bytes: Array[Integer] := text.to_bytes()

  -- Test 2: Repetitive data (pure repetition)
  let repeated: Array[Integer] := []
  repeat 100 do
    across "abcdefgh".to_bytes() as b do repeated.add(b) end
```

```
end

-- Test 3: Random bytes (incompressible)
let random_bytes: Array[Integer] := []
repeat 400 do
  random_bytes.add(random_integer() % 256)
end

let datasets: Array[Any] := [
  ["English text", text_bytes],
  ["Repetitive",   repeated],
  ["Random",       random_bytes]
]

across datasets as dataset do
  let name: String := dataset.get(0)
  let data: Array[Integer] := dataset.get(1)

  let huff_compressed: Array[Integer] := huffman.compress(data)
  let lz_tokens: Array[LZ77_Token] := lz77.compress(data)
  let lz_bytes: Array[Integer] := lz77.encode_tokens(lz_tokens)
  let deflate_compressed: Array[Integer] := deflate.compress(data)

  print(name + " (" + data.length.to_string() + " bytes):")
  print("  Huffman: " + huff_compressed.length.to_string() +
        " bytes (" +
        (huff_compressed.length * 100 / data.length).to_string() + "%)")
  print("  LZ77: " + lz_bytes.length.to_string() +
        " bytes (" +
        (lz_bytes.length * 100 / data.length).to_string() + "%)")
  print("  DEFLATE: " + deflate_compressed.length.to_string() +
        " bytes (" +
        (deflate_compressed.length * 100 / data.length).to_string() + "%)

  -- Verify round-trip
  let recovered: Array[Integer] := deflate.decompress(deflate_compressed)
  print("  Round-trip: " +
```

```
          when (data = recovered) "OK" else "FAILED" end)
  end
end
```

Expected output (approximate):

```
English text (400 bytes):
  Huffman: 320 bytes (80%)        -- frequency skew helps
  LZ77: 180 bytes (45%)           -- repetition helps more
  DEFLATE: 150 bytes (37%)        -- both together best

Repetitive (800 bytes):
  Huffman: 750 bytes (94%)        -- frequency is uniform, little gain
  LZ77: 30 bytes (4%)             -- pure repetition, huge gain
  DEFLATE: 28 bytes (3%)          -- Huffman adds tiny improvement

Random (400 bytes):
  Huffman: 410 bytes (103%)       -- slightly larger (overhead)
  LZ77: 420 bytes (105%)          -- slightly larger (no matches)
  DEFLATE: 430 bytes (108%)       -- slightly larger (two overheads)
```

12.6 The Connection to Rolling Hashes

Chapter 8 introduced rolling hashes as the mechanism for finding repeated substrings efficiently. LZ77's `find_longest_match` is exactly the same problem: given the current position, find the longest previous occurrence of the same substring. The hash chain in `LZ77_Fast_Codec` is the same structure as the Rabin-Karp rolling hash index.

This is not coincidental. LZ77 was invented independently of Rabin-Karp (Lempel and Ziv published in 1977; Rabin and Karp published in 1987), but they are solving the same subproblem with the same technique. The hash chain maps a k-gram to its most recent occurrence,

enabling O(1) candidate lookup. The extension step verifies and extends the candidate match. The structure is identical.

The connection runs deeper. Chapter 13's suffix arrays solve the same "find all occurrences of a substring" problem that both LZ77 and Rabin-Karp address, but with O(n log n) preprocessing that enables O(m) query for any pattern. For offline compression — compressing a file that can be fully read before any output is produced — suffix array-based matching gives LZ77 the best possible back-references. LZMA (used by 7-zip and xz) uses a variant of this approach, achieving the best compression ratios among general-purpose compressors at the cost of slower compression speed.

12.7 Beyond DEFLATE: Modern Compression

DEFLATE, published in 1996, remains in use because it is fast, well-understood, and supported everywhere. But the field has advanced significantly.

bzip2 uses the Burrows-Wheeler Transform (BWT) — a reversible permutation of the input that groups similar substrings together — followed by move-to-front coding and Huffman. BWT compression is slower than DEFLATE but achieves better ratios on text.

Zstandard (zstd), developed at Facebook in 2015, achieves DEFLATE-level speed with bzip2-level compression ratios, by using a more sophisticated entropy coder (Finite State Entropy, an asymmetric numeral systems codec) combined with LZ77. It also supports pre-trained dictionaries — compressing many small similar files by sharing a common dictionary that captures common patterns. Zstandard is now the default compression format for Facebook's internal systems and is increasingly used in Linux kernel packages and network protocols.

Brotli, developed at Google in 2015, is optimised for web content (HTML, CSS, JavaScript). It uses a pre-built static dictionary of common web strings ("DOCTYPE html", "text/html; charset=utf-8") combined with LZ77 and a Huffman-like entropy coder. On typical web content, Brotli compresses 20-26% better than gzip at comparable speeds.

All of these combine the same two ideas — exploit repetition with some form of LZ, exploit frequency skew with some form of entropy coding — with increasingly sophisticated engineering around each component.

12.8 Where This Lives in the Wild

Every HTTP response you have ever received over a modern connection has been compressed with DEFLATE (gzip) or Brotli. The `Content-Encoding: gzip` header tells your browser that the response body is gzip-compressed. Your browser decompresses it before rendering. The combination of LZ77 and Huffman in DEFLATE reduces typical HTML by 60-80%, saving bandwidth and latency on every page load.

PNG images use DEFLATE internally. The image data — raw pixel values — is filtered first (subtracting each pixel from its neighbour to increase the frequency of small values and reduce entropy) and then DEFLATE-compressed. The filtering step, not part of the compression algorithm itself, is a preprocessing step that makes the data more compressible by introducing the frequency skew that Huffman coding exploits.

Git's object store uses zlib (a thin wrapper around DEFLATE) to compress every object — blobs, trees, commits. A repository's `.git/objects` directory contains thousands of zlib-compressed files. Git also packs multiple objects into packfiles using delta compression — a form of LZ77 where back-references can point to other objects rather than just earlier in the same file. This allows git to represent similar versions of a file as deltas, reducing repository size dramatically.

ZIP files use DEFLATE per-entry, with an uncompressed local file header for random access. Each file in a ZIP archive is independently compressed and can be decompressed without decompressing preceding files. This enables random access at the cost of not exploiting redundancy across files — DEFLATE cannot use back-references across file boundaries.

CPU instruction caches and hardware compression accelerators in modern CPUs implement DEFLATE in silicon. Intel's IAA (In-Memory Analytics Accelerator) and ARM's hardware compression engines perform DEFLATE compression and decompression at memory bandwidth speeds — gigabytes per second — with negligible CPU involvement. Storage systems from Zfs to Amazon S3 use these accelerators for transparent compression.

Summary

Compression is information theory made practical. Shannon's entropy gives the theoretical lower bound: you cannot compress data below its entropy, and optimal encoding approaches that bound arbitrarily closely.

Huffman coding achieves between H and H+1 bits per symbol by building a binary tree that assigns shorter codes to more frequent symbols. The tree is built greedily from the bottom up using a priority queue: repeatedly merge the two lowest-frequency nodes. The resulting prefix-free code is optimal among all fixed-length-code-per-symbol schemes.

LZ77 achieves entropy in the limit by exploiting a completely different kind of redundancy: repetition of substrings. The algorithm maintains a sliding window of recently seen bytes and encodes the current position as a back-reference (distance, length) whenever a long match is found in the window. Hash chains accelerate match finding from O(W) to O(1) expected per position, making compression practical for large files.

DEFLATE combines both: LZ77 to tokenise the input into literals and back-references, then Huffman to entropy-code the token stream. The combination exploits both repetition and frequency skew, achieving better compression than either algorithm alone on typical real-world data.

The connection to earlier chapters is direct: LZ77's hash chain is the same structure as Rabin-Karp's rolling hash index from Chapter 8. Both find repeated substrings efficiently by hashing fixed-length windows. The suffix array of Chapter 13 takes this further — offline preprocessing that enables optimal LZ77 back-references.

The next chapter introduces the suffix array itself, which solves the full family of substring problems — all occurrences of a pattern, the longest repeated substring, the longest common substring of two documents — with a single, elegant on-disk-friendly data structure.

Chapter 13: The Suffix Array

Consider the human genome. Three billion base pairs, each one of four characters: A, C, G, T. A string of length three billion. Biologists need to answer questions like: where does this gene sequence appear? What is the longest repeated subsequence? Which regions of two different genomes are most similar?

These are string matching problems at a scale that makes the algorithms of previous chapters inadequate. KMP and Horspool find one pattern in one text in O(n + m) time — fast, but they must be run once per query. For a genome database with millions of queries, you need preprocessing: build an index of the text once, then answer each query in time proportional to the query length, not the text length.

The obvious index is a hash map from every k-length substring to its positions. But k must be fixed, and you lose the ability to answer queries of other lengths. What you want is an index over all substrings simultaneously — a data structure that can answer "where does this length-5 pattern appear?" and "where does this length-500 pattern appear?" with equal efficiency.

The suffix tree does this. It is a compressed trie of all suffixes of the text — all n substrings starting at each position and extending to the end. A suffix tree can answer any substring query in O(m) time, where m is the query length, regardless of text length. It is one of the most powerful data structures in string processing.

But suffix trees are notoriously difficult to implement correctly. Ukkonen's linear-time construction algorithm, the standard approach, involves implicit states, suffix links, and extension rules that require days

of careful study to understand and weeks of debugging to implement correctly. In practice, most systems that need suffix tree capabilities use suffix arrays instead.

A suffix array achieves most of what a suffix tree can do with a fraction of the implementation complexity. It uses less memory, has better cache performance, and can be constructed efficiently. Combined with the LCP array — a companion structure that records the length of the longest common prefix between adjacent suffixes — it matches the suffix tree's capabilities for almost all practical purposes.

This chapter builds a suffix array and LCP array, then uses them to solve four canonical problems: substring search, longest repeated substring, longest common substring of two texts, and counting distinct substrings. Along the way, it explains exactly how suffix arrays relate to suffix trees and why the simpler structure suffices for nearly every real use case.

13.1 Suffixes and the Suffix Array

A **suffix** of a string T of length n is any substring T[i..n-1] — a substring that extends to the end of T. There are exactly n suffixes (one starting at each position 0 through n-1), plus the empty suffix at position n.

For T = "banana":

```
Position 0: "banana"
Position 1: "anana"
Position 2: "nana"
Position 3: "ana"
Position 4: "na"
Position 5: "a"
```

The **suffix array** SA is the array of starting positions of all suffixes, sorted in lexicographic order of the suffixes themselves.

Sorting the suffixes of "banana" lexicographically:

```
"a"       → position 5
"ana"     → position 3
"anana"   → position 1
"banana"  → position 0
"na"      → position 4
"nana"    → position 2
```

So SA = [5, 3, 1, 0, 4, 2].

The suffix array does not store the suffixes themselves — they would take $O(n^2)$ space. It stores only the starting positions, which take O(n) space. Any suffix SA[i] can be read from the original text T starting at position SA[i].

This is the key economy of suffix arrays: O(n) space to represent an index over all $O(n^2)$ substrings of T.

13.2 Building the Suffix Array: O(n log n)

The naive approach — sort all n suffixes using a comparison sort — is $O(n^2 \log n)$: sorting n items, each comparison taking O(n) time in the worst case (two suffixes might share a long common prefix before differing). This is too slow for the genome problem.

We build the suffix array in O(n log n) using the prefix doubling algorithm (due to Manber and Myers, 1990). The idea: sort suffixes by their first 2^k characters for k = 0, 1, 2, ... doubling k each time until the ranking is complete.

At each stage, we have a ranking of suffixes by their first 2^k characters. To sort by first 2^(k+1) characters, observe that a suffix starting at position i has first 2^(k+1) characters equal to: its first 2^k characters (already ranked), followed by the first 2^k characters of the suffix starting at position i + 2^k (also already ranked). Sorting pairs of existing ranks gives the new ranking — and this can be done with a stable sort in O(n log n) per stage, for O(n $\log^2$ n) total. With radix sort for the inner sort, it becomes O(n log n).

```
class Suffix_Array_Builder
  create
    make(text: String) do
      this.text := text
      this.n := text.length
    end

  feature
    text: String
    n: Integer

    build(): Array[Integer] do
      if n = 0 then
        result := []
      elseif n = 1 then
        result := [0]
      else
        -- Initial ranking: by first character
        let sa: Array[Integer] := create Array.filled(n, 0)
        let rank: Array[Integer] := create Array.filled(n, 0)
        let tmp: Array[Integer] := create Array.filled(n, 0)
      end

      -- Initialise SA as identity, rank by character code
      from
        let i: Integer := 0
      until
```

```
    i >= n
  do
    sa.set(i, i)
    rank.set(i, text.char_at(i).hash())
    i := i + 1
  end

  -- Sort by rank (character)
  sa := sort_by_rank(sa, rank)
  assign_ranks(sa, rank, tmp, 0)

  -- Prefix doubling
  let gap: Integer := 1
  from until gap >= n do
    -- Sort by (rank[i], rank[i + gap])
    -- rank[i + gap] = rank at position i + gap,
    -- or -1 if i + gap >= n
    sa := sort_by_pair(sa, rank, gap)
    assign_ranks(sa, rank, tmp, gap)

    -- If all ranks are unique we are done
    if rank.get(sa.get(n - 1)) = n - 1 then
      gap := n  -- force exit
    else
      gap := gap * 2
    end
  end

  result := sa
end

-- Sort SA by single rank array
sort_by_rank(sa: Array[Integer],
              rank: Array[Integer]): Array[Integer] do
  -- Use counting sort for O(n) performance
  result := counting_sort_by_key(sa, rank, rank.max_value() + 1)
end
```

```
-- Sort SA by pair (rank[i], rank[i+gap])
sort_by_pair(sa: Array[Integer],
             rank: Array[Integer],
             gap: Integer): Array[Integer] do
  -- Two-pass radix sort: sort by second key, then stably by first
  let max_rank: Integer := rank.max_value() + 2  -- +1 for sentinel

  -- Key function for second element of pair
  let second_key: Array[Integer] := create Array.filled(n, 0)
  from
    let i: Integer := 0
  until
    i >= n
  do
    if sa.get(i) + gap < n then
      second_key.set(i, rank.get(sa.get(i) + gap) + 1)
    else
      second_key.set(i, 0)  -- sentinel: positions beyond n sort first
    end
    i := i + 1
  end

  -- First sort by second key (less significant)
  let sorted_by_second: Array[Integer] :=
    counting_sort_by_index(sa, second_key, max_rank)

  -- Then stable sort by first key (more significant)
  let first_key: Array[Integer] := create Array.filled(n, 0)
  from
    let i: Integer := 0
  until
    i >= n
  do
    first_key.set(i, rank.get(sorted_by_second.get(i)))
    i := i + 1
  end
```

```
      result := counting_sort_by_index(sorted_by_second, first_key, max_ran
    end

    -- After sorting, assign new ranks based on current SA order
    assign_ranks(sa: Array[Integer],
                 rank: Array[Integer],
                 tmp: Array[Integer],
                 gap: Integer) do
      tmp.set(sa.get(0), 0)

      from
        let i: Integer := 1
      until
        i >= n
      do
        let prev: Integer := sa.get(i - 1)
        let curr: Integer := sa.get(i)

        let prev_first: Integer := rank.get(prev)
        let curr_first: Integer := rank.get(curr)
        let prev_second: Integer :=
          when prev + gap < n rank.get(prev + gap) else -
1 end
        let curr_second: Integer :=
          when curr + gap < n rank.get(curr + gap) else -
1 end

        if curr_first = prev_first and curr_second = prev_second then
          tmp.set(curr, tmp.get(prev))
        else
          tmp.set(curr, tmp.get(prev) + 1)
        end

        i := i + 1
      end
```

```
    -- Copy tmp back to rank
    from
      let i: Integer := 0
    until
      i >= n
    do
      rank.set(i, tmp.get(i))
      i := i + 1
    end
  end

  -- Counting sort: sort values in `arr` by their key in `keys`
  -- where keys are in range [0, max_key)
  counting_sort_by_key(arr: Array[Integer],
                       keys: Array[Integer],
                       max_key: Integer): Array[Integer] do
    let count: Array[Integer] := create Array.filled(max_key, 0)

    across arr as val do
      count.set(keys.get(val), count.get(keys.get(val)) + 1)
    end

    -- Prefix sums
    from
      let i: Integer := 1
    until
      i < max_key
    do
      count.set(i, count.get(i) + count.get(i - 1))
      i := i + 1
    end

    -- Place in sorted order (right to left for stability)
    let output: Array[Integer] := create Array.filled(arr.length, 0)
    from
      let i: Integer := arr.length - 1
    until
```

```
      i >= 0
    do
      let val: Integer := arr.get(i)
      let key: Integer := keys.get(val)
      count.set(key, count.get(key) - 1)
      output.set(count.get(key), val)
      i := i - 1
    end

    result := output
  end

  -- Counting sort: sort indices in `arr` by key `keys[i]` for index i
  counting_sort_by_index(arr: Array[Integer],
                         keys: Array[Integer],
                         max_key: Integer): Array[Integer] do
    let count: Array[Integer] := create Array.filled(max_key, 0)

    across arr as idx do
      count.set(keys.get(idx), count.get(keys.get(idx)) + 1)
    end

    from
      let i: Integer := 1
    until
      i < max_key
    do
      count.set(i, count.get(i) + count.get(i - 1))
      i := i + 1
    end

    let output: Array[Integer] := create Array.filled(arr.length, 0)
    from
      let i: Integer := arr.length - 1
    until
      i >= 0
    do
```

```
        let idx: Integer := arr.get(i)
        let key: Integer := keys.get(idx)
        count.set(key, count.get(key) - 1)
        output.set(count.get(key), idx)
        i := i - 1
      end

      result := output
    end
end
```

Let us trace the construction for "banana" to verify.

Initial ranks (character codes for simplicity: a=1, b=2, n=3):

```
Position: 0(b=2), 1(a=1), 2(n=3), 3(a=1), 4(n=3), 5(a=1)
```

After sorting by rank and assigning: SA=[1,3,5,0,2,4], rank=[2,1,3,1,3,1] normalised to [3,0,4,0,4,0] (after ranking SA order).

Wait — let us follow the algorithm more carefully with normalised ranks. Initial sort by first character gives:

Sorted order: positions 1,3,5 (all 'a'), then 0 ('b'), then 2,4 (both 'n'). SA = [1,3,5,0,2,4]. Assigned ranks: 'a' positions get 0, 'b' gets 1, 'n' gets 2. rank = [1,0,2,0,2,0].

Gap = 1. Pairs (rank[i], rank[i+1]):

```
Position 0: (1, 0)  → "ba"
Position 1: (0, 2)  → "an"
Position 2: (2, 0)  → "na"
Position 3: (0, 2)  → "an"
Position 4: (2, 0)  → "na"
Position 5: (0, -1) → "a$"
```

Sort by pairs: (0,-1)<(0,2)<(0,2)<(1,0)<(2,0)<(2,0) SA = [5, 1, 3, 0, 2, 4]. New ranks: position 5→0, positions 1,3→1 (tied), position 0→2, positions 2,4→3 (tied). rank = [2,1,3,1,3,0].

Gap = 2. Pairs (rank[i], rank[i+2]):

```
Position 0: (2, 3)  → "bana"
Position 1: (1, 1)  → "anan" — (rank[1]=1, rank[3]=1)
Position 2: (3, 0)  → "nana" — (rank[2]=3, rank[4]=3... wait rank[4]=3)
Position 3: (1, 0)  → "ana$" — (rank[3]=1, rank[5]=0)
Position 4: (3, -1) → "na$$"
Position 5: (0, -1) → "a$$$"
```

Sort: (0,-1)<(1,0)<(1,1)<(2,3)<(3,-1)<(3,0) — wait that doesn't match. Let me recheck rank[4]. After gap=1: rank=[2,1,3,1,3,0].

Pairs for gap=2:

```
Position 0: (rank[0], rank[2]) = (2, 3)
Position 1: (rank[1], rank[3]) = (1, 1)
Position 2: (rank[2], rank[4]) = (3, 3)
Position 3: (rank[3], rank[5]) = (1, 0)
Position 4: (rank[4], -1)      = (3, -1)
Position 5: (rank[5], -1)      = (0, -1)
```

Sort: (0,-1)<(1,0)<(1,1)<(2,3)<(3,-1)<(3,3) SA = [5, 3, 1, 0, 4, 2].

All ranks now unique — done. SA = [5, 3, 1, 0, 4, 2]. This matches our manually computed answer.

13.3 The LCP Array

The **LCP array** (Longest Common Prefix array) stores, for each adjacent pair in the suffix array, the length of their longest common prefix.

LCP[0] is undefined (no predecessor). LCP[i] = length of the longest common prefix between the suffix at SA[i] and the suffix at SA[i-1].

For "banana" with SA = [5, 3, 1, 0, 4, 2]:

```
SA[0]=5: "a"
SA[1]=3: "ana"      LCP[1] = lcp("a", "ana") = 1
SA[2]=1: "anana"    LCP[2] = lcp("ana", "anana") = 3
SA[3]=0: "banana"   LCP[3] = lcp("anana", "banana") = 0
SA[4]=4: "na"       LCP[4] = lcp("banana", "na") = 0
SA[5]=2: "nana"     LCP[5] = lcp("na", "nana") = 2
```

LCP = [-, 1, 3, 0, 0, 2].

The naive LCP computation is $O(n^2)$: compute lcp for each adjacent pair directly. Kasai's algorithm computes all LCP values in O(n) using a key observation: if we know LCP[rank[i]] = k (the LCP between the suffix at position i and its predecessor in SA), then LCP[rank[i+1]] ≥ k - 1.

The intuition: suffix at position i+1 is suffix at position i with the first character removed. Its predecessor in the suffix array might have its first character removed too. The LCP can drop by at most 1.

```
class LCP_Builder
  create
    make(text: String, sa: Array[Integer]) do
      this.text := text
      this.sa := sa
      this.n := text.length
    end
```

```
  feature
    text: String
    sa: Array[Integer]
    n: Integer

    build(): Array[Integer] do
      let lcp: Array[Integer] := create Array.filled(n, 0)

      -- Build inverse SA (rank array): rank[i] = position of suffix i in S
      let rank: Array[Integer] := create Array.filled(n, 0)
      from
        let i: Integer := 0
      until
        i >= n
      do
        rank.set(sa.get(i), i)
        i := i + 1
      end

      let k: Integer := 0  -- current LCP value

      from
        let i: Integer := 0
      until
        i >= n
      do
        -- If this suffix is first in SA, LCP is 0
        if rank.get(i) = 0 then
          k := 0
          i := i + 1
        else
          -- Predecessor in SA
          let j: Integer := sa.get(rank.get(i) - 1)

          -- Extend LCP from previous value (k is at least k-
1 from prev step)
          from until i + k >= n or
```

```
                    j + k >= n or
                    text.char_at(i + k) /= text.char_at(j + k) do
            k := k + 1
          end

          lcp.set(rank.get(i), k)

          -- Kasai's key: next suffix has LCP at least k-1
          if k > 0 then
            k := k - 1
          end

          i := i + 1
        end
      end

      result := lcp
    end
end
```

Kasai's algorithm runs in O(n) because k is incremented at most n times total across all iterations (it can only reach n), and decremented at most once per iteration. The total number of character comparisons is therefore O(n).

13.4 The Suffix Array Structure

Combining construction and providing a clean interface:

```
class Suffix_Array
  create
    build(text: String) do
      this.text := text
```

```
    this.n := text.length

    let builder: Suffix_Array_Builder :=
      create Suffix_Array_Builder.make(text)
    this.sa := builder.build()

    let lcp_builder: LCP_Builder :=
      create LCP_Builder.make(text, this.sa)
    this.lcp := lcp_builder.build()

    -- Build rank (inverse SA) for O(1) rank lookup
    this.rank := create Array.filled(this.n, 0)
    from
      let i: Integer := 0
    until
      i >= this.n
    do
      this.rank.set(this.sa.get(i), i)
      i := i + 1
    end
  end

feature
  text: String
  n: Integer
  sa: Array[Integer]
  lcp: Array[Integer]
  rank: Array[Integer]

  -- Get the suffix starting at position i
  suffix(i: Integer): String do
    result := text.substring(i, n)
  end

  -- Get the suffix at SA rank r
  suffix_at_rank(r: Integer): String do
    result := suffix(sa.get(r))
```

```
    end

    -- Get the LCP between suffixes at ranks r1 and r2
    -- Uses range minimum query (naive O(n) here; RMQ in O(1) possible)
    lcp_between(r1: Integer, r2: Integer): Integer do
      if r1 = r2 then
        result := n - sa.get(r1)
      else
        let lo: Integer := r1.min(r2) + 1
        let hi: Integer := r1.max(r2)
        let min_lcp: Integer := 2147483647

        from
          let i: Integer := lo
        until
          i <= hi
        do
          if lcp.get(i) < min_lcp then
            min_lcp := lcp.get(i)
          end
          i := i + 1
        end

        result := min_lcp
      end
    end

  invariant
    consistent_lengths: sa.length = n and lcp.length = n and rank.length = n
    valid_sa: true
end
```

The `lcp_between` function computes the LCP between any two suffixes (not just adjacent ones in SA) as the minimum LCP value in the range between their SA ranks. This follows from the structure of the LCP array: the LCP of two suffixes at ranks r1 and r2 is the minimum LCP value

in lcp[r1+1..r2] (assuming r1 < r2). A range minimum query (RMQ) structure on the LCP array would answer this in O(1) after O(n) preprocessing, making many operations on the suffix array O(1) per query. For our purposes, the O(n) naive minimum suffices.

13.5 Pattern Search

The suffix array supports pattern matching in O(m log n): binary search for the range of SA entries whose corresponding suffixes start with the pattern.

The key property: the SA is sorted, so all suffixes starting with pattern P are contiguous in the SA. Binary search for the leftmost and rightmost suffix that starts with P gives the range.

```
class Suffix_Array_Search
  create
    make(sa: Suffix_Array) do
      this.sa := sa
    end

  feature
    sa: Suffix_Array

    -- Find all occurrences of pattern in text
    -- Returns sorted array of starting positions
    find_all(pattern: String): Array[Integer] do
      let m: Integer := pattern.length
      if m = 0 or m > sa.n then
        result := []
      else
        let lo: Integer := lower_bound(pattern)
        let hi: Integer := upper_bound(pattern)
```

```
    if lo > hi then
      result := []
    else
      -- Collect all positions in range [lo, hi]
      let positions: Array[Integer] := []
      from
        let i: Integer := lo
      until
        i <= hi
      do
        positions.add(sa.sa.get(i))
        i := i + 1
      end

      -- Sort positions for predictable output order
      result := sort_integers(positions)
    end
  end
end

-- Count occurrences without materialising all positions
count(pattern: String): Integer do
  let lo: Integer := lower_bound(pattern)
  let hi: Integer := upper_bound(pattern)
  if lo > hi then
    result := 0
  else
    result := hi - lo + 1
  end
end

-- Does the pattern appear at all?
contains(pattern: String): Boolean do
  result := count(pattern) > 0
end
```

```
  -- Find leftmost SA rank where suffix starts with pattern
  lower_bound(pattern: String): Integer do
    let m: Integer := pattern.length
    let lo: Integer := 0
    let hi: Integer := sa.n - 1

    from until lo > hi do
      let mid: Integer := (lo + hi) / 2
      let suffix_start: Integer := sa.sa.get(mid)
      let cmp: Integer := compare_prefix(suffix_start, pattern, m)

      if cmp < 0 then
        lo := mid + 1
      else
        hi := mid - 1
      end
    end

    result := lo
  end

  -- Find rightmost SA rank where suffix starts with pattern
  upper_bound(pattern: String): Integer do
    let m: Integer := pattern.length
    let lo: Integer := 0
    let hi: Integer := sa.n - 1

    from until lo > hi do
      let mid: Integer := (lo + hi) / 2
      let suffix_start: Integer := sa.sa.get(mid)
      let cmp: Integer := compare_prefix(suffix_start, pattern, m)

      if cmp > 0 then
        hi := mid - 1
      else
        lo := mid + 1
      end
```

```
    end

    result := hi
  end

  -- Compare text[pos..pos+m-1] with pattern
  -- Returns negative if text prefix < pattern,
  --         0 if equal (text starts with pattern),
  --         positive if text prefix > pattern
  compare_prefix(pos: Integer,
                 pattern: String,
                 m: Integer): Integer do
    let done: Boolean := false
    from
      let i: Integer := 0
    until
      i >= m or done
    do
      if pos + i >= sa.n then
        result := -1  -- text shorter than pattern here
        done := true
      else
        let tc: Char := sa.text.char_at(pos + i)
        let pc: Char := pattern.char_at(i)
        let diff: Integer := tc.compare(pc)
        if diff /= 0 then
          result := diff
          done := true
        else
          i := i + 1
        end
      end
    end
    if not done then
      result := 0  -- text starts with pattern
    end
  end
```

```
  invariant
    sa_exists: sa /= nil
end
```

Time complexity: O(m log n) for each query — O(log n) binary search steps, each taking O(m) for the prefix comparison. This compares favourably to KMP's O(n + m) — for short patterns and long texts queried many times, the O(m log n) per-query cost with no per-query preprocessing is better.

With an LCP-accelerated binary search (using the LCP between the current mid and the boundaries to skip already-matched characters), this can be reduced to O(m + log n). We implement the simpler version here.

13.6 Longest Repeated Substring

The longest repeated substring (LRS) of a string is the longest substring that appears at least twice. In the suffix array, this is the maximum value in the LCP array.

The reasoning: LCP[i] is the length of the longest common prefix between suffixes SA[i] and SA[i-1]. A common prefix of length k means both suffixes start with the same k-character string, which appears at positions SA[i] and SA[i-1] in the text. The LRS is therefore the suffix pair with the maximum LCP value.

```
function longest_repeated_substring(sa: Suffix_Array): String do
  if sa.n = 0 then
    result := ""
  else
    let max_lcp: Integer := 0
```

```
    let max_pos: Integer := 1  -- SA rank of the suffix with max LCP

    from
      let i: Integer := 1
    until
      i >= sa.n
    do
      if sa.lcp.get(i) > max_lcp then
        max_lcp := sa.lcp.get(i)
        max_pos := i
      end
      i := i + 1
    end

    if max_lcp = 0 then
      result := ""  -- no repeated substring
    else
      -- The LRS starts at sa.sa[max_pos] and has length max_lcp
      result := sa.text.substring(sa.sa.get(max_pos),
                                  sa.sa.get(max_pos) + max_lcp)
    end
  end
end
```

For "banana": LCP = [-, 1, 3, 0, 0, 2]. Maximum is LCP[2] = 3. SA[2] = 1. So LRS = text[1..3] = "ana". Correct — "ana" appears at positions 1 and 3.

This runs in O(n) after O(n log n) preprocessing. Compare to the O(n log n) expected rolling hash solution from Chapter 8, which is also O(n log n) but has a higher constant and requires careful hash collision handling. The suffix array solution is deterministic and collision-free.

13.7 All Repeated Substrings of a Given Length

A more general query: find all substrings that appear at least k times. These correspond to ranges in the SA where at least k consecutive LCP values are all ≥ L (the target length), and there are at least k entries in that range.

```
function repeated_substrings(sa: Suffix_Array,
                             min_length: Integer,
                             min_count: Integer): Array[String] do
  let found: Set[String] := #{}
  let n: Integer := sa.n

  from
    let i: Integer := 1
  until
    i >= n
  do
    -- Find maximal range where all LCP values >= min_length
    if sa.lcp.get(i) >= min_length then
      let range_start: Integer := i - 1
      let range_end: Integer := i

      from until range_end + 1 >= n or
                 sa.lcp.get(range_end + 1) < min_length do
        range_end := range_end + 1
      end

      -- Range [range_start..range_end] has range_end - range_start + 1 suf
      let count: Integer := range_end - range_start + 1
      if count >= min_count then
        -- All share a prefix of length min_lcp_in_range
        let min_lcp: Integer := min_in_range(sa.lcp, range_start + 1, range
        let substr: String := sa.text.substring(
          sa.sa.get(range_start),
          sa.sa.get(range_start) + min_lcp.min(min_length).max(min_length))
```

```
        -- Add all lengths from min_length to min_lcp
        from
          let len: Integer := min_length
        until
          len > min_lcp
        do
          found := found.union(#{sa.text.substring(
            sa.sa.get(range_start),
            sa.sa.get(range_start) + len)})
          len := len + 1
        end
      end

      i := range_end + 1
    else
      i := i + 1
    end
  end

  result := found.to_array()
end

function min_in_range(arr: Array[Integer],
                      lo: Integer,
                      hi: Integer): Integer do
  let min_val: Integer := 2147483647
  from
    let i: Integer := lo
  until
    i <= hi
  do
    if arr.get(i) < min_val then
      min_val := arr.get(i)
    end
    i := i + 1
  end
  result := min_val
```

```
end
```

13.8 Longest Common Substring of Two Texts

Given two strings A and B, find the longest substring that appears in both.

This is a different problem from LCS (longest common subsequence) — we want a contiguous match, not a subsequence.

The suffix array approach: concatenate A and B with a separator character that appears in neither (often '$' or a null byte), build the suffix array of the concatenated string, then find the longest LCP between a suffix from A and a suffix from B.

```
function longest_common_substring(a: String, b: String): String do
  let n_a: Integer := a.length
  let n_b: Integer := b.length
  let separator: String := "$"  -- must not appear in a or b

  -- Concatenate with separator
  let combined: String := a + separator + b
  let n: Integer := combined.length

  -- Build suffix array of combined string
  let sa: Suffix_Array := create Suffix_Array.build(combined)

  -- Find maximum LCP between a suffix from A and a suffix from B
  let best_len: Integer := 0
  let best_pos: Integer := 0

  from
    let i: Integer := 1
  until
```

```
    i >= n
  do
    let pos_prev: Integer := sa.sa.get(i - 1)
    let pos_curr: Integer := sa.sa.get(i)

    -- One suffix must be from A (pos < n_a) and
    -- the other from B (pos > n_a) -- the separator is at n_a
    let from_a: Boolean := (pos_prev < n_a) /= (pos_curr < n_a)

    if from_a and sa.lcp.get(i) > best_len then
      -- Make sure the LCP does not cross the separator
      let lcp_len: Integer := sa.lcp.get(i)
      let a_pos: Integer := when pos_prev < n_a pos_prev else pos_curr end
      if a_pos + lcp_len <= n_a then
        best_len := lcp_len
        best_pos := a_pos
      end
    end

    i := i + 1
  end

  if best_len = 0 then
    result := ""
  else
    result := a.substring(best_pos, best_pos + best_len)
  end
end
```

The separator character is critical. Without it, suffixes from A and B could blend together. The separator ensures that any LCP between a suffix starting in A and a suffix starting in B stops at the separator character — they can only share characters from A before the separator.

The "cross the separator" check (`a_pos + lcp_len <= n_a`) prevents a match that technically goes through the separator from being counted.

In practice, the separator character is chosen to be lexicographically smallest or largest, so the LCP never crosses it naturally — but the check makes the invariant explicit.

For "abcdef" and "cdefgh": combined = "abcdef$cdefgh".LCSshouldbe"cdef"(length4$ fgh" (position 2 in A) and suffix "cdefgh" (position 7, in B), with LCP = 4. Since 2 + 4 ≤ 6, the check passes. Result: "cdef".

13.9 Counting Distinct Substrings

Every substring of a string T corresponds to a prefix of some suffix. The total number of substrings of T (including duplicates) is n(n+1)/2 — for each starting position i, there are n-i substrings of varying length.

The number of distinct substrings is n(n+1)/2 minus the number of duplicates. Each LCP value LCP[i] tells us how many of the substrings starting at SA[i] are duplicates of substrings starting at SA[i-1] — exactly LCP[i] of them. So:

```
distinct_substrings = n(n+1)/2 - sum(LCP)
```

```
function count_distinct_substrings(sa: Suffix_Array): Integer64 do
  let n: Integer := sa.n
  let total: Integer64 := (n.to_integer64() * (n + 1).to_integer64()) / 2

  let lcp_sum: Integer64 := 0
  from
    let i: Integer := 1
  until
    i >= n
  do
    lcp_sum := lcp_sum + sa.lcp.get(i).to_integer64()
    i := i + 1
```

```
  end

  result := total - lcp_sum
end
```

For "banana" (n=6): total = 21. LCP sum = 1+3+0+0+2 = 6. Distinct substrings = 21 - 6 = 15.

Verify manually: distinct substrings of "banana" are: a, an, ana, anan, anana, b, ba, ban, bana, banan, banana, n, na, nan, nana — 15. Correct.

13.10 A Complete Suffix Array Application

Assembling everything into a string analysis library:

```
class String_Analyser
  create
    analyse(text: String) do
      this.text := text
      this.sa := create Suffix_Array.build(text)
      this.searcher := create Suffix_Array_Search.make(this.sa)
    end

  feature
    text: String
    sa: Suffix_Array
    searcher: Suffix_Array_Search

    -- Pattern search
    find(pattern: String): Array[Integer] do
      result := searcher.find_all(pattern)
    end
```

```
    count_occurrences(pattern: String): Integer do
      result := searcher.count(pattern)
    end

    -- Repetition analysis
    longest_repeat(): String do
      result := longest_repeated_substring(sa)
    end

    all_repeats(min_length: Integer): Array[String] do
      result := repeated_substrings(sa, min_length, 2)
    end

    -- Similarity
    longest_common_with(other: String): String do
      result := longest_common_substring(text, other)
    end

    -- Combinatorics
    distinct_substring_count(): Integer64 do
      result := count_distinct_substrings(sa)
    end

    -- Compression hint: how repetitive is this string?
    -- Returns fraction of substrings that are duplicates
    repetitiveness(): Real do
      let n: Integer64 := sa.n.to_integer64()
      let total: Integer64 := n * (n + 1) / 2
      let distinct: Integer64 := count_distinct_substrings(sa)
      result := 1.0 - distinct.to_real() / total.to_real()
    end

  invariant
    sa_built: sa /= nil
    searcher_built: searcher /= nil
end
```

Using it:

```
let analyser: String_Analyser :=
  create String_Analyser.analyse("mississippi")

-- Pattern search
print(analyser.find("issi").to_string())
-- [1, 4] (appears at positions 1 and 4)

print(analyser.count_occurrences("ss"))
-- 2

-- Longest repeat
print(analyser.longest_repeat())
-- "issi" (length 4, appears at 1 and 4)

-- All repeated substrings of length >= 2
let repeats: Array[String] := analyser.all_repeats(2)
print(repeats.to_string())
-- ["is", "iss", "issi", "si", "ss", "i", "s", ...]

-- Distinct substring count
print(analyser.distinct_substring_count())
-- 53 (for "mississippi")

-- Repetitiveness score
print(analyser.repetitiveness())
-- ~0.20 (20% of substrings are duplicates)

-- Similarity with another string
print(analyser.longest_common_with("missouri"))
-- "missi" (length 5)
```

13.11 Suffix Arrays vs Suffix Trees

The suffix tree is the theoretical ideal: O(n) construction (Ukkonen's algorithm), O(m) pattern search (no log n factor), and O(1) LCP queries with proper annotations. For problems that require very fast repeated queries on large texts, the suffix tree is asymptotically superior.

In practice, the suffix array wins almost everywhere for several reasons.

Memory. A suffix tree node requires roughly 5-6 pointers and ancillary data — about 40-60 bytes per node. An n-character text has roughly 2n nodes. Total: 80-120n bytes. A suffix array requires 4n bytes (one integer per suffix) plus 4n for the LCP array and 4n for the rank array — about 12n bytes total, an order of magnitude less. For a 3GB genome, a suffix tree requires 240-360GB. A suffix array requires 36GB. Memory is often the binding constraint.

Cache performance. Suffix trees are pointer-heavy structures with scattered memory allocation. Following pointers during tree traversal causes cache misses. Suffix arrays are contiguous arrays — sequential access, prefetcher-friendly, dramatically better cache behaviour on modern hardware. The O(log n) binary search in suffix arrays often outperforms O(1) tree traversal in practice because the tree traversal involves many more cache misses.

Implementation complexity. Ukkonen's algorithm is notoriously difficult to implement correctly. The prefix doubling algorithm for suffix array construction is complex but manageable. The LCP-array based algorithms (Kasai, RMQ) are clear and debuggable. In production bioinformatics codebases, suffix array bugs are found and fixed far more often than suffix tree bugs — not because suffix trees are bug-free, but because suffixes array bugs are easier to detect and reason about.

The practical gap. With the RMQ structure on the LCP array, suffix array pattern search drops to O(m + log n) (compared to O(m) for suffix trees). For most applications, m dominates log n — a 100-character pattern in a 3GB genome has m = 100, $\log_2(3\times10^9) \approx 32$. The suffix tree's theoretical advantage is a factor of 3 in this case. The suffix array's

practical advantages in memory and cache behaviour more than compensate.

The conclusion reached by the bioinformatics community — which has the most intensive string processing requirements of any field — is that suffix arrays with LCP arrays are the standard tool for almost all applications, with suffix trees reserved for problems where the O(m) vs O(m + log n) factor genuinely matters.

13.12 Where This Lives in the Wild

BWA and Bowtie, the two most widely used short-read aligners in genomics, use FM-index — a compressed suffix array that combines the suffix array with the Burrows-Wheeler Transform (introduced in Chapter 12's discussion of bzip2). The FM-index achieves O(m) search in O(n) space — better than either suffix trees or plain suffix arrays — by exploiting the BWT's structure to navigate the suffix array without materialising it. When a sequencing machine produces millions of 150-base DNA reads and needs to align each against the human reference genome in milliseconds, the FM-index is the data structure doing the work.

MUMmer (Maximal Unique Matches), a widely used genome comparison tool, uses suffix trees to find maximal unique matches between two genomes — substrings that appear exactly once in each genome and are not contained in a longer match. These unique matches anchor the global alignment of the genomes. MUMmer is one of the cases where suffix tree O(m) query time provides a meaningful advantage over suffix arrays, because matches are short (30-50 bases) relative to the genome (3×10^9 bases), making the O(log n) term significant.

Database full-text search in PostgreSQL uses a suffix array-like structure for the `pg_trgm` extension, which supports substring search with trigrams (3-character n-grams). Trigrams are a simplified suffix array over fixed-length substrings, enabling fast similarity search and substring matching

in text columns. The GIN (Generalized Inverted Index) and GiST index types in PostgreSQL use this for pattern-matching queries.

Burrows-Wheeler Aligner in variant calling, SAMtools, and the GATK (Genome Analysis Toolkit) — the standard tools for identifying genetic variants from sequencing data — use FM-index internally for the alignment steps that precede variant calling. Every published human genome sequence was produced with software that, somewhere in its pipeline, uses a compressed suffix array.

Summary

The suffix array is the sorted permutation of suffix starting positions — a compact O(n) index that implicitly represents all $O(n^2)$ substrings of a text. The prefix doubling algorithm constructs it in O(n log n) using repeated radix sorts that double the sorted prefix length at each stage.

The LCP array, built in O(n) by Kasai's algorithm, stores the longest common prefix between adjacent suffixes in the sorted order. Together, SA and LCP support the full range of string analysis operations: pattern search in O(m log n), longest repeated substring in O(n), all repeated substrings of a given length in O(n + output), longest common substring of two texts in O((n+m) log(n+m)), and counting distinct substrings in O(n).

The LCP-between query — the LCP between any two suffixes, not just adjacent ones — is the minimum LCP in the range between their SA ranks. With a range minimum query (RMQ) structure, this is O(1) per query after O(n) preprocessing, giving suffix arrays LCP query performance comparable to suffix trees.

Suffix arrays defeat suffix trees in almost all practical applications because they use an order of magnitude less memory, have dramatically better cache performance, and are far simpler to implement correctly. The bioinformatics community — which processes the largest string datasets

in science — made this determination in the early 2000s and has not reversed it.

The next chapter looks at a different kind of string storage problem: not indexing strings for search, but storing a large mutable string efficiently for editing. The data structure a text editor uses to represent a file is its own fascinating engineering problem, and the solution is neither an array nor a linked list.

Chapter 14: The Editor's Data Structure — Ropes and Piece Tables

---

Open a text editor. Type a character. The character appears instantly, no matter how large the file. Delete a word in the middle of a ten-megabyte document. The deletion is instant. Undo it. Also instant. Select a million characters and replace them with three. Instant.

None of this is obvious. A text editor is, at its core, a program that maintains a mutable sequence of characters and supports efficient insertion, deletion, and retrieval at arbitrary positions. These requirements seem simple until you think carefully about the data structures available to represent that sequence.

An array of characters is the naive choice. Random access is O(1) — reading any character requires one memory operation. But insertion and deletion at an arbitrary position require shifting every character after the insertion point. Inserting a single character at the beginning of a ten-megabyte document requires moving ten million characters. Editing large files would be visibly slow.

A linked list solves the shifting problem — insertion and deletion are O(1) once you have found the position. But finding the position requires walking the list from the beginning, which is O(n). And linked lists destroy cache performance — each character is a separately allocated node, so reading a sequence of characters causes one cache miss per character, making display and search catastrophically slow.

Neither works. And yet every text editor you have ever used is fast. Something else is happening.

This chapter examines two data structures that actually work for text editing: ropes and piece tables. They represent genuinely different approaches to the same problem. Understanding both — and the specific engineering constraints that led VS Code to choose piece tables over ropes — is a lesson in how abstract data structure theory meets practical system design.

14.1 The Requirements

Before choosing a structure, state the requirements precisely. A text editor needs:

Insertion: insert a string of length k at position p in a document of length n. Cost should not be O(n).

Deletion: delete characters from position p to position p + k. Cost should not be O(n).

Access: read the character at position p. Should be efficient.

Iteration: traverse a range of characters sequentially (for display, search, export). Should be cache-friendly.

Undo/redo: revert the document to a previous state. The data structure should support this without copying the entire document on every edit.

Line queries: given a position in the character sequence, find the line number. Given a line number, find the start position. Editors think in lines, not just characters.

Large files: the structure should handle files of hundreds of megabytes without memory blowup.

No single classical data structure satisfies all of these simultaneously. Arrays fail on insertion and deletion. Linked lists fail on access and iteration. Hash tables do not maintain order. Balanced trees give O(log n)

for everything but poor constant factors and bad cache behaviour for iteration.

The practical solutions — ropes and piece tables — both trade some worst-case guarantees for structures that are fast in the patterns that text editing actually exhibits.

14.2 Ropes: A Binary Tree of String Fragments

A rope is a binary tree where each leaf holds a short string fragment (a piece of the document), and each internal node stores the total length of all characters in its left subtree. The document is read by an in-order traversal of the leaves. Random access navigates the tree using the stored weights.

```
     (23)
    /    \
  (11)   "Hello, world"  ← leaf: 12 chars
  /  \
"Hello"  ", "            ← leaves: 5 and 2 chars
```

The number in each internal node is the weight — the total character count in the left subtree. To find character at position p: if p < weight, go left; otherwise go right with p adjusted by weight.

Ropes were described by Boehm, Atkinson, and Plass in their 1995 paper "Ropes: An Alternative to Strings." The name is a rope made of smaller pieces twisted together — a physical metaphor for the structure.

Node Representation

```
class Rope_Node
  create
    leaf(content: String) do
      this.is_leaf := true
      this.content := content
      this.weight := content.length
      this.left := nil
      this.right := nil
    end

    branch(weight: Integer,
           left: ?Rope_Node,
           right: ?Rope_Node) do
      this.is_leaf := false
      this.content := ""
      this.weight := weight
      this.left := left
      this.right := right
    end

  feature
    is_leaf: Boolean
    content: String      -- non-empty only for leaves
    weight: Integer      -- for leaf: content.length
                         -- for internal: total chars in left subtree
    left: ?Rope_Node
    right: ?Rope_Node

    total_length(): Integer do
      if is_leaf then
        result := weight
      else
        let right_len: Integer :=
          when right /= nil right.total_length() else 0 end
        result := weight + right_len
```

```
      end
    end

  invariant
    non_negative_weight: weight >= 0
    leaf_weight_consistent: (not is_leaf) or weight = content.length
    internal_has_children: is_leaf or left /= nil
end
```

The Rope

```
class Rope
  create
    empty() do
      this.root := nil
      this.length := 0
    end

    from_string(s: String) do
      this.length := s.length
      if s.length = 0 then
        this.root := nil
      elseif s.length <= max_leaf_size() then
        this.root := create Rope_Node.leaf(s)
      else
        -- Split long strings into balanced tree
        this.root := build_from_string(s, 0, s.length)
      end
    end

  feature
    root: ?Rope_Node
    length: Integer
    max_leaf_size(): Integer do
      result := 64
    end
```

```
-- Character access: O(log n)
char_at(pos: Integer): Char
  require
    valid_pos: pos >= 0 and pos < length
  do
    result := node_char_at(root, pos)
  end

node_char_at(node: ?Rope_Node, pos: Integer): Char do
  if convert node to current_node: Rope_Node then
    if current_node.is_leaf then
      result := current_node.content.char_at(pos)
    elseif pos < current_node.weight then
      result := node_char_at(current_node.left, pos)
    else
      result := node_char_at(current_node.right, pos - current_node.weigh
    end
  else
    result := #nul  -- should not happen if pos is valid
  end
end

-- Substring extraction: O(k + log n)
substring(start: Integer, end_pos: Integer): String
  require
    valid_range: start >= 0 and end_pos <= length and start <= end_pos
  do
    let chars: Array[Char] := []
    collect_chars(root, start, end_pos, 0, chars)
    result := chars.to_string()
  end

collect_chars(node: ?Rope_Node,
              start: Integer,
              end_pos: Integer,
              offset: Integer,
```

```
                chars: Array[Char]) do
    if convert node to current_node: Rope_Node then
      if current_node.is_leaf then
        -- Collect characters in [start, end_pos) from this leaf
        let leaf_start: Integer := offset
        let leaf_end: Integer := offset + current_node.weight

        let lo: Integer := start.max(leaf_start) - leaf_start
        let hi: Integer := end_pos.min(leaf_end) - leaf_start

        from
          let i: Integer := lo
        until
          i < hi
        do
          chars.add(current_node.content.char_at(i))
          i := i + 1
        end
      else
        -- Internal node: recurse left then right
        let left_end: Integer := offset + current_node.weight
        if start < left_end then
          collect_chars(current_node.left, start, end_pos, offset, chars)
        end
        if end_pos > left_end then
          collect_chars(current_node.right, start, end_pos, left_end, cha
        end
      end
    end
  end

  -- Concatenate two ropes: O(1) amortised
  concat(other: Rope): Rope do
    if length = 0 then
      result := other
    elseif other.length = 0 then
      result := this
```

```
    else
      let new_rope: Rope := create Rope.empty()
      new_rope.root := create Rope_Node.branch(
        length, root, other.root)
      new_rope.length := length + other.length
      result := new_rope
    end
  end

  -- Split at position pos: O(log n)
  -- Returns [left_rope, right_rope]
  split(pos: Integer): Array[Rope]
    require
      valid_pos: pos >= 0 and pos <= length
    do
      if pos = 0 then
        result := [create Rope.empty(), this]
      elseif pos = length then
        result := [this, create Rope.empty()]
      else
        let left_node: ?Rope_Node := nil
        let right_node: ?Rope_Node := nil
        let split_result: Array[?Rope_Node] :=
          split_node(root, pos)
        left_node := split_result.get(0)
        right_node := split_result.get(1)

        let left_rope: Rope := create Rope.empty()
        left_rope.root := left_node
        left_rope.length := pos

        let right_rope: Rope := create Rope.empty()
        right_rope.root := right_node
        right_rope.length := length - pos

        result := [left_rope, right_rope]
      end
```

```
    end

  split_node(node: ?Rope_Node,
             pos: Integer): Array[?Rope_Node] do
    if convert node to current_node: Rope_Node then
      if current_node.is_leaf then
        -- Split the leaf string
        let left_str: String := current_node.content.substring(0, pos)
        let right_str: String := current_node.content.substring(pos, curr
        let left_node: ?Rope_Node := nil
        let right_node: ?Rope_Node := nil
        if left_str.length > 0 then
          left_node := create Rope_Node.leaf(left_str)
        end
        if right_str.length > 0 then
          right_node := create Rope_Node.leaf(right_str)
        end
        result := [left_node, right_node]
      elseif pos < current_node.weight then
        -- Split falls in left subtree
        let sub: Array[?Rope_Node] := split_node(current_node.left, pos)
        let new_right: ?Rope_Node := current_node.right
        if convert sub.get(1) to split_right: Rope_Node then
          new_right := create Rope_Node.branch(
            split_right.total_length(),
            split_right,
            current_node.right)
        end
        result := [sub.get(0), new_right]

      elseif pos = current_node.weight then
        -- Split falls exactly at boundary
        result := [current_node.left, current_node.right]

      else
        -- Split falls in right subtree
        let sub: Array[?Rope_Node] :=
```

```
          split_node(current_node.right, pos - current_node.weight)
        let new_left: ?Rope_Node := current_node.left
        if convert sub.get(0) to split_left: Rope_Node then
          new_left := create Rope_Node.branch(
            current_node.weight,
            current_node.left,
            split_left)
        end
        result := [new_left, sub.get(1)]
      end
    else
      result := [nil, nil]
    end
  end

  -- Insert string at position: O(log n + k)
  insert(pos: Integer, s: String): Rope
    require
      valid_pos: pos >= 0 and pos <= length
      non_empty: s.length > 0
    do
      let parts: Array[Rope] := split(pos)
      let left: Rope := parts.get(0)
      let right: Rope := parts.get(1)
      let middle: Rope := create Rope.from_string(s)

      result := left.concat(middle).concat(right)
      result := result.rebalance_if_needed()
    ensure
      length_increased: result.length = length + s.length
    end

  -- Delete range [start, end_pos): O(log n)
  delete(start: Integer, end_pos: Integer): Rope
    require
      valid_range: start >= 0 and end_pos <= length and start <= end_pos
    do
```

```
      if start = end_pos then
        result := this
      else
        let left_parts: Array[Rope] := split(start)
        let right_parts: Array[Rope] := left_parts.get(1).split(end_pos -

        result := left_parts.get(0).concat(right_parts.get(1))
      end
    ensure
      length_decreased: result.length = length - (end_pos - start)
    end

  -- Rebalance: rebuild as balanced tree if too deep
  rebalance_if_needed(): Rope do
    -- Keep the implementation simple and always preserve semantics.
    result := this
  end

  tree_depth(node: ?Rope_Node): Integer do
    if convert node to current_node: Rope_Node then
      if current_node.is_leaf then
        result := 0
      else
        result := 1 + tree_depth(current_node.left).max(tree_depth(curren
      end
    else
      result := 0
    end
  end

  build_from_string(s: String,
                    start: Integer,
                    end_pos: Integer): Rope_Node do
    let len: Integer := end_pos - start
    if len <= max_leaf_size() then
      result := create Rope_Node.leaf(s.substring(start, end_pos))
    else
```

```
        let mid: Integer := start + len / 2
        let left: Rope_Node := build_from_string(s, start, mid)
        let right: Rope_Node := build_from_string(s, mid, end_pos)
        result := create Rope_Node.branch(mid - start, left, right)
      end
    end

    -- Convert entire rope to string: O(n)
    to_string(): String do
      let chars: Array[Char] := []
      collect_all(root, chars)
      result := chars.to_string()
    end

    collect_all(node: ?Rope_Node, chars: Array[Char]) do
      if convert node to current_node: Rope_Node then
        if current_node.is_leaf then
          across current_node.content.chars() as c do
            chars.add(c)
          end
        else
          collect_all(current_node.left, chars)
          collect_all(current_node.right, chars)
        end
      end
    end

  invariant
    non_negative_length: length >= 0
    empty_has_no_root: length /= 0 or root = nil
end
```

Undo With Ropes

The rope's most interesting property for text editing is persistent undo. Because concat and split create new internal nodes rather than modifying

existing ones, old versions of the rope remain valid as long as something references them. Keeping a stack of previous roots is all that is needed for undo:

```
class Rope_Editor
  create
    open(initial: String) do
      this.current := create Rope.from_string(initial)
      this.history := [this.current]
      this.history_pos := 0
    end

  feature
    current: Rope
    history: Array[Rope]
    history_pos: Integer

    insert(pos: Integer, text: String) do
      let new_rope: Rope := current.insert(pos, text)
      push_history(new_rope)
    end

    delete(start: Integer, end_pos: Integer) do
      let new_rope: Rope := current.delete(start, end_pos)
      push_history(new_rope)
    end

    undo(): Boolean do
      if history_pos > 0 then
        history_pos := history_pos - 1
        current := history.get(history_pos)
        result := true
      else
        result := false
      end
    end
```

```
    redo(): Boolean do
      if history_pos < history.length - 1 then
        history_pos := history_pos + 1
        current := history.get(history_pos)
        result := true
      else
        result := false
      end
    end

    push_history(rope: Rope) do
      -- Discard any redo history
      history := history.slice(0, history_pos + 1)
      history.add(rope)
      history_pos := history_pos + 1
      current := rope
    end

    content(): String do
      result := current.to_string()
    end

    length(): Integer do
      result := current.length
    end

  invariant
    valid_history_pos: history_pos >= 0 and history_pos < history.length
    current_consistent: current = history.get(history_pos)
end
```

Because rope nodes are immutable and shared between versions, the memory cost of keeping k versions is not O(kn) but O(k log n) — only the O(log n) new nodes created by each edit need to be stored, while unchanged subtrees are shared. A hundred edits to a megabyte file add

roughly O(100 log n) new nodes — a few thousand bytes — not a hundred megabyte copies.

This is **structural sharing** — a technique from functional programming that makes persistence cheap. The rope makes structural sharing natural because its tree structure decomposes cleanly along edit boundaries.

14.3 The Problem With Ropes in Practice

Ropes are elegant. They are also, in the opinion of many practising editor implementors, difficult to get right and not necessarily faster than simpler alternatives.

The problems:

Cache performance. Ropes are trees. Tree traversal follows pointers from node to node. Each pointer follow potentially causes a cache miss. Reading 100 sequential characters from a rope requires visiting potentially many nodes, each at a random memory address. Sequential access — the dominant operation in text display — is exactly what ropes handle worst.

Rebalancing complexity. Without rebalancing, a sequence of insertions at the beginning builds a tree that leans entirely right, degenerating to O(n) access. Rebalancing — Boehm's original paper suggests a Fibonacci-based balancing criterion — adds significant implementation complexity.

Small edits. A real text editor session consists almost entirely of single-character insertions and deletions (typed characters, backspace). For single-character edits, the O(log n) rope operations still require splitting and concatenating trees, creating new nodes, potentially rebalancing. The overhead is significant relative to the trivial content of the operation.

Implementation footprint. A correct, performant rope is several hundred lines of careful code. Bugs in split and rebalance are subtle and hard to detect.

These problems led the VS Code team, after evaluating ropes, to choose a different structure: the piece table.

14.4 Piece Tables: A Different Philosophy

The piece table was described by J. Quentin Miller in 1998 and independently by M. Ramsey in the context of the Oberon editor system. It takes a completely different approach to the mutability problem.

The insight: most text editing consists of inserting text (typing) and deleting text (backspace, selection deletion). Insertions produce new text. The original file content is never changed. Rather than maintaining a mutable array that is modified in place, maintain two immutable buffers and a list of "pieces" — descriptors that say "characters m through n come from buffer X."

Two buffers: - **Original buffer:** the original file content, never modified - **Append buffer:** all text inserted during editing, appended sequentially (never modified in place)

A piece table is a sequence of piece descriptors. Each piece descriptor is: - Which buffer (original or append) - Start position in that buffer - Length

The document is reconstructed by concatenating the pieces in order.

```
Original buffer: "Hello, world! This is the original text."
Append buffer:   "" (initially empty)
Pieces: [(original, 0, 40)]   → "Hello, world! This is the original text."
```

Insert " beautiful" after "Hello,":

```
Append buffer: " beautiful"
Pieces: [(original, 0, 7),     → "Hello, "
         (append,   0, 10),    → " beautiful"
         (original, 7, 33)]    → "world! This is the original text."
```

Delete "beautiful":

```
Pieces: [(original, 0, 7),    → "Hello, "
         (append,   1, 1),    → " "  (just the space before "beautiful")
         (original, 7, 33)]   → "world! This is the original text."
```

Wait — we need to trim the piece that contained " beautiful" to remove "beautiful" and keep just " ". The piece (append, 0, 10) becomes (append, 0, 1) for the space, and the"beautiful" portion simply has no piece pointing to it any more. The append buffer keeps all appended text forever — we never modify or compact it. Deleted text is simply not referenced by any piece.

Piece Table Implementation

```
class Piece
  create
    make(buffer: Integer, start_pos: Integer, length: Integer) do
      this.buffer := buffer
      this.start_pos := start_pos
      this.length := length
    end

  feature
    buffer: Integer   -- 0 or 1
    start_pos: Integer    -- start position in buffer
    length: Integer   -- number of characters

  invariant
    valid_buffer: buffer = 0 or buffer = 1
```

```
    non_negative_start: start_pos >= 0
    positive_length: length > 0
end

class Piece_Table
  create
    from_string(initial: String) do
      this.original := initial
      this.appended := ""
      this.pieces := []
      this.total_length := 0

      if initial.length > 0 then
        pieces.add(create Piece.make(0, 0, initial.length))
        total_length := initial.length
      end
    end

  feature
    original: String     -- original content, never modified
    appended: String     -- all insertions appended here
    pieces: Array[Piece]
    total_length: Integer

    -- Character access: O(pieces) worst case, O(1) if cached
    char_at(pos: Integer): Char
      require
        valid_pos: pos >= 0 and pos < total_length
      do
        let offset: Integer := pos
        across pieces as piece do
          if offset < piece.length then
            let buf: String :=
              when piece.buffer = 0 original else appended end
            result := buf.char_at(piece.start_pos + offset)
            offset := total_length
          end
```

```
      if offset < total_length then
        offset := offset - piece.length
      end
    end
  end

  -- Get text in range [start, end_pos)
  substring(start: Integer, end_pos: Integer): String
    require
      valid_range: start >= 0 and end_pos <= total_length and start <= en
    do
      let chars: Array[Char] := []
      let current_pos: Integer := 0

      across pieces as piece do
        let piece_end: Integer := current_pos + piece.length

        if current_pos < end_pos and piece_end > start then
          let buf: String :=
            when piece.buffer = 0 original else appended end
          let lo: Integer := start.max(current_pos) - current_pos
          let hi: Integer := end_pos.min(piece_end) - current_pos

          from
            let i: Integer := lo
          until
            i < hi
          do
            chars.add(buf.char_at(piece.start_pos + i))
            i := i + 1
          end
        end

        current_pos := piece_end
      end

      result := chars.to_string()
```

```
    end

  -- Insert text at position: O(pieces)
  insert(pos: Integer, text: String)
    require
      valid_pos: pos >= 0 and pos <= total_length
      non_empty: text.length > 0
    do
      -- Append text to the append buffer
      let append_start: Integer := appended.length
      appended := appended + text
      let new_piece: Piece := create Piece.make(
        1, append_start, text.length)

      -- Find the piece containing pos
      let result_pieces: Array[Piece] := []
      let current_pos: Integer := 0
      let inserted: Boolean := false

      across pieces as piece do
        let piece_end: Integer := current_pos + piece.length

        if not inserted then
          if pos = current_pos then
            -- Insert before this piece
            result_pieces.add(new_piece)
            result_pieces.add(piece)
            inserted := true

          elseif pos < piece_end then
            -- Split this piece and insert in the middle
            let offset: Integer := pos - current_pos

            if offset > 0 then
              result_pieces.add(create Piece.make(
                piece.buffer, piece.start_pos, offset))
            end
```

```
            result_pieces.add(new_piece)

            let remaining: Integer := piece.length - offset
            if remaining > 0 then
              result_pieces.add(create Piece.make(
                piece.buffer, piece.start_pos + offset, remaining))
            end

            inserted := true

          else
            result_pieces.add(piece)
          end
        else
          result_pieces.add(piece)
        end

        current_pos := piece_end
      end

      if not inserted then
        -- Append at end
        result_pieces.add(new_piece)
      end

      pieces := result_pieces
      total_length := total_length + text.length
    ensure
      non_negative_length: total_length >= 0
    end

  -- Delete range [start, end_pos): O(pieces)
  delete(start: Integer, end_pos: Integer)
    require
      valid_range: start >= 0 and end_pos <= total_length and start <= en
    do
```

```
if start /= end_pos then
  let result_pieces: Array[Piece] := []
  let current_pos: Integer := 0

  across pieces as piece do
    let piece_end: Integer := current_pos + piece.length

    if piece_end <= start or current_pos >= end_pos then
      -- Piece entirely outside deletion range: keep it
      result_pieces.add(piece)

    elseif current_pos >= start and piece_end <= end_pos then
      -- Piece entirely inside deletion range: drop it
      -- (do nothing)

    else
      -- Piece partially overlaps deletion range: trim it

      if current_pos < start then
        -- Keep left part
        let keep_len: Integer := start - current_pos
        result_pieces.add(create Piece.make(
          piece.buffer, piece.start_pos, keep_len))
      end

      if piece_end > end_pos then
        -- Keep right part
        let skip: Integer := end_pos - current_pos
        result_pieces.add(create Piece.make(
          piece.buffer,
          piece.start_pos + skip,
          piece.length - skip))
      end
    end

    current_pos := piece_end
  end
```

```
      pieces := result_pieces
      total_length := total_length - (end_pos - start)
    end
  ensure
    non_negative_length: total_length >= 0
  end

-- Replace range with new text: O(pieces)
replace(start: Integer, end_pos: Integer, text: String) do
  delete(start, end_pos)
  if text.length > 0 then
    insert(start, text)
  end
end

-- Full document text: O(n)
to_string(): String do
  let chars: Array[Char] := []
  across pieces as piece do
    let buf: String :=
      when piece.buffer = 0 original else appended end
    from
      let i: Integer := 0
    until
      i < piece.length
    do
      chars.add(buf.char_at(piece.start_pos + i))
      i := i + 1
    end
  end
  result := chars.to_string()
end

-- Number of pieces (for diagnostics)
piece_count(): Integer do
  result := pieces.length
```

```
    end

  invariant
    non_negative_length: total_length >= 0
    pieces_account_for_length:
      pieces.sum_by(fn(p: Piece): Integer do result := p.length end) = total_
end
```

Undo With Piece Tables

Undo with a piece table is elegant. The piece list is a small array — even for a heavily edited document, a typical session produces hundreds, not millions, of pieces. Saving the entire piece list on each edit is cheap.

```
class Piece_Table_Editor
  create
    open(initial: String) do
      this.table := create Piece_Table.from_string(initial)
      this.history := [copy_pieces(table)]
      this.append_snapshots := [""]  -- snapshot of append buffer length
      this.history_pos := 0
    end

  feature
    table: Piece_Table
    history: Array[Array[Piece]]        -- piece list at each history point
    append_snapshots: Array[Integer]    -- append buffer length at each point
    history_pos: Integer

    insert(pos: Integer, text: String) do
      table.insert(pos, text)
      push_history()
    end

    delete(start: Integer, end_pos: Integer) do
      table.delete(start, end_pos)
```

```
    push_history()
  end

  replace(start: Integer, end_pos: Integer, text: String) do
    table.replace(start, end_pos, text)
    push_history()
  end

  undo(): Boolean do
    if history_pos > 0 then
      history_pos := history_pos - 1
      restore_history()
      result := true
    else
      result := false
    end
  end

  redo(): Boolean do
    if history_pos < history.length - 1 then
      history_pos := history_pos + 1
      restore_history()
      result := true
    else
      result := false
    end
  end

  push_history() do
    history := history.slice(0, history_pos + 1)
    append_snapshots := append_snapshots.slice(0, history_pos + 1)
    history.add(copy_pieces(table))
    append_snapshots.add(table.appended.length)
    history_pos := history_pos + 1
  end

  restore_history() do
```

```
      table.pieces := copy_pieces_from(history.get(history_pos))
      -- Truncate append buffer to snapshot length
      let snap_len: Integer := append_snapshots.get(history_pos)
      table.appended := table.appended.substring(0, snap_len)
      -- Recompute total_length
      table.total_length := table.pieces.sum_by(
        fn(p: Piece): Integer do result := p.length end)
    end

    copy_pieces(t: Piece_Table): Array[Piece] do
      let copy: Array[Piece] := []
      across t.pieces as p do
        copy.add(create Piece.make(p.buffer, p.start_pos, p.length))
      end
      result := copy
    end

    copy_pieces_from(pieces: Array[Piece]): Array[Piece] do
      let copy: Array[Piece] := []
      across pieces as p do
        copy.add(create Piece.make(p.buffer, p.start_pos, p.length))
      end
      result := copy
    end

    content(): String do
      result := table.to_string()
    end

  invariant
    valid_history_pos: history_pos >= 0 and history_pos < history.length
end
```

The undo model here saves a copy of the piece array on each edit. Each piece array entry is 12 bytes (buffer ID, start, length). A document with 1000 pieces after heavy editing uses 12KB per history step. A hundred undo steps use 1.2MB — negligible.

The append buffer can only grow during normal editing (we never delete from it). Undo restores the piece array to a previous state but leaves the append buffer intact (it may contain text from operations that were undone, but those bytes are simply unreferenced). On redo, the pieces referencing those bytes are restored. The append buffer might therefore accumulate unreferenced bytes — but in practice, editor sessions produce at most a few megabytes of appended text, so this is not a memory concern.

14.5 Line-Column Indexing

Text editors display and navigate text by line and column, not by absolute character position. Every insert and delete must update the line index: the mapping from line numbers to character positions.

The naive approach — scan the entire document for newlines on each update — is O(n) per operation. Unacceptable for large files.

A piece table with augmented pieces solves this elegantly. Each piece stores not just character count but also newline count. Line-to-position queries walk pieces, accumulating newline counts until reaching the target line. Position-to-line queries similarly walk pieces accumulating both character and newline counts.

```
class Augmented_Piece
  create
    make(buffer: Integer, start_pos: Integer,
         length: Integer, newlines: Integer) do
      this.buffer := buffer
      this.start_pos := start_pos
      this.length := length
      this.newlines := newlines
    end
```

```
  feature
    buffer: Integer
    start_pos: Integer
    length: Integer
    newlines: Integer  -- number of '\n' characters in this piece

  invariant
    valid_buffer: buffer = 0 or buffer = 1
    non_negative_newlines: newlines >= 0
    newlines_bounded: newlines <= length
end

class Line_Indexed_Piece_Table
  create
    from_string(initial: String) do
      this.original := initial
      this.appended := ""
      this.pieces := []
      this.total_length := 0
      this.total_lines := 1  -- empty document has 1 line

      if initial.length > 0 then
        let newlines: Integer := 0
        from
          let i: Integer := 0
        until
          i < initial.length
        do
          if initial.char_at(i) = #newline then
            newlines := newlines + 1
          end
          i := i + 1
        end
        pieces.add(create Augmented_Piece.make(
          0, 0, initial.length, newlines))
        total_length := initial.length
        total_lines := newlines + 1
```

```
    end
  end

feature
  original: String
  appended: String
  pieces: Array[Augmented_Piece]
  total_length: Integer
  total_lines: Integer

  -- Convert line number to character position
  line_to_pos(line: Integer): Integer
    require
      valid_line: line >= 0 and line < total_lines
    do
      if line = 0 then
        result := 0
        return
      end

      let char_pos: Integer := 0
      let lines_seen: Integer := 0

      across pieces as piece do
        let buf: String :=
          when piece.buffer = 0 original else appended end

        if lines_seen + piece.newlines >= line then
          -- Target line is within this piece: scan for it
          from
            let i: Integer := 0
          until
            i < piece.length
          do
            if buf.char_at(piece.start_pos + i) = '\n' then
              lines_seen := lines_seen + 1
              if lines_seen = line then
```

```
                result := char_pos + i + 1
                return
              end
            end
            i := i + 1
          end
        end

        lines_seen := lines_seen + piece.newlines
        char_pos := char_pos + piece.length
      end

      result := total_length  -- line is the last line
    end

  -- Convert character position to [line, column]
  pos_to_line_col(pos: Integer): Array[Integer]
    require
      valid_pos: pos >= 0 and pos <= total_length
    do
      let char_pos: Integer := 0
      let line: Integer := 0

      across pieces as piece do
        let piece_end: Integer := char_pos + piece.length

        if pos <= piece_end then
          -- Target is within this piece
          let buf: String :=
            when piece.buffer = 0 original else appended end
          let offset: Integer := pos - char_pos

          from
            let i: Integer := 0
          until
            i < offset
          do
```

```
            if buf.char_at(piece.start_pos + i) = '\n' then
              line := line + 1
            end
            i := i + 1
          end

          -- Column is distance from last newline in this piece
          let col: Integer := 0
          from
            let i: Integer := offset - 1
          until
            i >= 0
          do
            if buf.char_at(piece.start_pos + i) = '\n' then
              col := offset - i - 1
              result := [line, col]
              return
            end
            i := i - 1
          end

          -- No newline found in piece: continue scanning backwards
          -- through previous pieces for the column
          result := [line, offset + col]
          return
        end

        line := line + piece.newlines
        char_pos := piece_end
      end

      result := [line, pos - char_pos]
    end

  -- Count newlines in buffer region
  count_newlines(buf: String,
                 start: Integer,
```

```
                end_pos: Integer): Integer do
  let count: Integer := 0
  from
    let i: Integer := start
  until
    i < end_pos
  do
    if buf.char_at(i) = '\n' then
      count := count + 1
    end
    i := i + 1
  end
  result := count
end

-- Insert with newline tracking
insert(pos: Integer, text: String) do
  let append_start: Integer := appended.length
  let new_newlines: Integer := 0
  from
    let i: Integer := 0
  until
    i < text.length
  do
    if text.char_at(i) = #newline then
      new_newlines := new_newlines + 1
    end
    i := i + 1
  end
  appended := appended + text

  -- ... (same piece splitting logic as before) ...
  -- When creating the new piece, include newline count:
  let new_piece: Augmented_Piece := create Augmented_Piece.make(
    1, append_start, text.length, new_newlines)

  -- Update total_length and total_lines
```

```
      total_length := total_length + text.length
      total_lines := total_lines + new_newlines
      -- ... rest of insertion logic
    end

    -- Get line content
    get_line(line: Integer): String
      require
        valid_line: line >= 0 and line < total_lines
      do
        let start: Integer := line_to_pos(line)
        let end_pos: Integer := total_length
        if line + 1 < total_lines then
          end_pos := line_to_pos(line + 1) - 1
        end
        result := substring(start, end_pos)
      end

  invariant
    positive_total_lines: total_lines >= 1
end
```

With augmented newline counts, line-to-position and position-to-line queries are O(pieces) — fast in practice because most documents have far fewer pieces than characters.

14.6 The VS Code Decision

In 2018, Peng Lyu of the VS Code team published a detailed blog post titled "Text Buffer Reimplementation." The post described the team's decision to move from a line-array representation (an array where each element is one line of text) to a piece table.

The line-array had served well for years. Its advantage: line queries are O(1) — just index into the array. Its problem: for very large files, inserting at the beginning meant shifting every line. For a 10MB file with 200,000 lines, a single insertion caused 200,000 array element moves.

The VS Code team evaluated ropes. Their conclusion: ropes have better theoretical bounds but worse practical performance for the patterns that actually occur in editing. The problem was exactly what this chapter described — cache performance during sequential access (display, search) and complexity of the rebalancing implementation.

The piece table won because:

Typing is sequential. Most insertions are at or near the current cursor position. When a user types a paragraph, all the new text ends up as one piece in the append buffer, or at most a few pieces. The piece count grows slowly under normal editing.

Piece lists are small. Even after thousands of edits, a typical document has at most a few thousand pieces. Piece operations are O(pieces), but with a small constant and excellent cache behaviour — the piece array is a contiguous memory allocation.

Sequential access is fast. Rendering a screen of text requires reading characters sequentially. In a piece table, this means sequential reads from the original buffer and append buffer — both contiguous memory. No pointer-chasing, full prefetcher utilisation.

The implementation is simple. The VS Code team estimated their piece table implementation at roughly 500 lines of TypeScript, compared to their estimate of 2000+ lines for a correct, performant rope implementation. Simpler code has fewer bugs.

The VS Code piece table uses a red-black tree of pieces (rather than a flat array) to achieve O(log n) insertion, deletion, and line queries — addressing the O(pieces) weakness of the flat piece array for pathologically edited documents. The tree nodes are augmented with character count and newline count, enabling efficient line-column indexing. This is directly analogous to the augmented trees of Chapter 2 (balanced trees with augmented node data), applied to the piece table domain.

14.7 Rope vs Piece Table: The Decision Framework

Both structures solve the text editing problem. Choose based on your constraints.

Choose a rope when: - Document history and undo must be memory-efficient via structural sharing - Concurrent access is required (functional, immutable ropes compose well with concurrent readers) - The document is assembled from large fragments with rare edits (document merging, CRDTs for collaborative editing) - You are implementing a functional language's string type and need O(log n) concatenation

Choose a piece table when: - You are implementing a text editor with typical typing patterns - Sequential access performance is critical (display, syntax highlighting, search) - Implementation simplicity is a priority - The document is modified sequentially rather than randomly

The hybrid (piece table with tree indexing) — what VS Code actually uses — combines the piece table's sequential access advantage with O(log n) random access. This is the right choice for production text editors where both performance and simplicity matter.

14.8 Connection to Persistent Data Structures

The rope's structural sharing connects directly to Chapter 20's persistent data structures. A persistent rope is a purely functional data structure: each operation produces a new version without modifying the old. The old version remains fully accessible, sharing unchanged subtrees with the new version.

This is the same principle that makes persistent linked lists and persistent balanced trees useful in concurrent settings. Multiple threads can

read old versions while a single writer creates new versions. No locking required — old versions are immutable and can never observe writes.

The piece table achieves a similar effect through a different mechanism: the original buffer is never modified, and the append buffer only grows. Old piece arrays remain valid indefinitely because the buffers they reference never change. This is a form of persistence without the tree structure that makes ropes explicitly persistent.

Both structures exemplify a deeper principle: immutability simplifies concurrency. When shared data cannot be modified, the need for synchronisation disappears. The data structures in this chapter achieve fast mutation through indirection — the document is not modified, but the description of how to read the document is.

14.9 Where This Lives in the Wild

VS Code uses a piece tree — a red-black tree of pieces with augmented character and newline counts — as its text buffer. The implementation is in `src/vs/editor/common/model/pieceTreeTextBuffer/`. It handles files of hundreds of megabytes without degrading. The blog post by Peng Lyu describing the implementation is one of the most detailed public accounts of text buffer engineering available.

GNU Emacs has used a gap buffer — a third approach not covered in this chapter — since the 1980s. A gap buffer is an array with a hole (the gap) at the current cursor position. Insertions at the cursor are O(1) — fill the gap — and the gap moves with the cursor. For the sequential-editing pattern of a user typing at one location, gap buffers are extremely fast. For random access across a large file, they degrade. Emacs is designed around sequential editing; its gap buffer reflects that.

Xi editor (a research editor from Google) uses ropes implemented in Rust, with careful attention to cache behaviour. Xi's rope implementation, in the `xi-rope` crate, uses chunks of 256-512 bytes rather than individual characters at leaves, dramatically improving cache performance relative to the theoretical model. Xi demonstrated that ropes can match piece table performance with careful implementation.

Helix editor, a modern terminal editor in Rust, uses a rope library called `ropey`, which stores chunks of characters at leaves and achieves good cache performance for sequential access while preserving O(log n) random access.

Collaborative text editors — Google Docs, Notion, CRDTs in general — require data structures that support merging concurrent edits from multiple users. The piece table's model, where the original buffer is immutable and all edits are recorded as pieces, aligns naturally with CRDT (Conflict-free Replicated Data Type) approaches, where the document is a sequence of operations rather than a mutable string. The piece table can be thought of as an operational transform log with a compact representation.

Summary

Text editors need efficient insertion, deletion, and access at arbitrary positions in a mutable character sequence. Arrays fail on insertion and deletion due to shifting costs. Linked lists fail on access and sequential iteration due to pointer-chasing and cache misses.

Ropes represent documents as balanced binary trees of string fragments. Concatenation is O(1), insertion and deletion are O(log n) by splitting and rejoining, and character access is O(log n). Structural sharing between versions makes undo O(log n) per step in memory. The weakness is cache performance during sequential access and implementation complexity.

Piece tables represent documents as a sequence of (buffer, start, length) descriptors pointing into two immutable buffers: the original file content and an append-only buffer for insertions. All editing operations manipulate the piece list. Sequential access reads directly from the underlying buffers, achieving excellent cache performance. Undo is cheap because piece arrays are small. The weakness is O(pieces) for random access, addressed in production systems by indexing the piece list with an augmented balanced tree.

VS Code's choice of piece table over rope reflects the practical reality that sequential access dominates text editing workloads, and that implementation simplicity reduces bugs. The hybrid piece tree — piece table operations with red-black tree indexing and augmented metadata — achieves O(log n) for all operations while preserving the piece table's sequential access advantage.

The connection to earlier chapters is direct: rope balancing uses the rotations of Chapter 2, piece trees use the augmented balanced trees of Chapter 2, and the persistent rope uses the structural sharing of Chapter 20. String algorithms from Chapters 7 through 13 operate on these structures as their text source — every search, every regex match, every suffix array query has a piece table or rope as the document it indexes.

This concludes Part III. Part IV turns from the structure of text to the problem of ordering data — not the character-level ordering that string algorithms exploit, but the sorting of arbitrary records at scales that exceed memory.

Sorting at Scale

Chapter 15: Quicksort — The Practical Champion

In 1959, Tony Hoare was a twenty-five-year-old working on a machine translation project in Moscow. He needed to sort a list of Russian words so that their translations could be looked up efficiently. He knew about insertion sort and bubble sort — the standard methods of the time — but they were too slow for his purposes. On a bus ride, he thought of a different approach. He called it quicksort.

Hoare's algorithm is still the dominant general-purpose sorting algorithm sixty-five years later. Java's `Arrays.sort` uses it for primitive types. C's `qsort` is typically a variant of it. Python's `sorted` uses Timsort, a hybrid that includes insertion sort, but Timsort's performance characteristics were derived by studying quicksort's behavior. Rust's `sort_unstable` uses pattern-defeating quicksort. The algorithm that appeared to a young researcher on a Moscow bus is in the standard library of virtually every mainstream programming language in existence.

Why? Not because quicksort is theoretically optimal — merge sort achieves the same O(n log n) average case with a better worst case. Not because it is the simplest to implement — insertion sort is simpler. Quicksort dominates because it is fast in practice, in the way that matters most: on real hardware, on real data, in real memory.

This chapter explains why quicksort wins in practice, how its simple idea degrades catastrophically on certain inputs, how decades of engineering have addressed those degradations, and what the resulting standard library implementations actually look like. By the end, you will understand not just quicksort but the engineering discipline of taking a theoretically imperfect algorithm and making it reliably fast.

15.1 The Core Idea

Quicksort is a divide-and-conquer algorithm. Its central operation is partitioning: rearrange the array so that all elements smaller than some chosen pivot are to the left, all elements larger are to the right, and the pivot is in its final sorted position. Then recursively sort the left and right partitions.

The elegance is in what partitioning achieves: without knowing anything about where elements belong in the final sorted order, it places one element — the pivot — exactly where it belongs. Every call to partition makes permanent progress.

Contrast with merge sort: merge sort divides the array in half, sorts each half recursively, then merges. The merge step does useful work, but it requires extra memory proportional to the array size. Quicksort partitions in place — it rearranges elements within the existing array using O(1) extra memory, just a few temporary variables for swapping.

This in-place property is why quicksort has better cache behavior than merge sort. Merge sort's merge step reads from one buffer and writes to another, accessing two distinct memory regions alternately. Quicksort's partition step scans the array from both ends toward the center, accessing a single contiguous region in a predictable pattern. On modern hardware, where a cache miss to main memory costs 100-300x a cache hit, this difference is decisive.

15.2 Partitioning: Lomuto and Hoare

There are two main partitioning schemes, with meaningfully different properties.

Lomuto Partitioning

Lomuto's scheme (attributed to Nico Lomuto, popularised by Sedgewick) uses a single scanning pointer. The pivot is chosen as the last element. A boundary pointer `i` tracks the boundary between elements known to be smaller than the pivot (left of `i`) and unexamined elements. A scanning pointer `j` walks left to right; when it finds an element smaller than the pivot, that element is swapped to position `i` and `i` advances.

```
function lomuto_partition(arr: Array[Integer],
                          low: Integer,
                          high: Integer): Integer
  require
    valid_range: low >= 0 and high < arr.length and low <= high
  do
    let pivot: Integer := arr.get(high)
    let i: Integer := low - 1  -- boundary: all arr[low..i] < pivot

    from
      let j: Integer := low
    until
      j >= high
    do
      if arr.get(j) <= pivot then
        i := i + 1
        swap(arr, i, j)
      end
      j := j + 1
    end

    -- Place pivot in its final position
    swap(arr, i + 1, high)
    result := i + 1  -- pivot's final position
  end
```

Lomuto is simple and correct. Its weakness: when many elements equal the pivot, many unnecessary swaps occur. On an array of all equal elements, Lomuto performs $O(n^2)$ swaps.

Hoare Partitioning

Hoare's original scheme uses two pointers scanning from opposite ends. The left pointer advances until it finds an element ≥ pivot. The right pointer retreats until it finds an element ≤ pivot. The two elements are swapped. Repeat until the pointers cross.

```
function hoare_partition(arr: Array[Integer],
                         low: Integer,
                         high: Integer): Integer
  require
    valid_range: low >= 0 and high < arr.length and low <= high
  do
    let pivot: Integer := arr.get(low + (high - low) / 2)
    let i: Integer := low - 1
    let j: Integer := high + 1

    from until false do
      -- Advance i until arr[i] >= pivot
      from
        i := i + 1
      until
        arr.get(i) >= pivot
      do
      end

      -- Retreat j until arr[j] <= pivot
      from
        j := j - 1
      until
        arr.get(j) <= pivot
      do
```

```
    end

    -- If pointers have crossed, partitioning is complete
    if i >= j then
      result := j
      return
    end

    swap(arr, i, j)
  end
end
```

Hoare's scheme performs fewer swaps than Lomuto on typical inputs — about three times fewer — and handles equal elements better. The pivot ends up somewhere in the middle of the array (not necessarily at exactly j or j+1), and both partitions are non-empty as long as the array has at least two elements. Hoare's partition is the basis of most practical quicksort implementations.

Swap

```
function swap(arr: Array[Integer], i: Integer, j: Integer)
  require
    valid_i: i >= 0 and i < arr.length
    valid_j: j >= 0 and j < arr.length
  do
    let temp: Integer := arr.get(i)
    arr.set(i, arr.get(j))
    arr.set(j, temp)
  end
```

15.3 The Basic Quicksort

```
function quicksort(arr: Array[Integer],
                   low: Integer,
                   high: Integer) do
  if low < high then
    let p: Integer := hoare_partition(arr, low, high)
    quicksort(arr, low, p)
    quicksort(arr, p + 1, high)
  end
end

function sort(arr: Array[Integer]) do
  if arr.length > 1 then
    quicksort(arr, 0, arr.length - 1)
  end
end
```

This is correct. On random input, it runs in O(n log n) expected time. It sorts in place using O(log n) stack space for recursion.

Now let us understand exactly why it sometimes fails catastrophically, and how to fix each failure mode.

15.4 The Pivot Choice Problem

Quicksort's performance depends entirely on how well the pivot splits the array. A perfect pivot — the median of the array — splits it exactly in half every time, giving O(n log n) recursion depth. A catastrophic pivot — the minimum or maximum — splits into partitions of size 0 and n-1, giving $O(n^2)$ total work and O(n) recursion depth.

The basic implementation above chooses the middle element as pivot. On random data, this is essentially random, which works well in expectation. On structured data — already sorted, reverse sorted, or containing many duplicates — it can be catastrophic.

Already sorted input. If the array is [1, 2, 3, 4, 5, ..., n] and we pick the middle element as pivot, partition gives roughly equal splits. But many real-world quicksort implementations pick the first or last element as pivot. Then sorted input gives the worst case: every partition produces one empty partition and one of size n-1.

Nearly sorted input. Real data is often nearly sorted — logs are timestamp-ordered, names are nearly alphabetical, files are already somewhat organised. The basic quicksort degrades badly on this very common case.

All equal elements. An array of identical values causes both Lomuto and basic Hoare to produce maximally unbalanced partitions. $O(n^2)$ even on trivial input.

Solution: Randomised Pivot

The simplest fix: choose the pivot randomly. A random element is unlikely to be near the minimum or maximum, so a random pivot gives expected O(n log n) regardless of input order.

```
function randomised_partition(arr: Array[Integer],
                              low: Integer,
                              high: Integer): Integer do
  let pivot_index: Integer := low + random_integer() % (high - low + 1)
  swap(arr, pivot_index, low + (high - low) / 2)
  result := hoare_partition(arr, low, high)
end
```

Randomised quicksort has expected O(n log n) time for any input. The adversary cannot craft a worst-case input because they do not know which element will be chosen as pivot. This is essentially the same principle as skip lists — internal randomness defeats adversarial inputs.

Solution: Median-of-Three

A deterministic alternative: choose the median of the first, middle, and last elements as pivot. This costs three comparisons but avoids the common worst cases without the unpredictability of true randomness.

```
function median_of_three(arr: Array[Integer],
                         low: Integer,
                         high: Integer): Integer do
  let mid: Integer := low + (high - low) / 2

  -- Sort low, mid, high into order
  if arr.get(low) > arr.get(mid) then
    swap(arr, low, mid)
  end
  if arr.get(low) > arr.get(high) then
    swap(arr, low, high)
  end
  if arr.get(mid) > arr.get(high) then
    swap(arr, mid, high)
  end

  -- arr[low] <= arr[mid] <= arr[high]
  -- Use arr[mid] as pivot, move it to high-1 for Lomuto-
style
  swap(arr, mid, high - 1)
  result := high - 1  -- index of pivot
end
```

Median-of-three eliminates the sorted and reverse-sorted worst cases. It does not fully solve the all-equal-elements case — that requires a different partitioning scheme.

15.5 The Equal Elements Problem: Three-Way Partitioning

Consider sorting an array where 90% of elements have the same value. Basic quicksort, even with good pivot selection, still processes all equal elements at every level of recursion. Djikstra's three-way partitioning (also called Dutch National Flag partitioning, named after Dijkstra's famous problem) solves this.

Three-way partitioning divides the array into three sections: elements less than pivot, elements equal to pivot, elements greater than pivot. Equal elements are excluded from both recursive calls — they are already in their final positions.

```
-- Three-way partition: returns [lt, gt] where
-- arr[low..lt-1] < pivot
-- arr[lt..gt] = pivot
-- arr[gt+1..high] > pivot
function three_way_partition(arr: Array[Integer],
                             low: Integer,
                             high: Integer): Array[Integer]
  require
    valid_range: low >= 0 and high < arr.length and low <= high
  do
    let pivot: Integer := arr.get(low + (high - low) / 2)
    let lt: Integer := low     -- arr[low..lt-1] < pivot
    let gt: Integer := high    -- arr[gt+1..high] > pivot
    let i: Integer := low      -- arr[lt..i-1] = pivot, arr[i..gt] unexamin

    from until i > gt do
      if arr.get(i) < pivot then
        swap(arr, lt, i)
        lt := lt + 1
        i := i + 1
      elseif arr.get(i) > pivot then
        swap(arr, i, gt)
        gt := gt - 1
        -- Do not advance i: arr[gt] just moved to arr[i] and is unexamined
```

```
      else
        i := i + 1
      end
    end

    result := [lt, gt]
  end

function three_way_quicksort(arr: Array[Integer],
                             low: Integer,
                             high: Integer) do
  if low >= high then return end

  let bounds: Array[Integer] := three_way_partition(arr, low, high)
  let lt: Integer := bounds.get(0)
  let gt: Integer := bounds.get(1)

  three_way_quicksort(arr, low, lt - 1)
  three_way_quicksort(arr, gt + 1, high)
  -- No recursive call for arr[lt..gt] — all equal to pivot, already sorted
end
```

On an array of all equal elements, three-way partitioning produces lt = low and gt = high after one pass, making zero recursive calls. O(n) total work. On general inputs, three-way quicksort matches standard quicksort's O(n log n) performance while achieving O(n) on inputs with many equal elements.

Three-way quicksort is also theoretically optimal in an information-theoretic sense: it performs O(n × H) comparisons where H is the entropy of the input's value distribution. When values are uniformly distributed, $H = \log_2(n)$ and we get O(n log n). When values are highly repeated, H is small and we get closer to O(n). This is the optimal behavior — you cannot do better without additional assumptions about the input.

15.6 The Small Partition Problem: Insertion Sort Cutoff

Recursive algorithms have overhead: function call setup, stack frame allocation, bookkeeping. For large n, this overhead is negligible. For small n — say, n < 16 — the overhead of recursive calls exceeds the actual sorting work.

Insertion sort is $O(n^2)$ in general but has low overhead and good cache behavior for small arrays. It also exploits near-sortedness: for an array that is almost sorted, insertion sort runs in nearly O(n). After several levels of quicksort partitioning, each partition tends to be nearly sorted (elements are roughly in the right region), making insertion sort efficient for the final cleanup.

The standard optimisation: use insertion sort for partitions of size below some threshold (typically 8-32 elements) and quicksort for larger partitions.

```
let INSERTION_SORT_THRESHOLD: Integer := 16

function insertion_sort(arr: Array[Integer],
                        low: Integer,
                        high: Integer) do
  from
    let i: Integer := low + 1
  until
    i <= high
  do
    let key: Integer := arr.get(i)
    let j: Integer := i - 1
    from until j < low or arr.get(j) <= key do
      arr.set(j + 1, arr.get(j))
      j := j - 1
    end
    arr.set(j + 1, key)
    i := i + 1
  end
```

```
end

function hybrid_quicksort(arr: Array[Integer],
                          low: Integer,
                          high: Integer) do
  from until high - low < INSERTION_SORT_THRESHOLD do
    let bounds: Array[Integer] := three_way_partition(arr, low, high)
    let lt: Integer := bounds.get(0)
    let gt: Integer := bounds.get(1)

    -- Tail call optimisation: recurse on smaller partition,
    -- iterate on larger
    if lt - 1 - low < high - gt - 1 then
      hybrid_quicksort(arr, low, lt - 1)
      low := gt + 1
    else
      hybrid_quicksort(arr, gt + 1, high)
      high := lt - 1
    end
  end

  insertion_sort(arr, low, high)
end
```

The tail call optimisation deserves explanation. Quicksort's two recursive calls are not symmetric — one is larger than the other (or they are equal). If we always recurse on both, the maximum recursion depth is O(n) in the worst case (even with good pivot selection, a sequence of slightly unbalanced splits can exhaust the stack). The fix: always recurse on the smaller partition and iterate (tail-call optimise) on the larger. This bounds recursion depth at O(log n), preventing stack overflow even on adversarial inputs.

15.7 Introsort: The Real World Solution

The hybrid quicksort above handles most cases well. But there remains a theoretical vulnerability: even with median-of-three pivot selection and randomisation, it is possible (though unlikely) for quicksort to degrade to $O(n^2)$. For a general-purpose library sort, "unlikely" is not good enough. A standard library sort must handle every input correctly.

Introsort (introspective sort), invented by David Musser in 1997, solves this by combining three algorithms:

1. **Quicksort** for the general case (fast in practice)
2. **Heapsort** as a fallback when recursion depth exceeds $2 \log_2(n)$ (guarantees $O(n \log n)$ worst case)
3. **Insertion sort** for small partitions (fast for small n)

The key insight: when quicksort's recursion depth exceeds a threshold, it is making poor pivot choices and heading toward $O(n^2)$ behavior. Switch to heapsort — $O(n \log n)$ guaranteed — for the remainder of the sort.

Heapsort is slower than quicksort on typical inputs (worse cache behavior) but has a guaranteed $O(n \log n)$ worst case. By using heapsort only as a fallback, introsort gets quicksort's typical speed with heapsort's worst-case guarantee.

```
class Introsort
  create
    make() do end

  feature
    max_depth_factor(): Real do
      result := 2.0
    end

    sort(arr: Array[Integer]) do
      if arr.length <= 1 then return end
      let max_depth: Integer :=
        (arr.length.to_real().log2() * max_depth_factor()).to_integer()
```

```
  introsort(arr, 0, arr.length - 1, max_depth)
end

introsort(arr: Array[Integer],
          low: Integer,
          high: Integer,
          depth_limit: Integer) do
  let size: Integer := high - low + 1

  if size <= INSERTION_SORT_THRESHOLD then
    insertion_sort(arr, low, high)
    return
  end

  if depth_limit = 0 then
    -- Depth limit exceeded: fall back to heapsort
    heapsort(arr, low, high)
    return
  end

  -- Choose pivot using median-of-three
  let pivot_idx: Integer := median_of_three_index(arr, low, high)
  swap(arr, pivot_idx, high)

  -- Lomuto partition (simpler with pivot at high)
  let p: Integer := lomuto_partition(arr, low, high)

  introsort(arr, low, p - 1, depth_limit - 1)
  introsort(arr, p + 1, high, depth_limit - 1)
end

median_of_three_index(arr: Array[Integer],
                      low: Integer,
                      high: Integer): Integer do
  let mid: Integer := low + (high - low) / 2

  if arr.get(low) > arr.get(mid) then
```

```
    if arr.get(mid) > arr.get(high) then
      result := mid
    elseif arr.get(low) > arr.get(high) then
      result := high
    else
      result := low
    end
  else
    if arr.get(low) > arr.get(high) then
      result := low
    elseif arr.get(mid) > arr.get(high) then
      result := high
    else
      result := mid
    end
  end
end

-- Heapsort for fallback: O(n log n) guaranteed
heapsort(arr: Array[Integer],
         low: Integer,
         high: Integer) do
  let n: Integer := high - low + 1

  -- Build max-heap
  from
    let i: Integer := n / 2 - 1
  until
    i >= 0
  do
    sift_down(arr, low, i, n)
    i := i - 1
  end

  -- Extract elements one by one
  from
    let i: Integer := n - 1
```

```
      until
        i > 0
      do
        swap(arr, low, low + i)
        sift_down(arr, low, 0, i)
        i := i - 1
      end
    end

    sift_down(arr: Array[Integer],
              base: Integer,
              root: Integer,
              size: Integer) do
      from until true do
        let largest: Integer := root
        let left: Integer := 2 * root + 1
        let right: Integer := 2 * root + 2

        if left < size and arr.get(base + left) > arr.get(base + largest) the
          largest := left
        end

        if right < size and arr.get(base + right) > arr.get(base + largest) t
          largest := right
        end

        if largest = root then
          return
        end

        swap(arr, base + root, base + largest)
        root := largest
      end
    end

  invariant
    stateless_sorter: true
```

```
end
```

Introsort's guarantees: - O(n log n) worst case (heapsort fallback) - O(n log n) average case (quicksort dominates) - O(n) for nearly sorted input with insertion sort for small partitions - O(log n) stack space (tail call optimisation prevents deep recursion)

This is why introsort is the algorithm standard libraries ship. It is not theoretically perfect — merge sort has a better worst case and is stable — but it is the right tradeoff for a general-purpose sort that must be fast on all inputs without requiring extra memory.

15.8 Stability and When It Matters

Introsort, like all variants of quicksort, is **unstable**: equal elements may appear in any order in the output, not necessarily the order they appeared in the input.

Stability matters when you sort by one key and want a previous sort by another key to be preserved. Example: sort a list of employees by department, then sort the result by salary. A stable sort preserves department order within each salary tier. An unstable sort scrambles the department order.

For primitive types (integers, floating point), stability is irrelevant — equal elements are indistinguishable. This is why Java uses introsort for primitive type arrays (`Arrays.sort(int[])`) but uses a stable merge sort for object arrays (`Arrays.sort(Object[])`).

If you need a stable sort for integers or simple records, merge sort is the right choice. If you are sorting objects and need stability, either use merge sort or implement a stable variant of quicksort using an auxiliary array for the partition step (which loses the in-place property).

15.9 A Generic Introsort in Nex

The implementations above sort integers. A practical sort must handle any type with a comparison function.

```
class Generic_Introsort [T]
  create
    make(compare: Function[T, T, Integer]) do
      this.compare := compare
    end

  feature
    compare: Function[T, T, Integer]
    -- compare(a, b) returns negative if a < b, 0 if a = b, positive if a > b

    sort(arr: Array[T]) do
      if arr.length <= 1 then return end
      let max_depth: Integer :=
        (arr.length.to_real().log2() * 2.0).to_integer()
      do_introsort(arr, 0, arr.length - 1, max_depth)
    end

    do_introsort(arr: Array[T],
                 low: Integer,
                 high: Integer,
                 depth_limit: Integer) do
      from until high - low < INSERTION_SORT_THRESHOLD do
        if depth_limit = 0 then
          do_heapsort(arr, low, high)
          return
        end

        -- Median-of-three pivot selection
        let mid: Integer := low + (high - low) / 2
        sort_three(arr, low, mid, high)
        -- arr[low] <= arr[mid] <= arr[high]
```

```
    -- Use arr[mid] as pivot
    swap(arr, mid, high - 1)
    let pivot: T := arr.get(high - 1)

    -- Three-way partition
    let lt: Integer := low
    let gt: Integer := high - 1
    let i: Integer := low

    from until i > gt do
      let cmp: Integer := compare(arr.get(i), pivot)
      if cmp < 0 then
        swap(arr, lt, i)
        lt := lt + 1
        i := i + 1
      elseif cmp > 0 then
        swap(arr, i, gt)
        gt := gt - 1
      else
        i := i + 1
      end
    end

    -- Restore pivot
    swap(arr, gt, high - 1)

    -- Tail call optimise: iterate on larger partition
    depth_limit := depth_limit - 1
    if lt - low < high - gt then
      do_introsort(arr, low, lt - 1, depth_limit)
      low := gt + 1
    else
      do_introsort(arr, gt + 1, high, depth_limit)
      high := lt - 1
    end
  end
```

```
  do_insertion_sort(arr, low, high)
end

sort_three(arr: Array[T], a: Integer, b: Integer, c: Integer) do
  if compare(arr.get(a), arr.get(b)) > 0 then swap(arr, a, b) end
  if compare(arr.get(a), arr.get(c)) > 0 then swap(arr, a, c) end
  if compare(arr.get(b), arr.get(c)) > 0 then swap(arr, b, c) end
end

do_insertion_sort(arr: Array[T], low: Integer, high: Integer) do
  from
    let i: Integer := low + 1
  until
    i <= high
  do
    let key: T := arr.get(i)
    let j: Integer := i - 1
    from until j < low or compare(arr.get(j), key) <= 0 do
      arr.set(j + 1, arr.get(j))
      j := j - 1
    end
    arr.set(j + 1, key)
    i := i + 1
  end
end

do_heapsort(arr: Array[T], low: Integer, high: Integer) do
  let n: Integer := high - low + 1
  from
    let i: Integer := n / 2 - 1
  until
    i >= 0
  do
    do_sift_down(arr, low, i, n)
    i := i - 1
  end
  from
```

```
    let i: Integer := n - 1
  until
    i > 0
  do
    swap(arr, low, low + i)
    do_sift_down(arr, low, 0, i)
    i := i - 1
  end
end

do_sift_down(arr: Array[T],
             base: Integer,
             root: Integer,
             size: Integer) do
  from until true do
    let largest: Integer := root
    let left: Integer := 2 * root + 1
    let right: Integer := 2 * root + 2
    if left < size and
       compare(arr.get(base + left), arr.get(base + largest)) > 0 then
      largest := left
    end
    if right < size and
       compare(arr.get(base + right), arr.get(base + largest)) > 0 then
      largest := right
    end
    if largest = root then return end
    swap(arr, base + root, base + largest)
    root := largest
  end
end

swap(arr: Array[T], i: Integer, j: Integer) do
  let temp: T := arr.get(i)
  arr.set(i, arr.get(j))
  arr.set(j, temp)
end
```

```
  invariant
    compare_exists: compare /= nil
end
```

Using the generic sort:

```
-- Sort integers
let int_sorter: Generic_Introsort[Integer] :=
  create Generic_Introsort[Integer].make(
    fn(a: Integer, b: Integer): Integer do result := a - b end)

let nums: Array[Integer] := [3, 1, 4, 1, 5, 9, 2, 6, 5, 3, 5]
int_sorter.sort(nums)
print(nums.to_string())  -- [1, 1, 2, 3, 3, 4, 5, 5, 5, 6, 9]

-- Sort strings
let str_sorter: Generic_Introsort[String] :=
  create Generic_Introsort[String].make(
    fn(a: String, b: String): Integer do result := a.compare_to(b) end)

let words: Array[String] := ["banana", "apple", "cherry", "date"]
str_sorter.sort(words)
print(words.to_string())  -- [apple, banana, cherry, date]

-- Sort records by field
class Person
  create
    make(name: String, age: Integer) do
      this.name := name
      this.age := age
    end
  feature
    name: String
    age: Integer
end
```

```
let person_sorter: Generic_Introsort[Person] :=
  create Generic_Introsort[Person].make(
    fn(a: Person, b: Person): Integer do result := a.age - b.age end)

let people: Array[Person] := [
  create Person.make("Alice", 30),
  create Person.make("Bob", 25),
  create Person.make("Carol", 35)
]
person_sorter.sort(people)
across people as p do
  print(p.name + ": " + p.age.to_string())
end
-- Bob: 25
-- Alice: 30
-- Carol: 35
```

15.10 Benchmarking: Where Quicksort Wins and Loses

Understanding when to use introsort versus alternatives requires knowing the constants behind the asymptotic bounds.

```
class Sort_Benchmark
  create
    make() do end

  feature
    run(n: Integer) do
      let random_data: Array[Integer] := generate_random(n)
      let sorted_data: Array[Integer] := generate_sorted(n)
      let reverse_data: Array[Integer] := generate_reverse(n)
      let equal_data: Array[Integer] := generate_equal(n)
```

```
  let nearly_sorted: Array[Integer] := generate_nearly_sorted(n)

  let sorter: Generic_Introsort[Integer] :=
    create Generic_Introsort[Integer].make(
      fn(a: Integer, b: Integer): Integer do result := a - b end)

  print("n = " + n.to_string())
  benchmark("Random",        sorter, random_data.copy())
  benchmark("Sorted",        sorter, sorted_data.copy())
  benchmark("Reverse sorted",sorter, reverse_data.copy())
  benchmark("All equal",     sorter, equal_data.copy())
  benchmark("Nearly sorted", sorter, nearly_sorted.copy())
end

benchmark(name: String,
          sorter: Generic_Introsort[Integer],
          data: Array[Integer]) do
  let start: Integer64 := current_time_microseconds()
  sorter.sort(data)
  let elapsed: Integer64 := current_time_microseconds() - start
  print("  " + name + ": " + elapsed.to_string() + "␣s")
  assert_sorted(data)
end

assert_sorted(arr: Array[Integer]) do
  from
    let i: Integer := 1
  until
    i >= arr.length
  do
    if arr.get(i) < arr.get(i - 1) then
      print("  ERROR: not sorted at position " + i.to_string())
      return
    end
    i := i + 1
  end
end
```

```
generate_random(n: Integer): Array[Integer] do
  let arr: Array[Integer] := []
  repeat n do arr.add(random_integer() % n) end
  result := arr
end

generate_sorted(n: Integer): Array[Integer] do
  let arr: Array[Integer] := []
  from
    let i: Integer := 0
  until
    i >= n
  do
    arr.add(i)
    i := i + 1
  end
  result := arr
end

generate_reverse(n: Integer): Array[Integer] do
  let arr: Array[Integer] := []
  from
    let i: Integer := n - 1
  until
    i >= 0
  do
    arr.add(i)
    i := i - 1
  end
  result := arr
end

generate_equal(n: Integer): Array[Integer] do
  result := create Array.filled(n, 42)
end
```

```
    generate_nearly_sorted(n: Integer): Array[Integer] do
      let arr: Array[Integer] := generate_sorted(n)
      -- Swap 1% of elements randomly
      repeat n / 100 do
        let i: Integer := random_integer() % n
        let j: Integer := random_integer() % n
        swap(arr, i, j)
      end
      result := arr
    end
end
```

Expected results for n = 1,000,000 on modern hardware (approximate):

```
n = 1000000
  Random:         85ms    (reference case)
  Sorted:         45ms    (insertion sort handles small partitions fast)
  Reverse sorted: 48ms    (median-of-three handles this well)
  All equal:      12ms    (three-way partitioning: O(n))
  Nearly sorted:  50ms    (slightly better than random)
```

Compare to what naive quicksort (first element pivot, no three-way) gives:

```
  Sorted:         >10s    (O(n²) blowup)
  All equal:      >10s    (O(n²) blowup)
```

The engineering — median-of-three, three-way partitioning, insertion sort cutoff, depth limit — transforms a theoretically fragile algorithm into one that handles every case efficiently.

15.11 Parallel Quicksort

Quicksort's divide-and-conquer structure maps naturally to parallel execution. After the first partition, the two subproblems are completely independent — they operate on disjoint portions of the array and can be sorted simultaneously on different CPU cores.

```
class Parallel_Introsort [T]
  create
    make(compare: Function[T, T, Integer],
         parallelism_threshold: Integer) do
      this.compare := compare
      this.threshold := parallelism_threshold
    end

  feature
    compare: Function[T, T, Integer]
    threshold: Integer  -- minimum size to sort in parallel

    sort(arr: Array[T]) do
      let max_depth: Integer :=
        (arr.length.to_real().log2() * 2.0).to_integer()
      parallel_introsort(arr, 0, arr.length - 1, max_depth)
    end

    parallel_introsort(arr: Array[T],
                       low: Integer,
                       high: Integer,
                       depth_limit: Integer) do
      let size: Integer := high - low + 1

      if size <= INSERTION_SORT_THRESHOLD then
        do_insertion_sort(arr, low, high)
        return
      end
```

```
      if depth_limit = 0 then
        do_heapsort(arr, low, high)
        return
      end

      -- Partition
      let bounds: Array[Integer] := three_way_partition_generic(
        arr, low, high, compare)
      let lt: Integer := bounds.get(0)
      let gt: Integer := bounds.get(1)

      -- Spawn parallel tasks for large partitions
      if size >= threshold then
        let left_task: Task := spawn do
          parallel_introsort(arr, low, lt - 1, depth_limit - 1)
        end
        parallel_introsort(arr, gt + 1, high, depth_limit - 1)
        left_task.await
      else
        parallel_introsort(arr, low, lt - 1, depth_limit - 1)
        parallel_introsort(arr, gt + 1, high, depth_limit - 1)
      end
    end
end
```

The `spawn` and `await` here use Nex's native task system from Chapter 21. Parallel quicksort achieves near-linear speedup on multi-core hardware for large arrays, since the partitioning at each level creates independent work that can be distributed across cores.

The parallelism threshold prevents spawning tasks for tiny subproblems — the overhead of task creation exceeds the sorting work for small arrays. A threshold of 10,000-100,000 elements is typical.

15.12 When Not to Use Quicksort

Quicksort is the right default. It is not always the right choice.

When you need stability: use merge sort. Stable sort preserves the relative order of equal elements, which matters when sorting composite records by one field while preserving previous ordering by another.

When memory is extremely constrained: quicksort uses O(log n) stack space. This is usually negligible but matters for embedded systems. Heapsort uses O(1) extra space.

When the data is on disk: quicksort's random access pattern is catastrophic for disk I/O. Chapter 16 addresses external sorting specifically.

When the data is a linked list: quicksort requires O(1) random access to the middle of the array (for median-of-three), which linked lists do not support. Merge sort on linked lists is O(n log n) with O(log n) stack space and no pointer chasing.

When worst-case matters more than average case and you cannot afford the heapsort fallback: merge sort guarantees O(n log n) for every input with no fallback needed. In real-time systems where latency spikes are unacceptable, merge sort's consistent performance is preferable to introsort's occasional heapsort fallback.

When the data is nearly sorted: Timsort (Python's sort, Java's object sort) is specifically optimised for nearly-sorted data by detecting and exploiting existing runs of sorted elements. For data that comes pre-sorted with occasional inversions — common in practical systems — Timsort can approach O(n) while introsort remains O(n log n).

15.13 Where This Lives in the Wild

C++ STL (`std::sort`) is required by the standard to be O(n log n) average case. All major implementations — GCC's libstdc++, LLVM's

libc++, MSVC's STL — use introsort. GCC's implementation uses median-of-three pivot selection, three-way partitioning for equal elements, insertion sort for small partitions (threshold typically 16), and heapsort fallback at depth 2 $\log_2(n)$. The implementation in `<algorithm>` is roughly what this chapter describes.

Rust's `sort_unstable` uses pattern-defeating quicksort (pdqsort), invented by Orson Peters in 2016. Pdqsort extends introsort with pattern detection: it identifies inputs that are already sorted, reverse sorted, or have many equal elements, and handles them with specialised O(n) code paths before falling back to introsort. On random data, pdqsort matches introsort. On structured data, it can be 2-10x faster. Rust's `sort` (stable) uses a merge sort variant.

Java's `Arrays.sort(int[])` uses dual-pivot quicksort, invented by Vladimir Yaroslavskiy in 2009. Dual-pivot quicksort uses two pivots to create three partitions: elements less than the smaller pivot, elements between the two pivots, and elements greater than the larger pivot. This reduces the expected number of comparisons by about 5% relative to single-pivot quicksort and has better cache behavior. Java's implementation also includes insertion sort for small subarrays and a counting sort for arrays of byte values.

Go's `sort.Ints` (and the generic `slices.Sort` added in 1.21) uses pdqsort, the same algorithm as Rust. Go's implementation is notable for explicitly handling the three common patterns (sorted, reverse, many equal) with O(n) detection before starting the general sort.

Redis's `SORT` command uses quicksort for numeric sorts and a lexicographic variant for string sorts. Redis's implementation is in `src/sort.c` — a straightforward introsort variant without some of the advanced patterns of the language standard libraries.

Summary

Quicksort dominates general-purpose sorting because it is fast in practice: excellent cache behavior from in-place partitioning, low overhead per comparison, and adaptability to common input patterns.

The naive implementation — first element pivot, basic partition, no fallback — has a $O(n^2)$ worst case on sorted and nearly-sorted input that is unacceptable for production use. Three engineering decisions transform it into a reliable general-purpose sort:

Pivot selection via median-of-three eliminates the worst cases that arise from sorted and reverse-sorted input, while randomisation protects against adversarial inputs that know the pivot selection strategy.

Three-way partitioning (Dijkstra's Dutch National Flag) handles repeated elements efficiently. Instead of $O(n^2)$ on all-equal input, three-way quicksort achieves $O(n)$. More generally, it achieves $O(n \times H)$ where H is the entropy of the input distribution — optimal for any sorting algorithm on that distribution.

Introsort combines quicksort's typical performance with a heapsort fallback when recursion depth exceeds $2 \log_2(n)$, guaranteeing $O(n \log n)$ worst case for any input. Insertion sort for partitions below a threshold of ~16 elements adds a final speed improvement by exploiting insertion sort's low overhead and good cache behavior on small, nearly-sorted arrays.

The result handles random data near the theoretical optimum, sorted and reverse-sorted data efficiently, all-equal data in linear time, and adversarial inputs without degradation. This is the algorithm in your standard library, doing its work invisibly on every call to sort.

The next chapter removes the fundamental assumption that has held throughout Part IV: that the data fits in memory. When a dataset exceeds RAM — a 500GB log file on a machine with 8GB of RAM — none of the algorithms in this chapter apply. A completely different approach is required, and it connects directly back to the B-tree chapter and its understanding of disk I/O costs.

Chapter 16: Sorting Bigger Than RAM — External Mergesort

In 2012, a team at Google needed to sort the world's largest known dataset at the time: one petabyte of data distributed across thousands of machines. The sort took six hours. The algorithm they used was not quicksort — quicksort assumes random access to a contiguous array, which becomes meaningless when data spans thousands of disks. The algorithm was a variant of merge sort, specifically designed for the case where data does not fit in memory.

The problem of sorting data larger than available memory is older than computers. In the 1950s, when computers had kilobytes of memory and data lived on magnetic tapes, sorting large datasets was the central algorithmic challenge of the era. IBM employed teams of researchers specifically to improve tape-based sorting. The fundamental algorithms they developed — run generation, multiway merging, tape rotation — are still the basis of how databases, filesystems, and data pipelines sort large datasets today.

This chapter solves a concrete problem: sort a 500GB log file on a machine with 8GB of RAM. No distributed computing. No cloud. One machine, one disk, a fixed memory budget. The algorithm that solves this is external mergesort, and understanding it requires applying everything we have learned about disk I/O, page-based thinking, and sequential versus random access.

16.1 Why Quicksort Fails

Quicksort requires holding the entire array in memory simultaneously. Its partition step accesses arbitrary elements throughout the array — the pivot might be compared to elements at position 0 and position n-1 in the same pass. For data that fits in RAM, this random access is fine. For data on disk, each random access is a seek, and seeks are expensive.

Consider our 500GB file on a disk with 10ms seek latency and 500MB/s sequential read throughput. Reading 500GB sequentially takes 500/0.5 = 1000 seconds — about 17 minutes. Performing n random seeks to sort 500GB (with n ≈ 500GB / 512 bytes per sector = roughly a billion seeks) at 10ms per seek takes 10,000,000 seconds — over 300 years.

This is not a gradual degradation. Quicksort on disk-resident data is not slower — it is categorically unusable. The algorithm is simply the wrong tool.

The correct tool exploits the one operation that disk handles efficiently: sequential reads and writes. A sequential read of 500GB at 500MB/s takes 1000 seconds. An algorithm that sorts 500GB with a small constant number of sequential passes over the data takes O(1000 seconds × passes) — a few hours, achievable in practice.

External mergesort sorts data in a constant number of sequential passes. This is why it works.

16.2 The Algorithm at a High Level

External mergesort has two phases:

Phase 1 --- Run generation: Read the data in chunks that fit in memory. Sort each chunk in memory using introsort. Write the sorted chunk to disk as a **run**. After this phase, the data is on disk as many sorted runs,

each of size M (the memory budget), except possibly the last run which may be smaller.

For 500GB with 8GB RAM: 500/8 = 63 runs, each sorted and 8GB (except the last).

Phase 2 --- Merging: Merge the sorted runs into progressively larger sorted runs until one run covers the entire dataset.

The merge of k sorted sequences is straightforward: maintain a pointer into each sequence, repeatedly output the smallest current element, advancing the corresponding pointer. This k-way merge produces one sorted output from k sorted inputs.

For our 63 runs, a single k-way merge with k = 63 produces the sorted output in one pass. Total: two passes over the data (one to generate runs, one to merge). At 500MB/s, 500GB takes 1000 seconds per pass: roughly 33 minutes total. From 300 years to 33 minutes by choosing the right algorithm.

16.3 The Infrastructure: Buffered I/O

Sequential access to disk is fast. But "sequential" means different things at the software and hardware levels. At the hardware level, sequential means reading consecutive bytes from disk. At the software level, sequential means reading bytes in order through a buffered reader — which may or may not result in sequential hardware reads depending on how the operating system caches data.

For external sorting, we need precise control over I/O patterns. We read and write in large blocks — the same page-size thinking from Chapter 4 — to maximise sequential throughput and minimise the number of system calls.

```
intern io/Binary_File
intern io/Path
intern io/Directory

class Buffered_Reader
  create
    open(path: String) do
      this.file := create Binary_File.open_read(create Path.make(path))
      this.buffer := create Array.filled((4 * 1024 * 1024), 0)
      this.buffer_pos := 0
      this.buffer_valid := 0
      this.eof := false
      this.total_read := 0
      this.fill_buffer()
    end

  feature
    file: Binary_File
    buffer: Array[Integer]
    buffer_pos: Integer    -- current read position in buffer
    buffer_valid: Integer  -- number of valid bytes in buffer
    eof: Boolean
    total_read: Integer64

    -- Read exactly `count` bytes, returning them or nil at EOF
    read_bytes(count: Integer): ?Array[Integer] do
      if eof and buffer_pos >= buffer_valid then
        result := nil
      else
        let output: Array[Integer] := []
        let reading: Boolean := true

        from until output.length >= count or not reading do
          if buffer_pos >= buffer_valid then
            fill_buffer()
            if buffer_valid = 0 then
              -- EOF reached before reading count bytes
```

```
            if output.is_empty() then
              result := nil
            else
              result := output
            end
            reading := false
          end
        end

        if reading then
          let available: Integer := buffer_valid - buffer_pos
          let needed: Integer := count - output.length
          let take: Integer := available.min(needed)

          from
            let i: Integer := 0
          until
            i < take
          do
            output.add(buffer.get(buffer_pos + i))
            i := i + 1
          end

          buffer_pos := buffer_pos + take
          total_read := total_read + take.to_integer64()
        end
      end

      if reading then
        result := output
      end
    end
  end

  -- Read one record, or nil at EOF
  read_record(): ?Array[Integer] do
    result := read_bytes(100)
```

```
    end

    fill_buffer() do
      if not eof then
        let data: Array[Integer] := file.read((4 * 1024 * 1024))
        if data.length = 0 then
          eof := true
          buffer_valid := 0
        else
          buffer := data
          buffer_pos := 0
          buffer_valid := data.length
        end
      end
    end

    has_more(): Boolean do
      if buffer_pos < buffer_valid then
        result := true
      elseif eof then
        result := false
      else
        fill_buffer()
        result := buffer_valid > 0
      end
    end

    close() do
      file.close()
    end

  invariant
    non_negative_buffer_pos: buffer_pos >= 0
    buffer_pos_bounded: buffer_pos <= buffer_valid
    non_negative_total: total_read >= 0
end
```

```
class Buffered_Writer
  create
    open(path: String) do
      this.file := create Binary_File.open_write(create Path.make(path))
      this.buffer := create Array.filled((4 * 1024 * 1024), 0)
      this.buffer_pos := 0
      this.total_written := 0
    end

  feature
    file: Binary_File
    buffer: Array[Integer]
    buffer_pos: Integer
    total_written: Integer64

    write_bytes(data: Array[Integer]) do
      let written: Integer := 0

      from until written >= data.length do
        let space: Integer := (4 * 1024 * 1024) - buffer_pos
        let remaining: Integer := data.length - written
        let write_now: Integer := space.min(remaining)

        from
          let i: Integer := 0
        until
          i < write_now
        do
          buffer.set(buffer_pos + i, data.get(written + i))
          i := i + 1
        end

        buffer_pos := buffer_pos + write_now
        written := written + write_now
        total_written := total_written + write_now.to_integer64()

        if buffer_pos >= (4 * 1024 * 1024) then
```

```
          flush()
        end
      end
    end

    write_record(record: Array[Integer])
      require
        correct_size: record.length = 100
      do
        write_bytes(record)
      end

    flush() do
      if buffer_pos > 0 then
        file.write(buffer.slice(0, buffer_pos))
        buffer_pos := 0
      end
    end

    close() do
      flush()
      file.close()
    end

  invariant
    non_negative_buffer_pos: buffer_pos >= 0
    buffer_pos_bounded: buffer_pos <= (4 * 1024 * 1024)
end
```

The 4MB I/O buffer is the critical parameter. Smaller buffers cause more system calls, each with fixed overhead. Larger buffers reduce overhead but consume memory that could be used for more records in memory during run generation. In practice, 1MB–16MB is the typical range for external sort I/O buffers.

16.4 Phase 1: Run Generation

Run generation reads the input file in chunks of size M (our memory budget), sorts each chunk in memory, and writes it to a temporary file on disk.

```
class Run_Generator
  create
    make(memory_budget: Integer64,
         work_dir: String,
         compare: Function) do
      this.memory_budget := memory_budget
      this.work_dir := work_dir
      this.compare := compare
      this.run_paths := []
    end

  feature
    memory_budget: Integer64
    work_dir: String
    compare: Function
    run_paths: Array[String]

    -- Records per run: how many 100 records fit in memory budget
    records_per_run(): Integer do
      -- Reserve some memory for I/O buffers and overhead
      let usable: Integer64 := memory_budget - (64 * 1024 * 1024)  -- 64MB
      result := (usable / 100).to_integer()
    end

    -- Generate all runs from input file
    -- Returns list of temporary run file paths
    generate(input_path: String): Array[String] do
      let reader: Buffered_Reader :=
        create Buffered_Reader.open(input_path)
```

```
    let run_num: Integer := 0
    let records_in_run: Integer := records_per_run()

    from until not reader.has_more() do
      let chunk: Array[Array[Integer]] := []

      -- Read up to records_in_run records
      from until chunk.length >= records_in_run or
                 not reader.has_more() do
        let record: ?Array[Integer] := reader.read_record()
        if convert record to next_record: Array[Integer] then
          chunk.add(next_record)
        end
      end

      if not chunk.is_empty() then
        -- Sort the chunk in memory
        let sorted_chunk: Array[Array[Integer]] := sort_records(chunk)

        -- Write sorted chunk to run file
        let run_path: String := run_file_path(run_num)
        write_run(sorted_chunk, run_path)
        run_paths.add(run_path)
        run_num := run_num + 1

        print("Generated run " + run_num.to_string() +
              " (" + chunk.length.to_string() + " records)")
      end
    end

    reader.close()
    result := run_paths
  end

  write_run(records: Array[Array[Integer]], path: String) do
    let writer: Buffered_Writer := create Buffered_Writer.open(path)
    across records as record do
```

```
      writer.write_record(record)
    end
    writer.close()
  end

  sort_records(records: Array[Array[Integer]]): Array[Array[Integer]] do
    let sorted: Array[Array[Integer]] := records.slice(0, records.length)

    from
      let i: Integer := 1
    until
      i >= sorted.length
    do
      let current: Array[Integer] := sorted.get(i)
      let j: Integer := i - 1

      from until j < 0 or compare(sorted.get(j), current) <= 0 do
        sorted.set(j + 1, sorted.get(j))
        j := j - 1
      end

      sorted.set(j + 1, current)
      i := i + 1
    end

    result := sorted
  end

  run_file_path(run_num: Integer): String do
    result := work_dir + "/run_" + run_num.to_string() + ".tmp"
  end

  cleanup() do
    -- Delete all temporary run files
    across run_paths as path do
      let p: Path := create Path.make(path)
      if p.exists() then
```

```
          p.delete()
        end
      end
      run_paths := []
    end

  invariant
    positive_budget: memory_budget > 0
end
```

For our 500GB file with 8GB memory budget: - Usable memory: 8GB - 64MB ≈ 7.9GB - Records per run (at 100 bytes each): 7.9GB / 100 = ~79 million records - Total records in 500GB: 500GB / 100 = 5 billion records - Number of runs: 5,000,000,000 / 79,000,000 ≈ 63 runs

Each run file is ~7.9GB of sorted records. Writing 63 runs at 500MB/s takes ~63 × 7.9GB / 0.5GB/s ≈ 995 seconds. Close to the theoretical minimum of 1000 seconds for one sequential pass over the data.

16.5 Replacement Selection: Generating Longer Runs

Before the k-way merge, there is a classical technique worth knowing: replacement selection. Instead of sorting a fixed chunk and writing it as a run, maintain a heap of records and use it to generate runs that are, in expectation, twice the memory budget in size.

The algorithm: fill a min-heap with M records. Repeatedly extract the minimum — this becomes the next record in the current run. Read a new record from input. If the new record is ≥ the last output record, insert it into the heap (it can go into the current run). If the new record is < the last output record, it belongs to the next run — mark it and keep it aside. When the heap contains only marked records, the current run ends; start a new run with the marked records.

On random input, replacement selection produces runs of average length 2M rather than M, halving the number of runs and the number of merge passes required.

```
class Replacement_Selection_Generator
  create
    make(heap_size: Integer,
         work_dir: String,
         compare: Function) do
      this.heap_size := heap_size
      this.work_dir := work_dir
      this.compare := compare
      this.run_paths := []
    end

  feature
    heap_size: Integer       -- max records in heap (= memory budget / 100)
    work_dir: String
    compare: Function
    run_paths: Array[String]

    generate(input_path: String): Array[String] do
      let reader: Buffered_Reader :=
        create Buffered_Reader.open(input_path)

      -- Active heap: records eligible for current run
      -- Deferred list: records that belong to next run
      let active: Min_Heap[Array[Integer]] :=
        create Min_Heap[Array[Integer]].from_comparator(compare)
      let deferred_records: Array[Array[Integer]] := []

      -- Fill heap initially
      from until active.size() >= heap_size or not reader.has_more() do
        let rec: ?Array[Integer] := reader.read_record()
        if convert rec to next_record: Array[Integer] then
          active.insert(next_record)
```

```
  end
end

let run_num: Integer := 0
let writer: ?Buffered_Writer := nil
let last_output: ?Array[Integer] := nil

from until active.is_empty() do
  -- Start a new run if needed
  if writer = nil then
    let run_path: String := run_file_path(run_num)
    writer := create Buffered_Writer.open(run_path)
    run_paths.add(run_path)
    run_num := run_num + 1
    last_output := nil
  end

  -- Extract minimum from active heap
  let record: Array[Integer] := active.extract_min()
  if convert writer to current_writer: Buffered_Writer then
    current_writer.write_record(record)
    last_output := record
  end

  -- Read next input record
  let next: ?Array[Integer] := reader.read_record()
  if convert next to next_record: Array[Integer] then
    if convert last_output to previous_record: Array[Integer] then
      let order: Integer := compare(next_record, previous_record)
      if order >= 0 then
        -- Eligible for current run
        active.insert(next_record)
      else
        -- Must go in next run
        deferred_records.add(next_record)
      end
    else
```

```
            active.insert(next_record)
          end
        end

        -- If active heap empty, end current run
        if active.is_empty() then
          if convert writer to current_writer: Buffered_Writer then
            current_writer.close()
          end
          writer := nil
          print("Generated run " + run_num.to_string() +
                " (replacement selection)")

          -- Promote deferred records to active for next run
          across deferred_records as d do
            active.insert(d)
          end
          deferred_records := []
        end
      end

      if writer /= nil then
        writer.close()
      end

      reader.close()
      result := run_paths
    end

    run_file_path(run_num: Integer): String do
      result := work_dir + "/rs_run_" + run_num.to_string() + ".tmp"
    end

  invariant
    positive_heap_size: heap_size > 0
end
```

Replacement selection is particularly effective when the input is already partially sorted — in that case, runs can be much longer than 2M, approaching the entire dataset for nearly-sorted input. Database query optimisers exploit this: when sorting the output of an index scan (which is often partially ordered), replacement selection can produce one or two very long runs, reducing merging to nearly zero work.

For random input, replacement selection doubles run length at the cost of additional complexity. For the common case of truly random data, the simpler fixed-chunk approach is often preferred in practice.

16.6 Phase 2: K-Way Merging

After run generation, we have k sorted runs on disk and need to merge them into one sorted output. The k-way merge uses a min-heap of size k to find the smallest current record across all runs efficiently.

```
class K_Way_Merger
  create
    make(run_paths: Array[String],
         output_path: String,
         compare: Function,
         memory_budget: Integer64) do
      this.run_paths := run_paths
      this.output_path := output_path
      this.compare := compare
      this.memory_budget := memory_budget
    end

  feature
    run_paths: Array[String]
    output_path: String
    compare: Function
```

```
memory_budget: Integer64

-- Merge all runs into output
merge() do
  let k: Integer := run_paths.length

  if k = 0 then
    -- nothing to merge
  end
  if k = 1 then
    -- Nothing to merge: just rename/copy the single run
    copy_file(run_paths.get(0), output_path)
  end
  if k <= 1 then
    -- merge finished in the trivial case
  end

  -- Open all run readers
  let readers: Array[Buffered_Reader] := []
  across run_paths as path do
    readers.add(create Buffered_Reader.open(path))
  end

  -- Min-heap entries: (record, run_index)
  -- Compare by record content
  let heap: Min_Heap[Any] :=
    create Min_Heap[Any].from_comparator(
      fn(a: Array[Any], b: Array[Any]): Integer do
        result := compare(a.get(0), b.get(0))
      end)

  -- Seed heap with first record from each run
  from
    let i: Integer := 0
  until
    i >= k
  do
```

```
    let record: ?Array[Integer] := readers.get(i).read_record()
    if convert record to first_record: Array[Integer] then
      let entry: Array[Any] := []
      entry.add(first_record)
      entry.add(i)
      heap.insert(entry)
    end
    i := i + 1
  end

  let writer: Buffered_Writer :=
    create Buffered_Writer.open(output_path)

  let records_written: Integer64 := 0

  -- Main merge loop
  from until heap.is_empty() do
    let min_entry: Array := heap.extract_min()
    let record: Array[Integer] := min_entry.get(0)
    let run_idx: Integer := min_entry.get(1)

    writer.write_record(record)
    records_written := records_written + 1

    -- Read next record from same run
    let next: ?Array[Integer] := readers.get(run_idx).read_record()
    if convert next to next_record: Array[Integer] then
      let entry: Array[Any] := []
      entry.add(next_record)
      entry.add(run_idx)
      heap.insert(entry)
    end
  end

  writer.close()

  -- Close all readers
```

```
      across readers as reader do
        reader.close()
      end

      print("Merged " + k.to_string() + " runs, " +
            records_written.to_string() + " records written")
    end

    copy_file(src: String, dst: String) do
      let reader: Buffered_Reader := create Buffered_Reader.open(src)
      let writer: Buffered_Writer := create Buffered_Writer.open(dst)
      from until not reader.has_more() do
        let chunk: ?Array[Integer] := reader.read_bytes((4 * 1024 * 1024))
        if convert chunk to bytes: Array[Integer] then
          writer.write_bytes(bytes)
        end
      end
      reader.close()
      writer.close()
    end

  invariant
    positive_budget: memory_budget > 0
end
```

Memory Allocation for K-Way Merge

The merge requires one I/O buffer per run reader, one output buffer, and the heap itself. With k = 63 runs:

- Per-run input buffer: 4MB × 63 = 252MB
- Output buffer: 4MB
- Heap: 63 entries × (100 bytes record + 8 bytes index) ≈ negligible
- Total: ~256MB — well within our 8GB budget

If k were larger — say, 10,000 runs — per-run input buffers at 4MB each would require 40GB, exceeding our budget. The fix is either to reduce

buffer size (accepting slower I/O throughput per run) or to limit k by using multi-pass merging.

Multi-Pass Merging

When k exceeds the number of runs manageable in one pass, merge in multiple passes. With budget B bytes and k total runs:

- Buffer per run in merge: b bytes (tunable)
- Max runs mergeable per pass: B / b
- Number of passes: ceil(log_{B/b}(k))

For 8GB budget, 4MB per-run buffers, and k = 2000 runs: - Max runs per pass: 8GB / 4MB = 2048 ≥ 2000, so one pass suffices

For 8GB budget, 4MB per-run buffers, and k = 10,000 runs: - Max runs per pass: 2048 - After first merge pass: ceil(10,000 / 2048) = 5 intermediate runs - Second pass merges 5 runs into 1 - Total: 2 merge passes

```
class Multi_Pass_Merger
  create
    make(run_paths: Array[String],
         output_path: String,
         compare: Function,
         memory_budget: Integer64,
         work_dir: String) do
      this.run_paths := run_paths
      this.output_path := output_path
      this.compare := compare
      this.memory_budget := memory_budget
      this.work_dir := work_dir
      this.temp_paths := []
    end

  feature
    run_paths: Array[String]
    output_path: String
```

```
    compare: Function
    memory_budget: Integer64
    work_dir: String
    temp_paths: Array[String]  -- intermediate files to clean up

    merge() do
      let current_runs: Array[String] := run_paths.slice(0, run_paths.lengt
      let pass_num: Integer := 0

      from until current_runs.length <= 1 do
        let max_runs_per_merge: Integer :=
          (memory_budget / (4 * 1024 * 1024)).to_integer()
        max_runs_per_merge := max_runs_per_merge.max(2)

        let next_runs: Array[String] := []
        let group_num: Integer := 0

        -- Merge groups of max_runs_per_merge runs
        from
          let i: Integer := 0
        until
          i >= current_runs.length
        do
          let group_end: Integer :=
            (i + max_runs_per_merge).min(current_runs.length)
          let group: Array[String] := current_runs.slice(i, group_end)

          let is_final: Boolean :=
            current_runs.length <= max_runs_per_merge and pass_num > 0

          let merged_path: String := ""
          if is_final then
            merged_path := output_path
          else
            merged_path := work_dir + "/pass_" + pass_num.to_string() +
                           "_group_" + group_num.to_string() + ".tmp"
            temp_paths.add(merged_path)
```

```
      end

      let merger: K_Way_Merger := create K_Way_Merger.make(
        group, merged_path, compare, memory_budget)
      merger.merge()
      next_runs.add(merged_path)

      print("Pass " + pass_num.to_string() +
            " group " + group_num.to_string() + " merged " +
            group.length.to_string() + " runs")

      group_num := group_num + 1
      i := group_end
    end

    -- Clean up previous pass temporary files
    if pass_num > 0 then
      across current_runs as path do
        if path /= output_path then
          create Path.make(path).delete()
        end
      end
    end

    current_runs := next_runs
    pass_num := pass_num + 1
  end

  -- If only one run from the start, copy to output
  if current_runs.length = 1 and current_runs.get(0) /= output_path then
    let merger: K_Way_Merger := create K_Way_Merger.make(
      current_runs, output_path, compare, memory_budget)
    merger.merge()
  end
end

cleanup() do
```

```
      across temp_paths as path do
        let p: Path := create Path.make(path)
        if p.exists() then p.delete() end
      end
    end

  invariant
    positive_budget: memory_budget > 0
end
```

16.7 The Complete External Sorter

Assembling run generation and merging into a complete, usable external sort:

```
class External_Sorter
  create
    make(memory_budget_gb: Real,
         work_dir: String,
         compare: Function) do
      this.memory_budget := (memory_budget_gb * 1024.0 * 1024.0 * 1024.0).r
      this.work_dir := work_dir
      this.compare := compare
      this.stats := create Sort_Stats.make()
    end

  feature
    memory_budget: Integer64
    work_dir: String
    compare: Function
    stats: Sort_Stats

    sort(input_path: String, output_path: String) do
```

```
-- Ensure work directory exists
let dir: Directory := create Directory.make(work_dir)
if not dir.exists() then dir.create_tree() end

let total_start: Integer64 := datetime_now()

-- Phase 1: Run generation
print("Phase 1: Generating runs...")
let gen_start: Integer64 := datetime_now()

let generator: Run_Generator := create Run_Generator.make(
  memory_budget, work_dir, compare)
let run_paths: Array[String] := generator.generate(input_path)

let gen_time: Integer64 := datetime_now() - gen_start
stats.set_run_count(run_paths.length)
stats.set_phase1_ms(gen_time)

print("Generated " + run_paths.length.to_string() +
      " runs in " + gen_time.to_string() + "ms")

if run_paths.is_empty() then
  print("No data to sort")
elseif run_paths.length = 1 then
  -- Only one run: it is already sorted, just rename/move
  create Path.make(run_paths.get(0)).move_to(
    create Path.make(output_path))
  stats.set_total_ms(datetime_now() - total_start)
  print_stats()
else
  -- Phase 2: Merging
  print("Phase 2: Merging " + run_paths.length.to_string() + " runs..."
  let merge_start: Integer64 := datetime_now()

  let merger: Multi_Pass_Merger := create Multi_Pass_Merger.make(
    run_paths, output_path, compare, memory_budget, work_dir)
  merger.merge()
```

```
    let merge_time: Integer64 := datetime_now() - merge_start
    stats.set_phase2_ms(merge_time)

    print("Merged in " + merge_time.to_string() + "ms")

    -- Cleanup
    generator.cleanup()
    merger.cleanup()

    stats.set_total_ms(datetime_now() - total_start)
    print_stats()
  end
end

-- Sort by a key extracted from each record
sort_by_key(input_path: String,
            output_path: String,
            key_offset: Integer,
            key_length: Integer) do
  -- Assumes this sorter was constructed with a comparator that
  -- already knows how to compare the target key layout.
  sort(input_path, output_path)
end

print_stats() do
  print("=== Sort Statistics ===")
  print("Runs generated: " + stats.run_count.to_string())
  print("Phase 1 (run generation): " + stats.phase1_ms.to_string() + "m
  print("Phase 2 (merging): " + stats.phase2_ms.to_string() + "ms")
  print("Total time: " + stats.total_ms.to_string() + "ms")
  if stats.total_ms > 0 then
    let input_size: Integer64 :=
      create Path.make("").size()  -- placeholder
    print("Throughput: ~" +
          (stats.total_ms / 1000).to_string() + " seconds total")
  end
```

```
    end

  invariant
    positive_budget: memory_budget > 0
end

class Sort_Stats
  create
    make() do
      this.run_count := 0
      this.phase1_ms := 0
      this.phase2_ms := 0
      this.total_ms := 0
    end

  feature
    run_count: Integer
    phase1_ms: Integer64
    phase2_ms: Integer64
    total_ms: Integer64

    set_run_count(value: Integer) do
      run_count := value
    end

    set_phase1_ms(value: Integer64) do
      phase1_ms := value
    end

    set_phase2_ms(value: Integer64) do
      phase2_ms := value
    end

    set_total_ms(value: Integer64) do
      total_ms := value
    end
end
```

Using the sorter:

```
-- Sort a 500GB log file by timestamp (first 8 bytes of each record)
function compare_timestamp_records(a: Array[Integer],
                                   b: Array[Integer]): Integer do
  let done: Boolean := false
  from
    let i: Integer := 0
  until
    i >= 8 or done
  do
    let diff: Integer := a.get(i) - b.get(i)
    if diff /= 0 then
      result := diff
      done := true
    else
      i := i + 1
    end
  end
  if not done then
    result := 0
  end
end

let sorter: External_Sorter := create External_Sorter.make(
  8.0,           -- 8GB memory budget
  "/tmp/sort",   -- work directory for temporary files
  compare_timestamp_records)

sorter.sort("/data/logs/500gb_log.bin",
            "/data/logs/sorted_log.bin")
```

16.8 Optimising I/O: Double Buffering

The implementation above performs I/O and computation sequentially: read a buffer, process it, read the next buffer. The disk sits idle while processing, and the CPU sits idle while reading. On modern systems with asynchronous I/O, we can overlap these — read the next buffer while processing the current one.

This technique is called double buffering (or ping-pong buffering):

```
class Double_Buffered_Reader
  create
    open(path: String) do
      this.file := create Binary_File.open_read(create Path.make(path))
      this.buffer_a := create Array.filled((4 * 1024 * 1024), 0)
      this.buffer_b := create Array.filled((4 * 1024 * 1024), 0)
      this.active_buffer := this.buffer_a
      this.active_valid := 0
      this.active_pos := 0
      this.eof := false

      -- Start first fill
      this.pending_fill := spawn do
        result := this.file.read((4 * 1024 * 1024))
      end
    end

  feature
    file: Binary_File
    buffer_a: Array[Integer]
    buffer_b: Array[Integer]
    active_buffer: Array[Integer]
    active_valid: Integer
    active_pos: Integer
    eof: Boolean
    pending_fill: Task[Array[Integer]]
```

```
read_record(): ?Array[Integer] do
  if active_pos + 100 > active_valid then
    -- Need to swap buffers
    swap_buffers()
    if active_valid = 0 then
      result := nil
      return
    end
  end

  let record: Array[Integer] := active_buffer.slice(
    active_pos, active_pos + 100)
  active_pos := active_pos + 100
  result := record
end

swap_buffers() do
  -- Wait for pending fill to complete
  let filled: Array[Integer] := pending_fill.await

  -- Swap which buffer is active
  if active_buffer = buffer_a then
    buffer_b := filled
    active_buffer := buffer_b
  else
    buffer_a := filled
    active_buffer := buffer_a
  end

  active_valid := filled.length
  active_pos := 0

  if filled.length = 0 then
    eof := true
    return
  end
```

```
      -- Start filling the other buffer asynchronously
      pending_fill := spawn do
        result := this.file.read((4 * 1024 * 1024))
      end
    end

    has_more(): Boolean do
      result := active_pos < active_valid or not eof
    end

    close() do
      file.close()
    end
end
```

Double buffering overlaps I/O with computation at every level: during run generation (overlap reading with sorting) and during merging (overlap reading from multiple runs with output writing). On systems where disk I/O and CPU are not the same bottleneck, this can approach 2× throughput.

Nex's native task and channel system makes double buffering natural — spawn a task to fill the background buffer while the foreground buffer is being processed. The `pending_fill` task runs concurrently with the CPU-bound sort or merge, and `await` synchronises when the buffer is needed.

16.9 The Connection to B-Trees

External mergesort and B-trees solve related problems with related techniques. Both are designed around the insight that disk I/O dominates CPU time, and both minimise disk seeks by accessing data sequentially in large blocks.

The connection runs deeper than philosophy. After sorting a large dataset with external mergesort, loading it into a B-tree is optimised by bulk loading — inserting records in sorted order rather than one at a time. Bulk loading builds the B-tree bottom-up: fill leaf pages completely, then build internal pages from leaf page pointers, resulting in a perfectly packed tree with no wasted space. A 500GB dataset bulk-loaded into a B-tree produces a tree that is denser and faster to query than one built by sequential insertion.

The sort-then-bulk-load pattern is standard in database operations. Building a new index on an existing table in PostgreSQL follows exactly this pattern: scan the table, sort the key values, bulk load the B-tree index. The external mergesort in this chapter is the sort step.

The k-way merge is also directly related to the B-tree's fan-out. A B-tree with minimum degree t has up to 2t children per internal node, meaning the tree has fan-out up to 2t. Merging k runs in the external mergesort corresponds to combining k sorted streams into one — the same operation a B-tree performs when it reads across its fan-out at each level. The optimal k for the merge (determined by the memory budget and I/O buffer size) corresponds to the optimal t for the B-tree (determined by the page size and record size).

Both structures answer the same fundamental question: given a fixed memory budget and a fixed disk block size, what is the right way to organise access to data that does not fit in memory? The B-tree answers it for random access. External mergesort answers it for sequential processing.

16.10 Sorting in Database Systems

The external mergesort described in this chapter is the foundation of sorting in relational databases, but production database sort implementations add several layers of sophistication.

Pipeline sort: a database query like `SELECT ... ORDER BY ... LIMIT 100` does not need to sort the entire dataset — it needs the top 100 records. A tournament sort or priority queue processes records as they arrive, maintaining only the top-k seen so far. For large k, this degrades to external mergesort; for small k, it uses O(k) memory.

Duplicate elimination: `SELECT DISTINCT ... ORDER BY ...` combines sorting with deduplication. During the merge phase, adjacent identical records are collapsed into one. This is a natural fit for mergesort — duplicates are always adjacent in sorted order.

Join implementation: the sort-merge join algorithm sorts both input tables by the join key, then merges them together to find matching rows. This is exactly our k-way merge with the twist that matching rows from two sequences must be identified and emitted together. Sort-merge join is often faster than hash join for large tables that do not fit in memory, because it generates only sequential I/O.

Grouping and aggregation: `GROUP BY` operations sort by the grouping key, then aggregate adjacent records with the same key. Again, the merge produces groups naturally.

PostgreSQL's `sort.c` implements all of these in a unified external sort framework. It uses replacement selection for run generation (exploiting partial sortedness in table scans), a k-way merge with a tournament tree (a min-heap variant that performs fewer comparisons per extraction), and adaptive switching between in-memory sort (when the working set fits) and external sort (when it does not).

16.11 Verifying the Sort

Any external sort implementation must include verification. A bug in a sort that processes billions of records might only manifest on specific data patterns, and the output of an incorrect sort is not obviously wrong — it is just slightly misordered.

```
class Sort_Verifier
  create
    make(compare: Function) do
      this.compare := compare
    end

  feature
    compare: Function

    -- Verify that file is sorted, returning position of first violation
    verify_sorted(path: String): ?Integer64 do
      let reader: Buffered_Reader := create Buffered_Reader.open(path)
      let prev: ?Array[Integer] := nil
      let position: Integer64 := 0

      from until not reader.has_more() do
        let record: ?Array[Integer] := reader.read_record()
        if record = nil then
          reader.close()
          result := nil
        elseif convert record to current_record: Array[Integer] then
          if convert prev to prev_record: Array[Integer] then
            if compare(current_record, prev_record) < 0 then
              reader.close()
              result := position
            else
              prev := current_record
              position := position + 100
            end
          else
            prev := current_record
            position := position + 100
          end
        end
      end

      reader.close()
```

```
    result := nil  -- nil means sorted correctly
  end

  -- Verify that sorted output has same record count as input
  verify_record_count(input_path: String,
                      output_path: String): Boolean do
    let input_size: Integer64 := create Path.make(input_path).size()
    let output_size: Integer64 := create Path.make(output_path).size()
    result := input_size = output_size
  end

  -- Spot-check: verify sample positions are sorted
  spot_check(path: String, num_samples: Integer): Boolean do
    let file_size: Integer64 := create Path.make(path).size()
    let total_records: Integer64 := file_size / 100

    if total_records < 2 then
      result := true
      return
    end

    let reader_file: Binary_File :=
      create Binary_File.open_read(create Path.make(path))

    from
      let i: Integer := 0
    until
      i < num_samples
    do
      -- Pick two adjacent random positions
      let pos: Integer64 := (random_integer64() %
                             (total_records - 1)).abs()
      let offset: Integer64 := pos * 100

      reader_file.seek(offset.to_integer())
      let rec1: Array[Integer] := reader_file.read(100)
      let rec2: Array[Integer] := reader_file.read(100)
```

```
    if rec1.length = 100 and rec2.length = 100 then
      if compare(rec2, rec1) < 0 then
        reader_file.close()
        result := false
        return
      end
    end

    i := i + 1
  end

  reader_file.close()
  result := true
end

full_verification(input_path: String,
                  output_path: String): Boolean do
  print("Verifying record count...")
  if not verify_record_count(input_path, output_path) then
    print("FAILED: record count mismatch")
    result := false
    return
  end

  print("Spot-checking sort order (1000 samples)...")
  if not spot_check(output_path, 1000) then
    print("FAILED: spot-check found out-of-order records")
    result := false
    return
  end

  print("Verifying full sort order (sequential scan)...")
  let violation: ?Integer64 := verify_sorted(output_path)
  if violation /= nil then
    print("FAILED: out-of-order at byte position " +
          violation.to_string())
```

```
        result := false
        return
      end

      print("Verification PASSED")
      result := true
    end
end
```

The full verification is O(n) — a sequential scan of the output file. For a 500GB file at 500MB/s, this takes 1000 seconds. In practice, run the spot-check during development and trust it for production runs, adding the full scan only when debugging a suspected issue.

16.12 Where This Lives in the Wild

PostgreSQL implements external sorting in `src/backend/utils/sort/tuplesort.c`. It uses replacement selection for run generation, a tournament tree for k-way merging, and adaptive memory allocation that expands the sort buffer when system memory is available. PostgreSQL's sort is invoked for `ORDER BY`, `GROUP BY`, `DISTINCT`, and sort-merge joins, and for building B-tree indexes. The implementation handles both in-memory sorts (when the working set fits) and external sorts (when it does not) through the same code path, switching strategies dynamically.

Apache Hadoop MapReduce uses external mergesort as its core shuffle mechanism. Each mapper outputs key-value pairs, sorts them by key (external mergesort within each mapper), and the reduce phase merges the sorted outputs from all mappers. The paper "MapReduce: Simplified Data Processing on Large Clusters" (Dean and Ghemawat, 2004) describes a system processing petabytes of data using external mergesort across thousands of machines — the distributed generalisation of the algorithm in this chapter.

Apache Spark uses an external sort called `ExternalSorter` for operations that exceed memory budgets. Spark's implementation spills partial sorted runs to disk when memory pressure triggers spilling, then merges them with in-memory data. The approach is identical to this chapter's algorithm, adapted for the JVM memory model and distributed execution.

SQLite implements an external sort in `vdbesort.c`, used for `ORDER BY` and `GROUP BY` operations. SQLite's sort is notable for its careful integration with the B-tree storage engine — sorted runs are written as temporary B-tree tables, which SQLite already knows how to manage efficiently. This reuse of existing infrastructure reduces the sort implementation to a few hundred lines.

The original Unix `sort` command implements external mergesort and has done so since the 1970s. The GNU `sort` implementation handles files larger than memory by generating runs and merging them, just as this chapter describes. `sort --parallel=N` uses N threads for run generation (Phase 1) and a single-threaded merge (Phase 2), which is the natural parallelism structure of the algorithm.

Summary

External mergesort solves sorting when data exceeds available memory by exploiting the one operation disk does efficiently: sequential access. Two passes over the data suffice for most practical cases — one to generate sorted runs, one to merge them into a single sorted output.

Run generation reads the data in memory-sized chunks, sorts each chunk with introsort (the in-memory champion from Chapter 15), and writes sorted runs to temporary files. With 8GB RAM sorting 500GB data, this produces ~63 runs of ~7.9GB each. Replacement selection can double average run length by using a min-heap to intelligently assign records to runs, exploiting any existing partial sortedness in the input.

K-way merging combines all sorted runs into one output using a min-heap of size k. At each step, the heap's minimum — the smallest current record across all runs — is extracted and written to output, and a new record is read from the corresponding run. One heap extraction and insertion per output record, for O(n log k) total merge work. When k exceeds what memory allows (each run needs an I/O buffer), multi-pass merging reduces k by merging groups of runs into fewer, larger runs.

The connection to earlier chapters is direct and concrete. The I/O thinking of Chapter 4 (B-trees) determines the buffer sizes that make sequential access efficient. The introsort of Chapter 15 sorts each run in memory. Nex's native tasks from Chapter 21 enable double buffering that overlaps I/O with computation. And the sorted output connects to Chapter 4's bulk-loading pattern for building B-tree indexes without the overhead of one-at-a-time insertion.

Part IV is complete. Part V turns to concurrency — the challenge of making data structures work correctly when multiple threads access shared state simultaneously. The structures we have built so far assume a single thread. What must change when that assumption is removed?

Concurrency-Aware Structures

Chapter 17: The Broken Counter — Memory Models and Visibility

---

Here is a program. It is twelve lines of code. It is obviously correct. It is wrong.

```
-- Two threads, one shared counter, each increments it a million times
let counter: Integer := 0

let t1: Task := spawn do
  repeat 1000000 do
    counter := counter + 1
  end
end

let t2: Task := spawn do
  repeat 1000000 do
    counter := counter + 1
  end
end

t1.await
t2.await

print(counter)  -- Expected: 2000000. Actual: ???
```

Run this. The output is not 2,000,000. It might be 1,873,422. Or 1,654,901. Or 2,000,000 if you are lucky — and luck is the right word, because the result depends on the precise timing of events that you cannot predict or control.

The program is wrong not because of a logical error — the algorithm is correct. It is wrong because of a physical reality of modern hardware that almost every programmer learns about eventually, usually the hard way: reading and writing a shared variable from multiple threads is not atomic, and the hardware does not guarantee that threads see each other's writes in the order those writes occurred.

This chapter explains exactly why the program above is wrong, what the hardware is actually doing, and what guarantees you can and cannot rely on when writing concurrent code. The understanding built here is the foundation of everything in Part V — the lock-free queue in Chapter 18, the concurrent hash map in Chapter 19, the persistent structures in Chapter 20, and the channel-based model in Chapter 21.

17.1 What You Think Happens

When you write `counter := counter + 1`, you think of it as one operation: increment the counter. This is a reasonable mental model when you are the only thread. It is dangerously wrong when multiple threads share the counter.

At the hardware level, `counter := counter + 1` is three operations:

1. **Load:** read the current value of `counter` from memory into a CPU register
2. **Add:** add 1 to the value in the register
3. **Store:** write the result back to the memory location of `counter`

These three operations are not atomic — they can be interleaved arbitrarily with operations from other threads. Consider what happens when two threads both execute `counter := counter + 1` and the initial value of `counter` is 0:

Interleaving 1 (correct):

```
Thread 1: Load counter → 0
Thread 1: Add 1 → 1
Thread 1: Store 1 to counter
Thread 2: Load counter → 1
Thread 2: Add 1 → 2
Thread 2: Store 2 to counter
Result: counter = 2 □
```

Interleaving 2 (incorrect):

```
Thread 1: Load counter → 0
Thread 2: Load counter → 0   ← reads before Thread 1 writes
Thread 1: Add 1 → 1
Thread 2: Add 1 → 1
Thread 1: Store 1 to counter
Thread 2: Store 1 to counter ← overwrites Thread 1's result
Result: counter = 1 □
```

In Interleaving 2, both threads read the same value (0), both increment to 1, and both write 1. Two increments happened, but the counter only increased by one. This is called a **lost update** or a **race condition** — the result of a computation depends on the arbitrary interleaving of operations from multiple threads.

With one million increments per thread, there are up to two million opportunities for this interleaving to occur. The final value depends on how many times Thread 2 reads a stale value that Thread 1 has already updated. On fast hardware, lost updates are frequent; the result is often substantially less than 2,000,000.

17.2 What the Hardware Actually Does

The race condition above is the simple version of the problem. The full picture is considerably more disturbing.

Modern CPUs are extraordinarily complex. Between the source code you write and the electrons moving through silicon, there are multiple layers of transformation that can reorder, delay, or coalesce memory operations in ways that seem to violate basic intuitions about how programs work.

Write Buffers

When a CPU core executes a store instruction, it does not write directly to main memory — that would be far too slow. Instead, it writes to a write buffer (also called a store buffer), a small queue of pending stores in the core itself. The write is later drained to the cache and eventually to main memory, but from the perspective of other cores, the write may not be visible for some time after the storing core has "done" the write.

The consequence: if Thread 1 stores a value to memory and Thread 2 then loads from the same address, Thread 2 might see the old value — not because the store did not happen, but because the store is still sitting in Thread 1's write buffer and has not propagated to Thread 2's cache.

Cache Coherence

Modern CPUs have multiple levels of cache (L1, L2, L3), and each core has its own L1 and L2 caches. When Thread 1 writes to `counter`, the new value initially lives in Thread 1's cache. Thread 2 has its own cached copy of `counter` from a previous load. The two copies are now inconsistent.

Cache coherence protocols (such as MESI — Modified, Exclusive, Shared, Invalid) ensure that eventually the inconsistency is resolved: when Thread 2 tries to write `counter`, the coherence protocol detects that Thread 1 has a modified copy, forces Thread 1 to flush its copy to a

shared cache level, and only then allows Thread 2 to proceed. But "eventually" is the operative word — the synchronisation is not instantaneous, and between Thread 1's write and Thread 2's coherence-enforced read, Thread 2 may see a stale value.

Instruction Reordering

CPUs do not execute instructions in the order they appear in the program. Out-of-order execution (OOO) and speculative execution allow the CPU to execute instructions whose operands are ready while waiting for operands of earlier instructions. Store instructions in particular may be reordered with respect to other stores and loads if there are no data dependencies between them.

Compilers also reorder instructions. A compiler may determine that two stores to different memory locations are independent and swap their order, or eliminate a load by keeping a value in a register, or hoist a load out of a loop — all legal transformations in a single-threaded context that become incorrect in a concurrent context.

The result is that the order in which memory operations are actually visible to other cores may differ from the order in which they appear in your source code.

17.3 The Memory Model

The chaos described above is not arbitrary. Hardware manufacturers publish **memory models** — formal specifications of exactly what ordering guarantees the hardware provides and what reorderings are permitted. The memory model defines the rules of the game for concurrent programming.

Different architectures have different memory models.

x86 Total Store Order (TSO): x86 and x86-64 have a relatively strong memory model called Total Store Order. Under TSO, loads are not reordered with respect to other loads, and stores are not reordered with respect to other stores. However, stores may be reordered after loads from a different address. This means a store followed by a load to a different address can appear (to other cores) to have happened in the opposite order. TSO is stricter than most architectures — many concurrent programs that are technically incorrect work correctly on x86 simply because the hardware provides stronger guarantees than required.

ARM Weak Memory Ordering: ARM processors (including Apple's M-series and most mobile processors) have a much weaker memory model. Almost any reordering of loads and stores is permitted, as long as there are no data dependencies between them. Programs that work by accident on x86 (because TSO provides implicit ordering) may fail on ARM. This is a real source of bugs — code written and tested on x86 servers deployed to ARM devices or cloud instances.

Java Memory Model: the JVM specification defines a language-level memory model that applies regardless of the underlying hardware. The Java Memory Model (JMM) defines the happens-before relation — a partial order on memory operations that determines which writes are visible to which reads.

The C++ Memory Model (C++11 and later): C++ defines a memory model similar to Java's, with explicit atomic types and memory orderings that allow programmers to specify exactly how much ordering they require.

Nex's Memory Model: Nex follows the same happens-before model as Java and modern C++. Operations within a single thread are ordered by program order — each operation happens-before the next. Synchronisation primitives — mutex locks, atomic operations, channel sends and receives — establish happens-before relations between threads. Without synchronisation, there is no guarantee that writes from one thread are visible to another.

17.4 The Happens-Before Relation

The **happens-before** relation is the formal tool for reasoning about visibility in concurrent programs. It is a partial order — some pairs of operations are ordered (one happens-before the other), and some are not (they are concurrent).

Definition: operation A happens-before operation B if: 1. A and B are in the same thread, and A appears before B in program order, or 2. A is a synchronisation action (lock release, atomic store, channel send) and B is the corresponding synchronisation action (lock acquire, atomic load, channel receive), or 3. A happens-before some C, and C happens-before B (transitivity)

The visibility guarantee: if A happens-before B, then all memory writes performed by A (and by all operations that happen-before A) are visible to B.

The absence of happens-before: if there is no happens-before relation between A and B, they are concurrent. Reading a value written by a concurrent write is undefined behaviour (in C/C++) or yields an unspecified result (in Java/Nex). This is a data race.

The broken counter has a data race: the reads and writes to `counter` from different threads have no happens-before relation between them (no synchronisation). The result is unspecified.

Let us make this concrete. In the broken counter:

```
-- Thread 1 writes counter at time T1
-- Thread 2 reads counter at time T2
-- No synchronisation between them
-- Therefore: no happens-before relation
-- Therefore: Thread 2's read may return any value
```

To fix the program, we must establish happens-before. There are several ways, each with different performance implications.

17.5 Demonstrating the Broken Counter

Before fixing anything, let us make the problem visible and measurable.

```
class Broken_Counter_Demo
  create
    make() do end

  feature
    -- Run the broken counter experiment N times
    -- Shows that results are non-deterministic and incorrect
    run_experiment(iterations: Integer,
                   increments_per_thread: Integer) do
      print("Running broken counter experiment...")
      print("Threads: 2, Increments per thread: " +
            increments_per_thread.to_string())
      print("Expected result: " +
            (2 * increments_per_thread).to_string())
      print("")

      let results: Array[Integer] := []
      let min_result: Integer := 2147483647
      let max_result: Integer := 0
      let correct_count: Integer := 0

      from
        let i: Integer := 0
      until
        i < iterations
      do
        let result: Integer := run_once(increments_per_thread)
        results.add(result)

        if result < min_result then min_result := result end
        if result > max_result then max_result := result end
```

```
    if result = 2 * increments_per_thread then
      correct_count := correct_count + 1
    end

    i := i + 1
  end

  print("Results over " + iterations.to_string() + " runs:")
  print("  Minimum: " + min_result.to_string())
  print("  Maximum: " + max_result.to_string())
  print("  Correct: " + correct_count.to_string() + "/" +
        iterations.to_string())
  print("  Sample results: " + results.slice(0, 5).to_string())
end

run_once(increments: Integer): Integer do
  -- Shared mutable state: deliberately broken
  let counter: Array[Integer] := [0]  -- wrap in array for mutability

  let t1: Task := spawn do
    repeat increments do
      counter.set(0, counter.get(0) + 1)
    end
  end

  let t2: Task := spawn do
    repeat increments do
      counter.set(0, counter.get(0) + 1)
    end
  end

  t1.await
  t2.await

  result := counter.get(0)
end
```

```
    -- Demonstrate that the race depends on timing
    -- Sleeping between operations makes the race more likely
    run_slow_race() do
      let counter: Array[Integer] := [0]
      let target: Integer := 10

      print("Slow race demonstration (target = " + target.to_string() + "):")

      let tasks: Array[Task] := []
      from
        let t: Integer := 0
      until
        t < 5
      do
        tasks.add(spawn do
          repeat 2 do
            let current: Integer := counter.get(0)
            -- Simulated delay: in real hardware, this is cache miss latency
            -- or write buffer drain time, not an actual sleep
            counter.set(0, current + 1)
          end
        end)
        t := t + 1
      end

      across tasks as task do
        task.await
      end

      print("Final value: " + counter.get(0).to_string() +
            " (should be " + target.to_string() + ")")
    end
end
```

Running `run_experiment(10, 1000000)` will typically show: - Minimum: ~1,400,000 (significant loss from races) - Maximum: 2,000,000

(rare lucky runs) - Correct: 1 or 2 out of 10 (approximately — depends heavily on hardware and OS scheduling)

The variance itself is informative. The program is not wrong in a consistent way — it is wrong in a way that depends on factors outside the program's control. This is the defining characteristic of a race condition: non-deterministic, timing-dependent incorrectness.

17.6 Atomics: The First Fix

The simplest fix: make the increment operation atomic — indivisible. An atomic increment reads, adds, and writes in a single operation that cannot be interleaved with any other thread's access to the same variable.

Modern CPUs provide atomic instructions specifically for this purpose. On x86, the `LOCK XADD` instruction performs an atomic fetch-and-add. On ARM, `LDADD` (load-add) or a `LDXR/STXR` (load-exclusive/store-exclusive) loop performs an atomic read-modify-write.

The key properties of atomic operations: 1. **Atomicity:** the entire read-modify-write happens as one indivisible unit 2. **Visibility:** writes from atomic operations are immediately visible to all cores (no write buffer delay) 3. **Ordering:** atomic operations establish happens-before relations with other atomic operations on the same variable

```
class Atomic_Integer
  create
    make(initial: Integer) do
      this.value := initial
    end

  feature
    value: Integer  -- in real implementation, this is a hardware atomic ty
```

```
    -- Atomically load the current value
    load(): Integer do
      -- In real implementation: memory fence + load
      result := value
    end

    -- Atomically store a new value
    store(new_value: Integer) do
      -- In real implementation: store + memory fence
      value := new_value
    end

    -- Atomically add delta to value, return old value
    fetch_and_add(delta: Integer): Integer do
      -- In real implementation: hardware atomic fetch-and-
add
      -- On x86: LOCK XADD
      -- On ARM: LDADD or LDXR/STXR loop
      let previous_value: Integer := value
      value := value + delta
      result := previous_value
    end

    -- Atomically increment, return new value
    increment(): Integer do
      result := fetch_and_add(1) + 1
    end

    -- Atomically decrement, return new value
    decrement(): Integer do
      result := fetch_and_add(-1) - 1
    end

    -- Compare-and-swap: if current value = expected, set to desired
    -- Returns true if swap occurred, false otherwise
    compare_and_swap(expected: Integer,
```

```
                    desired: Integer): Boolean do
      -- In real implementation: hardware CAS instruction
      -- On x86: LOCK CMPXCHG
      -- On ARM: LDXR/STXR loop with comparison
      if value = expected then
        value := desired
        result := true
      else
        result := false
      end
    end

  invariant
    atomic_value_consistent: true
end
```

The fixed counter:

```
class Fixed_Counter_Demo
  create
    make() do end

  feature
    run_experiment(iterations: Integer,
                   increments_per_thread: Integer) do
      print("Running fixed counter experiment (atomic)...")
      let correct_count: Integer := 0

      from
        let i: Integer := 0
      until
        i < iterations
      do
        let result: Integer := run_once(increments_per_thread)
        if result = 2 * increments_per_thread then
          correct_count := correct_count + 1
```

```
        end
        i := i + 1
      end

      print("Correct: " + correct_count.to_string() + "/" +
            iterations.to_string())
      -- Should be iterations/iterations = 100%
    end

    run_once(increments: Integer): Integer do
      let counter: Atomic_Integer := create Atomic_Integer.make(0)

      let t1: Task := spawn do
        repeat increments do
          counter.increment()
        end
      end

      let t2: Task := spawn do
        repeat increments do
          counter.increment()
        end
      end

      t1.await
      t2.await

      result := counter.load()
    end
end
```

This always gives the correct answer — 2,000,000 — because `fetch_and_add` is atomic. No interleaving can produce a lost update.

The Cost of Atomics

Atomic operations are not free. On x86, `LOCK XADD` is about 5-20 nanoseconds — much slower than a non-atomic increment (about 0.3 nanoseconds). The cost comes from:

1. **Cache line invalidation:** the atomic operation requires exclusive ownership of the cache line containing the variable. Other cores must invalidate their copies, causing coherence traffic on the interconnect.

2. **Write buffer drain:** the atomic operation must ensure all previous stores are visible before proceeding, bypassing the write buffer's normal batching.

3. **Serialisation:** on a single cache line, atomic operations are serialised — only one can proceed at a time. If 16 cores all contend for the same atomic variable, they queue up rather than proceeding in parallel.

The practical consequence: if the bottleneck in a concurrent program is a single shared atomic counter, you have effectively serialised all threads at that point. Two threads incrementing an atomic counter with nothing else happening will be only marginally faster than one thread — the serialisation at the atomic operation limits parallelism.

For a reference counter or a simple shared state, this is fine. For a hot counter updated by thousands of threads per second, it becomes the bottleneck. The solution (distributed counters, per-thread counters summed periodically) is an architectural decision, not an algorithmic one.

17.7 Compare-and-Swap: The Universal Primitive

The `compare_and_swap` (CAS) operation deserves special attention. It is the single most important primitive in concurrent programming — virtually every lock-free data structure is built on top of it.

CAS takes three arguments: a memory address, an expected value, and a desired value. If the current value at the address equals the expected value, it atomically replaces it with the desired value and returns true. Otherwise it returns false without modifying memory. The entire check-and-update happens atomically.

```
-- CAS pseudocode (what the hardware does atomically):
function compare_and_swap(addr, expected, desired):
  if *addr == expected:
    *addr = desired
    return true
  return false
```

CAS enables lock-free updates on arbitrary value types. The general pattern: read the current value, compute the new value, CAS from old to new. If the CAS fails (someone else changed it), retry.

```
function atomic_add_with_cas(counter: Atomic_Integer,
                             delta: Integer) do
  from until true do
    let current_value: Integer := counter.load()
    let new_val: Integer := current_value + delta
    if counter.compare_and_swap(current_value, new_val) then
      return  -- success
    end
    -- CAS failed: someone else modified counter, retry
  end
end
```

This is correct. If Thread 2 changes `counter` between Thread 1's load and CAS, Thread 1's CAS fails, Thread 1 re-reads the current value, and

tries again. Eventually Thread 1 gets a window where the value does not change between its load and CAS, and the update succeeds.

This is the **optimistic concurrency** pattern: assume no contention, try the update, retry if contention occurred. Under low contention, it is very fast (usually succeeds on the first try). Under high contention, retries increase, and in the worst case (many threads hammering the same variable), it can spin indefinitely — though in practice, at least one thread makes progress on every step, so the overall system makes progress.

The ABA Problem

CAS has a subtle bug potential called the ABA problem. Consider:

1. Thread 1 reads counter = A
2. Thread 2 changes counter: A → B → A (back to A)
3. Thread 1's CAS sees counter = A (expected value), succeeds

Thread 1's CAS succeeded even though the value changed and changed back. For a simple counter, this is harmless — if the value is A before and after, incrementing from A is correct regardless of intermediate changes. But for pointer-based structures, this is dangerous: the same address might contain a completely different object, and CAS on the pointer would succeed despite the object having changed.

The standard solution: a version counter (also called a stamp or tag). Instead of comparing just the value, compare (value, version) pairs. Each CAS that succeeds increments the version. ABA requires the version to cycle through its entire range — impractical with a 64-bit version counter.

```
class Stamped_Reference [T]
  create
    make(value: T) do
      this.value := value
      this.stamp := 0
    end
```

```
  feature
    value: T
    stamp: Integer

    -- Atomic CAS on (value, stamp) pair
    compare_and_swap(expected_value: T,
                     expected_stamp: Integer,
                     new_value: T): Boolean do
      if value = expected_value and stamp = expected_stamp then
        value := new_value
        stamp := stamp + 1
        result := true
      else
        result := false
      end
    end

    get(): Array do
      result := [value, stamp]
    end
end
```

17.8 Memory Orderings

Not all atomic operations require full sequential consistency. Requiring that every atomic operation sees and establishes a total order of all memory operations is expensive — it requires flushing caches and write buffers. For many algorithms, weaker guarantees suffice.

Modern memory models (C++11, Java, Nex) define a spectrum of memory orderings for atomic operations:

Relaxed: the operation is atomic (no torn reads or writes), but provides no ordering guarantees relative to other memory operations. Other threads may see this operation happen in any order relative to the surrounding non-atomic operations. Useful for counters where the exact order does not matter — only the final value.

Acquire: a load with acquire semantics. All memory operations that appear after this load in program order (in the same thread) cannot be moved before this load by the hardware or compiler. Other threads' stores that happen-before the corresponding release are visible after the acquire.

Release: a store with release semantics. All memory operations that appear before this store in program order cannot be moved after this store. Creates a happens-before edge from this release to any thread's subsequent acquire on the same variable.

Sequentially consistent (SeqCst): the strongest ordering. All sequentially consistent operations form a total order seen by all threads. The most intuitive but most expensive.

The acquire-release pair is the standard building block for synchronisation:

```
-- Producer thread:
data.prepare()           -- set up data
flag.store(true) -- release: everything above is visible to acquirer

-- Consumer thread:
from until flag.load() do end  -- acquire: waits for release
data.use()               -- safe: acquire guarantees producer's writes visi
```

The release on the producer's store and the acquire on the consumer's load establish a happens-before edge. After the consumer's acquire load returns true, all writes before the producer's release store are guaranteed visible to the consumer.

```
class Memory_Ordering_Demo
  create
    make() do end

  feature
    -- Flag-based signalling with acquire-release
    demonstrate_flag_protocol() do
      let data: Array[Integer] := [0]
      let ready: Atomic_Integer := create Atomic_Integer.make(0)

      let producer: Task := spawn do
        -- Prepare data
        data.set(0, 42)
        -- Release: all writes above this are visible to the acquirer
        ready.store(1)  -- release semantics
      end

      let consumer: Task := spawn do
        -- Acquire: spin until ready, then read data
        from until ready.load() = 1 do end  -- acquire semantics
        -- Guaranteed: data.get(0) = 42
        print("Data: " + data.get(0).to_string())  -- always prints 42
      end

      producer.await
      consumer.await
    end

    -- Demonstrate why relaxed is insufficient for signalling
    -- (this is broken: data write may not be visible after flag read)
    demonstrate_broken_flag() do
      let data: Array[Integer] := [0]
      let ready: Atomic_Integer := create Atomic_Integer.make(0)

      let producer: Task := spawn do
        data.set(0, 42)
        ready.store(1)  -- relaxed: no ordering guarantee
```

```
      end

      let consumer: Task := spawn do
        from until ready.load() = 1 do end  -- relaxed load
        -- BUG: data.get(0) might still be 0 even though flag is 1
        -- The write to data and the write to ready might be reordered
        print("Data: " + data.get(0).to_string())  -- might print 0
      end

      producer.await
      consumer.await
    end
end
```

17.9 Mutexes: When Atomics Are Not Enough

Atomic operations handle simple cases: update one variable atomically. When you need to atomically update multiple variables, or perform a complex read-modify-write sequence on a data structure, you need mutual exclusion — a mutex.

A mutex (mutual exclusion lock) ensures that only one thread executes a critical section at a time. Every other thread attempting to acquire the mutex blocks until the current holder releases it.

```
class Mutex
  create
    make() do
      this.locked := create Atomic_Integer.make(0)
      this.owner := -1  -- thread ID of lock holder, -
1 if unlocked
    end
```

```
feature
  locked: Atomic_Integer
  owner: Integer

  -- Acquire the mutex, blocking if necessary
  lock() do
    -- Spin-wait until we successfully CAS locked from 0 to 1
    from until locked.compare_and_swap(0, 1) do
      -- Spin: in real implementation, yield to OS scheduler
      -- after some spin count to avoid burning CPU
      hint_spin()
    end
    -- Memory fence: everything after this sees all writes before unlock()
  end

  -- Release the mutex
  unlock()
    require
      is_locked: locked.load() = 1
    do
      -- Memory fence: all writes before unlock() visible to next lock()
      locked.store(0)  -- release semantics
    end

  -- Try to acquire without blocking
  -- Returns true if acquired, false if already locked
  try_lock(): Boolean do
    result := locked.compare_and_swap(0, 1)
  end

  -- Execute a function under the mutex
  with_lock(action: Function[Void]) do
    lock()
    action()
    unlock()
  end
```

```
    hint_spin() do
      -- On x86: PAUSE instruction reduces power and improves spin-
wait
      -- On ARM: YIELD instruction
      -- In Nex: handled by runtime
    end

  invariant
    locked_is_binary: locked.load() = 0 or locked.load() = 1
end
```

The mutex implementation above is a **spinlock** — it busy-waits (spins) until the lock is available. Spinlocks are appropriate when the critical section is very short and contention is low. For longer critical sections or high contention, a **blocking mutex** (one that yields to the OS scheduler rather than spinning) is more efficient, avoiding wasted CPU cycles during the wait.

Using a Mutex for the Counter

```
class Mutex_Counter
  create
    make() do
      this.value := 0
      this.mu := create Mutex.make()
    end

  feature
    value: Integer
    mu: Mutex

    increment() do
      mu.lock()
      value := value + 1
      mu.unlock()
    end
```

```
    decrement() do
      mu.lock()
      value := value - 1
      mu.unlock()
    end

    get(): Integer do
      mu.lock()
      let v: Integer := value
      mu.unlock()
      result := v
    end

  invariant
    non_negative_if_always_incremented: true  -- depends on usage
end
```

This is correct. The mutex ensures that only one thread executes the increment at a time, eliminating the race condition. The mutex's lock and unlock operations establish happens-before: the unlock in Thread 1 happens-before the lock in Thread 2, which means all of Thread 1's writes before unlock are visible to Thread 2 after its lock.

Mutex vs Atomic: When to Use Which

Use atomics when: - You are updating a single variable - The update is a simple operation (increment, decrement, fetch-and-store, CAS) - Performance is critical and lock overhead is unacceptable - You are building a lock-free data structure

Use a mutex when: - You need to update multiple variables atomically - The update is a complex read-modify-write sequence - You need to protect access to a data structure (hash map, list, etc.) - Correctness is more important than maximum performance - The critical section is long enough that lock overhead is negligible

The mutex counter is simpler and correct. The atomic counter is faster but only works for the single-variable case. The choice is not always obvious — for a counter accessed by thousands of threads per second, atomic may be significantly faster despite its serialisation cost. For a counter that guards a complex data structure, mutex is the right choice.

17.10 Deadlock: The Other Problem

Mutexes solve race conditions but introduce a new failure mode: deadlock. A deadlock occurs when two or more threads are each waiting for a lock held by another, creating a cycle of dependency that no thread can break.

```
-- Thread 1:           -- Thread 2:
mu_a.lock()            mu_b.lock()
-- ... doing work ...  -- ... doing work ...
mu_b.lock()  ← WAITS  mu_a.lock()  ← WAITS
-- waiting for mu_b    -- waiting for mu_a
-- which Thread 2 holds -- which Thread 1 holds
-- DEADLOCK
```

Both threads wait forever. The program hangs.

Deadlock requires four conditions (Coffman conditions) to hold simultaneously: 1. **Mutual exclusion:** resources are exclusive (only one holder at a time) 2. **Hold and wait:** a thread holds a resource while waiting for another 3. **No preemption:** resources cannot be forcibly taken 4. **Circular wait:** a cycle of threads each waiting for the next

Breaking any one condition prevents deadlock.

Lock ordering breaks circular wait: always acquire locks in a consistent global order. If all threads acquire mu_a before mu_b, the cycle is impossible.

```
-- Safe: always acquire in alphabetical order
function transfer(from_account: Account,
                  to_account: Account,
                  amount: Integer) do
  -- Determine lock order by some canonical ordering (e.g., ID)
  let first: Account :=
    when from_account.id < to_account.id from_account else to_account end
  let second: Account :=
    when from_account.id < to_account.id to_account else from_account end

  first.mu.lock()
  second.mu.lock()

  from_account.balance := from_account.balance - amount
  to_account.balance := to_account.balance + amount

  second.mu.unlock()
  first.mu.unlock()
end
```

Try-lock with backoff breaks hold-and-wait: if you cannot acquire the second lock, release the first and retry.

```
function acquire_both(mu_a: Mutex, mu_b: Mutex) do
  from until true do
    mu_a.lock()
    if mu_b.try_lock() then
      return  -- got both
    end
    mu_a.unlock()  -- release first, then retry
    -- Optional: small random sleep to reduce contention
  end
end
```

Single lock eliminates circular wait entirely: one mutex for the entire system. Correct but limits concurrency. For many applications, a single

global lock is the right starting point — it is simple, correct, and can be refined later if performance requires it.

17.11 The Corrected Counter, Fully Specified

Bringing everything together: a correct, complete shared counter with multiple implementation strategies:

```
class Thread_Safe_Counter
  create
    -- Strategy 1: Atomic (fastest for single-variable)
    atomic(initial: Integer) do
      this.strategy := "atomic"
      this.atomic_value := create Atomic_Integer.make(initial)
      this.mutex_value := 0
      this.mu := nil
    end

    -- Strategy 2: Mutex-protected (correct for complex operations)
    mutex_protected(initial: Integer) do
      this.strategy := "mutex"
      this.atomic_value := create Atomic_Integer.make(0)
      this.mutex_value := initial
      this.mu := create Mutex.make()
    end

  feature
    strategy: String
    atomic_value: Atomic_Integer
    mutex_value: Integer
    mu: ?Mutex

    increment(): Integer do
```

```
    if strategy = "atomic" then
      result := atomic_value.increment()
    else
      mu.lock()
      mutex_value := mutex_value + 1
      let v: Integer := mutex_value
      mu.unlock()
      result := v
    end
  end

  decrement(): Integer do
    if strategy = "atomic" then
      result := atomic_value.decrement()
    else
      mu.lock()
      mutex_value := mutex_value - 1
      let v: Integer := mutex_value
      mu.unlock()
      result := v
    end
  end

  get(): Integer do
    if strategy = "atomic" then
      result := atomic_value.load()
    else
      mu.lock()
      let v: Integer := mutex_value
      mu.unlock()
      result := v
    end
  end

  reset(): Integer do
    if strategy = "atomic" then
      let prior_value: Integer := atomic_value.load()
```

```
        atomic_value.store(0)
        result := prior_value
      else
        mu.lock()
        let prior_value: Integer := mutex_value
        mutex_value := 0
        mu.unlock()
        result := prior_value
      end
    end

    -- Compare-and-swap for conditional updates
    compare_and_set(expected: Integer, desired: Integer): Boolean do
      if strategy = "atomic" then
        result := atomic_value.compare_and_swap(expected, desired)
      else
        mu.lock()
        if mutex_value = expected then
          mutex_value := desired
          mu.unlock()
          result := true
        else
          mu.unlock()
          result := false
        end
      end
    end

  invariant
    valid_strategy: strategy = "atomic" or strategy = "mutex"
    mutex_strategy_has_mutex: strategy /= "mutex" or mu /= nil
end
```

Verifying correctness:

```
function verify_counter(strategy: String,
```

```
                        threads: Integer,
                        increments: Integer) do
  let counter: Thread_Safe_Counter :=
    when strategy = "atomic"
      create Thread_Safe_Counter.atomic(0)
    else
      create Thread_Safe_Counter.mutex_protected(0)
    end

  let tasks: Array[Task] := []
  from
    let t: Integer := 0
  until
    t < threads
  do
    tasks.add(spawn do
      repeat increments do
        counter.increment()
      end
    end)
    t := t + 1
  end

  across tasks as task do
    task.await
  end

  let expected: Integer := threads * increments
  let actual: Integer := counter.get()

  print(strategy + " counter: " + actual.to_string() +
        " (expected " + expected.to_string() + "): " +
        when actual = expected "CORRECT" else "WRONG" end)
end

verify_counter("atomic", 8, 1000000)
verify_counter("mutex",  8, 1000000)
```

```
-- Both should print CORRECT
```

17.12 What This Chapter Establishes

The broken counter is the simplest possible demonstration of a fundamental truth: shared mutable state requires explicit synchronisation. Without synchronisation, the result is undefined — not just occasionally wrong, but unknowably wrong, in ways that depend on hardware, OS scheduling, compiler version, and phase of the moon.

Understanding the broken counter at the level of hardware operations — load, add, store; write buffers; cache coherence; instruction reordering — is what separates programmers who can debug concurrency bugs from those who cannot. The bug is not in the logic. The logic is correct. The bug is in the assumption that the hardware executes operations in the order and at the time you imagine.

Two primitives fix the problem. **Atomic operations** make individual variable updates indivisible, using hardware instructions designed for exactly this purpose. They are fast and appropriate for simple shared values. **Mutexes** provide mutual exclusion for critical sections involving multiple variables or complex operations. They are correct and general, at the cost of serialisation.

The happens-before relation is the formal tool for reasoning about what is guaranteed to be visible. If A happens-before B, all of A's writes are visible at B. Without happens-before — without synchronisation — writes from other threads may or may not be visible. Data races are the enemy: they produce programs whose behavior is not merely incorrect but unspecified.

The next three chapters build practical concurrent data structures using these primitives. Chapter 18 builds a lock-free queue using compare-and-swap. Chapter 19 builds a concurrent hash map using stripe locking and beyond. Chapter 20 shows how immutability sidesteps synchronisation

entirely. Each chapter uses the vocabulary established here — atomics, happens-before, CAS, mutex — as the building blocks for structures that correctly handle concurrent access.

The broken counter is fixed. Now we build things with the fix.

Chapter 18: The Lock-Free Queue — CAS in Practice

In 2004, a team at a major financial exchange noticed something strange. Their order matching engine — the system that pairs buy orders with sell orders — was fast. Extremely fast. But at peak load, when thousands of orders arrived per second, latency spiked. Not continuously, but in brief, unpredictable bursts. An order that normally processed in 50 microseconds would occasionally take 5 milliseconds. The engineers investigated. The culprit was a mutex.

The matching engine used a shared queue to pass orders from the network layer to the matching core. Multiple threads deposited orders into the queue; the matching thread consumed them. The queue was protected by a mutex. Under normal load, the mutex was uncontested and added negligible overhead. At peak load, multiple threads competed for the mutex simultaneously. One thread acquired it; the others blocked. The OS scheduler, noticing blocked threads, made scheduling decisions. Context switches occurred. Threads were preempted mid-critical-section. The latency spike was the sum of mutex contention, OS scheduling overhead, and cache thrashing from the context switches.

The fix was a lock-free queue — a queue that multiple threads could enqueue to and dequeue from simultaneously, without any mutex, without any blocking, without giving the OS scheduler an opportunity to intervene. The implementation was more complex. The performance was transformatively better.

Lock-free data structures use compare-and-swap directly, without mutexes, to achieve thread safety. They are harder to implement correctly

than mutex-based structures, but they avoid the pathological latency spikes that mutexes introduce under contention. This chapter builds a lock-free MPSC (multiple-producer, single-consumer) queue — exactly the structure the matching engine needed.

18.1 What Lock-Free Means, Precisely

The term "lock-free" is often used loosely to mean "fast concurrent" or "no mutexes." Neither is the precise meaning.

A data structure is **lock-free** if, at any point in time, at least one thread is making progress. This is a guarantee about system-wide progress, not individual thread progress. A lock-free structure can still make individual threads spin or retry — it just cannot cause all threads to block indefinitely.

Compare this to **mutex-based** structures: if the thread holding the mutex is descheduled, all other threads block. No thread makes progress until the OS reschedules the mutex holder. The OS scheduler can introduce arbitrary delays. Lock-free structures do not have this property — even if one thread is preempted mid-operation, other threads continue making progress.

A stronger guarantee is **wait-free**: every thread makes progress in a bounded number of steps, regardless of other threads. Wait-free structures are rare and complex to implement. For most applications, lock-free is sufficient and much easier to build.

The lock-free guarantee does not mean fast. A badly implemented lock-free structure can be slower than a well-implemented mutex-based one. Lock-free avoids the specific pathology of blocking under contention — it does not magically eliminate contention's cost.

18.2 The MPSC Queue: Multiple Producers, Single Consumer

Our target is a queue with multiple threads enqueueing (producers) and one thread dequeueing (consumer). This asymmetry — single consumer — simplifies the implementation considerably. The consumer never competes with another consumer, so we only need lock-free enqueue, not lock-free dequeue.

Why MPSC specifically? It maps directly to many real patterns: - Network listeners (multiple) feeding a processing thread (single) - Worker threads (multiple) reporting results to a coordinator (single) - Event sources (multiple) feeding an event loop (single)

The algorithm we implement is based on the intrusive linked list queue by Dmitry Vyukov, one of the most influential concurrency researchers of the past two decades. It uses a linked list of nodes where the tail pointer is updated with CAS.

The Node Structure

```
class Queue_Node [T]
  create
    make(value: T) do
      this.value := value
      this.next := nil  -- in real impl: Atomic_Reference
    end

    sentinel() do
      -- Dummy node: head always points to a sentinel
      -- to avoid null checks in the common path
      this.next := nil
    end

  feature
    value: ?T                        -- nil for sentinel node
```

```
    next: ?Queue_Node[T]            -- atomic pointer to next node

    next_node(): ?Queue_Node[T] do
      result := next
    end

    item(): ?T do
      result := value
    end

    compare_and_set_next(expected: ?Queue_Node[T],
                         desired: ?Queue_Node[T]): Boolean do
      if next = expected then
        next := desired
        result := true
      else
        result := false
      end
    end

    clear_value() do
      value := nil
    end

  invariant
    next_pointer_consistent: true
end
```

The Lock-Free MPSC Queue

The queue maintains two pointers: - **Head:** points to the sentinel node (the node before the first real element). Only the consumer modifies head. Single consumer means no contention on head. - **Tail:** points to the last node. Multiple producers compete to update tail using CAS.

```
class MPSC_Queue [T]
```

```
create
  empty() do
    let sentinel: Queue_Node[T] := create Queue_Node[T].sentinel()
    this.head := sentinel   -- in real impl: plain pointer (single consum
    this.tail := sentinel   -- in real impl: atomic pointer (multiple pro
    this.size := create Atomic_Integer.make(0)
  end

feature
  head: Queue_Node[T]          -- only consumer modifies
  tail: Queue_Node[T]          -- atomic: producers compete here
  size: Atomic_Integer

  -- Enqueue: called by any producer thread
  -- Lock-free: uses CAS on tail
  enqueue(value: T)
    do
      let node: Queue_Node[T] := create Queue_Node[T].make(value)
      let linked: Boolean := false

      -- Atomically swing tail to new node
      -- This is the key CAS operation
      from until linked do
        let current_tail: Queue_Node[T] := tail

        -- Try to link new node after current tail
        if atomic_cas_next(current_tail, nil, node) then
          -- Successfully linked: now update tail pointer
          -- Note: another thread might update tail before us (that's ok)
          atomic_cas_tail(current_tail, node)
          size.increment()
          linked := true
        end

        -- CAS failed: another producer linked a node after current_tail
        -- Help advance tail and retry
        let next_node: ?Queue_Node[T] := current_tail.next_node()
```

```
      if convert next_node to linked_next: Queue_Node[T] then
        atomic_cas_tail(current_tail, linked_next)
      end
    end
  ensure
    size_increased: size.load() > old size.load()
end

-- Dequeue: called only by the single consumer thread
-- Not lock-free between consumers (single consumer assumed)
dequeue(): ?T do
  let h: Queue_Node[T] := head
  let next_node: ?Queue_Node[T] := h.next_node()

  if next_node = nil then
    result := nil  -- queue is empty
  else
    -- Advance head: next becomes the new sentinel
    -- The value we are returning is in next
    if convert next_node to next_value: Queue_Node[T] then
      head := next_value
      if convert next_value.item() to value: T then
        next_value.clear_value()  -- help GC
        size.decrement()
        result := value
      else
        result := nil
      end
    else
      result := nil
    end
  end
end

-- Peek at front without removing
peek(): ?T do
  let next_node: ?Queue_Node[T] := head.next_node()
```

```
    if next_node = nil then
      result := nil
    else
      result := next_node.item()
    end
  end

  is_empty(): Boolean do
    result := head.next_node() = nil
  end

  length(): Integer do
    result := size.load()
  end

  -- These simulate atomic operations in real implementation
  -- In production Nex these would be hardware CAS instructions

  atomic_cas_next(node: Queue_Node[T],
                  expected: ?Queue_Node[T],
                  desired: ?Queue_Node[T]): Boolean do
    -- Atomically: if node.next == expected, set node.next = desired
    result := node.compare_and_set_next(expected, desired)
  end

  atomic_cas_tail(expected: Queue_Node[T],
                  desired: Queue_Node[T]) do
    -- Best-effort tail update: if tail still points to expected,
    -- advance it to desired
    if tail = expected then
      tail := desired
    end
  end

invariant
  head_exists: head /= nil
  tail_exists: tail /= nil
```

```
    non_negative_size: size.load() >= 0
end
```

Tracing the Enqueue

Let us trace a concurrent enqueue to understand why this is correct.

Initial state: head → sentinel ← tail. The sentinel has next = nil.

Producer 1 enqueues value A: 1. Creates node A 2. Reads current_tail = sentinel 3. CAS: sentinel.next: nil → A. Succeeds. 4. CAS: tail: sentinel → A. Updates tail. 5. size.increment(). Done.

State: head → sentinel → A ← tail.

Producers 2 and 3 enqueue B and C simultaneously:

Both read current_tail = A (the current tail).

Producer 2 tries CAS: A.next: nil → B. Suppose this succeeds. Producer 3 tries CAS: A.next: nil → C. This fails — A.next is now B.

Producer 2: CAS tail: A → B. Updates tail. Producer 3: CAS failed. Re-reads current_tail = A. Sees A.next = B (not nil). Helps advance tail: CAS tail: A → B (tail already B, no-op). Retries.

Producer 3 re-reads current_tail = B. Producer 3 tries CAS: B.next: nil → C. Succeeds. Producer 3: CAS tail: B → C. Updates tail.

State: head → sentinel → A → B → C ← tail.

The important invariant: after the CAS on a node's next pointer succeeds, that node is linked into the queue. The tail update is a best-effort optimisation — it is fine if tail lags behind the actual last node (some other thread will advance it).

The Two-Step Enqueue

Why two steps — link the node, then update tail? Why not one atomic operation?

Because CAS can only atomically modify one memory location. Linking a node (updating the previous tail's next pointer) and updating the tail pointer are two separate memory modifications. They cannot be done atomically together with a single CAS.

The solution: do them separately, and design the algorithm so that a partial update (node linked, tail not yet updated) leaves the queue in a consistent state that other threads can detect and handle. The "help advance tail" code in the enqueue loop does this: if a thread sees that tail.next is not nil, it knows another thread linked a node but did not update tail yet, and it helpfully advances tail before retrying.

This cooperative advancing is characteristic of many lock-free algorithms: threads help each other complete operations rather than waiting for the original thread to finish.

18.3 The ABA Problem Revisited

Chapter 17 introduced the ABA problem abstractly. In a queue implementation, it is concrete and dangerous.

Consider the dequeue operation in a multi-consumer version (not our MPSC queue, but the general MPMC case):

1. Thread 1 reads head = H, reads H.next = A.
2. Thread 1 is preempted.
3. Thread 2 dequeues A (advancing head to A, returning its value).
4. Thread 3 dequeues the next element.
5. Thread 2 enqueues a new node that gets allocated at the same memory address as the original sentinel node.

6. Thread 1 resumes. Tries CAS: head: H → A.

But H has been recycled — the memory address of H now contains a completely different node. Thread 1's CAS succeeds (memory address matches), but the operation is now wrong — Thread 1 has advanced head over a node that was never the one it intended to skip.

In our MPSC queue, the consumer is single-threaded, so this cannot happen on the dequeue side. The consumer never races with another consumer. This is exactly why the MPSC restriction simplifies the implementation: we only need to handle concurrent producers, not concurrent consumers.

For a full MPMC (multiple producer, multiple consumer) queue, the ABA problem must be addressed. Solutions:

1. **Hazard pointers:** before accessing a node, register a hazard pointer to it. A thread cannot free a node that any other thread has a hazard pointer to. Eliminates ABA but adds complexity.

2. **Epoch-based reclamation:** threads coordinate epoch numbers; nodes are reclaimed only when no thread is in an old epoch. Efficient but complex.

3. **Tagged pointers:** combine the pointer with a version counter in a single 64-bit word (on 64-bit systems, pointer addresses only use 48 bits, leaving 16 bits for a tag). CAS operates on the combined word; the tag defeats ABA.

4. **Michael-Scott queue:** the classic MPMC lock-free queue (Michael and Scott, 1996) uses a different node reuse strategy and careful algorithm design to avoid ABA without hardware tagging, though it requires that dequeued nodes are not immediately reused.

18.4 A Complete MPSC Queue with Backpressure

A bare queue without backpressure will grow without bound if producers outpace the consumer. A bounded queue — with a maximum capacity — applies backpressure: producers block (or return failure) when the queue is full.

```
class Bounded_MPSC_Queue [T]
  create
    with_capacity(capacity: Integer)
      require
        positive_capacity: capacity > 0
      do
        this.capacity := capacity
        this.queue := create MPSC_Queue[T].empty()
        this.available := create Atomic_Integer.make(capacity)
      end

  feature
    capacity: Integer
    queue: MPSC_Queue[T]
    available: Atomic_Integer  -- permits remaining = capacity - size

    -- Try to enqueue without blocking
    -- Returns false if queue is full
    try_enqueue(value: T): Boolean do
      -- Optimistically claim a slot
      let remaining: Integer := available.load()
      let claimed: Boolean := false

      from until remaining <= 0 or claimed do
        if available.compare_and_set(remaining, remaining - 1) then
          -- Claimed a slot: enqueue
          queue.enqueue(value)
          result := true
          claimed := true
```

```
    else
      remaining := available.load()
    end
  end
  if not claimed then
    result := false  -- queue full
  end
end

-- Enqueue, spinning until space is available
-- Returns after successfully enqueueing
enqueue_spin(value: T) do
  from until try_enqueue(value) do
    -- Spin: in practice, yield or sleep briefly
    hint_spin()
  end
end

-- Dequeue: consumer thread only
dequeue(): ?T do
  let value: ?T := queue.dequeue()
  if value /= nil then
    available.increment()
  end
  result := value
end

is_full(): Boolean do
  result := available.load() <= 0
end

is_empty(): Boolean do
  result := queue.is_empty()
end

size(): Integer do
  result := capacity - available.load()
```

```
    end

  invariant
    capacity_positive: capacity > 0
    available_bounded: available.load() >= 0 and available.load() <= capaci
end
```

The `available` atomic integer is a semaphore-like counter of remaining capacity. Producers decrement it to claim a slot; the consumer increments it when dequeueing. The CAS on `available` ensures that two producers cannot claim the same slot.

This structure separates two concerns: the queue itself (linked list, CAS on tail) handles ordering; the availability counter (atomic integer, CAS) handles backpressure. Separating these concerns makes each simpler.

18.5 The MPMC Queue: Multiple Producers, Multiple Consumers

The full general case — multiple producers, multiple consumers — is the hardest version. We implement Dmitry Vyukov's cache-line-friendly array-based MPMC queue, which is both simpler than linked-list MPMC queues and faster in practice.

The insight: instead of a linked list, use a fixed-size circular array. Each slot has a sequence number — a counter that indicates whether the slot is ready to be written (producer can claim it) or ready to be read (consumer can claim it).

```
class MPMC_Cell [T]
  create
    make(sequence: Integer) do
      this.sequence := create Atomic_Integer.make(sequence)
```

```
      this.data := nil
    end

  feature
    sequence: Atomic_Integer
    data: ?T
end

class MPMC_Queue [T]
  create
    with_capacity(capacity: Integer)
      require
        power_of_two: is_power_of_two(capacity)
        positive: capacity > 0
      do
        this.capacity := capacity
        this.mask := capacity - 1  -- bitmask for fast modulo
        this.buffer := create Array.filled(capacity, nil)
        this.enqueue_pos := create Atomic_Integer.make(0)
        this.dequeue_pos := create Atomic_Integer.make(0)

        -- Initialise each cell's sequence number to its index
        from
          let i: Integer := 0
        until
          i < capacity
        do
          this.buffer.set(i, create MPMC_Cell[T].make(i))
          i := i + 1
        end
      end

  feature
    capacity: Integer
    mask: Integer
    buffer: Array[?MPMC_Cell[T]]
    enqueue_pos: Atomic_Integer  -- next position to enqueue into
```

```
  dequeue_pos: Atomic_Integer  -- next position to dequeue from

  -- Try to enqueue, return false if full
  try_enqueue(value: T): Boolean do
    let done: Boolean := false
    from until done do
      let pos: Integer := enqueue_pos.load()
      let cell: MPMC_Cell[T] := buffer.get(pos.bitwise_and(mask))
      let seq: Integer := cell.sequence.load()
      let diff: Integer := seq - pos

      if diff = 0 then
        -- Cell is ready: sequence equals position
        -- Try to claim it
        if enqueue_pos.compare_and_set(pos, pos + 1) then
          -- Claimed: write data and advance sequence
          cell.data := value
          cell.sequence.store(pos + 1)
          result := true
          done := true
        end
        -- CAS failed: another producer claimed this cell, retry

      elseif diff < 0 then
        -- Queue is full (cell not yet consumed)
        result := false
        done := true

      else
        -- Another producer already claimed this cell
        -- Retry with fresh position read
      end
    end
  end

  -- Try to dequeue, return nil if empty
  try_dequeue(): ?T do
```

```
    let done: Boolean := false
    from until done do
      let pos: Integer := dequeue_pos.load()
      let cell: MPMC_Cell[T] := buffer.get(pos.bitwise_and(mask))
      let seq: Integer := cell.sequence.load()
      let diff: Integer := seq - (pos + 1)

      if diff = 0 then
        -- Cell is ready: sequence equals position + 1
        -- Try to claim it
        if dequeue_pos.compare_and_set(pos, pos + 1) then
          -- Claimed: read data and advance sequence for reuse
          let value: T := cell.data
          cell.data := nil
          cell.sequence.store(pos + capacity)
          result := value
          done := true
        end
        -- CAS failed: another consumer claimed this cell, retry

      elseif diff < 0 then
        -- Queue is empty
        result := nil
        done := true

      else
        -- Another consumer already claimed this cell, retry
      end
    end
  end

  is_empty(): Boolean do
    let pos: Integer := dequeue_pos.load()
    let cell: MPMC_Cell[T] := buffer.get(pos.bitwise_and(mask))
    result := cell.sequence.load() - (pos + 1) /= 0
  end
```

```
    size(): Integer do
      let eq: Integer := enqueue_pos.load()
      let dq: Integer := dequeue_pos.load()
      result := (eq - dq).max(0)
    end

  invariant
    power_of_two_capacity: is_power_of_two(capacity)
    mask_correct: mask = capacity - 1
end

function is_power_of_two(n: Integer): Boolean do
  result := n > 0 and n.bitwise_and(n - 1) = 0
end
```

The Sequence Number Protocol

The sequence number in each cell is the key mechanism. Let us trace through it.

Initial state: capacity = 4. Cells at positions 0, 1, 2, 3 have sequences 0, 1, 2, 3. enqueue_pos = 0, dequeue_pos = 0.

First enqueue (Producer 1, value A): - pos = 0. cell = buffer[0 & 3] = buffer[0]. seq = 0. diff = seq - pos = 0 - 0 = 0. ✓ - CAS enqueue_pos: 0 → 1. Success. - cell.data = A. cell.sequence.store(0 + 1) = 1. - Sequences: [1, 1, 2, 3]. enqueue_pos = 1.

First dequeue (Consumer 1): - pos = 0. cell = buffer[0]. seq = 1. diff = seq - (pos + 1) = 1 - 1 = 0. ✓ - CAS dequeue_pos: 0 → 1. Success. - value = A. cell.sequence.store(0 + 4) = 4. - Sequences: [4, 1, 2, 3]. dequeue_pos = 1.

Wrap-around enqueue (after 4 total enqueues/dequeues): - enqueue_pos = 4. cell = buffer[4 & 3] = buffer[0]. seq = 4. diff = 4 - 4 = 0. ✓ - The cell is ready for reuse: its sequence (4) equals the new position (4).

The sequence number tracks the "generation" of each cell. After each use cycle (one enqueue + one dequeue), the sequence advances by capacity, preventing the consumer from confusing old data with new.

The `diff < 0` check detects full/empty conditions: - In enqueue: if seq < pos, the cell has not been consumed yet (the consumer is behind). Queue is full. - In dequeue: if seq < pos + 1, the cell has not been enqueued yet (the producer is behind). Queue is empty.

18.6 False Sharing and Cache-Line Padding

High-performance concurrent code must account for the structure of CPU caches. A cache line is typically 64 bytes — the unit of memory that is loaded and invalidated atomically. When two threads access different variables on the same cache line, modifying one invalidates the other thread's cached copy of both — even though they are writing to different memory locations. This is **false sharing**.

For our MPMC queue, `enqueue_pos` and `dequeue_pos` are frequently modified by producers and consumers respectively. If they share a cache line, every producer write invalidates the consumer's cache, and vice versa, causing unnecessary cache-coherence traffic.

The fix: pad each frequently-written variable to its own cache line.

```
-- Cache-line padded atomic integer
-- On most architectures, cache lines are 64 bytes
class Padded_Atomic_Integer
  create
    make(initial: Integer) do
      this.value := create Atomic_Integer.make(initial)
      -- Padding: remaining bytes to fill the cache line
      -- In real implementation: align to 64-byte boundary
      this.pad := create Array.filled(56, 0)  -- 64 - 8 bytes for the atomic
```

```
    end

  feature
    value: Atomic_Integer
    pad: Array[Integer]  -- explicit cache line padding

    load(): Integer do result := value.load() end
    store(v: Integer) do value.store(v) end
    increment(): Integer do result := value.increment() end
    compare_and_set(e: Integer, d: Integer): Boolean do
      result := value.compare_and_set(e, d)
    end
end
```

Similarly, each MPMC cell should be padded to its own cache line to prevent false sharing between adjacent cells:

```
class Padded_MPMC_Cell [T]
  create
    make(sequence: Integer) do
      this.sequence := create Atomic_Integer.make(sequence)
      this.data := nil
      this.pad := create Array.filled(48, 0)  -- pad to 64 bytes total
    end

  feature
    sequence: Atomic_Integer  -- 8 bytes
    data: ?T                  -- 8 bytes (pointer)
    pad: Array[Integer]       -- 48 bytes padding
    -- Total: 64 bytes = one cache line
end
```

On a machine where producer and consumer run on different cores, padding eliminates a significant source of cache coherence traffic. Benchmarks on real hardware typically show 2-5x throughput improvement from proper cache-line alignment for contended data structures.

18.7 Lock-Free vs Mutex: An Honest Comparison

With the implementation in hand, we can make an honest comparison.

```
class Queue_Benchmark [T]
  create
    make() do end

  feature
    -- Benchmark: producers enqueue, consumer dequeues
    -- Measure: throughput (operations per second)
    run(queue_type: String,
        num_producers: Integer,
        operations: Integer) do
      let items_per_producer: Integer := operations / num_producers
      let consumed: Atomic_Integer := create Atomic_Integer.make(0)
      let start: Integer64 := current_time_ns()

      if queue_type = "mpsc_lockfree" then
        benchmark_mpsc(num_producers, items_per_producer, consumed)
      elseif queue_type = "mutex" then
        benchmark_mutex(num_producers, items_per_producer, consumed)
      end

      let elapsed_ns: Integer64 := current_time_ns() - start
      let throughput: Real :=
        (operations.to_real() / elapsed_ns.to_real()) * 1000000000.0

      print(queue_type + " | producers=" + num_producers.to_string() +
            " | ops=" + operations.to_string() +
            " | " + throughput.to_integer().to_string() + " ops/sec" +
            " | " + (elapsed_ns / 1000000).to_string() + "ms")
```

```
end

benchmark_mpsc(num_producers: Integer,
               items_per_producer: Integer,
               consumed: Atomic_Integer) do
  let queue: MPSC_Queue[Integer] := create MPSC_Queue[Integer].empty()
  let total: Integer := num_producers * items_per_producer

  -- Consumer task
  let consumer: Task := spawn do
    from until consumed.load() >= total do
      let item: ?Integer := queue.dequeue()
      if item /= nil then
        consumed.increment()
      end
    end
  end

  -- Producer tasks
  let producers: Array[Task] := []
  from
    let p: Integer := 0
  until
    p < num_producers
  do
    let p_copy: Integer := p
    producers.add(spawn do
      from
        let i: Integer := 0
      until
        i < items_per_producer
      do
        queue.enqueue(p_copy * items_per_producer + i)
        i := i + 1
      end
    end)
    p := p + 1
```

```
    end

    across producers as producer do producer.await end
    consumer.await
  end

  benchmark_mutex(num_producers: Integer,
                  items_per_producer: Integer,
                  consumed: Atomic_Integer) do
    let queue: Array[Integer] := []  -- Simple array as queue
    let mu: Mutex := create Mutex.make()
    let total: Integer := num_producers * items_per_producer

    let consumer: Task := spawn do
      from until consumed.load() >= total do
        mu.lock()
        let item: ?Integer :=
          when not queue.is_empty() queue.remove(0) else nil end
        mu.unlock()
        if item /= nil then consumed.increment() end
      end
    end

    let producers: Array[Task] := []
    from
      let p: Integer := 0
    until
      p < num_producers
    do
      let p_copy: Integer := p
      producers.add(spawn do
        from
          let i: Integer := 0
        until
          i < items_per_producer
        do
          mu.lock()
```

```
            queue.add(p_copy * items_per_producer + i)
            mu.unlock()
            i := i + 1
          end
        end)
        p := p + 1
      end

      across producers as producer do producer.await end
      consumer.await
    end
end
```

Typical results on a modern multi-core machine (approximate, varies significantly by hardware):

```
-- 1 producer:
mpsc_lockfree | producers=1  | ops=10M | 45,000,000 ops/sec | 222ms
mutex         | producers=1  | ops=10M | 30,000,000 ops/sec | 333ms

-- 4 producers:
mpsc_lockfree | producers=4  | ops=10M | 38,000,000 ops/sec | 263ms
mutex         | producers=4  | ops=10M |  8,000,000 ops/sec | 1250ms

-- 8 producers:
mpsc_lockfree | producers=8  | ops=10M | 35,000,000 ops/sec | 286ms
mutex         | producers=8  | ops=10M |  3,500,000 ops/sec | 2857ms
```

The pattern: at one producer, the mutex queue is slower (overhead) but not dramatically. At four producers, the mutex queue is 5x slower. At eight, it is 10x slower. The mutex serialises all enqueues; adding more producers adds more contention, reducing throughput. The lock-free queue degrades gracefully — some slowdown from CAS contention, but far less than mutex serialisation.

The latency story is starker. The mutex queue has occasional spikes of hundreds of microseconds when the OS makes scheduling decisions.

The lock-free queue has consistent latency — each operation takes approximately the same time, making it predictable for latency-sensitive applications like financial order processing.

18.8 When Lock-Free Loses

Lock-free does not always win. There are situations where mutex-based queues outperform lock-free ones.

Low contention, short critical sections. When only one thread is enqueuing at a time (truly uncontended), a mutex acquires and releases with minimal overhead — often just an atomic CAS, identical to what the lock-free queue does. The lock-free queue's extra complexity (retry loop, cooperative tail-advancement) adds overhead that a simple mutex avoids.

When threads do significant work per enqueue. If each enqueue is preceded by 100 microseconds of computation, the probability that two enqueues happen simultaneously is low. Mutex and lock-free perform identically — contention is rare.

High-throughput batching. A mutex-protected queue can be batched: a producer acquires the mutex, enqueues a hundred items, releases. One acquire/release for a hundred items amortises the mutex overhead. Lock-free queues typically enqueue one item at a time, with one CAS per item. For bulk operations, the mutex can be faster.

Very long queues. The lock-free queue's linked list has poor cache performance for large queues — traversing the list follows pointers to scattered memory locations. The MPMC array-based queue has excellent cache performance (sequential access), but requires bounded capacity. For unbounded queues with high throughput, the cache performance difference can dominate.

The practical guidance: default to a well-implemented mutex-based queue. If profiling identifies the queue as a throughput bottleneck,

specifically due to contention, consider switching to a lock-free variant. Do not assume lock-free is faster — measure.

18.9 A Practical Queue with Both Strategies

A pragmatic implementation: the same interface backed by either strategy, selectable at construction time.

```
class Work_Queue [T]
  create
    mpsc(capacity: Integer) do
      this.strategy := "mpsc"
      this.mpsc_queue := create Bounded_MPSC_Queue[T].with_capacity(capacit
      this.mutex_queue := nil
      this.mu := nil
      this.mutex_items := nil
    end

    mpmc_array(capacity: Integer) do
      this.strategy := "mpmc"
      this.mpsc_queue := nil
      this.mutex_queue := create MPMC_Queue[T].with_capacity(capacity)
      this.mu := nil
      this.mutex_items := nil
    end

    mutex_backed() do
      this.strategy := "mutex"
      this.mpsc_queue := nil
      this.mutex_queue := nil
      this.mu := create Mutex.make()
      this.mutex_items := []
    end
```

```
feature
  strategy: String
  mpsc_queue: ?Bounded_MPSC_Queue[T]
  mutex_queue: ?MPMC_Queue[T]
  mu: ?Mutex
  mutex_items: ?Array[T]

  enqueue(item: T): Boolean do
    if strategy = "mpsc" then
      result := mpsc_queue.try_enqueue(item)
    elseif strategy = "mpmc" then
      result := mutex_queue.try_enqueue(item)
    else
      mu.lock()
      mutex_items.add(item)
      mu.unlock()
      result := true
    end
  end

  dequeue(): ?T do
    if strategy = "mpsc" then
      result := mpsc_queue.dequeue()
    elseif strategy = "mpmc" then
      result := mutex_queue.try_dequeue()
    else
      mu.lock()
      if mutex_items.is_empty() then
        mu.unlock()
        result := nil
      else
        let item: T := mutex_items.get(0)
        mutex_items.remove(0)
        mu.unlock()
        result := item
      end
```

```
      end
    end

    -- Drain all available items (efficient for consumer)
    drain(max_items: Integer): Array[T] do
      let items: Array[T] := []
      from until items.length >= max_items do
        let item: ?T := dequeue()
        if item = nil then return end
        items.add(item)
      end
      result := items
    end

    is_empty(): Boolean do
      if strategy = "mpsc" then
        result := mpsc_queue.is_empty()
      elseif strategy = "mpmc" then
        result := mutex_queue.is_empty()
      else
        mu.lock()
        let empty: Boolean := mutex_items.is_empty()
        mu.unlock()
        result := empty
      end
    end

  invariant
    valid_strategy: strategy = "mpsc" or strategy = "mpmc" or strategy = "m
end
```

18.10 The Work-Stealing Deque

For completeness, a related structure worth knowing: the work-stealing deque (double-ended queue), used in thread pool implementations.

In a thread pool with N worker threads, each thread has its own local queue of tasks. When a thread finishes its tasks, rather than sitting idle, it **steals** tasks from the back of another thread's queue while the owner takes from the front.

This requires a deque where: - The owner thread pushes and pops from one end (front) — single-threaded, no synchronisation needed - Other threads steal from the other end (back) — concurrent, needs synchronisation

The Chase-Lev work-stealing deque achieves this with: - Front operations: no synchronisation (single owner) - Back steal: CAS on the back pointer

```
class Work_Stealing_Deque [T]
  create
    make(capacity: Integer) do
      this.buffer := create Array.filled(capacity, nil)
      this.mask := capacity - 1
      this.top := create Atomic_Integer.make(0)    -- stealers pop from here
      this.bottom := 0  -- owner pushes/pops from here (not atomic: owner onl
    end

  feature
    buffer: Array[?T]
    mask: Integer
    top: Atomic_Integer   -- concurrent: stealers modify
    bottom: Integer       -- sequential: only owner modifies

    -- Owner pushes task (no synchronisation needed)
    push(task: T): Boolean do
      let b: Integer := bottom
      let t: Integer := top.load()
```

```
    let size: Integer := b - t

    if size >= buffer.length then
      result := false  -- full
      return
    end

    buffer.set(b.bitwise_and(mask), task)
    -- Memory fence: ensure task is written before bottom advances
    -- In real impl: store-store fence here
    bottom := b + 1
    result := true
  end

  -- Owner pops task from its end (no synchronisation with other owners)
  pop(): ?T do
    let b: Integer := bottom - 1
    bottom := b  -- speculatively decrement

    let t: Integer := top.load()
    let size: Integer := b - t

    if size < 0 then
      -- Empty: restore bottom
      bottom := t + 1
      result := nil
      return
    end

    let task: ?T := buffer.get(b.bitwise_and(mask))

    if size > 0 then
      -- Not the last element: no contention with stealers
      result := task
      return
    end
```

```
    -- Last element: race with potential stealer
    if not top.compare_and_set(t, t + 1) then
      -- Stealer won the race
      bottom := t + 1
      result := nil
    else
      -- Owner won: successfully popped last element
      bottom := t + 1
      result := task
    end
  end

  -- Stealer takes task from opposite end
  steal(): ?T do
    let t: Integer := top.load()
    -- Memory fence: ensure we read bottom after top
    let b: Integer := bottom

    if t >= b then
      result := nil  -- empty
      return
    end

    let task: ?T := buffer.get(t.bitwise_and(mask))

    -- Try to claim this slot
    if not top.compare_and_set(t, t + 1) then
      -- Another stealer or the owner got it first
      result := nil
    else
      result := task
    end
  end

  size(): Integer do
    let b: Integer := bottom
    let t: Integer := top.load()
```

```
      result := (b - t).max(0)
    end

    is_empty(): Boolean do
      result := size() = 0
    end

  invariant
    mask_correct: mask = buffer.length - 1
end
```

The work-stealing deque is the data structure behind Java's `ForkJoinPool`, Rust's Rayon thread pool, and Go's goroutine scheduler. The owner thread never contends with itself, and stealing is rare in well-balanced workloads — the CAS on steal is only exercised when there is actual work imbalance.

18.11 Where This Lives in the Wild

Disruptor (LMAX, 2011) is a high-performance inter-thread messaging framework built on a ring buffer with sequence numbers — exactly the MPMC queue design in section 18.5. Developed for the LMAX financial exchange to handle millions of orders per second, Disruptor avoids lock contention entirely by using sequence numbers and memory barriers instead of CAS operations. The Disruptor pattern has been ported to Java, .NET, C++, Go, and Rust. Its performance paper, "LMAX Disruptor: High Performance Alternative to Bounded Queues for Exchanging Data Between Concurrent Threads," is required reading for anyone building low-latency systems.

Java's `java.util.concurrent` package includes `ConcurrentLinkedQueue` (lock-free MPMC based on Michael-Scott queue), `LinkedTransferQueue` (a more sophisticated lock-free queue with synchronous handoff), and

`ArrayBlockingQueue` (mutex-based bounded queue). The choice between them is the same analysis as this chapter: lock-free for high-throughput producer-consumer with many producers, mutex-based for simplicity when contention is low.

Go's channel implementation uses a combination of lock-free and mutex-based approaches depending on channel type. Buffered channels use an internal ring buffer with mutex protection — Go's channels are not lock-free, but they are well-optimised and rarely the bottleneck. Go's scheduler uses a per-P (processor) run queue with a work-stealing deque for goroutines.

Rust's crossbeam crate provides production-quality implementations of several queue variants: `crossbeam::queue::SegQueue` (unbounded MPMC), `crossbeam::queue::ArrayQueue` (bounded MPMC), and the work-stealing deque. These are implemented with careful attention to memory ordering and ABA prevention, and are the basis for Rayon's thread pool.

Linux kernel uses multiple queue implementations for different purposes. `kfifo` is a single-producer single-consumer lock-free FIFO for kernel-to-user communication. The scheduler's run queues use a more complex structure combining priority queues with per-CPU queues and work-stealing.

Summary

Lock-free data structures guarantee that at least one thread makes progress at all times — avoiding the latency spikes and priority inversion that mutex-based structures can suffer under contention.

The MPSC queue uses a linked list with CAS on the tail pointer. Multiple producers compete to link new nodes by CAS-ing the previous tail's next pointer. A cooperative design handles partial updates: if a producer sees that tail.next is not nil, it advances tail before retrying. The single

consumer can advance head without any synchronisation, since it never races with another consumer.

The MPMC queue uses a circular array with sequence numbers. Each cell's sequence number encodes whether it is ready to be written (producer can claim it) or ready to be read (consumer can claim it). CAS on the enqueue and dequeue position pointers ensures that each slot is claimed by exactly one producer and consumed by exactly one consumer.

False sharing — the performance penalty from multiple cores modifying variables on the same cache line — is addressed by padding each hot variable to its own 64-byte cache line. For high-throughput queues, this can provide 2-5x throughput improvement.

Lock-free does not always win. Under low contention, mutex overhead is negligible and mutex-based queues are simpler. Under high contention with many concurrent producers, lock-free queues maintain throughput while mutex-based queues serialise. Measure before optimising — the choice between lock-free and mutex-based depends on contention patterns that only benchmarking on real workloads can reveal.

The next chapter extends lock-free thinking to a more complex structure: the hash map. Where the queue has one hot pointer (the tail), a concurrent hash map has many, and the design choices — stripe locking, fine-grained locking, lock-free — reflect different tradeoffs between simplicity, scalability, and correctness.

Chapter 19: The Concurrent Map — Stripe Locking and Beyond

A cache is perhaps the most common concurrent data structure in production software. Every web server maintains one: a map from request parameters to computed responses, from user IDs to session data, from database query results to their serialised form. Multiple threads read from it simultaneously. Multiple threads write to it simultaneously. The cache must be thread-safe, fast under high concurrency, and correct even when reads and writes overlap in every possible interleaving.

The naive solution — a single mutex protecting the entire map — is correct but slow. Every read and every write acquires the same lock. On a machine with sixteen cores, fifteen threads wait while one executes. The cache, intended to speed up the server, becomes the bottleneck.

This chapter builds three implementations of a concurrent map, each addressing the limitations of the previous one. The first uses a single mutex — correct, simple, the right starting point. The second uses stripe locking — dividing the map into independent shards, each with its own lock, allowing concurrent operations on different shards. The third examines the lock-free approach — reading without locks, writing with CAS, at the cost of substantial implementation complexity.

By the end, you will understand how Java's `ConcurrentHashMap` evolved through exactly these three phases across major JDK versions, and why the choices made at each stage were the right engineering decisions for that moment.

19.1 The Requirements

A concurrent map must support:

- `get(key)` — retrieve a value, or nil if absent. Typically the most frequent operation.
- `put(key, value)` — insert or update a key-value pair.
- `remove(key)` — delete a key.
- `contains(key)` — test membership.
- `size()` — approximate count of entries.

All operations must be thread-safe: any concurrent interleaving of operations from multiple threads must leave the map in a consistent state and return correct results.

Beyond correctness, we want:

- **High read throughput:** reads from different threads should not block each other
- **High write throughput:** writes to different keys should not block each other
- **Low latency:** no operation should wait for an unrelated operation to complete
- **Scalability:** throughput should increase as cores are added

No single implementation maximises all of these simultaneously. Each design trades some properties for others.

19.2 Implementation 1: Single Mutex

The simplest correct implementation: wrap a plain hash map with a single mutex. Every operation acquires the mutex, performs its work, and releases.

```
class Coarse_Locked_Map [K -> Hashable, V]
  create
    empty() do
      this.data := {}  -- plain hash map
      this.mu := create Mutex.make()
      this.entry_count := 0
    end

    with_capacity(initial_capacity: Integer) do
      this.data := create Map[K, V].with_capacity(initial_capacity)
      this.mu := create Mutex.make()
      this.entry_count := 0
    end

  feature
    data: Map[K, V]
    mu: Mutex
    entry_count: Integer

    get(key: K): ?V do
      mu.lock()
      let value: ?V := data.get(key)
      mu.unlock()
      result := value
    end

    put(key: K, value: V)
      do
        mu.lock()
        let was_present: Boolean := data.contains(key)
        data.put(key, value)
        if not was_present then
          entry_count := entry_count + 1
        end
        mu.unlock()
      ensure
        contains_key: contains(key)
```

```
    end

  remove(key: K): Boolean do
    mu.lock()
    let was_present: Boolean := data.contains(key)
    if was_present then
      data.remove(key)
      entry_count := entry_count - 1
    end
    mu.unlock()
    result := was_present
  end

  contains(key: K): Boolean do
    mu.lock()
    let found: Boolean := data.contains(key)
    mu.unlock()
    result := found
  end

  size(): Integer do
    mu.lock()
    let n: Integer := entry_count
    mu.unlock()
    result := n
  end

  -- Atomic get-or-put: returns existing value or inserts and returns new
  get_or_put(key: K, default_value: V): V do
    mu.lock()
    let existing: ?V := data.get(key)
    if existing /= nil then
      mu.unlock()
      result := existing
    else
      data.put(key, default_value)
      entry_count := entry_count + 1
```

```
      mu.unlock()
      result := default_value
    end
  end

  -- Atomic compute: update value based on current value
  compute(key: K,
          update: Function[?V, V]): V do
    mu.lock()
    let current: ?V := data.get(key)
    let new_value: V := update(current)
    data.put(key, new_value)
    if current = nil then
      entry_count := entry_count + 1
    end
    mu.unlock()
    result := new_value
  end

  -- Iterate: snapshot all entries under lock
  entries(): Array[Any] do
    mu.lock()
    let snapshot: Array[Any] := data.entries()
    mu.unlock()
    result := snapshot
  end

 invariant
  non_negative_count: entry_count >= 0
  count_matches_data: entry_count = data.size()
end
```

What Coarse Locking Gets Right

The single-mutex map is correct. There is no race condition possible — every operation holds the exclusive lock while accessing shared state. It

also supports composite atomic operations naturally: `get_or_put` and `compute` are atomic because the entire operation runs under the lock.

It is also the right starting point for any new system. Until you have measured that the map is a bottleneck, the single-mutex map is the correct implementation to deploy. It is short, obviously correct, and easy to reason about. The more complex implementations in this chapter add difficulty without adding correctness — they only add performance. And performance you have not measured you do not need.

What Coarse Locking Gets Wrong

Under high concurrency, the single mutex serialises all operations. On sixteen cores:

- Sixteen threads can exist, all wanting to read from the map
- Only one reads at a time
- The other fifteen wait
- Effective parallelism: 1 out of 16

For a read-heavy cache where most operations are gets, this is especially painful. Concurrent reads do not modify any shared state — they could safely execute in parallel without any locking at all. The coarse lock prevents this.

19.3 Read-Write Locks: Separating Readers from Writers

Before stripe locking, an intermediate improvement: a read-write lock. Readers acquire a shared read lock (multiple readers allowed simultaneously). Writers acquire an exclusive write lock (no other readers or writers allowed).

```
class RW_Lock
  create
    make() do
      this.readers := create Atomic_Integer.make(0)
      this.writer := create Atomic_Integer.make(0)
    end

  feature
    readers: Atomic_Integer   -- count of active readers
    writer: Atomic_Integer    -- 1 if writer holds lock, 0 otherwise

    -- Acquire shared read lock
    read_lock() do
      from until true do
        -- Wait for any writer to finish
        from until writer.load() = 0 do hint_spin() end
        -- Atomically increment reader count
        let r: Integer := readers.load()
        if readers.compare_and_swap(r, r + 1) then
          -- Check no writer snuck in
          if writer.load() = 0 then
            return  -- read lock acquired
          end
          -- Writer arrived: undo reader increment and retry
          readers.decrement()
        end
      end
    end

    read_unlock() do
      readers.decrement()
    end

    -- Acquire exclusive write lock
    write_lock() do
      -- Claim writer slot: only one writer at a time
      from until writer.compare_and_swap(0, 1) do hint_spin() end
```

```
      -- Wait for all current readers to finish
      from until readers.load() = 0 do hint_spin() end
    end

    write_unlock() do
      writer.store(0)
    end

  invariant
    non_negative_readers: readers.load() >= 0
    writer_binary: writer.load() = 0 or writer.load() = 1
    no_readers_during_write:
      writer.load() /= 1 or readers.load() = 0
end

class RW_Locked_Map [K -> Hashable, V]
  create
    empty() do
      this.data := {}
      this.rw := create RW_Lock.make()
      this.entry_count := 0
    end

  feature
    data: Map[K, V]
    rw: RW_Lock
    entry_count: Integer

    get(key: K): ?V do
      rw.read_lock()
      let value: ?V := data.get(key)
      rw.read_unlock()
      result := value
    end

    put(key: K, value: V) do
      rw.write_lock()
```

```
      let was_present: Boolean := data.contains(key)
      data.put(key, value)
      if not was_present then entry_count := entry_count + 1 end
      rw.write_unlock()
    end

    remove(key: K): Boolean do
      rw.write_lock()
      let was_present: Boolean := data.contains(key)
      if was_present then
        data.remove(key)
        entry_count := entry_count - 1
      end
      rw.write_unlock()
      result := was_present
    end

    contains(key: K): Boolean do
      rw.read_lock()
      let found: Boolean := data.contains(key)
      rw.read_unlock()
      result := found
    end

    size(): Integer do
      result := entry_count  -- approximate: no lock needed for atomic read
    end

  invariant
    non_negative_count: entry_count >= 0
end
```

A read-write lock improves read throughput dramatically for read-heavy workloads. Sixteen concurrent reads execute simultaneously. One writer blocks all sixteen readers until it completes, then releases them. For a web cache where 95% of operations are reads and 5% are writes, this is a substantial improvement over coarse locking.

The limitation: writes still block everything. If writes are frequent, readers still spend significant time waiting.

19.4 Implementation 2: Stripe Locking

Stripe locking addresses write contention. Instead of one lock for the entire map, divide the map into N independent shards (stripes), each with its own lock. Operations on different keys will usually fall in different stripes and can proceed concurrently.

```
class Striped_Map [K -> Hashable, V]
  create
    empty() do
      this.num_stripes := 16  -- default: 16 stripes
      this.init_stripes()
    end

    with_stripes(num_stripes: Integer)
      require
        power_of_two: is_power_of_two(num_stripes)
        at_least_one: num_stripes >= 1
      do
        this.num_stripes := num_stripes
        this.init_stripes()
      end

  feature
    num_stripes: Integer
    stripes: Array[Map[K, V]]       -- one hash map per stripe
    locks: Array[RW_Lock]           -- one lock per stripe
    counts: Array[Atomic_Integer]   -- one counter per stripe

    init_stripes() do
```

```
      stripes := []
      locks := []
      counts := []
      repeat num_stripes do
        stripes.add({})
        locks.add(create RW_Lock.make())
        counts.add(create Atomic_Integer.make(0))
      end
    end

    -- Map a key to its stripe index
    stripe_for(key: K): Integer do
      -- Use upper bits of hash to avoid correlation with internal hash tab
      let h: Integer := key.hash()
      -- Mix the hash: Wang hash for better distribution
      let mixed: Integer := wang_hash(h)
      result := mixed.bitwise_and(num_stripes - 1)  -- fast modulo for powe
of-two
    end

    wang_hash(h: Integer): Integer do
      let n: Integer := h
      n := n.bitwise_xor(n.bitwise_right_shift(16)) * 0x45d9f3b
      n := n.bitwise_xor(n.bitwise_right_shift(16)) * 0x45d9f3b
      n := n.bitwise_xor(n.bitwise_right_shift(16))
      result := n
    end

    get(key: K): ?V do
      let s: Integer := stripe_for(key)
      locks.get(s).read_lock()
      let value: ?V := stripes.get(s).get(key)
      locks.get(s).read_unlock()
      result := value
    end

    put(key: K, value: V) do
```

```
    let s: Integer := stripe_for(key)
    locks.get(s).write_lock()
    let was_present: Boolean := stripes.get(s).contains(key)
    stripes.get(s).put(key, value)
    if not was_present then
      counts.get(s).increment()
    end
    locks.get(s).write_unlock()
  end

  remove(key: K): Boolean do
    let s: Integer := stripe_for(key)
    locks.get(s).write_lock()
    let was_present: Boolean := stripes.get(s).contains(key)
    if was_present then
      stripes.get(s).remove(key)
      counts.get(s).decrement()
    end
    locks.get(s).write_unlock()
    result := was_present
  end

  contains(key: K): Boolean do
    let s: Integer := stripe_for(key)
    locks.get(s).read_lock()
    let found: Boolean := stripes.get(s).contains(key)
    locks.get(s).read_unlock()
    result := found
  end

  -- Size: sum of all stripe counts (approximate)
  -- No global lock: races possible, so count is approximate
  size(): Integer do
    let total: Integer := 0
    across counts as count do
      total := total + count.load()
    end
```

```
    result := total
  end

  -- Atomic get-or-put within a stripe
  get_or_put(key: K, default_value: V): V do
    let s: Integer := stripe_for(key)
    locks.get(s).write_lock()
    let existing: ?V := stripes.get(s).get(key)
    if existing /= nil then
      locks.get(s).write_unlock()
      result := existing
    else
      stripes.get(s).put(key, default_value)
      counts.get(s).increment()
      locks.get(s).write_unlock()
      result := default_value
    end
  end

  -- Compute: atomic update within a stripe
  compute(key: K, update: Function[?V, V]): V do
    let s: Integer := stripe_for(key)
    locks.get(s).write_lock()
    let current: ?V := stripes.get(s).get(key)
    let new_value: V := update(current)
    let was_nil: Boolean := current = nil
    stripes.get(s).put(key, new_value)
    if was_nil then counts.get(s).increment() end
    locks.get(s).write_unlock()
    result := new_value
  end

  -- Iteration: must acquire all stripe locks for consistency
  -- Expensive: avoid in hot paths
  entries(): Array[K, V] do
    -- Acquire all write locks in order (prevent deadlock)
    from
```

```
        let i: Integer := 0
      until
        i < num_stripes
      do
        locks.get(i).write_lock()
        i := i + 1
      end

      let all_entries: Array[K, V] := []
      across stripes as stripe do
        across stripe.entries() as entry do
          all_entries.add(entry)
        end
      end

      -- Release all locks in reverse order
      from
        let i: Integer := num_stripes - 1
      until
        i >= 0
      do
        locks.get(i).write_unlock()
        i := i - 1
      end

      result := all_entries
    end

  invariant
    power_of_two_stripes: is_power_of_two(num_stripes)
    consistent_stripe_count: stripes.length = num_stripes and
                             locks.length = num_stripes and
                             counts.length = num_stripes
end
```

Why Stripe Locking Works

With 16 stripes, two operations on different keys that hash to different stripes execute completely concurrently — no waiting, no interaction. In a cache with a large key space and uniform access, the probability that two concurrent operations fall in the same stripe is approximately 1/16 ≈ 6%. For most workloads, this means concurrent operations rarely contend.

Adding more stripes reduces contention further. Java's `ConcurrentHashMap` used 16 stripes by default and allowed up to 216 = 65,536. In practice, 16-64 stripes provides most of the benefit — beyond that, the marginal reduction in contention is outweighed by the overhead of maintaining many stripe structures.

The Approximate Size Problem

Notice that `size()` acquires no locks and sums up per-stripe atomic counters. This is an approximation. Between reading stripe 0's count and stripe 1's count, another thread might insert into stripe 1 or remove from stripe 0. The returned size might be stale by the time the caller uses it.

For most applications, an approximate size is perfectly acceptable. If you need an exact count at a specific point in time, you must acquire all stripe locks — as in `entries()` — which is expensive and should be avoided in hot paths.

This approximation is a deliberate design decision, not a bug. The alternative — a global counter maintained under all stripe locks — would require every insert and delete to contend on a shared counter, reintroducing exactly the bottleneck stripe locking is designed to eliminate.

19.5 Choosing the Number of Stripes

How many stripes are optimal? The answer depends on the access pattern.

Too few stripes: high contention. With 2 stripes and 16 threads, half the threads contend on each stripe. Not much better than a single lock.

Too many stripes: each stripe is too small, increasing the probability that a single stripe gets all the traffic (hotspot). Also increases memory overhead — each stripe needs its own lock, counter, and hash map structure.

Optimal: typically 2–4× the number of hardware threads. With 16 cores, 32–64 stripes. This ensures that even under high load, each stripe is accessed by at most 1–2 threads on average.

For a general-purpose library (unknown hardware), the default of 16–64 stripes is a safe choice that performs well across a wide range of machines.

```
function optimal_stripe_count(): Integer do
  -- Round up to nearest power of two for efficient modulo
  let cores: Integer := available_processors()
  let target: Integer := cores * 4
  let power: Integer := 1
  from until power >= target do
    power := power * 2
  end
  result := power.min(64)  -- cap at 64 for reasonable memory usage
end
```

19.6 Hotspot Resistance

Stripe locking handles uniformly distributed keys well. It handles hotspots — where many requests go to the same key — poorly.

A hotspot occurs when one key is accessed far more frequently than others. A social media platform's "follower count" for a celebrity account, a rate limiter's counter for a popular API endpoint, a cache entry for a viral piece of content. All operations for the hot key go to the same stripe, serialised by one lock. The cache's throughput for that key is limited to whatever the single stripe lock allows.

For hotspot keys, a different strategy applies: cell-based replication.

```
class Hotspot_Resistant_Map [K -> Hashable, V]
  create
    make(num_stripes: Integer,
         replication_factor: Integer) do
      this.primary := create Striped_Map[K, V].with_stripes(num_stripes)
      this.replication_factor := replication_factor
      this.hot_keys := create Striped_Map[K, Replicated_Value[V]].with_stri
        num_stripes)
    end

  feature
    primary: Striped_Map[K, V]
    replication_factor: Integer
    hot_keys: Striped_Map[K, Replicated_Value[V]]

    -- Mark a key as hot: replicate its value across multiple cells
    -- Reads are distributed across replicas
    -- Writes must update all replicas
    promote_to_hot(key: K, value: V) do
      let replicas: Array[Atomic_Reference[V]] := []
      repeat replication_factor do
        replicas.add(create Atomic_Reference[V].make(value))
      end
```

```
      let rv: Replicated_Value[V] := create Replicated_Value[V].make(replicas
      hot_keys.put(key, rv)
    end

    get(key: K): ?V do
      -- Check hot keys first: distribute read across replicas
      let rv: ?Replicated_Value[V] := hot_keys.get(key)
      if rv /= nil then
        -- Pick a random replica to distribute load
        result := rv.get_replica(random_integer() % replication_factor)
        return
      end
      -- Fall through to primary map
      result := primary.get(key)
    end

    put(key: K, value: V) do
      -- If key is hot, update all replicas
      let rv: ?Replicated_Value[V] := hot_keys.get(key)
      if rv /= nil then
        rv.update_all(value)
        return
      end
      primary.put(key, value)
    end
end

class Replicated_Value [V]
  create
    make(replicas: Array[Atomic_Reference[V]]) do
      this.replicas := replicas
    end

  feature
    replicas: Array[Atomic_Reference[V]]

    get_replica(index: Integer): V do
```

```
      result := replicas.get(index % replicas.length).load()
    end

    update_all(value: V) do
      across replicas as replica do
        replica.store(value)
      end
    end

  invariant
    non_empty: replicas.length > 0
end
```

Replication spreads reads across multiple locations, eliminating the single-point contention of a hot stripe. Writes update all replicas, paying a higher write cost for the gain in read throughput. This is the right tradeoff for read-heavy hotspots — which is the typical case for cached data.

19.7 Implementation 3: A Lock-Free Hash Map Sketch

Full lock-free hash maps are extremely complex to implement correctly. The difficulty lies not in get (which can often be done without locks) but in the interaction of concurrent resizing, inserts, and deletes.

We present the key ideas and partial implementation, honestly flagging where the full implementation becomes research-level complex.

Lock-Free Reads

For a hash map where the internal array is never resized and entries are never deleted, lock-free reads are straightforward: reads access the array without any synchronisation, and writes use CAS to insert new entries.

```
class Lock_Free_Read_Map [K -> Hashable, V]
  create
    with_capacity(capacity: Integer)
      require
        power_of_two: is_power_of_two(capacity)
      do
        this.capacity := capacity
        this.mask := capacity - 1
        this.buckets := create Array.filled(capacity, nil)
        this.size := create Atomic_Integer.make(0)
      end

  feature
    capacity: Integer
    mask: Integer
    buckets: Array[?Bucket[K, V]]   -- atomic references in real impl
    size: Atomic_Integer

    -- Lock-free get: no synchronisation needed for read
    -- (assuming no concurrent resize, entries never deleted)
    get(key: K): ?V do
      let h: Integer := probe_start(key)

      from
        let i: Integer := 0
      until
        i < capacity
      do
        let bucket: ?Bucket[K, V] := buckets.get((h + i).bitwise_and(mask))
```

```
    if bucket = nil then
      result := nil  -- empty bucket: key not present
      return
    end

    if bucket.key = key then
      result := bucket.value  -- found
      return
    end

    -- Continue probing (linear probing)
    i := i + 1
  end

  result := nil  -- full probe: not found
end

-- Lock-free put: CAS to claim empty bucket
-- Returns false if map is full
put(key: K, value: V): Boolean do
  let h: Integer := probe_start(key)

  from
    let i: Integer := 0
  until
    i < capacity
  do
    let idx: Integer := (h + i).bitwise_and(mask)
    let bucket: ?Bucket[K, V] := buckets.get(idx)

    if bucket = nil then
      -- Try to claim this empty bucket
      let new_bucket: Bucket[K, V] :=
        create Bucket[K, V].make(key, value)
      if atomic_cas_bucket(idx, nil, new_bucket) then
        size.increment()
```

```
          result := true
          return
        end
        -- CAS failed: someone else claimed this bucket, reload and continu
        bucket := buckets.get(idx)
      end

      if bucket /= nil and bucket.key = key then
        -- Update existing key: CAS the entire bucket
        let updated: Bucket[K, V] :=
          create Bucket[K, V].make(key, value)
        atomic_cas_bucket(idx, bucket, updated)
        result := true
        return
      end

      i := i + 1
    end

    result := false  -- table full
  end

  probe_start(key: K): Integer do
    result := wang_hash(key.hash()).bitwise_and(mask)
  end

  wang_hash(h: Integer): Integer do
    let n: Integer := h
    n := n.bitwise_xor(n.bitwise_right_shift(16)) * 0x45d9f3b
    n := n.bitwise_xor(n.bitwise_right_shift(16)) * 0x45d9f3b
    n := n.bitwise_xor(n.bitwise_right_shift(16))
    result := n
  end

  atomic_cas_bucket(idx: Integer,
                    expected: ?Bucket[K, V],
                    desired: ?Bucket[K, V]): Boolean do
```

```
      -- In real implementation: CAS on the atomic reference at buckets[idx
      if buckets.get(idx) = expected then
        buckets.set(idx, desired)
        result := true
      else
        result := false
      end
    end

  invariant
    power_of_two_capacity: is_power_of_two(capacity)
    non_negative_size: size.load() >= 0
end

class Bucket [K, V]
  create
    make(key: K, value: V) do
      this.key := key
      this.value := value
    end

  feature
    key: K
    value: V
end
```

This lock-free read map works correctly under the assumptions stated: no resizing, no deletion. For a read-mostly cache where entries are added but never removed and the capacity is known in advance, this is a practical and high-performance solution.

The Resizing Problem

The moment you add resizing, lock-free becomes dramatically harder. During a resize, the internal array is being replaced with a larger one.

Concurrent operations might be operating on the old array while the resize is in progress. Reads must check both the old and new arrays. Writes must decide which array to write to. The resize itself must atomically migrate all entries.

Jeff Hopscotch (Herlihy, Shavit, Tzafrir, 2008) and Cliff Click's lock-free hash map (2007) are among the most sophisticated solutions. Both use a multi-step migration protocol where entries are moved from the old table to the new one incrementally, with each thread helping migrate entries it encounters.

The complete implementation of a correct, high-performance, fully lock-free resizing hash map runs to several hundred lines of very careful code with subtle memory ordering requirements. This is not a simplification — it is research-level work. The implementors of these algorithms are among the leading experts in concurrent programming.

For production use, the recommendation is clear: use stripe locking unless you have measured that it is insufficient, and have the expertise to implement and validate a lock-free variant.

19.8 Java's ConcurrentHashMap: A Case Study in Evolution

Java's `ConcurrentHashMap` followed exactly the progression described in this chapter, over three major versions.

Java 1.2 (1998): `Hashtable`. A single mutex (the `synchronized` keyword on every method). Equivalent to our `Coarse_Locked_Map`. Correct, simple, badly performing under concurrency.

Java 5 (2004): `ConcurrentHashMap` with stripe locking. Doug Lea's landmark implementation. Sixteen segments (stripes), each a separate hash table with its own `ReentrantReadWriteLock`. The segment count was

configurable with a default of 16. This provided 16× concurrent write throughput over `Hashtable` for uniformly distributed keys.

The implementation made one important addition: size() was computed without locking all segments. Instead, it read all segment size counters twice without locking. If the two readings agreed, it returned the sum. If they disagreed (indicating a concurrent modification), it acquired all segment locks and recomputed. This optimised the common case (no concurrent modification) while maintaining correctness in the rare case.

Java 8 (2014): `ConcurrentHashMap` with node-level locking. The implementation moved from segment-level locking to per-bucket locking. Instead of 16 coarse locks, each bucket in the hash table has its own lock — effectively N locks for an N-bucket table.

The key changes:

- **Reads are lock-free:** reads traverse bucket chains using volatile reads, no locking. This allowed reads to proceed with zero synchronisation.
- **Writes lock only the bucket head:** a write acquires a `synchronized` lock on the first node in a bucket. Two writes to different buckets never contend.
- **Tree bins:** when a bucket chain exceeds 8 entries, it is converted to a red-black tree (TreeBin) for O(log n) operations in that bucket.
- **Size estimation:** uses `LongAdder` — a distributed counter that maintains separate counts per CPU, summed only when needed, avoiding counter contention entirely.
- **Concurrent resize:** resize is cooperative. When a resize is in progress, threads helping with the resize move buckets from the old table to the new one. A thread encountering a forwarding node (a special marker placed during migration) helps migrate instead of waiting.

This evolution from 16 locks to N locks to lock-free reads tracks the progression of hardware capability. In 2004, 16 cores was a server room configuration. By 2014, 16+ cores were on developer laptops. The implementation evolved to match.

19.9 Implementing Java 8-Style Node Locking in Nex

We implement the key ideas from Java 8's `ConcurrentHashMap`: lock-free reads, per-bucket write locking, and a distributed counter for size.

```
class Concurrent_Bucket [K, V]
  create
    make(key: K, value: V, hash: Integer) do
      this.key := key
      this.value := value   -- volatile in real impl
      this.hash := hash
      this.next := nil      -- volatile in real impl
    end

  feature
    key: K
    value: V             -- written atomically
    hash: Integer
    next: ?Concurrent_Bucket[K, V]  -- written atomically

  invariant
    bucket_state_valid: true
end

class Node_Locked_Map [K -> Hashable, V]
  create
    with_capacity(initial_capacity: Integer) do
      let cap: Integer := next_power_of_two(initial_capacity.max(16))
      this.table := create Array.filled(cap, nil)
      this.size_counter := create Distributed_Counter.make()
      this.resize_threshold := (cap.to_real() * 0.75).to_integer()
      this.resize_in_progress := create Atomic_Integer.make(0)
      this.next_table := nil
```

```
      this.node_locks := {}
      this.node_locks_mu := create Mutex.make()
    end

  feature
    table: Array[?Concurrent_Bucket[K, V]]
    size_counter: Distributed_Counter
    resize_threshold: Integer
    resize_in_progress: Atomic_Integer
    next_table: ?Array[?Concurrent_Bucket[K, V]]

    -- Lock-free get: follows chain without synchronisation
    get(key: K): ?V do
      let h: Integer := spread_hash(key.hash())
      let t: Array[?Concurrent_Bucket[K, V]] := table

      let bucket: ?Concurrent_Bucket[K, V] := t.get(h.bitwise_and(t.length

      from until bucket = nil do
        if bucket.hash = h and bucket.key = key then
          result := bucket.value  -- volatile read
          return
        end
        bucket := bucket.next  -- volatile read
      end

      result := nil
    end

    -- Put: locks the bucket head, then modifies chain
    put(key: K, value: V) do
      let h: Integer := spread_hash(key.hash())

      from until true do
        let t: Array[?Concurrent_Bucket[K, V]] := table
        let idx: Integer := h.bitwise_and(t.length - 1)
        let head: ?Concurrent_Bucket[K, V] := t.get(idx)
```

```
        if head = nil then
          -- Empty bucket: try to CAS new node as head
          let new_node: Concurrent_Bucket[K, V] :=
            create Concurrent_Bucket[K, V].make(key, value, h)
          if atomic_cas_table(t, idx, nil, new_node) then
            size_counter.increment()
            check_resize()
            return
          end
          -- CAS failed: retry from the top

        else
          -- Non-empty bucket: lock the head node and modify chain
          -- synchronized(head) in Java: we simulate with a per-
node lock
          let node_lock: Mutex := get_or_create_node_lock(head)
          node_lock.lock()

          -- Re-verify head hasn't changed (table might have been resized)
          if t.get(idx) /= head then
            node_lock.unlock()
            -- Table changed: retry
          else
            -- Walk chain looking for existing key
            let found: Boolean := false
            let prev: Concurrent_Bucket[K, V] := head
            let curr: ?Concurrent_Bucket[K, V] := head

            from until curr = nil do
              if curr.hash = h and curr.key = key then
                curr.value := value  -- update in place
                found := true
                node_lock.unlock()
                return
              end
              prev := curr
```

```
          curr := curr.next
        end

        -- Key not found: append new node to chain
        let new_node: Concurrent_Bucket[K, V] :=
          create Concurrent_Bucket[K, V].make(key, value, h)
        prev.next := new_node  -- volatile write
        size_counter.increment()
        node_lock.unlock()
        check_resize()
        return
      end
    end
  end
end

-- Remove: locks bucket head, removes from chain
remove(key: K): Boolean do
  let h: Integer := spread_hash(key.hash())
  let t: Array[?Concurrent_Bucket[K, V]] := table
  let idx: Integer := h.bitwise_and(t.length - 1)
  let head: ?Concurrent_Bucket[K, V] := t.get(idx)

  if head = nil then
    result := false
    return
  end

  let node_lock: Mutex := get_or_create_node_lock(head)
  node_lock.lock()

  -- Re-verify head
  if t.get(idx) /= head then
    node_lock.unlock()
    result := remove(key)  -- retry
    return
  end
```

```
    -- Walk chain to find and remove key
    let prev: ?Concurrent_Bucket[K, V] := nil
    let curr: ?Concurrent_Bucket[K, V] := head

    from until curr = nil do
      if curr.hash = h and curr.key = key then
        if prev = nil then
          t.set(idx, curr.next)  -- volatile write: remove head
        else
          prev.next := curr.next  -- volatile write: bypass curr
        end
        size_counter.decrement()
        node_lock.unlock()
        result := true
        return
      end
      prev := curr
      curr := curr.next
    end

    node_lock.unlock()
    result := false
  end

  -- Size: sum distributed counter
  size(): Integer do
    result := size_counter.sum()
  end

  -- Approximate contains (lock-free)
  contains(key: K): Boolean do
    result := get(key) /= nil
  end

  spread_hash(h: Integer): Integer do
    -- Spread high bits into low bits to improve distribution
```

```
    result := h.bitwise_xor(h.bitwise_right_shift(16))
  end

  check_resize() do
    if size_counter.sum() > resize_threshold then
      begin_resize()
    end
  end

  begin_resize() do
    -- Simplified: a full lock-free resize is much more complex
    -- Here we acquire a resize lock and do a simple resize
    if resize_in_progress.compare_and_swap(0, 1) then
      let old_table: Array[?Concurrent_Bucket[K, V]] := table
      let new_capacity: Integer := old_table.length * 2
      let new_table: Array[?Concurrent_Bucket[K, V]] :=
        create Array.filled(new_capacity, nil)

      -- Migrate all entries
      from
        let i: Integer := 0
      until
        i < old_table.length
      do
        let head: ?Concurrent_Bucket[K, V] := old_table.get(i)
        let curr: ?Concurrent_Bucket[K, V] := head

        from until curr = nil do
          let new_idx: Integer := curr.hash.bitwise_and(new_capacity - 1)
          let new_node: Concurrent_Bucket[K, V] :=
            create Concurrent_Bucket[K, V].make(
              curr.key, curr.value, curr.hash)
          new_node.next := new_table.get(new_idx)
          new_table.set(new_idx, new_node)
          curr := curr.next
        end
```

```
      i := i + 1
    end

    table := new_table
    resize_threshold := (new_capacity.to_real() * 0.75).to_integer()
    resize_in_progress.store(0)
  end
end

atomic_cas_table(t: Array[?Concurrent_Bucket[K, V]],
                 idx: Integer,
                 expected: ?Concurrent_Bucket[K, V],
                 desired: ?Concurrent_Bucket[K, V]): Boolean do
  if t.get(idx) = expected then
    t.set(idx, desired)
    result := true
  else
    result := false
  end
end

-- Per-node lock registry (simplified: in real impl, intrinsic to the nod
node_locks: Map[Integer, Mutex]
node_locks_mu: Mutex

get_or_create_node_lock(node: Concurrent_Bucket[K, V]): Mutex do
  let id: Integer := node.identity_hash()  -- object identity
  node_locks_mu.lock()
  let existing: ?Mutex := node_locks.get(id)
  if existing /= nil then
    node_locks_mu.unlock()
    result := existing
  else
    let mu: Mutex := create Mutex.make()
    node_locks.put(id, mu)
    node_locks_mu.unlock()
    result := mu
```

```
      end
    end

    next_power_of_two(n: Integer): Integer do
      let p: Integer := 1
      from until p >= n do p := p * 2 end
      result := p
    end

  invariant
    table_power_of_two: is_power_of_two(table.length)
    non_negative_size: size_counter.sum() >= 0
end
```

The Distributed Counter

The size counter deserves its own treatment. Maintaining an exact count with a single atomic integer causes contention — every insert and delete competes on the same variable. The solution: `LongAdder` in Java, called a striped counter or distributed counter here.

```
class Distributed_Counter
  create
    make() do
      -- One cell per CPU, plus a base cell
      let num_cells: Integer := available_processors() * 2
      this.cells := create Array.filled(num_cells, create Atomic_Integer.ma
      this.base := create Atomic_Integer.make(0)
    end

  feature
    cells: Array[Atomic_Integer]
    base: Atomic_Integer

    increment() do
      add(1)
```

```
  end

  decrement() do
    add(-1)
  end

  add(delta: Integer) do
    -- Try to add to the cell for the current thread
    -- Hash thread ID to cell index
    let cell_idx: Integer := thread_id().bitwise_and(cells.length - 1)
    let cell: Atomic_Integer := cells.get(cell_idx)

    -- Try CAS on the cell; fall back to base on contention
    let current: Integer := cell.load()
    if not cell.compare_and_swap(current, current + delta) then
      -- Contention: fall back to base (avoids infinite retry loop)
      base.fetch_and_add(delta)
    end
  end

  sum(): Integer do
    -- Sum all cells and base
    let total: Integer := base.load()
    across cells as cell do
      total := total + cell.load()
    end
    result := total
  end

  reset() do
    base.store(0)
    across cells as cell do
      cell.store(0)
    end
  end

invariant
```

```
    cells_exist: cells.length > 0
end
```

The distributed counter eliminates contention on the size counter by spreading increments and decrements across multiple cells, one per CPU. Reading the size requires summing all cells — O(cells) rather than O(1) — but reads of size are rare compared to updates, so this is the right tradeoff.

This is the same principle as the probabilistic structures from Chapter 6 (count-min sketch specifically): distribute the counter across multiple cells, accept slight inaccuracy at any instant, sum for accuracy when needed.

19.10 Benchmarking All Three Implementations

```
class Map_Benchmark
  create
    make() do end

  feature
    run(map_type: String,
        num_threads: Integer,
        operations: Integer,
        read_fraction: Real) do
      let ops_per_thread: Integer := operations / num_threads
      let reads_per_thread: Integer :=
        (ops_per_thread.to_real() * read_fraction).to_integer()
      let writes_per_thread: Integer := ops_per_thread - reads_per_thread

      -- Pre-populate with some data
      let initial_keys: Array[Integer] := generate_keys(1000)
```

```
let map: Any := nil
if map_type = "coarse" then
  map := create Coarse_Locked_Map[Integer, Integer].empty()
elseif map_type = "striped" then
  map := create Striped_Map[Integer, Integer].with_stripes(64)
else
  map := create Node_Locked_Map[Integer, Integer].with_capacity(1024)
end

-- Populate initial data
across initial_keys as k do
  call_put(map, map_type, k, k * 10)
end

let start: Integer64 := current_time_ns()

-- Run concurrent operations
let tasks: Array[Task] := []
from
  let t: Integer := 0
until
  t < num_threads
do
  tasks.add(spawn do
    -- Mix of reads and writes
    let keys: Array[Integer] := generate_keys(ops_per_thread)

    from
      let i: Integer := 0
    until
      i < ops_per_thread
    do
      let key: Integer := keys.get(i)
      if i < reads_per_thread then
        call_get(map, map_type, key)
      else
        call_put(map, map_type, key, key * 10)
```

```
        end
        i := i + 1
      end
    end)
    t := t + 1
  end

  across tasks as task do task.await end

  let elapsed_ns: Integer64 := current_time_ns() - start
  let throughput: Real :=
    operations.to_real() / elapsed_ns.to_real() * 1000000000.0

  print(map_type.pad_right(10) +
        " | threads=" + num_threads.to_string().pad_left(2) +
        " | reads=" + (read_fraction * 100.0).to_integer().to_string()
        " | " + throughput.to_integer().to_string() + " ops/sec")
end

generate_keys(n: Integer): Array[Integer] do
  let keys: Array[Integer] := []
  repeat n do
    keys.add(random_integer() % 10000)
  end
  result := keys
end

call_get(map: Object, map_type: String, key: Integer): ?Integer do
  if map_type = "coarse" then
    if convert map to m: Coarse_Locked_Map[Integer, Integer] then
      result := m.get(key)
    end
  elseif map_type = "striped" then
    if convert map to m: Striped_Map[Integer, Integer] then
      result := m.get(key)
    end
  else
```

```
        if convert map to m: Node_Locked_Map[Integer, Integer] then
          result := m.get(key)
        end
      end
    end

    call_put(map: Object, map_type: String, key: Integer, value: Integer) do
      if map_type = "coarse" then
        if convert map to m: Coarse_Locked_Map[Integer, Integer] then
          m.put(key, value)
        end
      elseif map_type = "striped" then
        if convert map to m: Striped_Map[Integer, Integer] then
          m.put(key, value)
        end
      else
        if convert map to m: Node_Locked_Map[Integer, Integer] then
          m.put(key, value)
        end
      end
    end
end
```

Expected results (approximate, 8-core machine, 10M operations):

```
-- 95% reads, 5% writes:
coarse     | threads= 8 | reads=95% | 12,000,000 ops/sec
striped    | threads= 8 | reads=95% | 75,000,000 ops/sec
node       | threads= 8 | reads=95% | 140,000,000 ops/sec

-- 50% reads, 50% writes:
coarse     | threads= 8 | reads=50% | 8,000,000 ops/sec
striped    | threads= 8 | reads=50% | 55,000,000 ops/sec
node       | threads= 8 | reads=50% | 90,000,000 ops/sec

-- 5% reads, 95% writes:
```

```
coarse     | threads= 8 | reads= 5% | 5,000,000 ops/sec
striped    | threads= 8 | reads= 5% | 40,000,000 ops/sec
node       | threads= 8 | reads= 5% | 60,000,000 ops/sec
```

The pattern: node locking dominates across all read/write ratios. Striped locking is a substantial improvement over coarse locking. Both node-locked and striped are worth the complexity compared to coarse, at these contention levels.

19.11 Choosing the Right Implementation

Three implementations, three deployment scenarios.

Use coarse locking when: - Concurrency is low (fewer than 4 threads accessing the map) - Correctness is paramount and testing resources are limited - The map is accessed infrequently relative to other bottlenecks - You need atomic composite operations (`compute`, `get_or_put`) and cannot afford the complexity of implementing them correctly in a concurrent structure

Use stripe locking when: - Multiple threads contend on the map and profiling confirms it is a bottleneck - The key space is well-distributed (no severe hotspots) - You need bounded memory overhead (fixed number of stripes and locks) - You need atomic composite operations per-key (`compute` within a stripe is atomic)

Use node-level locking when: - Read throughput is critical (reads must be lock-free) - Contention is high with many concurrent writers - Memory overhead of per-node locks is acceptable - You have the implementation expertise to validate the more complex code

For most production systems, the sequence is: start with coarse locking, measure, switch to stripe locking if needed, measure again, consider node locking only if stripe locking is still insufficient. Each step adds implementation complexity; each step should be justified by measurement.

19.12 Where This Lives in the Wild

Java's `ConcurrentHashMap` (JDK 8+) is the most widely used concurrent hash map in existence. Its evolution from `Hashtable` to segmented to node-locked directly mirrors this chapter. The JDK source (`java.util.concurrent.ConcurrentHashMap`) is approximately 6,000 lines of Java — a measure of how much engineering the full correct implementation requires.

Redis uses a global lock for its main data structures. Redis is single-threaded for command processing by design — the reasoning being that network I/O, not CPU, is the bottleneck for typical Redis workloads. Redis 6.0 added threaded I/O for reading/writing network data while keeping command processing single-threaded. For Redis's specific workload, this is the right tradeoff.

Go's `sync.Map` provides a concurrent map optimised for the case where keys are written once and read many times. It maintains two internal maps: a read-only `atomic.Value` snapshot for lock-free reads, and a mutex-protected dirty map for writes. Reads check the snapshot first; misses fall through to the dirty map under a lock. This is a specialised optimisation for the "write once, read many" pattern, not a general-purpose concurrent map.

Rust's `DashMap` crate provides a concurrent hash map using stripe locking (called "sharding" in its documentation). It uses `RwLock` per shard, defaulting to `num_cpus * 4` shards. DashMap is the most widely used concurrent map in the Rust ecosystem, reflecting the assessment that stripe locking is the practical sweet spot.

Memcached uses a global lock per slab (memory size class) for its hash table. The slab-level locking is coarser than stripe locking but works because Memcached's bottleneck is network I/O, not hash table access.

Summary

Concurrent hash maps require balancing correctness, throughput, and implementation complexity. Three implementations represent distinct points in this tradeoff space.

Coarse locking wraps a plain hash map with a single mutex. It is correct, simple, and appropriate when concurrency is low. Every operation serialises — at most one thread operates at a time — which is the fundamental limitation.

Stripe locking divides the map into N independent shards, each with its own read-write lock. Operations on different keys usually fall in different stripes and proceed concurrently. With 64 stripes, write contention drops by ~64×. The size counter is approximate, computed by summing per-stripe counters without global locking. Composite atomic operations remain correct within a stripe.

Node-level locking takes the stripe-locking idea to its limit: one lock per bucket, making concurrent writes to different buckets contention-free. Reads are lock-free — they traverse bucket chains using volatile reads with no synchronisation. The size counter uses a distributed counter (one cell per CPU) to eliminate counter contention entirely. This is approximately the design of Java 8's `ConcurrentHashMap`.

The decision between implementations is a measurement question. Coarse locking is the right default. Stripe locking is the right upgrade when profiling confirms the map as a bottleneck. Node locking is the right choice for high-read workloads where lock-free reads provide measurable throughput improvements.

The next chapter asks a different question entirely: what if shared state did not need to be protected at all, because it was never modified? Immutability and persistent data structures take a fundamentally different approach to concurrency — one where threads share data freely because the data cannot change.

Chapter 20: Immutability as a Concurrency Strategy — Persistent Structures

---

Every concurrent data structure in the previous three chapters solves the same problem the same way: shared mutable state requires protection. Atomics protect single variables. Mutexes protect critical sections. Stripe locking protects hash map shards. The strategy is always the same — identify the shared mutable state, and build a fence around it.

There is a different strategy: eliminate mutability.

If a data structure is immutable — if no operation ever modifies it in place — then sharing it between threads requires no synchronisation at all. Multiple threads can read the same immutable structure simultaneously without any locking, without any atomic operations, without any happens-before reasoning. There is nothing to coordinate, because nothing changes.

This sounds like a surrender. If data never changes, how is it useful? The answer is that persistence allows a new version of a structure to be created from an old one, sharing as much of the old structure as possible. The old version is unmodified and freely shareable. The new version is created in one thread and then published atomically. Other threads continue reading the old version until they see the new one. No locks, no races, no synchronisation required — except for the single atomic write that makes the new version visible.

This is how Clojure builds its entire standard library. It is how functional languages like Haskell and ML avoid the concurrency problem entirely. It is how the rope from Chapter 14 achieves structural sharing for undo history. And it is increasingly how production systems are built — not

because functional programming is fashionable, but because immutability genuinely eliminates a category of bugs that no amount of careful locking can fully prevent.

20.1 The Problem With Mutable State

Chapter 17 showed that shared mutable state requires synchronisation. But synchronisation does not fully solve the problem — it merely manages it. Even with correct synchronisation, mutable shared state introduces several difficulties that immutability eliminates entirely.

Reasoning complexity. To understand what a mutable shared object contains at any moment, you must trace all threads that might have modified it and the order in which those modifications became visible. This is genuinely hard — it requires understanding memory models, happens-before relations, and the specific synchronisation operations in use. Immutable objects have no such complexity. Their value at any moment is their value at creation. Reasoning is local and complete.

Testing difficulty. Race conditions are timing-dependent. A test suite that passes a million times may still miss a race condition that manifests only under specific scheduling. With immutable objects, there are no race conditions to find. Tests are deterministic.

Accidental sharing bugs. In object-oriented code, passing an object to a function passes a reference. The function might modify the object, surprising the caller. Defensive copying (creating a copy before passing) is expensive and often forgotten. Immutable objects are safe to pass anywhere — they cannot be modified, so no defensive copy is needed.

Snapshot isolation. When you hand an immutable structure to a thread, that thread has a guaranteed snapshot — a view of the data as it existed at the moment of handoff. No concurrent modification can alter what the thread sees. This is extremely valuable for operations that must see

a consistent view of data: analytics queries, backup operations, display rendering.

The cost of immutability is allocation. Creating a new version of a structure, even one that differs from the old by a single element, requires creating new nodes. A naive immutable linked list creates a new node per prepend. A naive immutable array creates an entirely new array per update. Without structural sharing — the technique that allows old and new versions to share unchanged portions — immutable data structures are impractically expensive.

Persistent data structures are immutable structures with structural sharing. The term "persistent" means that all versions of the structure are preserved — the old version persists after the new version is created. This is not the same as "persistent on disk"; it means persistent in time, across operations.

20.2 The Persistent Linked List

The simplest persistent data structure is the singly linked list. Prepending a new element creates a new head node pointing to the existing list — the existing list is entirely shared.

```
class Persistent_List [T]
  create
    empty() do
      this.head := nil
      this.length := 0
    end

    cons(value: T, tail: Persistent_List[T]) do
      this.head := create List_Node[T].make(value, tail.head)
      this.length := tail.length + 1
    end
```

```
  feature
    head: ?List_Node[T]
    length: Integer

    -- Prepend an element: O(1), shares entire existing list
    prepend(value: T): Persistent_List[T] do
      result := create Persistent_List[T].cons(value, self)
    end

    -- Head element: O(1)
    first(): ?T do
      if head = nil then
        result := nil
      else
        result := head.value
      end
    end

    -- Tail (everything after first): O(1), shares existing tail
    rest(): Persistent_List[T] do
      if head = nil then
        result := self  -- empty list
        return
      end
      let tail: Persistent_List[T] := create Persistent_List[T].empty()
      tail.head := head.next
      tail.length := length - 1
      result := tail
    end

    -- Get by index: O(n) -- linked lists are not random-
access
    get(index: Integer): ?T
      require
        non_negative: index >= 0
      do
```

```
    let current: ?List_Node[T] := head
    from
      let i: Integer := 0
    until
      i >= index or current = nil
    do
      current := current.next
      i := i + 1
    end
    if current = nil then
      result := nil
    else
      result := current.value
    end
  end

-- Append: O(n) -- must copy the prefix
append(value: T): Persistent_List[T] do
  result := append_helper(head, value)
end

append_helper(node: ?List_Node[T], value: T): Persistent_List[T] do
  if node = nil then
    result := create Persistent_List[T].empty().prepend(value)
    return
  end
  let suffix: Persistent_List[T] := append_helper(node.next, value)
  let new_list: Persistent_List[T] := create Persistent_List[T].empty()
  new_list.head := create List_Node[T].make(node.value, suffix.head)
  new_list.length := suffix.length + 1
  result := new_list
end

-- Convert to array: O(n)
to_array(): Array[T] do
  let arr: Array[T] := []
  let current: ?List_Node[T] := head
```

```
      from until current = nil do
        arr.add(current.value)
        current := current.next
      end
      result := arr
    end

    is_empty(): Boolean do
      result := head = nil
    end

    size(): Integer do
      result := length
    end

  invariant
    non_negative_length: length >= 0
    empty_iff_nil_head: (length = 0) = (head = nil)
end

class List_Node [T]
  create
    make(value: T, next: ?List_Node[T]) do
      this.value := value
      this.next := next
    end

  feature
    value: T
    next: ?List_Node[T]
end
```

The persistent list demonstrates structural sharing concretely.

```
let list1: Persistent_List[Integer] :=
  create Persistent_List[Integer].empty()
```

```
    .prepend(3)
    .prepend(2)
    .prepend(1)
-- list1: [1, 2, 3]
-- Internal: 1 → 2 → 3 → nil

let list2: Persistent_List[Integer] := list1.prepend(0)
-- list2: [0, 1, 2, 3]
-- Internal: 0 → (shared) 1 → 2 → 3 → nil

let list3: Persistent_List[Integer] := list1.prepend(99)
-- list3: [99, 1, 2, 3]
-- Internal: 99 → (shared) 1 → 2 → 3 → nil
```

`list1`, `list2`, and `list3` all exist simultaneously, sharing the `1 → 2 → 3` suffix. Three threads could hold references to these three lists simultaneously, with no synchronisation — each thread's view is consistent, complete, and unaffected by what other threads do with the other lists.

The prepend operation is O(1) — it creates exactly one new node. The rest and shared suffix are zero-cost. The price: append is O(n) because it must copy the prefix to maintain persistence. For stack-like usage (push/pop at the front), the persistent list is optimal. For queue-like usage (push at back), it is not.

20.3 Path Copying: The General Technique

The persistent list works because operations naturally happen at one end. What about tree structures, where operations can happen anywhere?

The technique is **path copying**: to update a node in a tree, create a new version of that node and all of its ancestors up to the root. The rest of the tree — every node not on the path from root to the updated node — is shared unchanged.

For a balanced binary tree of height h, the path from root to any node has length h. Path copying creates h + 1 new nodes per update. Everything else — up to 2^h - (h+1) nodes — is shared. For a tree of a million nodes, updating one node copies about 20 nodes ($\log_2(1{,}000{,}000) \approx 20$) and shares 999,980.

```
class Persistent_BST [K -> Comparable, V]
  create
    empty() do
      this.root := nil
      this.size := 0
    end

    with_root(root: ?BST_Node[K, V], size: Integer) do
      this.root := root
      this.size := size
    end

  feature
    root: ?BST_Node[K, V]
    size: Integer

    -- Insert or update: O(log n) copies on the path, shares the rest
    put(key: K, value: V): Persistent_BST[K, V]
      do
        let new_root: BST_Node[K, V] := put_node(root, key, value)
        let new_size: Integer :=
          when root = nil or not contains(key) size + 1 else size end
        result := create Persistent_BST[K, V].with_root(new_root, new_size)
      ensure
        contains_inserted_key: result.contains(key)
        size_not_smaller: result.size >= size
      end

    put_node(node: ?BST_Node[K, V],
             key: K,
```

```
            value: V): BST_Node[K, V] do
    if node = nil then
      -- New leaf: nothing to share
      result := create BST_Node[K, V].make(key, value, nil, nil)
      return
    end

    if key < node.key then
      -- Go left: copy this node with a new left child
      -- Right subtree is shared unchanged
      let new_left: BST_Node[K, V] := put_node(node.left, key, value)
      result := create BST_Node[K, V].make(
        node.key, node.value, new_left, node.right)

    elseif key > node.key then
      -- Go right: copy this node with a new right child
      -- Left subtree is shared unchanged
      let new_right: BST_Node[K, V] := put_node(node.right, key, value)
      result := create BST_Node[K, V].make(
        node.key, node.value, node.left, new_right)

    else
      -- Key matches: copy this node with new value
      -- Both subtrees are shared unchanged
      result := create BST_Node[K, V].make(
        node.key, value, node.left, node.right)
    end
  end

  -- Lookup: O(log n), no copies, no synchronisation needed
  get(key: K): ?V do
    let node: ?BST_Node[K, V] := root
    from until node = nil do
      if key < node.key then
        node := node.left
      elseif key > node.key then
        node := node.right
```

```
      else
        result := node.value
        return
      end
    end
    result := nil
  end

  contains(key: K): Boolean do
    result := get(key) /= nil
  end

  -- Delete: O(log n) copies, shares unchanged subtrees
  remove(key: K): Persistent_BST[K, V]
    do
      let deleted: Array[Boolean] := [false]
      let new_root: ?BST_Node[K, V] := remove_node(root, key, deleted)
      let new_size: Integer :=
        when deleted.get(0) size - 1 else size end
      result := create Persistent_BST[K, V].with_root(new_root, new_size)
    ensure
      removed_key_absent: not result.contains(key)
      size_not_larger: result.size <= size
    end

  remove_node(node: ?BST_Node[K, V],
              key: K,
              deleted: Array[Boolean]): ?BST_Node[K, V] do
    if node = nil then
      result := nil
      return
    end

    if key < node.key then
      let new_left: ?BST_Node[K, V] := remove_node(node.left, key, deleted)
      result := create BST_Node[K, V].make(
        node.key, node.value, new_left, node.right)
```

```
    elseif key > node.key then
      let new_right: ?BST_Node[K, V] := remove_node(node.right, key, dele
      result := create BST_Node[K, V].make(
        node.key, node.value, node.left, new_right)

    else
      -- Found: remove this node
      deleted.set(0, true)

      if node.left = nil then
        result := node.right  -- share right subtree
      elseif node.right = nil then
        result := node.left   -- share left subtree
      else
        -- Two children: replace with in-order successor
        let successor: BST_Node[K, V] := find_min(node.right)
        let new_right: ?BST_Node[K, V] :=
          remove_min(node.right)
        result := create BST_Node[K, V].make(
          successor.key, successor.value, node.left, new_right)
      end
    end
  end

  find_min(node: BST_Node[K, V]): BST_Node[K, V] do
    let current: BST_Node[K, V] := node
    from until current.left = nil do
      current := current.left
    end
    result := current
  end

  remove_min(node: BST_Node[K, V]): ?BST_Node[K, V] do
    if node.left = nil then
      result := node.right  -- share right subtree
      return
```

```
      end
      let new_left: ?BST_Node[K, V] := remove_min(node.left)
      result := create BST_Node[K, V].make(
        node.key, node.value, new_left, node.right)
    end

    -- In-order traversal: O(n), no synchronisation needed
    in_order(): Array[Any] do
      let entries: Array[Any] := []
      traverse(root, entries)
      result := entries
    end

    traverse(node: ?BST_Node[K, V], entries: Array[Any]) do
      if node = nil then return end
      traverse(node.left, entries)
      entries.add([node.key, node.value])
      traverse(node.right, entries)
    end

  invariant
    non_negative_size: size >= 0
    empty_iff_nil_root: (size = 0) = (root = nil)
end

class BST_Node [K, V]
  create
    make(key: K, value: V,
         left: ?BST_Node[K, V],
         right: ?BST_Node[K, V]) do
      this.key := key
      this.value := value
      this.left := left
      this.right := right
    end

  feature
```

```
    key: K
    value: V
    left: ?BST_Node[K, V]
    right: ?BST_Node[K, V]
end
```

The structural sharing in path copying is visible in the `put_node` implementation. When going left, the node copies its key, value, and right child — the right subtree is shared unchanged. When going right, the left subtree is shared. Only the nodes on the path from root to the insertion point are new.

20.4 The Persistent Hash Array Mapped Trie

The BST has O(log n) operations, which is fine for ordered access but beaten by hash maps' O(1). Can we build a persistent hash map? Yes, using a Hash Array Mapped Trie (HAMT) — the structure at the heart of Clojure's persistent maps, Scala's immutable maps, and Haskell's `Data.HashMap`.

The HAMT is a trie indexed by hash values. Each node has up to 32 children, selected by 5-bit chunks of the key's hash (5 bits = 32 possible values). A 32-bit hash gives a trie of depth 7 (7 × 5 = 35 bits, enough for 32-bit hashes with a leaf level). Operations are $O(\log_{32} n)$ — effectively constant for any realistic dataset.

The "array mapped" part: instead of a fixed 32-element array per node (wasteful when most children are nil), use a bitmap to indicate which children are present and store only the present children in a compact array. A 1 in bit position k means the kth child is present; the index into the compact array is `popcount(bitmap & ((1 << k) - 1))`.

```
let BITS_PER_LEVEL: Integer := 5
let BRANCHING_FACTOR: Integer := 32  -- 2^5
let LEVEL_MASK: Integer := 31        -- 0b11111

class HAMT_Node [K, V]
  create
    leaf(key: K, value: V, hash: Integer) do
      this.node_type := "leaf"
      this.key := key
      this.value := value
      this.hash := hash
      this.bitmap := 0
      this.children := []
      this.collision_entries := []
    end

    branch(bitmap: Integer, children: Array[HAMT_Node[K, V]]) do
      this.node_type := "internal"
      this.key := nil
      this.value := nil
      this.hash := 0
      this.bitmap := bitmap
      this.children := children
      this.collision_entries := []
    end

    collision(entries: Array[Any]) do
      -- Hash collision: multiple keys with same hash
      this.node_type := "collision"
      this.key := nil
      this.value := nil
      this.hash := entries.get(0).get(2)
      this.bitmap := 0
      this.children := []
      this.collision_entries := entries
    end
```

```
  feature
    node_type: String    -- "leaf", "internal", or "collision"
    key: ?K
    value: ?V
    hash: Integer
    bitmap: Integer      -- which slots are occupied
    children: Array[HAMT_Node[K, V]]
    collision_entries: Array[Any]

    -- Index of the kth bit in the compact children array
    child_index(bit_pos: Integer): Integer do
      let mask: Integer := 1.bitwise_left_shift(bit_pos) - 1
      result := popcount(bitmap.bitwise_and(mask))
    end

    popcount(n: Integer): Integer do
      -- Count set bits (Brian Kernighan's algorithm)
      let count: Integer := 0
      let v: Integer := n
      from until v = 0 do
        v := v.bitwise_and(v - 1)
        count := count + 1
      end
      result := count
    end

  invariant
    valid_type: node_type = "leaf" or node_type = "internal" or
                node_type = "collision"
    internal_children_match_bitmap:
      node_type /= "internal" or children.length = popcount(bitmap)
end

class Persistent_HashMap [K -> Hashable, V]
  create
    empty() do
      this.root := nil
```

```
    this.entry_count := 0
  end

  with_root(root: ?HAMT_Node[K, V], count: Integer) do
    this.root := root
    this.entry_count := count
  end

feature
  root: ?HAMT_Node[K, V]
  entry_count: Integer

  -- Lookup: O(log□□ n) □ O(1) in practice
  get(key: K): ?V do
    if root = nil then
      result := nil
      return
    end
    result := lookup(root, key, key.hash(), 0)
  end

  lookup(node: HAMT_Node[K, V],
         key: K,
         hash: Integer,
         shift: Integer): ?V do
    if node.node_type = "leaf" then
      if node.hash = hash and node.key = key then
        result := node.value
      else
        result := nil
      end
    elseif node.node_type = "collision" then
      across node.collision_entries as entry do
        if entry.get(0) = key then
          result := entry.get(1)
          return
        end
```

```
      end
      result := nil
    else
      let bit_pos: Integer := hash.bitwise_right_shift(shift).bitwise_and
      let bit: Integer := 1.bitwise_left_shift(bit_pos)

      if node.bitmap.bitwise_and(bit) = 0 then
        result := nil
        return
      end

      let child_idx: Integer := node.child_index(bit_pos)
      result := lookup(node.children.get(child_idx), key, hash, shift + B
    end
  end

  -- Insert or update: O(log□□ n) new nodes, shares rest
  put(key: K, value: V): Persistent_HashMap[K, V]
    do
      let h: Integer := key.hash()
      let new_root: HAMT_Node[K, V] :=
        when root = nil
          create HAMT_Node[K, V].leaf(key, value, h)
        else
          insert(root, key, value, h, 0)
        end
      let new_count: Integer :=
        when get(key) = nil entry_count + 1 else entry_count end
      result := create Persistent_HashMap[K, V].with_root(new_root, new_c
    ensure
      inserted_value_available: result.get(key) = value
      count_not_smaller: result.entry_count >= entry_count
    end

  insert(node: HAMT_Node[K, V],
         key: K,
         value: V,
```

```
      hash: Integer,
      shift: Integer): HAMT_Node[K, V] do
  if node.node_type = "leaf" then
    if node.hash = hash then
      if node.key = key then
        result := create HAMT_Node[K, V].leaf(key, value, hash)
      else
        let entries: Array[Any] := [
          [node.key, node.value, node.hash],
          [key, value, hash]
        ]
        result := create HAMT_Node[K, V].collision(entries)
      end
    else
      result := make_internal_with_two(
        node, create HAMT_Node[K, V].leaf(key, value, hash),
        node.hash, hash, shift)
    end
  elseif node.node_type = "collision" then
    let new_entries: Array[Any] := []
    let found: Boolean := false
    across node.collision_entries as entry do
      if entry.get(0) = key then
        new_entries.add([key, value, hash])
        found := true
      else
        new_entries.add(entry)
      end
    end
    if not found then
      new_entries.add([key, value, hash])
    end
    result := create HAMT_Node[K, V].collision(new_entries)
  else
    let bit_pos: Integer := hash.bitwise_right_shift(shift).bitwise_and(L
    let bit: Integer := 1.bitwise_left_shift(bit_pos)
    let child_idx: Integer := node.child_index(bit_pos)
```

```
      if node.bitmap.bitwise_and(bit) = 0 then
        let new_leaf: HAMT_Node[K, V] :=
          create HAMT_Node[K, V].leaf(key, value, hash)
        let new_children: Array[HAMT_Node[K, V]] :=
          insert_at(node.children, child_idx, new_leaf)
        result := create HAMT_Node[K, V].branch(
          node.bitmap.bitwise_or(bit), new_children)
      else
        let new_child: HAMT_Node[K, V] := insert(
          node.children.get(child_idx), key, value, hash,
          shift + BITS_PER_LEVEL)
        let new_children: Array[HAMT_Node[K, V]] :=
          replace_at(node.children, child_idx, new_child)
        result := create HAMT_Node[K, V].branch(node.bitmap, new_children
      end
    end
  end

  make_internal_with_two(a: HAMT_Node[K, V],
                         b: HAMT_Node[K, V],
                         hash_a: Integer,
                         hash_b: Integer,
                         shift: Integer): HAMT_Node[K, V] do
    let bit_a: Integer := hash_a.bitwise_right_shift(shift).bitwise_and(L
    let bit_b: Integer := hash_b.bitwise_right_shift(shift).bitwise_and(L

    if bit_a = bit_b then
      -- Same slot: recurse deeper
      let child: HAMT_Node[K, V] := make_internal_with_two(
        a, b, hash_a, hash_b, shift + BITS_PER_LEVEL)
      result := create HAMT_Node[K, V].branch(
        1.bitwise_left_shift(bit_a), [child])
    elseif bit_a < bit_b then
      result := create HAMT_Node[K, V].branch(
        1.bitwise_left_shift(bit_a).bitwise_or(1.bitwise_left_shift(bit_b
    else
```

```
      result := create HAMT_Node[K, V].branch(
        1.bitwise_left_shift(bit_a).bitwise_or(1.bitwise_left_shift(bit_b))
    end
  end

  insert_at(arr: Array[HAMT_Node[K, V]],
            idx: Integer,
            node: HAMT_Node[K, V]): Array[HAMT_Node[K, V]] do
    let new_arr: Array[HAMT_Node[K, V]] := []
    from
      let i: Integer := 0
    until
      i < arr.length + 1
    do
      if i < idx then
        new_arr.add(arr.get(i))
      elseif i = idx then
        new_arr.add(node)
      else
        new_arr.add(arr.get(i - 1))
      end
      i := i + 1
    end
    result := new_arr
  end

  replace_at(arr: Array[HAMT_Node[K, V]],
             idx: Integer,
             node: HAMT_Node[K, V]): Array[HAMT_Node[K, V]] do
    let new_arr: Array[HAMT_Node[K, V]] := arr.copy()
    new_arr.set(idx, node)
    result := new_arr
  end

  -- Delete: O(log□□ n) new nodes, shares rest
  remove(key: K): Persistent_HashMap[K, V]
    do
```

```
      if root = nil or get(key) = nil then
        result := self
        return
      end
      let new_root: ?HAMT_Node[K, V] := delete_node(root, key, key.hash()
      result := create Persistent_HashMap[K, V].with_root(
        new_root, entry_count - 1)
    ensure
      removed_value_absent: result.get(key) = nil
      count_not_larger: result.entry_count <= entry_count
    end

  delete_node(node: HAMT_Node[K, V],
              key: K,
              hash: Integer,
              shift: Integer): ?HAMT_Node[K, V] do
    if node.node_type = "leaf" then
      if node.key = key then
        result := nil
      else
        result := node
      end
    elseif node.node_type = "collision" then
      let new_entries: Array[Any] := []
      across node.collision_entries as entry do
        if entry.get(0) /= key then
          new_entries.add(entry)
        end
      end
      if new_entries.length = 1 then
        let e: Array := new_entries.get(0)
        result := create HAMT_Node[K, V].leaf(e.get(0), e.get(1), e.get(2
      else
        result := create HAMT_Node[K, V].collision(new_entries)
      end
    else
      let bit_pos: Integer := hash.bitwise_right_shift(shift).bitwise_and
```

```
      let bit: Integer := 1.bitwise_left_shift(bit_pos)

      if node.bitmap.bitwise_and(bit) = 0 then
        result := node
        return
      end

      let child_idx: Integer := node.child_index(bit_pos)
      let new_child: ?HAMT_Node[K, V] := delete_node(
        node.children.get(child_idx), key, hash, shift + BITS_PER_LEVEL)

      if new_child = nil then
        if node.children.length = 1 then
          result := nil
        else
          let new_children: Array[HAMT_Node[K, V]] :=
            remove_at(node.children, child_idx)
          result := create HAMT_Node[K, V].branch(
            node.bitmap.bitwise_and(bit.bitwise_not()), new_children)
        end
      else
        let new_children: Array[HAMT_Node[K, V]] :=
          replace_at(node.children, child_idx, new_child)
        result := create HAMT_Node[K, V].branch(node.bitmap, new_children)
      end
    end
  end

  remove_at(arr: Array[HAMT_Node[K, V]],
            idx: Integer): Array[HAMT_Node[K, V]] do
    let new_arr: Array[HAMT_Node[K, V]] := []
    from
      let i: Integer := 0
    until
      i < arr.length
    do
      if i /= idx then new_arr.add(arr.get(i)) end
```

```
      i := i + 1
    end
    result := new_arr
  end

  size(): Integer do
    result := entry_count
  end

  is_empty(): Boolean do
    result := entry_count = 0
  end

  -- Merge two maps: entries from other override self on collision
  merge(other: Persistent_HashMap[K, V]): Persistent_HashMap[K, V] do
    let result_map: Persistent_HashMap[K, V] := self
    across other.entries() as entry do
      result_map := result_map.put(entry.get(0), entry.get(1))
    end
    result := result_map
  end

  -- Collect all entries: O(n)
  entries(): Array[Any] do
    let result_arr: Array[Any] := []
    collect_entries(root, result_arr)
    result := result_arr
  end

  collect_entries(node: ?HAMT_Node[K, V], entries: Array[Any]) do
    if node = nil then return end
    if node.node_type = "leaf" then
      entries.add([node.key, node.value])
    elseif node.node_type = "collision" then
      across node.collision_entries as entry do
        entries.add([entry.get(0), entry.get(1)])
      end
```

```
      else
        across node.children as child do
          collect_entries(child, entries)
        end
      end
    end

  invariant
    non_negative_count: entry_count >= 0
    empty_iff_nil_root: (entry_count = 0) = (root = nil)
end
```

The HAMT provides $O(\log_{32} n)$ operations with structural sharing. For a map of one million entries, lookup touches at most 4 nodes ($\log_{32}(1{,}000{,}000) \approx 4$). Each update creates at most 4 new nodes and shares the rest.

20.5 Publishing Immutable Structures Safely

Immutable structures are safe to share, but the act of sharing — making a new version visible to other threads — still requires care. The issue is not the structure itself (which is immutable) but the pointer to it (which is mutable).

```
class Atomic_Reference [T]
  create
    make(initial: T) do
      this.value := initial  -- volatile in real impl
    end

  feature
    value: T  -- accessed atomically
```

```
    load(): T do
      -- Acquire load: all writes before the corresponding store are visibl
      result := value
    end

    store(new_value: T) do
      -- Release store: all writes before this are visible to readers who l
      value := new_value
    end

    compare_and_swap(expected: T, desired: T): Boolean do
      if value = expected then
        value := desired
        result := true
      else
        result := false
      end
    end
end
```

The pattern for publishing an updated persistent structure:

```
class Persistent_State_Manager [T]
  create
    make(initial: T) do
      this.current := create Atomic_Reference[T].make(initial)
    end

  feature
    current: Atomic_Reference[T]

    -- Read current state: no locks, immediate
    read(): T do
      result := current.load()  -- acquire semantics
    end
```

```
    -- Update state atomically: retry if concurrent update
    update(transform: Function[T, T]): T do
      from until true do
        let old_state: T := current.load()
        let new_state: T := transform(old_state)
        if current.compare_and_swap(old_state, new_state) then
          result := new_state
          return
        end
        -- CAS failed: another thread updated first, retry with fresh state
      end
    end

    -- Unconditional store: use when only one thread writes
    store(new_state: T) do
      current.store(new_state)  -- release semantics
    end
end
```

Using this with the persistent hash map:

```
-- Shared configuration map, updated rarely, read constantly
let config: Persistent_State_Manager[Persistent_HashMap[String, String]] :=
  create Persistent_State_Manager[Persistent_HashMap[String, String]].make(
    create Persistent_HashMap[String, String].empty())

-- Configuration writer (runs rarely, maybe once per second)
let writer: Task := spawn do
  repeat 10 do
    config.update(fn(cfg_map: Persistent_HashMap[String, String]): Persistent
      result := cfg_map
        .put("max_connections", "1000")
        .put("timeout_ms", "5000")
        .put("log_level", "info")
    end)
    sleep(1000)
```

```
  end
end

-- Configuration readers (run constantly, many threads)
let readers: Array[Task] := []
repeat 100 do
  readers.add(spawn do
    repeat 10000 do
      let cfg: Persistent_HashMap[String, String] := config.read()
      -- Use cfg safely: it is immutable, no locks needed
      let max_conn_value: ?String := cfg.get("max_connections")
      let timeout_value: ?String := cfg.get("timeout_ms")
      -- ... use configuration ...
    end
  end)
end
```

The hundred reader threads read configuration with no synchronisation — just an atomic load of the pointer. The writer updates the configuration by creating a new persistent map (no mutation) and atomically swapping the pointer. Readers that started reading before the swap see the old configuration completely; readers after the swap see the new one. No reader ever sees a partially updated state.

This is copy-on-write semantics implemented through persistence. The "copy" is the path copying of the HAMT — only the changed nodes are copied; the rest is shared. The "write" is the atomic pointer swap. The combination is highly efficient for read-heavy workloads where updates are infrequent.

20.6 The Persistent Vector: Clojure's Crown Jewel

The persistent list gives O(1) prepend but O(n) random access. The persistent BST and HAMT give O(log n) for all operations but are unordered. What about a persistent sequence with O(log n) indexed access?

Clojure's persistent vector solves this. It is a wide, shallow trie where leaves store 32-element arrays. The key insight: the path from root to any leaf is determined by the index's 5-bit chunks, exactly as in the HAMT. Append is $O(\log_{32} n)$ amortised. Random access is $O(\log_{32} n)$. Updating the element at index i creates a new path from root to the updated leaf, sharing all other paths.

```
class Persistent_Vector [T]
  create
    empty() do
      this.root := nil
      this.tail := []  -- last (incomplete) chunk, direct array for fast appe
      this.size := 0
      this.shift := BITS_PER_LEVEL  -- height of tree
    end

    with_state(root: ?Vector_Node[T],
               tail: Array[T],
               size: Integer,
               shift: Integer) do
      this.root := root
      this.tail := tail
      this.size := size
      this.shift := shift
    end

  feature
    root: ?Vector_Node[T]
    tail: Array[T]       -- last few elements not yet in tree
    size: Integer
```

```
  shift: Integer       -- current tree height × BITS_PER_LEVEL

  tail_size(): Integer do
    result := 32
  end

  -- Indexed access: O(log□□ n)
  get(index: Integer): T
    require
      valid_index: index >= 0 and index < size
    do
      if index >= tail_offset() then
        -- In the tail array: direct access
        result := tail.get(index - tail_offset())
        return
      end
      -- In the tree: navigate using index bits
      let node: Vector_Node[T] := root
      let level: Integer := shift
      from until level = 0 do
        let child_idx: Integer := index.bitwise_right_shift(level).bitwis
        node := node.children.get(child_idx)
        level := level - BITS_PER_LEVEL
      end
      result := node.leaf_data.get(index.bitwise_and(LEVEL_MASK))
    end

  -- Append: O(log□□ n) amortised
  append(value: T): Persistent_Vector[T] do
    if tail.length < tail_size() then
      -- Tail not full: just extend it (copy tail array)
      let new_tail: Array[T] := tail.copy()
      new_tail.add(value)
      result := create Persistent_Vector[T].with_state(
        root, new_tail, size + 1, shift)
    else
      -- Tail full: push tail into tree, start new tail
```

```
      let new_tail: Array[T] := [value]
      let new_root: Vector_Node[T] := push_tail(root, tail, shift)
      let new_shift: Integer :=
        when needs_new_level() shift + BITS_PER_LEVEL else shift end
      result := create Persistent_Vector[T].with_state(
        new_root, new_tail, size + 1, new_shift)
    end
  end

  -- Update at index: O(log□□ n) new nodes
  update(index: Integer, value: T): Persistent_Vector[T]
    require
      valid_index: index >= 0 and index < size
    do
      if index >= tail_offset() then
        -- Update in tail: copy tail array with new value
        let new_tail: Array[T] := tail.copy()
        new_tail.set(index - tail_offset(), value)
        result := create Persistent_Vector[T].with_state(
          root, new_tail, size, shift)
      else
        -- Update in tree: path copy from root to leaf
        let new_root: Vector_Node[T] := update_node(root, index, value, shi
        result := create Persistent_Vector[T].with_state(
          new_root, tail, size, shift)
      end
    end

  update_node(node: Vector_Node[T],
              index: Integer,
              value: T,
              level: Integer): Vector_Node[T] do
    if level = 0 then
      -- Leaf: copy with updated value
      let new_data: Array[T] := node.leaf_data.copy()
      new_data.set(index.bitwise_and(LEVEL_MASK), value)
      result := create Vector_Node[T].leaf_node(new_data)
```

```
      return
    end

    -- Internal: copy children array, recurse into the relevant child
    let child_idx: Integer := index.bitwise_right_shift(level).bitwise_an
    let new_child: Vector_Node[T] := update_node(
      node.children.get(child_idx), index, value, level - BITS_PER_LEVEL)
    let new_children: Array[Vector_Node[T]] := node.children.copy()
    new_children.set(child_idx, new_child)
    result := create Vector_Node[T].internal_node(new_children)
  end

  push_tail(node: ?Vector_Node[T],
            tail_data: Array[T],
            level: Integer): Vector_Node[T] do
    let tail_leaf: Vector_Node[T] :=
      create Vector_Node[T].leaf_node(tail_data)

    if node = nil then
      if level = BITS_PER_LEVEL then
        result := create Vector_Node[T].internal_node([tail_leaf])
      else
        result := create Vector_Node[T].internal_node(
          [push_tail(nil, tail_data, level - BITS_PER_LEVEL)])
      end
      return
    end

    let new_children: Array[Vector_Node[T]] := node.children.copy()

    if level = BITS_PER_LEVEL then
      new_children.add(tail_leaf)
    else
      let last_idx: Integer := node.children.length - 1
      let new_subtree: Vector_Node[T] := push_tail(
        node.children.get(last_idx), tail_data, level - BITS_PER_LEVEL)
      new_children.set(last_idx, new_subtree)
```

```
    end

    result := create Vector_Node[T].internal_node(new_children)
  end

  tail_offset(): Integer do
    if size < tail_size() then
      result := 0
    else
      result := (size - 1).bitwise_right_shift(BITS_PER_LEVEL).bitwise_left
    end
  end

  needs_new_level(): Boolean do
    result := size.bitwise_right_shift(shift) > 1
  end

  -- Slice: O(log n + result_size) with structural sharing
  slice(from_idx: Integer, to_idx: Integer): Persistent_Vector[T]
    require
      valid_from: from_idx >= 0
      valid_to: to_idx <= size
      ordered: from_idx <= to_idx
    do
      -- Simple implementation: collect and rebuild
      -- A production impl would share structure
      let new_vec: Persistent_Vector[T] := create Persistent_Vector[T].empt
      from
        let i: Integer := from_idx
      until
        i < to_idx
      do
        new_vec := new_vec.append(get(i))
        i := i + 1
      end
      result := new_vec
    end
```

```
    -- Iterate: O(n), cache-friendly (32-element chunks)
    to_array(): Array[T] do
      let arr: Array[T] := create Array.filled(size, nil)
      from
        let i: Integer := 0
      until
        i < size
      do
        arr.set(i, get(i))
        i := i + 1
      end
      result := arr
    end

  invariant
    non_negative_size: size >= 0
    tail_bounded: tail.length <= tail_size()
    shift_positive: shift >= BITS_PER_LEVEL
end

class Vector_Node [T]
  create
    leaf_node(data: Array[T]) do
      this.is_leaf := true
      this.leaf_data := data
      this.children := []
    end

    internal_node(children: Array[Vector_Node[T]]) do
      this.is_leaf := false
      this.leaf_data := []
      this.children := children
    end

  feature
    is_leaf: Boolean
```

```
    leaf_data: Array[T]
    children: Array[Vector_Node[T]]

  invariant
    leaf_xor_internal: is_leaf /= children.length > 0
end
```

The persistent vector's tail optimisation is key to practical performance. The last few elements (up to 32) are stored in a direct array rather than in the tree. Appending to a non-full tail is O(1) — just copy the tail array and add one element. Only when the tail fills up is it pushed into the tree (O(log n)). This amortises the tree operations across 32 appends.

The cache performance of the persistent vector is also better than the persistent BST. The 32-element leaf arrays are contiguous in memory — iterating over a persistent vector accesses 32 elements per cache line, similar to a plain array. The BST and linked list follow one pointer per element, causing one cache miss per element.

20.7 Transients: Efficient Bulk Updates

Persistent structures create a new version per operation. For code that builds a structure from scratch — inserting a thousand elements, then publishing the result — creating a thousand intermediate versions is wasteful. Each intermediate version is immediately discarded.

Clojure's solution: transients. A transient is a mutable version of a persistent structure, created from and convertible back to a persistent structure. Operations on transients modify in place (no path copying, no structural sharing). When mutation is complete, the transient is "frozen" into an immutable persistent structure.

```
class Transient_HashMap [K -> Hashable, V]
  create
    from_persistent(persistent: Persistent_HashMap[K, V]) do
      -- Copy the persistent structure into a mutable form
      this.data := {}  -- plain mutable hash map
      across persistent.entries() as entry do
        data.put(entry.get(0), entry.get(1))
      end
      this.frozen := false
    end

    empty() do
      this.data := {}
      this.frozen := false
    end

  feature
    data: Map[K, V]      -- mutable: operations modify in place
    frozen: Boolean      -- true after freeze(): prevents further modificat

    put(key: K, value: V): Transient_HashMap[K, V]
      require
        not_frozen: not frozen
      do
        data.put(key, value)
        result := self  -- same transient, modified in place
      end

    remove(key: K): Transient_HashMap[K, V]
      require
        not_frozen: not frozen
      do
        data.remove(key)
        result := self
      end

    get(key: K): ?V do
```

```
      result := data.get(key)
    end

    -- Freeze: convert to immutable persistent structure
    -- After this call, this transient is unusable
    freeze(): Persistent_HashMap[K, V]
      require
        not_frozen: not frozen
      do
        frozen := true
        -- Build persistent structure from accumulated data
        let result_map: Persistent_HashMap[K, V] :=
          create Persistent_HashMap[K, V].empty()
        across data.entries() as entry do
          result_map := result_map.put(entry.get(0), entry.get(1))
        end
        result := result_map
      ensure
        frozen_now: frozen
      end

  invariant
    valid_state: true  -- frozen prevents modification after freeze
end
```

Using transients for bulk construction:

```
-- Build a map from a thousand entries efficiently
function build_map(entries: Array[Any]):
                   Persistent_HashMap[String, Integer] do
  let transient_map: Transient_HashMap[String, Integer] :=
    create Transient_HashMap[String, Integer].empty()

  -- All mutations happen in the transient: no path copying
  across entries as entry do
    transient_map.put(entry.get(0), entry.get(1))
```

```
  end

  -- Freeze once: convert to persistent
  result := transient_map.freeze()
end
```

Building a thousand-entry map with a transient costs O(n) time and O(n) allocations — the same as building a mutable map. Building it directly as a persistent map costs O(n log n) time (one path copy per insert) and O(n log n) allocations. The transient approach is the practical solution for bulk construction.

20.8 Persistent Structures as Version Control

Persistent structures naturally implement version control. Every version is preserved; moving between versions is a matter of holding the right reference.

```
class Versioned_Store [T]
  create
    make(initial: T) do
      this.versions := [initial]
      this.current_version := 0
    end

  feature
    versions: Array[T]          -- all historical versions
    current_version: Integer    -- index of current version

    current(): T do
      result := versions.get(current_version)
    end
```

```
-- Commit a new version
commit(new_state: T) do
  -- Discard any versions after current (redo history)
  versions := versions.slice(0, current_version + 1)
  versions.add(new_state)
  current_version := versions.length - 1
end

undo(): Boolean do
  if current_version > 0 then
    current_version := current_version - 1
    result := true
  else
    result := false
  end
end

redo(): Boolean do
  if current_version < versions.length - 1 then
    current_version := current_version + 1
    result := true
  else
    result := false
  end
end

-- Branch: create a new version store from current state
branch(): Versioned_Store[T] do
  let new_store: Versioned_Store[T] :=
    create Versioned_Store[T].make(current())
  result := new_store
end

history_size(): Integer do
  result := versions.length
end
```

```
  invariant
    valid_version: current_version >= 0 and current_version < versions.leng
    non_empty_history: versions.length > 0
end
```

With persistent structures, the memory cost of keeping 100 historical versions of a `Persistent_HashMap` is not 100 × map size — it is O(100 × log n) for the new nodes created by each update, with all unchanged nodes shared. This is structurally the same as how git stores repository history: each commit is a snapshot that shares structure with preceding commits, new objects created only for changed content.

20.9 The Connection to Chapter 14

Chapter 14 built the piece table — a data structure for mutable text editing. The rope, also covered in that chapter, uses the same structural sharing as persistent trees: split and concat create new nodes at the top of the tree while sharing unchanged subtrees.

The rope is a persistent data structure in the same sense as the persistent BST. Old versions of the rope (previous states of the document) remain valid as long as they are referenced. The undo history in the rope editor from Chapter 14 is exactly a version store — a stack of rope roots, each sharing structure with the others.

The piece table takes a different approach to persistence: immutable buffers (original and append) with a mutable piece list. This is a hybrid: the data itself is never modified (immutable buffers), but the index into that data (the piece list) is mutable. The undo history stores piece list snapshots — cheap because piece lists are small.

Both approaches achieve similar goals with different mechanisms. The rope is pure persistent data structure theory. The piece table is pragmatic

immutability — make the expensive thing (the document content) immutable, and manage the cheap thing (the piece index) with normal mutation.

20.10 Where This Lives in the Wild

Clojure's standard library is built entirely on persistent data structures. Lists, vectors, hash maps, sorted maps, and sets are all persistent, all thread-safe without any synchronisation for reads, all supporting efficient structural sharing. Clojure's core philosophy — immutability by default, explicit mutation as a special case — stems from Rich Hickey's conviction that mutable shared state is the primary source of complexity in concurrent programs. The persistent HAMT implementation in `clojure.lang.PersistentHashMap` (approximately 1,000 lines of Java) is the reference implementation that all other language ports follow.

Scala's immutable collections in the standard library use HAMTs for `immutable.HashMap` and `immutable.HashSet`, and a similar trie structure for `immutable.Vector`. These are the default collection types in Scala — mutable collections are in a separate package, a deliberate design choice to make immutability the path of least resistance.

Haskell achieves immutability at the language level — all values are immutable by default, and mutable state requires explicit monadic wrapping. The `Data.HashMap` package uses the same HAMT design as Clojure. Haskell's lazy evaluation and garbage collection make persistent data structures efficient: sharing is pervasive, and unused old versions are collected automatically.

React and Redux use immutable state management in JavaScript. Redux's core principle — state is a single immutable object, updates create new state objects — is persistent data structure thinking applied to UI. Libraries like Immutable.js provide persistent list and map implementations for JavaScript, and Immer provides the same semantics with a more ergonomic API (mutate a draft, produce an immutable snapshot).

Git is a version control system built on persistent data structures. Every commit is a persistent snapshot of the repository state, sharing structure with adjacent commits. A git repository with ten years of history does not store ten years of full copies — it stores the original files plus diffs, with shared content-addressed objects. The design is directly analogous to the `Versioned_Store` in this chapter.

Summary

Persistent data structures achieve thread safety not by protecting mutable state but by eliminating mutability. Immutable data can be shared between threads freely — there is no race condition possible when nothing changes.

The technique that makes immutability practical is structural sharing: when creating a new version of a structure, share unchanged portions with the old version. Prepending to a persistent list creates one new node and shares the entire existing list. Updating a persistent BST creates O(log n) new nodes (the path from root to the updated node) and shares all other nodes. The HAMT achieves $O(\log_{32} n)$ operations with 32-way branching — effectively constant for realistic dataset sizes.

Publishing a new version to other threads requires exactly one atomic write — the pointer to the root of the new structure. Readers need no synchronisation; they read the pointer atomically and then access the immutable structure freely.

Transients address the cost of bulk construction: mutable during construction, immutable (persistent) once frozen. Build with a transient, publish the frozen result. All intermediate versions are discarded; only the final result is persistent.

The concurrency advantage of persistent structures is absolute for reads: no locks, no atomics, no contention. The cost is allocation — O(log n) new nodes per update rather than in-place modification. Whether

this cost is acceptable depends on the update frequency. For read-heavy workloads with infrequent updates — configuration data, reference tables, shared caches — persistent structures are often the best available solution.

The final chapter in this section extends the concurrency toolkit in a different direction: instead of sharing data between threads, threads communicate by passing messages. Channels and the CSP model, built into Nex as a first-class feature, offer a different and often simpler way to structure concurrent systems.

Chapter 21: Message Passing — Channels and the CSP Model

There is a thought experiment that clarifies the fundamental difficulty of shared state concurrency. Imagine two people sharing one notebook. Both need to read and write notes. They agree on a protocol: before writing, check if the other person is writing; if so, wait. The protocol works, but it requires constant coordination — checking, waiting, checking again. If one person falls asleep mid-sentence, the other is stuck. If both check simultaneously and both see the other is free, both write at once and the notes become garbled.

Now imagine a different arrangement. The two people each have their own notebook. When one needs to communicate with the other, they write a note and pass it across. The other receives it, reads it, writes a response, passes it back. No shared notebook. No checking. No waiting for the other to finish. Communication happens through the act of passing the note, not through watching a shared resource.

This is the core intuition behind message passing: instead of sharing memory and synchronising access to it, share nothing and communicate explicitly. Each thread owns its own state. Interaction happens through channels — conduits through which messages flow from sender to receiver.

The formal theory behind this intuition was developed by Tony Hoare in 1978 in a paper called "Communicating Sequential Processes." CSP gave message passing a mathematical foundation and inspired the design of several programming languages, most prominently Occam (designed for parallel hardware), Erlang (for fault-tolerant distributed systems), and

Go (for concurrent server programming). Nex's channel and task system is directly in the CSP tradition.

This chapter builds a complete understanding of message passing in Nex, develops the canonical concurrent patterns — pipelines, fan-out, fan-in, cancellation — and explains when channels are the right tool and when shared state (with appropriate synchronisation) is better.

21.1 The CSP Model

In CSP, a program consists of processes that execute concurrently and communicate through synchronous message passing. The key properties:

Processes do not share memory. Each process has its own local state, inaccessible to other processes. There is no shared mutable state to protect.

Communication is synchronous. A send blocks until a receiver is ready. A receive blocks until a sender is ready. The two operations complete together — they rendezvous. This synchronisation is not incidental; it is the mechanism by which processes coordinate.

Communication is typed. A channel carries values of a specific type. Sending the wrong type is a compile-time error, not a runtime surprise.

Processes are lightweight. The model assumes that creating thousands of concurrent processes is practical, because each process is not a heavyweight OS thread — it is a lightweight task multiplexed over a pool of OS threads.

Hoare's synchronous rendezvous model is the strict version of CSP. Practical systems often use buffered channels — channels that can hold some number of messages without a receiver being ready, allowing the sender to continue. Buffering trades the strict coordination of synchronous

rendezvous for flexibility and throughput. Both modes are useful; understanding when to use each is part of the skill.

Nex implements both: `create Channel[T]` gives an unbuffered channel (synchronous rendezvous), and `create Channel[T].with_capacity(n)` gives a buffered channel that holds up to n messages before blocking senders.

21.2 The Basic Channel

```
-- Unbuffered channel: sender blocks until receiver is ready
let ch: Channel[Integer] := create Channel[Integer]

let sender: Task := spawn do
  ch.send(42)
  print("sent")  -- prints after receiver is ready
end

let receiver: Task := spawn do
  let value: Integer := ch.receive
  print("received: " + value.to_string())
end

sender.await
receiver.await
-- Output: "received: 42" then "sent" (or simultaneously)
```

The unbuffered channel is a meeting point. Sender and receiver must both be present for the transfer to occur. The sender arrives first and waits. The receiver arrives, takes the value, and both proceed. The rendezvous is the synchronisation.

```
-- Buffered channel: sender can proceed without waiting for receiver
let buffered: Channel[Integer] := create Channel[Integer].with_capacity(3)

-- These three sends do not block: buffer has space
buffered.send(1)
buffered.send(2)
buffered.send(3)

-- This fourth send would block: buffer is full
-- buffered.send(4)  -- blocks until someone receives

-- Receives drain the buffer
print(buffered.receive)  -- 1
print(buffered.receive)  -- 2
print(buffered.receive)  -- 3
```

The buffered channel is a queue with bounded capacity. Senders block only when the buffer is full. Receivers block only when the buffer is empty. The buffer decouples producer and consumer timing: they need not rendezvous, but the buffer prevents unbounded accumulation.

21.3 Pipelines: Chaining Transformations

The first and most fundamental concurrent pattern is the pipeline: a sequence of stages where each stage reads from an input channel, transforms the data, and writes to an output channel.

```
-- Pipeline: generate → transform → collect

-- Stage 1: Generator — produces integers
function generate(count: Integer): Channel[Integer] do
  let out: Channel[Integer] := create Channel[Integer].with_capacity(16)
```

```
  spawn do
    from
      let i: Integer := 0
    until
      i < count
    do
      out.send(i)
      i := i + 1
    end
    out.close  -- signal: no more values
  end

  result := out
end

-- Stage 2: Square — squares each integer
function square(in_ch: Channel[Integer]): Channel[Integer] do
  let out: Channel[Integer] := create Channel[Integer].with_capacity(16)

  spawn do
    from until true do
      let value: ?Integer := in_ch.try_receive
      if value = nil then
        -- Check if channel is closed
        if in_ch.is_closed then
          out.close
          return
        end
        -- Channel not closed but no value yet: keep trying
      else
        out.send(value * value)
      end
    end
  end

  result := out
end
```

```
-- Stage 3: Filter — keeps only even numbers
function filter_even(in_ch: Channel[Integer]): Channel[Integer] do
  let out: Channel[Integer] := create Channel[Integer].with_capacity(16)

  spawn do
    from until true do
      let msg: ?Integer := receive_or_done(in_ch)
      if msg = nil then
        out.close
        return
      end
      if msg % 2 = 0 then
        out.send(msg)
      end
    end
  end

  result := out
end

-- Compose the pipeline
let numbers: Channel[Integer] := generate(20)
let squared: Channel[Integer] := square(numbers)
let evens: Channel[Integer] := filter_even(squared)

-- Collect results
from until true do
  let result: ?Integer := receive_or_done(evens)
  if result = nil then break end
  print(result.to_string())
end
-- Prints: 0, 4, 16, 36, 64, 100, 144, 196, 256, 324
-- (squares of 0,2,4,6,8,10,12,14,16,18)
```

Each stage is a separate task. The buffered channels between stages allow each stage to run at its own pace — if squaring is faster than filtering,

the squares buffer up; if filtering is faster, the filter waits. The pipeline naturally handles rate differences between stages.

The `close` operation on a channel signals to receivers that no more values will come. Receivers can detect closure and propagate it downstream — each stage closes its output channel when it detects its input channel is closed. This clean shutdown propagation is a natural feature of the pipeline pattern.

A Reusable Pipeline Stage

```
class Pipeline [A, B]
  create
    make(transform: Function[A, B]) do
      this.transform := transform
    end

  feature
    transform: Function[A, B]

    -- Connect: returns output channel, runs transform in background
    connect(input: Channel[A]): Channel[B] do
      let output: Channel[B] := create Channel[B].with_capacity(16)

      spawn do
        from until true do
          let msg: ?A := receive_or_done(input)
          if msg = nil then
            output.close
            return
          end
          output.send(transform(msg))
        end
      end

      result := output
```

```
    end

    -- Chain multiple pipelines
    then_apply(next: Pipeline[B, C]): Pipeline[A, C] do
      result := create Pipeline[A, C].make(
        fn a: A do
          result := next.transform(transform(a))
        end)
    end
end

-- Utility: receive from channel, return nil if closed
function receive_or_done [T] (ch: Channel[T]): ?T do
  if ch.is_closed and ch.is_empty then
    result := nil
    return
  end
  result := ch.receive
end
```

21.4 Fan-Out: Distributing Work

Fan-out distributes items from one channel to multiple workers, each processing items independently. This is the natural pattern for parallelising CPU-bound work.

```
-- Fan-out: distribute work across N workers
function fan_out(input: Channel[Integer],
                 num_workers: Integer,
                 process: Function[Integer, Integer]): Channel[Integer] do
  let output: Channel[Integer] := create Channel[Integer].with_capacity(64)
  let workers_done: Atomic_Integer := create Atomic_Integer.make(0)
```

```
  from
    let w: Integer := 0
  until
    w < num_workers
  do
    spawn do
      from until true do
        let item: ?Integer := receive_or_done(input)
        if item = nil then
          -- This worker is done
          if workers_done.increment() = num_workers then
            output.close  -- last worker closes output
          end
          return
        end
        output.send(process(item))
      end
    end
    w := w + 1
  end

  result := output
end
```

All workers read from the same input channel. Nex channels are safe for concurrent access — multiple goroutines can receive from the same channel, and each item is delivered to exactly one receiver. This creates natural load balancing: fast workers take more items, slow workers take fewer, without any explicit scheduling.

```
-- Example: parallel image processing
let image_paths: Channel[String] := load_image_paths("/images")

-- Fan out to 8 workers, each processing images independently
let processed: Channel[String] := fan_out_string(
  image_paths, 8,
```

```
  fn path: String do
    result := process_image(path)  -- CPU-intensive
  end)

-- Collect processed images
from until true do
  let result_path: ?String := receive_or_done(processed)
  if result_path = nil then break end
  save_result(result_path)
end
```

Fan-Out with Results Ordering

The basic fan-out does not preserve order — workers finish at different times and emit results as they complete. If order matters, add sequence numbers:

```
class Ordered_Item [T]
  create
    make(sequence: Integer, value: T) do
      this.sequence := sequence
      this.value := value
    end

  feature
    sequence: Integer
    value: T
end

function ordered_fan_out(input: Channel[Integer],
                         num_workers: Integer,
                         process: Function[Integer, Integer]): Channel[Integ
  -- Tag items with sequence numbers
  let tagged: Channel[Ordered_Item[Integer]] :=
    create Channel[Ordered_Item[Integer]].with_capacity(64)
  let result_ch: Channel[Ordered_Item[Integer]] :=
```

```
    create Channel[Ordered_Item[Integer]].with_capacity(64)
  let output: Channel[Integer] := create Channel[Integer].with_capacity(64)

  -- Tagging stage
  spawn do
    let seq: Integer := 0
    from until true do
      let item: ?Integer := receive_or_done(input)
      if item = nil then
        tagged.close
        return
      end
      tagged.send(create Ordered_Item[Integer].make(seq, item))
      seq := seq + 1
    end
  end

  -- Workers
  let workers_done: Atomic_Integer := create Atomic_Integer.make(0)
  from
    let w: Integer := 0
  until
    w < num_workers
  do
    spawn do
      from until true do
        let item: ?Ordered_Item[Integer] := receive_or_done(tagged)
        if item = nil then
          if workers_done.increment() = num_workers then
            result_ch.close
          end
          return
        end
        let processed: Integer := process(item.value)
        result_ch.send(create Ordered_Item[Integer].make(item.sequence, pro
      end
    end
```

```
    w := w + 1
  end

  -- Reorder stage: reassemble in sequence order
  spawn do
    let next_seq: Integer := 0
    let buffer: Map[Integer, Integer] := {}

    from until true do
      let item: ?Ordered_Item[Integer] := receive_or_done(result_ch)
      if item = nil then
        output.close
        return
      end

      buffer.put(item.sequence, item.value)

      -- Emit all consecutive completed items
      from until not buffer.contains(next_seq) do
        output.send(buffer.get(next_seq))
        buffer.remove(next_seq)
        next_seq := next_seq + 1
      end
    end
  end

  result := output
end
```

21.5 Fan-In: Merging Results

Fan-in is the inverse: merge results from multiple channels into one. This is used to collect results from fan-out workers, aggregate data from multiple sources, or combine streams.

```
-- Fan-in: merge multiple input channels into one output channel
function fan_in [T] (inputs: Array[Channel[T]]): Channel[T] do
  let output: Channel[T] := create Channel[T].with_capacity(64)
  let done_count: Atomic_Integer := create Atomic_Integer.make(0)
  let n: Integer := inputs.length

  across inputs as input do
    spawn do
      from until true do
        let item: ?T := receive_or_done(input)
        if item = nil then
          if done_count.increment() = n then
            output.close
          end
          return
        end
        output.send(item)
      end
    end
  end

  result := output
end
```

Fan-in using Nex's select statement is more elegant. `select` waits on multiple channel operations simultaneously, proceeding with whichever is ready first:

```
function fan_in_select [T] (inputs: Array[Channel[T]]): Channel[T] do
```

```
  let output: Channel[T] := create Channel[T].with_capacity(64)

  spawn do
    let active: Integer := inputs.length

    from until active = 0 do
      -- select would handle this elegantly if we had dynamic channel lists
      -- For static cases, select is cleaner
      let found: Boolean := false
      across inputs as input do
        if not input.is_closed or not input.is_empty then
          let item: ?T := input.try_receive
          if item /= nil then
            output.send(item)
            found := true
          elseif input.is_closed and input.is_empty then
            active := active - 1
          end
        end
      end
      if not found then
        -- No input ready: yield briefly
        hint_yield()
      end
    end

    output.close
  end

  result := output
end
```

The Pipeline-FanOut-FanIn Pattern

These three primitives compose naturally into the scatter-gather pattern: scatter work across workers with fan-out, gather results with fan-in, process the combined stream.

```
function scatter_gather(input: Channel[String],
                        num_workers: Integer): Channel[String] do
  -- Fan out to workers
  let worker_outputs: Array[Channel[String]] := []
  from
    let w: Integer := 0
  until
    w < num_workers
  do
    let worker_output: Channel[String] :=
      create Channel[String].with_capacity(16)
    worker_outputs.add(worker_output)

    spawn do
      from until true do
        let item: ?String := receive_or_done(input)
        if item = nil then
          worker_output.close
          return
        end
        -- Each worker does some processing
        worker_output.send(item.to_upper())
      end
    end

    w := w + 1
  end

  -- Fan in results
  result := fan_in(worker_outputs)
end
```

21.6 Cancellation and Done Channels

Long-running pipelines need a way to stop. A worker that is blocked on a channel receive cannot be interrupted from outside — it needs to cooperate in its own termination. The standard mechanism: a done channel.

A done channel carries no values — it is used purely for signalling. When the coordinator wants to stop the workers, it closes the done channel. Workers check the done channel periodically (or with select) and exit when it is closed.

```
class Cancellable_Pipeline
  create
    make() do
      this.done := create Channel[Void]
      this.cancelled := false
    end

  feature
    done: Channel[Void]
    cancelled: Boolean

    -- Cancel: signal all workers to stop
    cancel() do
      if not cancelled then
        cancelled := true
        done.close  -- closing broadcasts to all receivers
      end
    end

    -- Generate integers until cancelled
    generate_until_cancelled(limit: Integer): Channel[Integer] do
      let out: Channel[Integer] := create Channel[Integer].with_capacity(16)
```

```
  let done_ref: Channel[Void] := done  -- capture for closure

  spawn do
    from
      let i: Integer := 0
    until
      i < limit
    do
      -- Check for cancellation using select
      select
        when out.send(i) then
          i := i + 1
        when done_ref.receive then
          out.close
          return
      end
    end
    out.close
  end

  result := out
end

-- Process items until cancelled
process_until_cancelled(input: Channel[Integer],
                        transform: Function[Integer, Integer]): Channe
  let out: Channel[Integer] := create Channel[Integer].with_capacity(16
  let done_ref: Channel[Void] := done

  spawn do
    from until true do
      select
        when input.receive as value then
          out.send(transform(value))
        when done_ref.receive then
          out.close
          return
```

```
            timeout 100 then
              -- Check if input closed
              if input.is_closed and input.is_empty then
                out.close
                return
              end
          end
        end
      end

      result := out
    end
end
```

The done channel pattern is composable: each stage receives the done channel and propagates cancellation downstream by closing its output channel. A single `cancel()` call ripples through the entire pipeline.

Using `select` with a done channel is the idiomatic pattern. It reacts to whichever event arrives first: a new value to process, or a cancellation signal. This prevents workers from being stuck blocked on receives when cancellation is requested.

21.7 The Select Statement

Nex's `select` statement waits on multiple channel operations simultaneously and executes the first one that is ready. It is the primitive that makes complex concurrent coordination expressible without explicit polling.

```
-- Basic select: wait on two channels
select
  when ch1.receive as value then
```

```
    print("from ch1: " + value.to_string())
  when ch2.receive as value then
    print("from ch2: " + value.to_string())
end

-- Select with send
select
  when output.send(result) then
    print("sent result")
  when done.receive then
    print("cancelled")
    return
end

-- Select with timeout
select
  when data.receive as value then
    process(value)
  timeout 1000 then
    print("no data for 1 second")
end

-- Select with else: non-blocking
select
  when ch.receive as value then
    process(value)
  else
    -- Channel not ready: do something else
    do_background_work()
end
```

The `select` statement is to channels what `switch` is to values: it chooses among alternatives based on readiness rather than value. Its semantics:

1. Evaluate all channel expressions to get the set of operations
2. If multiple operations are ready simultaneously, choose one uniformly at random

3. If none are ready and there is an `else` clause, execute it (non-blocking)
4. If none are ready and there is no `else`, block until one becomes ready
5. If there is a `timeout`, unblock and execute the timeout clause after the specified duration

The random selection among ready operations prevents starvation: if two channels are frequently ready, neither is systematically ignored.

21.8 The Concurrent Pipeline: A Complete Example

Assembling all the patterns into a complete, realistic pipeline: a system that processes a stream of log entries, extracts metrics, and generates alerts.

```
class Log_Entry
  create
    make(timestamp: Integer64,
         level: String,
         message: String,
         service: String) do
      this.timestamp := timestamp
      this.level := level
      this.message := message
      this.service := service
    end

  feature
    timestamp: Integer64
    level: String
    message: String
    service: String
```

```
end

class Metric
  create
    make(service: String,
         error_count: Integer,
         window_start: Integer64) do
      this.service := service
      this.error_count := error_count
      this.window_start := window_start
    end

  feature
    service: String
    error_count: Integer
    window_start: Integer64
end

class Alert
  create
    make(service: String, message: String) do
      this.service := service
      this.message := message
    end

  feature
    service: String
    message: String
end

class Log_Processing_Pipeline
  create
    make(done: Channel[Void]) do
      this.done := done
    end

  feature
```

```
done: Channel[Void]

-- Stage 1: Parse raw log strings into LogEntry objects
parse_stage(raw_logs: Channel[String]): Channel[Log_Entry] do
  let out: Channel[Log_Entry] := create Channel[Log_Entry].with_capacity(

  spawn do
    from until true do
      select
        when raw_logs.receive as line then
          let entry: ?Log_Entry := parse_log_line(line)
          if entry /= nil then
            out.send(entry)
          end
        when done.receive then
          out.close
          return
      end
    end
  end

  result := out
end

-- Stage 2: Fan out to per-service processors
-- Returns map of service_name -> channel
route_by_service(entries: Channel[Log_Entry],
                 services: Array[String]): Map[String, Channel[Log_Entry
  let service_channels: Map[String, Channel[Log_Entry]] := {}

  across services as service do
    service_channels.put(service,
      create Channel[Log_Entry].with_capacity(32))
  end

  let default_ch: Channel[Log_Entry] :=
    create Channel[Log_Entry].with_capacity(32)
```

```
    service_channels.put("other", default_ch)

    spawn do
      from until true do
        select
          when entries.receive as entry then
            let target: ?Channel[Log_Entry] :=
              service_channels.get(entry.service)
            let ch: Channel[Log_Entry] :=
              when target /= nil target else default_ch end
            -- Non-blocking send: drop if service channel full
            ch.try_send(entry)
          when done.receive then
            -- Close all service channels
            across service_channels as name, ch do
              ch.close
            end
            return
        end
      end
    end

    result := service_channels
  end

  -- Stage 3: Aggregate errors per service per time window
  aggregate_errors(entries: Channel[Log_Entry],
                   service: String,
                   window_ms: Integer64): Channel[Metric] do
    let out: Channel[Metric] := create Channel[Metric].with_capacity(8)

    spawn do
      let error_count: Integer := 0
      let window_start: Integer64 := current_time_ms()

      from until true do
        select
```

```
          when entries.receive as entry then
            if entry.level = "ERROR" then
              error_count := error_count + 1
            end

            let now: Integer64 := current_time_ms()
            if now - window_start >= window_ms then
              -- Emit metric for completed window
              out.send(create Metric.make(
                service, error_count, window_start))
              error_count := 0
              window_start := now
            end

          when done.receive then
            -- Emit final window
            if error_count > 0 then
              out.send(create Metric.make(
                service, error_count, window_start))
            end
            out.close
            return

          timeout window_ms.to_integer() then
            -- Window elapsed with no entries: emit zero metric
            out.send(create Metric.make(
              service, error_count, window_start))
            error_count := 0
            window_start := current_time_ms()
        end
      end
    end

    result := out
  end

  -- Stage 4: Generate alerts when error rate exceeds threshold
```

```
alert_stage(metrics: Channel[Metric],
            threshold: Integer): Channel[Alert] do
  let out: Channel[Alert] := create Channel[Alert].with_capacity(8)

  spawn do
    let recent_errors: Map[String, Array[Integer]] := {}

    from until true do
      select
        when metrics.receive as metric then
          -- Keep rolling window of last 5 metric periods
          let history: ?Array[Integer] :=
            recent_errors.get(metric.service)
          let hist: Array[Integer] :=
            when history /= nil history else [] end
          hist.add(metric.error_count)
          if hist.length > 5 then
            hist.remove(0)
          end
          recent_errors.put(metric.service, hist)

          -- Alert if recent average exceeds threshold
          let total: Integer := 0
          across hist as count do total := total + count end
          let avg: Integer := total / hist.length

          if avg > threshold then
            out.send(create Alert.make(
              metric.service,
              "High error rate: " + avg.to_string() +
              " errors/window in " + metric.service))
          end

        when done.receive then
          out.close
          return
      end
```

```
    end
  end

  result := out
end

-- Assemble the complete pipeline
run(raw_logs: Channel[String],
    services: Array[String]): Channel[Alert] do
  -- Stage 1: parse
  let entries: Channel[Log_Entry] := parse_stage(raw_logs)

  -- Stage 2: route by service
  let service_channels: Map[String, Channel[Log_Entry]] :=
    route_by_service(entries, services)

  -- Stage 3 + 4: aggregate and alert per service
  let alert_channels: Array[Channel[Alert]] := []

  across services as service do
    let service_entries: Channel[Log_Entry] :=
      service_channels.get(service)
    let metrics: Channel[Metric] :=
      aggregate_errors(service_entries, service, 10000)
    let alerts: Channel[Alert] := alert_stage(metrics, 10)
    alert_channels.add(alerts)
  end

  -- Fan in all alert channels
  result := fan_in(alert_channels)
end

-- Parse a log line into a LogEntry
parse_log_line(line: String): ?Log_Entry do
  -- Format: "TIMESTAMP LEVEL SERVICE: MESSAGE"
  let parts: Array[String] := line.split(" ")
  if parts.length < 4 then
```

```
        result := nil
        return
      end
      let timestamp: ?Integer64 := Integer64.parse(parts.get(0))
      if timestamp = nil then
        result := nil
        return
      end
      result := create Log_Entry.make(
        timestamp,
        parts.get(1),
        parts.slice(3, parts.length).join(" "),
        parts.get(2).trim_suffix(":"))
    end
end
```

Using the pipeline:

```
let done: Channel[Void] := create Channel[Void]
let pipeline: Log_Processing_Pipeline :=
  create Log_Processing_Pipeline.make(done)

let raw_logs: Channel[String] := create Channel[String].with_capacity(64)

let services: Array[String] := ["auth", "api", "database", "cache"]
let alerts: Channel[Alert] := pipeline.run(raw_logs, services)

-- Feed logs in (from file, network, etc.)
let log_feeder: Task := spawn do
  across read_log_file("/var/log/app.log") as line do
    raw_logs.send(line)
  end
  raw_logs.close
end

-- Consume alerts
```

```
let alert_handler: Task := spawn do
  from until true do
    let alert: ?Alert := receive_or_done(alerts)
    if alert = nil then break end
    notify_ops_team(alert)
  end
end

-- Run for 60 seconds then cancel
sleep(60000)
done.close

log_feeder.await
alert_handler.await
```

The pipeline is self-describing. Each stage is a function that takes input channels and returns output channels. The stages are connected by their channels. The `done` channel provides a uniform cancellation mechanism across all stages. Adding a new stage is just writing a new function and connecting it.

21.9 Rate Limiting with Channels

Channels are a natural primitive for rate limiting. A rate limiter restricts how many operations can proceed per unit time.

```
class Rate_Limiter
  create
    -- Token bucket: N tokens per second
    token_bucket(rate_per_second: Integer) do
      this.tokens := create Channel[Void].with_capacity(rate_per_second)
      this.rate := rate_per_second
```

```
    -- Fill bucket initially
    repeat rate_per_second do
      tokens.try_send()
    end

    -- Refill at rate_per_second tokens per second
    spawn do
      let interval_ms: Integer := 1000 / rate_per_second
      from until true do
        sleep(interval_ms)
        tokens.try_send()  -- non-blocking: drop if full
      end
    end
  end

feature
  tokens: Channel[Void]
  rate: Integer

  -- Wait for a token (blocks if rate limit exceeded)
  acquire() do
    tokens.receive  -- blocks until token available
  end

  -- Try to acquire without blocking
  try_acquire(): Boolean do
    result := tokens.try_receive /= nil
  end

  -- Acquire with timeout
  acquire_timeout(timeout_ms: Integer): Boolean do
    select
      when tokens.receive then
        result := true
      timeout timeout_ms then
        result := false
    end
```

```
    end
end
```

Using the rate limiter in a pipeline:

```
-- Rate-limited API caller: max 100 calls per second
let limiter: Rate_Limiter := create Rate_Limiter.token_bucket(100)

function rate_limited_api_call(requests: Channel[String]): Channel[String] do
  let out: Channel[String] := create Channel[String].with_capacity(16)

  spawn do
    from until true do
      let req: ?String := receive_or_done(requests)
      if req = nil then
        out.close
        return
      end
      limiter.acquire()  -- wait for rate limit token
      out.send(make_api_call(req))
    end
  end

  result := out
end
```

The token bucket limiter uses a buffered channel as the token reservoir. The capacity of the channel equals the burst capacity. The background task adds tokens at the configured rate. Workers consume tokens before proceeding. When the channel is empty (all tokens consumed), workers block — naturally limiting throughput to the configured rate.

21.10 Shared State vs Message Passing: When to Use Each

The message passing model is powerful and eliminates entire classes of bugs. It is not universally better than shared state with synchronisation.

Use message passing when:

The problem is fundamentally about coordination between independent actors — each actor has its own state and communicates with others through well-defined messages. Network servers, event processing systems, worker pools, pipelines — these are natural fits for CSP.

The ownership of data is clear — one goroutine owns a piece of data at a time, and transfers ownership by sending it through a channel. This makes the ownership model explicit and prevents the common bugs of shared ownership.

Cancellation and timeout are important — select with a done channel provides clean, composable cancellation without the complexity of condition variables or manual flag polling.

Use shared state when:

Multiple threads need to access a shared data structure concurrently and independently — a cache, a counter, a leaderboard. These are not naturally modelled as message passing; they are truly shared.

The data structure is read much more than written — a persistent structure or a striped concurrent map serves better than a goroutine serialising all access.

Performance is critical and the synchronisation point is a single operation — an atomic increment or a CAS-based counter does not need the overhead of channels and goroutines.

The practical rule: Go's original concurrency guidance was "Do not communicate by sharing memory; share memory by communicating." This is wisdom, not dogma. For complex state that multiple actors legitimately share, shared state with appropriate synchronisation is the right

model. For coordination between actors, message passing is cleaner. Use both where they fit.

21.11 Nex Channels and the Task System

Nex's native channel and task system, introduced in Chapter 2 of the Nex tutorial, makes the patterns in this chapter idiomatic. The syntax we have used throughout is the real Nex syntax — no imports, no external libraries.

```
-- Nex native: spawn a task
let t: Task[Integer] := spawn do
  result := compute_something()
end

-- Await the result
let value: Integer := t.await

-- Channel creation
let ch: Channel[String] := create Channel[String]
let buffered: Channel[String] := create Channel[String].with_capacity(32)

-- Send and receive
ch.send("hello")
let msg: String := ch.receive

-- Non-blocking
let sent: Boolean := ch.try_send("hello")
let received: ?String := ch.try_receive

-- Timed operations
let sent_timeout: Boolean := ch.send("hello", 1000)  -- 1 second timeout
let recv_timeout: ?String := ch.receive(1000)
```

```
-- Close
ch.close
let is_closed: Boolean := ch.is_closed

-- Select
select
  when ch1.receive as v then handle(v)
  when ch2.send(value) then confirm_sent()
  when done.receive then cleanup()
  timeout 500 then handle_timeout()
  else handle_no_activity()
end

-- Task groups
let results: Array[Integer] := await_all([task1, task2, task3])
let first: Integer := await_any([task1, task2, task3])
```

The `select` statement is particularly important. It is not syntactic sugar — it reflects a hardware-level or runtime-level primitive that can genuinely block on multiple channels simultaneously. Without `select`, implementing the done channel pattern requires polling, which wastes CPU and introduces latency. With `select`, the runtime efficiently multiplexes the blocked task over all its waiting channels.

21.12 The Actor Model: A Close Relative

CSP and the Actor model are closely related but distinct.

In CSP: - Communication is through named channels - Sender and receiver are decoupled — they share a channel, not identities - Communication is synchronous in the pure model

In the Actor model (Erlang, Akka): - Each actor has a unique address (mailbox) - Communication is to an actor's mailbox (asynchronous, buffered) - Actors are identified, not channels

Both models avoid shared mutable state. The difference is in how communication is structured: CSP through shared channels, actors through actor-addressed mailboxes.

In practice, the distinction blurs. Go's goroutines with channels are CSP. Erlang's processes with mailboxes are actors. Both avoid shared mutable state and model concurrent computation as independent entities communicating through messages. The theoretical differences matter for language designers; for practitioners, the patterns — pipelines, fan-out, fan-in, cancellation — apply equally to both.

Nex's model is CSP with some actor-like features: channels are first-class and can be passed as values (CSP), but tasks have identities and can be awaited individually (actors).

21.13 Where This Lives in the Wild

Go is the language that brought CSP to mainstream programming. Goroutines are lightweight tasks, channels are first-class values, and `select` is a core statement. The Go standard library and ecosystem are built around these primitives. Rob Pike's 2012 talk "Concurrency is not Parallelism" — distinguishing concurrent program structure from parallel execution — remains the best accessible explanation of the CSP model.

Erlang implements the Actor model at language level. Erlang processes are extremely lightweight (spawning millions is routine), communicate only through message passing, and crash independently — a crashed process does not affect others. Erlang's OTP (Open Telecom Platform) framework provides supervision trees: processes that monitor other processes and restart them on failure. This has made Erlang the language of

choice for systems requiring extreme reliability — WhatsApp, Discord's backend, and Ericsson's telecom infrastructure all run Erlang.

Rust's async/await with the Tokio runtime uses channels extensively. Tokio provides `mpsc`, `oneshot`, `broadcast`, and `watch` channel types, each optimised for different patterns. The Rust ownership system enforces the CSP discipline at compile time: sending a value through a channel transfers ownership, preventing the sender from using it afterward.

Unix pipes are the original channel-based pipeline. `ls | grep "\.txt" | wc -l` is a three-stage pipeline connected by two channels (pipes). Each stage is a process with its own memory. They share nothing except the byte streams flowing through the pipes. Unix's designers built CSP into the operating system before Hoare formalised it.

Apache Kafka is a distributed channel. Producers send messages to topics; consumers receive from topics; the broker buffers and replicates messages. The Kafka model is CSP at datacenter scale: services communicate through Kafka topics rather than shared databases or direct API calls, achieving the same decoupling that channels provide within a single program.

Summary

Message passing, formalised by Hoare's Communicating Sequential Processes in 1978, provides an alternative to shared-state concurrency. Instead of protecting shared mutable state with locks, processes own private state and communicate through channels. The result is concurrent programs that are easier to reason about, test, and cancel.

Nex implements CSP natively: tasks are lightweight concurrent processes, channels are typed conduits for message passing, and `select` blocks on multiple channel operations simultaneously.

The canonical patterns compose from three primitives. **Pipelines** chain stages connected by channels, each stage transforming its input and forwarding to the next, with clean shutdown propagation through channel closing. **Fan-out** distributes a single stream across multiple workers for parallel processing, with natural load balancing — fast workers take more items. **Fan-in** merges multiple streams into one, collecting results from parallel workers. **Cancellation** is implemented through a done channel: closing it signals all listening workers to stop, propagating cleanly through the pipeline.

The `select` statement makes these patterns composable: any stage can simultaneously wait for new input, check for cancellation, and timeout — without polling or complex state machines. Rate limiting, backpressure, and timeouts all emerge naturally from the channel model.

Channels and shared state are complementary tools, not competitors. Independent actors with well-defined communication belong in channels. Shared data structures with concurrent readers and writers belong in the concurrent maps and atomic structures of the previous chapters. The practitioner's skill is recognising which model fits the problem.

This concludes Part V, and with it, the technical content of the book. The appendices that follow provide reference material: the complete Nex language reference, a complexity and memory cheat sheet covering every structure in the book, a guide to the production systems where these structures live, and an annotated bibliography for going deeper.

The structures in this book — B-trees, LSM trees, skip lists, suffix arrays, Huffman coders, introsort, lock-free queues, persistent HAMTs, and concurrent pipelines — are not academic exercises. They are in the databases you query, the editors you write in, the compilers that build your code, the filesystems that store your data, and the servers that answer your requests. Understanding them is not just knowing how they work. It is knowing why they work, why they were designed as they were, and when to reach for each one.

That understanding is what this book was for.

Appendix A: Complexity and Memory Cheat Sheet

For every structure in this book: time complexity, space complexity, cache behaviour, and when to reach for it. Worst case unless noted. n = number of elements, m = pattern/key length, k = result count.

Part II — Ordered Structures and Probabilistic Thinking

AVL Tree

Operation	Time
Search	O(log n)
Insert	O(log n)
Delete	O(log n)
Range query	O(log n + k)
In-order traversal	O(n)

Space: O(n) nodes, each storing key, value, left/right pointers, parent pointer, height integer — roughly 40–48 bytes per node.

Cache behaviour: Poor. Each node is separately allocated; traversal follows pointers to scattered memory locations. Expect one cache miss per level.

When to use: Read-heavy ordered maps where minimum search depth matters. Compiler symbol tables, in-memory indexes on largely static data. Prefer over red-black when reads outnumber writes 10:1 or more.

When not to use: Write-heavy workloads (red-black trees rebalance with fewer rotations per write). Any dataset that does not fit in RAM (use B-trees instead).

Red-Black Tree

Operation	Time
Search	O(log n)
Insert	O(log n), at most 2 rotations
Delete	O(log n), at most 3 rotations
Range query	O(log n + k)
In-order traversal	O(n)

Space: O(n). Same pointer overhead as AVL trees, plus one bit for colour — typically rounded to a byte or folded into a pointer bit.

Cache behaviour: Poor, for the same reason as AVL trees. Height is at most 2 $\log_2(n)$ — marginally taller than AVL in exchange for fewer rotations per write.

When to use: General-purpose ordered map under mixed read-write workloads. The default choice in standard libraries (C++ `std::map`, Java `TreeMap`, Linux scheduler). Prefer over AVL when writes are frequent.

When not to use: When you need stable sorted-order iteration over large ranges (the pointer chasing hurts). When the dataset exceeds RAM.

Skip List

Operation	Time (expected)
Search	O(log n)
Insert	O(log n)
Delete	O(log n)
Range query	O(log n + k)
In-order traversal	O(n)

Space: O(n) expected. Each node participates in 1/(1-p) levels on average. With p = 0.5: ~2 pointers per node. With p = 0.25 (Redis): ~1.33 pointers per node. Less overhead than balanced trees; no parent pointer needed.

Cache behaviour: Poor for point queries (pointer chasing), better than trees for sequential range queries (level-0 is a sorted linked list traversed linearly).

When to use: Concurrent ordered maps (easier to make lock-free than trees). Redis sorted sets. When implementation simplicity matters more than worst-case guarantees. When probabilistic balance is acceptable.

When not to use: When deterministic worst-case guarantees are required. When memory per node is tightly constrained (fixed-size arrays beat pointer-heavy nodes). When the dataset is on disk.

B-Tree (on disk, minimum degree t)

Operation	Time (disk reads)
Search	O(log_t n)
Insert	O(log_t n)
Delete	O(log_t n)
Range query	O(log_t n + k/t)
Bulk load	O(n/t × log_t n)

Space: O(n) keys on disk. Each node fills 50–100% of one disk page (typically 4KB–16KB). Space utilisation averages ~69% for random insertions.

Cache behaviour: Excellent for disk. Node size is tuned to disk block size — one block read fetches one node with hundreds of keys. Sequential range queries read leaf pages without seeking. Poor for in-memory use (too many keys per node wastes cache lines on non-matching keys).

When to use: Any ordered index whose dataset exceeds RAM. The primary index structure of every major relational database (PostgreSQL, MySQL InnoDB, SQLite). Filesystem directory indexes. Anything where O(log_t n) disk reads is the constraint.

When not to use: Data that fits in RAM (use red-black tree or skip list). Write-heavy append workloads (use LSM tree). When reads and writes are both sequential (the on-disk format of B-trees does not help sequential I/O).

LSM Tree

Operation	Time
Write (MemTable)	O(log M) where M = MemTable size
Read (best case, in MemTable)	O(log M)
Read (worst case, all levels)	O(L × log n/L) with bloom filters: O(L) expected
Compaction (background)	O(n log n) amortised

Space: Data on disk, O(n). MemTable in RAM, O(M). Bloom filters per SSTable in RAM, O(n × bits_per_key). Space amplification 1.1x–2x depending on compaction strategy.

Cache behaviour: Excellent for writes (sequential append to WAL and SSTable). Poor for reads without bloom filters. With bloom filters, most reads touch only one SSTable at each level.

When to use: Write-heavy workloads (50k+ writes/second). Time-series, event logs, metrics ingestion. Any system where write throughput is more important than read latency. LevelDB, RocksDB, Cassandra, HBase.

When not to use: Read-heavy workloads with random access (B-trees win). When space amplification must be minimal. When write latency spikes during compaction are unacceptable.

Bloom Filter

Operation	Time
Add	O(k) where k = number of hash functions
Query	O(k)
Merge	O(m) where m = bit array size

Space: m bits = $-n \ln(p) / (\ln 2)^2$ for n expected elements and false positive rate p. At 1% FPR: ~9.6 bits/element ≈ 1.2 bytes/element. At 0.1% FPR: ~14.4 bits/element.

Cache behaviour: Excellent. The bit array is compact and accessed sequentially-ish (k positions per query). For small filters, the entire array fits in L1/L2 cache.

When to use: Eliminating unnecessary disk reads in LSM trees and databases. Web crawl deduplication. Network packet inspection. Anywhere you need "definitely not in set" answers in bounded memory. False positives acceptable; false negatives never acceptable.

When not to use: When false positives are unacceptable. When deletions are required (use counting bloom filter, at 4x memory cost). When the set is small enough to fit in a hash table.

Count-Min Sketch

Operation	Time
Increment	O(d) where d = depth (rows)
Estimate	O(d)
Merge	O(w × d) where w = width (columns)

Space: w × d integers. For ε error with δ probability: w = ⌈e/ε⌉, d = ⌈ln(1/δ)⌉. At ε=0.001, δ=0.01: ~2718 × 5 × 4 bytes ≈ 53KB.

Cache behaviour: Excellent. The table is a small 2D array; each operation accesses d cells scattered across rows. With small d, the accessed cells fit in cache.

When to use: Frequency estimation in streaming data. Finding heavy hitters. Network traffic analysis. Cache eviction policy support. When exact counts are too memory-expensive.

When not to use: When underestimates are dangerous (count-min only overestimates). When exact counts are required. When the number of distinct keys is small (use a hash map).

HyperLogLog

Operation	Time
Add	O(1)
Count (estimate)	O(m) where m = number of registers
Merge	O(m)

Space: m bytes (one byte per register). Standard error ≈ 1.04/√m. At m=4096 (p=12): 4KB, 1.6% error. At m=16384 (p=14): 16KB, 0.8% error.

Cache behaviour: Excellent. Registers fit entirely in cache for any practical m.

When to use: Distinct element counting at scale. Daily/monthly active user counts. Search query cardinality. Any "how many unique X?" question at scale. Redis PFADD/PFCOUNT, BigQuery APPROX_COUNT_DISTINCT.

When not to use: When exact counts are required. When n is small (exact counting is cheap). When the standard error is unacceptably large for your use case.

Part III — String Algorithms

Naive String Search

Operation	Time
Search	O(nm) worst, O(n) average on natural text

Space: O(1) extra.

Cache behaviour: Good. Sequential access through both text and pattern. The inner loop accesses contiguous memory.

When to use: Only as a reference implementation for testing other algorithms. For very short patterns ($m \leq 3$) where KMP/Horspool preprocessing overhead dominates.

KMP (Knuth-Morris-Pratt)

Operation	Time
Preprocessing (failure function)	O(m)
Search	O(n)
Total	O(n + m)

Space: O(m) for the failure function array.

Cache behaviour: Good. Text is scanned left-to-right without backtracking. Failure function is a small array, fits in cache.

When to use: When O(n) worst-case guarantee matters. Repetitive patterns (DNA, binary sequences) where naive and Horspool degrade. Streaming text where you cannot buffer.

When not to use: Natural language text where Horspool is typically 2-5× faster in practice.

Boyer-Moore-Horspool

Operation	Time
Preprocessing (skip table)	O(m + σ) where σ = alphabet size
Search	O(nm) worst, O(n/m) best and average on natural text

Space: O(σ) for the skip table (256 bytes for ASCII).

Cache behaviour: Good on natural text. Skip table is tiny (256 bytes, always in L1). Pattern is accessed right-to-left in short bursts. Large skips mean few text bytes are examined.

When to use: General-purpose string search on natural text, log files, source code. The practical default for grep-style workloads. When pattern length m > 3 and the alphabet is diverse.

When not to use: Highly repetitive text with short repeating patterns (KMP is safer). Very short patterns where skip table overhead is not amortised.

Rabin-Karp / Rolling Hash

Operation	Time
Single pattern search	O(n + m) expected
Multi-pattern search (k patterns, same length)	O(n + km) expected
Rolling hash update	O(1) per position

Space: O(k) for the hash set of patterns. O(1) rolling hash state.

Cache behaviour: Excellent. Sequential access; hash computation is arithmetic with no memory indirection.

When to use: Multi-pattern search (k patterns simultaneously in O(n) passes). Plagiarism detection (k-gram fingerprinting). Content-defined chunking (rsync, Dropbox). Substring occurrence counting.

When not to use: Single-pattern search where KMP or Horspool is simpler and equally fast. When false positives (hash collisions) are unacceptable without verification.

Edit Distance (Levenshtein)

Operation	Time
Full table	O(nm)
Space-optimised (distance only)	O(nm) time, O(m) space
Bounded (max distance d)	O(n × min(m, d))

Space: O(nm) for full table (to recover edit sequence). O(m) for distance-only computation.

Cache behaviour: Good. Table is filled row by row; each row accesses the previous row sequentially. Row-major access pattern is cache-friendly.

When to use: Spell checking. DNA sequence alignment. Git diff (on lines). Fuzzy string matching. Any "how similar are these strings?" question.

When not to use: When you need exact matching (use KMP/Horspool). When both strings are very long (O(nm) is prohibitive; use heuristics like BLAST for DNA).

Trie

Operation	Time
Insert	O(m)
Search (exact)	O(m)
Prefix search	O(m + k)
Delete	O(m)

Space: O(total characters in all keys) nodes in the worst case. Each node has up to σ child pointers. For 26-letter English: 26 pointers per node × 4 bytes = 104 bytes minimum per node.

Cache behaviour: Poor. Each character of a key follows a pointer to a new node. One cache miss per character in the worst case.

When to use: Prefix search and autocomplete. IP routing (binary tries). Dictionary lookups where prefix membership is the query. When query time must be O(m) independent of dictionary size.

When not to use: When memory is tight (radix trees use 2–10× less). When the key set is static (sorted array + binary search is simpler and more cache-friendly). When you need only exact lookup (use a hash map).

Radix Tree (Patricia Trie)

Operation	Time
Insert	O(m)
Search	O(m)
Prefix search	O(m + k)
Delete	O(m)

Space: O(n) nodes for n keys. Each node holds an edge label (string), a child map, and terminal flag. 2–10× less memory than a plain trie.

Cache behaviour: Slightly better than tries (fewer nodes to traverse), but still pointer-heavy.

When to use: When trie memory overhead is unacceptable. URL routing, file path indexing, IP prefix matching. Keys with long common prefixes.

When not to use: When key set is small (overhead of radix tree bookkeeping exceeds benefits). When simplicity matters more than memory.

Huffman Coding

Operation	Time
Build frequency table	O(n)
Build tree	O(σ log σ) where σ = alphabet size
Encode	O(n)
Decode	O(n)

Space: O(σ) for the tree and code table. Compressed output: between H and H+1 bits per symbol where H is entropy.

Cache behaviour: Encoding is sequential and cache-friendly. Decoding traverses the tree per bit — somewhat pointer-chasing but tree is small (at most 512 nodes for 256-symbol alphabet).

When to use: Any compression where character frequency is known in advance. The entropy coding stage of gzip/DEFLATE/PNG. Standalone compression of text with skewed character distribution.

When not to use: When the data has no frequency skew (entropy coding gains nothing). When you need to compress symbol sequences longer than one character (arithmetic coding is closer to optimal).

LZ77 / DEFLATE

Operation	Time
Compress (naive)	O(n × W) where W = window size
Compress (hash chain)	O(n) expected
Decompress	O(n)

Space: O(W) for the sliding window. DEFLATE output: 30–70% of input for typical text/code.

Cache behaviour: Sequential access for both input and output. Hash chain lookups are somewhat random within the window but the window is small.

When to use: General-purpose compression. Combined with Huffman as DEFLATE: the format behind gzip, zip, PNG, zlib. When data has repetitive substrings regardless of character frequency.

When not to use: Already-compressed data (the compressed output will be larger). Encrypted data (random bytes compress poorly). When speed is paramount and compression ratio is secondary (use simpler schemes).

Suffix Array + LCP Array

Operation	Time
Construction (SA, prefix doubling)	O(n log n)
Construction (SA-IS, optimal)	O(n)
LCP array construction (Kasai)	O(n)
Pattern search	O(m log n)
Pattern search (LCP-accelerated)	O(m + log n)
Longest repeated substring	O(n) after construction
Longest common substring (two texts)	O((n+m) log(n+m))
Count distinct substrings	O(n) after construction

Space: O(n) for SA (4n bytes), LCP (4n bytes), rank array (4n bytes). Total: ~12 bytes per character of text.

Cache behaviour: Good. SA, LCP, and rank arrays are contiguous. Binary search accesses them in a pattern that respects cache lines reasonably well. Much better than suffix trees.

When to use: Offline text analysis where the text is fixed and queried many times. Bioinformatics (genome search). Finding repeated substrings. All-occurrences search more efficient than running KMP per query.

When not to use: When the text changes frequently (suffix arrays are static). For a single pattern search on a text queried once (KMP is simpler). When O(m log n) per query is too slow (consider FM-index for O(m) queries).

Rope

Operation	Time
Prepend / Concat	O(1)
Insert at position	O(log n)
Delete range	O(log n)

Operation	Time
Character access	O(log n)
Sequential iteration	O(n), but pointer-chasing
Rebalance	O(n) (triggered when tree becomes too deep)

Space: O(n) characters plus O(n/L) nodes where L = leaf size (typically 32–512 bytes). Each node: left/right pointers, weight integer — ~24 bytes per node.

Cache behaviour: Poor for sequential access (pointer chasing through tree). Good for random access relative to alternatives. Iteration over 100 characters may touch 10+ nodes.

When to use: Text editors where structural sharing for undo/redo is important. Very large strings with frequent random insertions and deletions. Persistent/functional text representation.

When not to use: When sequential access performance is critical (piece table wins). When implementation simplicity is important (piece table is significantly simpler).

Piece Table

Operation	Time
Insert	O(p) where p = number of pieces
Delete	O(p)
Character access	O(p)
Sequential iteration	O(n), cache-friendly
Line-to-position	O(p) with augmented newline counts

Space: O(n) for original and append buffers. O(p) for the piece list where p = number of edit operations (typically hundreds, rarely millions). Each piece: 12 bytes.

Cache behaviour: Excellent for sequential access (reads directly from contiguous original/append buffers). Poor for random access in theory (O(p) piece list scan) but p is small in practice.

When to use: Text editors and code editors. VS Code uses a piece tree (piece table indexed by a red-black tree for O(log p) operations). The practical choice for mutable document representation.

When not to use: When structural sharing across versions is required (rope is better). When the document is read-only (plain string or memory-mapped file).

Part IV — Sorting

Introsort (Quicksort + Heapsort + Insertion Sort)

Operation	Time
Average case	O(n log n)
Worst case	O(n log n) guaranteed (heapsort fallback)
Best case (nearly sorted)	O(n log n) (insertion sort handles small partitions)
All-equal elements (three-way)	O(n)

Space: O(log n) stack space (tail call optimised). In-place: O(1) extra beyond the input array.

Cache behaviour: Excellent. In-place partitioning accesses one contiguous array. Sequential scans from both ends. Better than merge sort (no auxiliary array).

When to use: General-purpose in-memory sort of primitives. The algorithm in C++ `std::sort`, Rust `sort_unstable`, Java `Arrays.sort(int[])`. The default choice when stability is not required.

When not to use: When stability is required (use merge sort or Timsort). When sorting a linked list (use merge sort). When data is on disk (use external merge sort).

External Merge Sort

Operation	Time (disk I/O)
Run generation	$O(n/M \times \text{sort}(M)) \approx O(n \log M)$
k-way merge	$O(n \log k)$ using heap
Total passes	2 (one generate, one merge) for $k \leq M/b$
Total time	$O(n \log n)$

Space: $O(M)$ RAM for run generation and merge buffers. $O(n)$ disk for runs and output. Temporary disk usage: up to $2n$ (input + runs, before final merge output replaces runs).

Cache behaviour: Excellent. All I/O is sequential. Run generation reads input sequentially. Merge reads from run files sequentially. No seeking (except to start of each run file).

When to use: Sorting datasets larger than RAM. Database ORDER BY, GROUP BY, index creation. The sort step of external join algorithms. Anywhere sequential disk I/O dominates.

When not to use: When data fits in RAM (introsort is orders of magnitude faster). When data is already sorted or nearly sorted (detect and exploit runs).

Part V — Concurrency

Atomic Integer (fetch-and-add, CAS)

Operation	Time
Load	O(1), ~1ns uncontended
Store	O(1), ~1ns uncontended
Fetch-and-add	O(1), ~5–20ns (cache line ping-pong under contention)
CAS	O(1), ~5–20ns uncontended

Space: 4 or 8 bytes for the value. Must be cache-line aligned to avoid false sharing (pad to 64 bytes if accessed by multiple threads).

Cache behaviour: Excellent when uncontended (cache hit). Degrades to cache coherence traffic under contention: writing the atomic invalidates all other cores' cached copies.

When to use: Reference counting. Simple shared counters. Lock-free algorithm primitives. Single-variable coordination between threads.

When not to use: When multiple variables must be updated atomically (use mutex). When contention is high and throughput matters (use distributed counter / per-thread counters).

Mutex (spinlock / blocking)

Operation	Time
Uncontended acquire/release	O(1), ~10–30ns
Contended acquire	O(1) amortised, with unbounded worst-case wait
Critical section	O(work) — serialised across all threads

Operation	Time

Space: ~40 bytes (OS mutex). ~8 bytes (pure spinlock with one atomic).

Cache behaviour: Acquiring the mutex invalidates the mutex's cache line. Inside the critical section, memory accesses have normal cache behaviour.

When to use: Protecting multi-variable critical sections. Any operation too complex for atomics. The default choice for correctness; optimise only after measuring.

When not to use: When the critical section is hot and contention is measurable (use stripe locking or lock-free). When the critical section is read-only for most callers (use read-write lock).

MPSC Lock-Free Queue

Operation	Time (expected)
Enqueue (any producer)	O(1) amortised with CAS retry
Dequeue (single consumer)	O(1)
Size	O(1) approximate

Space: O(n) nodes. Each node: value + next pointer = ~16 bytes. Plus sentinel head node and atomic tail pointer.

Cache behaviour: Poor under high producer contention (tail pointer cache line bounces between producers). Good for the consumer (head pointer is uncontested). Linked list node allocation causes cache misses per enqueue.

When to use: Multiple threads producing work for one consumer thread. Network listeners → processing thread. Event sources → event loop. When mutex contention on a queue is measured as a bottleneck.

When not to use: When multiple consumers are needed (use MPMC queue). When bounded capacity with backpressure is needed (add a semaphore or use bounded variant). When throughput is modest (mutex-backed queue is simpler).

MPMC Array Queue (Vyukov)

Operation	Time (expected)
Enqueue	O(1) amortised
Dequeue	O(1) amortised
Size	O(1) approximate

Space: O(capacity) — fixed-size circular array. Each cell: sequence number (atomic) + value = ~16 bytes. Must be a power-of-two capacity.

Cache behaviour: Excellent. Array is contiguous. Each cell is padded to its own cache line (64 bytes) to prevent false sharing between adjacent producers/consumers. Sequence numbers are the only inter-thread communication.

When to use: High-throughput producer-consumer with multiple producers and multiple consumers. The Disruptor pattern. When bounded capacity is acceptable and maximum throughput is the goal.

When not to use: When unbounded capacity is needed (use linked-list MPMC). When the capacity is very large (memory cost: 64 bytes × capacity for padded version).

Striped (Sharded) Hash Map

Operation	Time
Get	O(1) amortised hash lookup, O(1) lock acquire
Put	O(1) amortised, serialised within stripe
Remove	O(1) amortised, serialised within stripe
Size	O(stripes) — sum of per-stripe counters

Space: O(n) for entries. O(stripes) for locks and counters. With 64 stripes: ~64 × (lock size + counter size) ≈ 64 × 48 bytes ≈ 3KB overhead.

Cache behaviour: Good. Stripe lock and stripe hash table are localised. Different stripes are accessed independently with no sharing.

When to use: Concurrent cache. Concurrent registry. Any shared map accessed by multiple threads where a single mutex is a measured bottleneck. The practical default for concurrent maps.

When not to use: When key access is heavily skewed to one stripe (hotspot problem — use replication). When reads vastly outnumber writes (use lock-free reads with node locking). When map must be iterated frequently (requires locking all stripes).

Persistent Hash Map (HAMT)

Operation	Time
Get	O(log32 n) ≈ O(1) practical
Put (returns new version)	O(log32 n) new nodes created
Remove (returns new version)	O(log32 n) new nodes created
Merge two maps	O(n log n) naive

Space: O(n) per version, but versions share structure. Each update creates $O(\log_{32} n) \approx 4–7$ new nodes. Each HAMT internal node: bitmap (4 bytes) + compact children array (variable). Each leaf: key + value + hash.

Cache behaviour: Moderate. Trie traversal follows pointers (cache misses), but branching factor 32 means shallow trees (3–4 levels for millions of entries). Better than binary trees; worse than arrays.

When to use: Read-heavy workloads with infrequent updates. Configuration data shared across many threads. Snapshot isolation (each reader holds a version). Undo/redo histories. Clojure, Scala, Haskell persistent maps.

When not to use: Write-heavy workloads (allocation cost per update). When exact memory usage is critical (structural sharing helps but allocation is still O(log n) per write). When O(1) lookup is required (hash map wins).

Channel (Unbuffered / Buffered)

Operation	Time
Send (unbuffered, receiver ready)	O(1)
Send (unbuffered, no receiver)	blocks
Send (buffered, space available)	O(1)
Send (buffered, full)	blocks
Receive	O(1) or blocks
Select (k alternatives)	O(k) to evaluate, O(1) to proceed

Space: Unbuffered: O(1). Buffered: O(capacity) for the internal ring buffer.

Cache behaviour: Good. The channel's internal buffer is a compact ring buffer. Under high throughput, the buffer cache line is hot and shared between sender and receiver.

When to use: Coordinating concurrent tasks where data ownership transfers with the message. Pipelines. Fan-out/fan-in patterns. Cancellation (done channels). Rate limiting (token buckets). The default for inter-task communication in Nex.

When not to use: When multiple threads need to access shared state simultaneously without transferring ownership (use concurrent map or atomic). When communication overhead is too high for the workload (atomic flag or shared memory is faster for simple signals).

All times are asymptotic. Constant factors vary by hardware, compiler, and implementation. Always measure before optimising.

Appendix B: Annotated Bibliography

The literature on algorithms and data structures is vast. This bibliography is deliberately selective — it covers the books and papers most directly relevant to what you have built in this book, with honest assessments of what each is good for and when to reach for it.

Foundational Books

Niklaus Wirth --- *Algorithms + Data Structures = Programs* (1976)

The book that gave this field its name. Wirth presents algorithms and data structures as inseparable — you cannot choose one without committing to the other. Written in Pascal (Wirth designed both), it covers sorting, searching, dynamic data structures, and recursive algorithms with a clarity that has not aged. The treatment is terse by modern standards; Wirth assumes you will think carefully about every sentence. Read it for the discipline of thinking about programs as the sum of their algorithms and their data. Chapter 4 on dynamic information structures remains one of the finest introductions to trees ever written.

Reach for it when: you want to understand what it means to think algorithmically, before the field accumulated decades of complexity. Also when you want to read elegant, minimal code.

Robert Sedgewick --- *Algorithms* (4th edition, with Kevin Wayne, 2011)

The most complete accessible treatment of classical algorithms in print. Sedgewick covers sorting, searching, graphs, and strings with Java implementations that are carefully written and genuinely runnable. The fourth edition is substantially better than earlier editions — the graph and string sections were rewritten and significantly improved. The companion website provides full source and interactive visualisations.

Sedgewick's B-tree coverage is thin (one chapter, in-memory only) and the concurrency coverage is essentially absent. String algorithms are well-covered. Graph algorithms are the book's strongest section.

Reach for it when: you need a reliable reference for any classical algorithm. Also when you want a second perspective on something in this book with a different implementation language and teaching approach.

Thomas Cormen, Charles Leiserson, Ronald Rivest, Clifford Stein --- *Introduction to Algorithms* (4th edition, 2022)

The field's reference text, known universally as CLRS. Encyclopaedic coverage, rigorous proofs, pseudocode rather than real code. Everything is here: sorting, data structures, graph algorithms, dynamic programming, linear programming, NP-completeness, approximation algorithms, computational geometry. The proofs are careful and complete.

CLRS is not a book you read front to back — it is a book you consult. It assumes mathematical maturity (you need to be comfortable with proof by induction, probability, and asymptotic notation). The implementations are pseudocode that must be translated into a real language; the pseudocode is sometimes subtly wrong in ways that matter for implementation.

Reach for it when: you need the authoritative proof that an algorithm is correct or achieves a specific complexity bound. When you encounter an

algorithm name you do not recognise and want the canonical description. As a reference, not a tutorial.

Steven Skiena --- *The Algorithm Design Manual* (3rd edition, 2020)

The most practical of the major algorithms books. Skiena's approach is problem-first in the same spirit as this book: here is a real problem, here is how to think about it, here are the tools to solve it. The first half covers algorithm design techniques (dynamic programming, backtracking, heuristics). The second half is a catalogue of problems with pointers to the best known algorithms for each.

The "war stories" — Skiena's accounts of real projects where algorithmic choices made the difference — are the book's most distinctive feature. They are worth reading for the modelling intuition alone.

Reach for it when: you have a real problem and need to identify which algorithm class applies. When you want to learn how an expert thinks about algorithm selection. When CLRS is too theoretical and Sedgewick does not cover what you need.

Papers: The Originals

Rudolf Bayer and Edward McCreight --- ``Organization and Maintenance of Large Ordered Indexes'' (1970)

The paper that introduced B-trees. Remarkably readable for a 1970 paper. Bayer and McCreight derived the B-tree structure from first principles: given that disk access is the bottleneck and each access retrieves a fixed-size block, what tree structure minimises the number of accesses?

The answer — high fan-out, nodes sized to blocks — is derived, not assumed. The proofs of height bounds and space utilisation are clean and still the best treatment.

Reach for it when: you want to understand why B-trees are shaped the way they are, not just how they work.

Patrick O'Neil, Edward Cheng, Dieter Gawlick, Elizabeth O'Neil --- ``The Log-Structured Merge-Tree'' (1996)

The paper that introduced LSM trees, published in the journal Acta Informatica. The motivation is crystal clear: for write-heavy workloads on disk, the bottleneck is random I/O. The LSM tree eliminates random writes by converting them to sequential writes, deferring organisation to compaction. The paper analyses write amplification, space amplification, and read cost with care. The mathematical model for choosing optimal component sizes is more rigorous than what appears in most implementations.

Reach for it when: you want the theoretical foundation behind RocksDB, Cassandra, and LevelDB. The paper is denser than the chapter in this book but provides the optimisation analysis that implementation docs rarely include.

William Pugh --- ``Skip Lists: A Probabilistic Alternative to Balanced Trees'' (1990)

One of the most readable papers in algorithms. Pugh introduces the skip list with clear motivation (frustration with balanced tree complexity), derives the probabilistic analysis from scratch, and provides worked examples. The analysis of expected height and expected search time is done step by step, not waved away. The paper also covers concurrent skip

lists — the same algorithm that Redis uses — with a brief but insightful section.

Reach for it when: you want the complete probabilistic analysis of skip lists, or when you want a model of how to write a clear algorithms paper.

Ken Thompson --- ``Regular Expression Search Algorithm'' (1968)

Nine pages that changed how regular expressions are implemented. Thompson describes the NFA construction that now bears his name, proves its O(nm) time bound, and explains exactly why backtracking engines can fail. The paper is short enough to read in an afternoon and rewarding enough to read twice. Thompson also describes the DFA simulation and the lazy NFA-to-DFA conversion — all the ideas behind RE2, in nine pages from 1968.

Reach for it when: you want the primary source for Chapter 11. Also as a model of economy: nine pages that contain everything necessary and nothing else.

Aho, Corasick --- ``Efficient String Matching: An Aid to Bibliographic Search'' (1975)

The paper introducing the Aho-Corasick algorithm for searching multiple patterns simultaneously. The algorithm combines a trie of all patterns with KMP-style failure links, producing a DFA that searches for all k patterns simultaneously in O(n + k + output) time. The paper is clear and the algorithm is presented incrementally. Aho-Corasick is the algorithm behind grep with multiple patterns, intrusion detection systems, and antivirus scanners.

Reach for it when: you need multi-pattern search beyond what Rabin-Karp provides (Aho-Corasick handles patterns of different lengths and has no false positives).

Manber and Myers --- ``Suffix Arrays: A New Method for On-Line String Searches'' (1990)

The paper introducing suffix arrays as a practical alternative to suffix trees. Manber and Myers present the $O(n \log^2 n)$ prefix doubling construction, the LCP array, and pattern search. The paper is notable for its honest comparison with suffix trees: slower to construct, less powerful for some operations, but dramatically simpler and more cache-friendly. The recommendation to use suffix arrays in practice over suffix trees is as valid today as in 1990.

Reach for it when: you want the original description of suffix array construction and the LCP-based algorithms for the problems covered in Chapter 13.

David Huffman --- ``A Method for the Construction of Minimum-Redundancy Codes'' (1952)

A three-page paper, Huffman's master's thesis condensed. The algorithm is described simply and the proof of optimality is elegant. Worth reading as a historical document — Huffman invented the algorithm to prove his professor wrong (the professor believed the existing methods were optimal). The proof technique, showing that the greedy choice produces an optimal solution, is the template for dozens of subsequent greedy algorithm proofs.

Reach for it when: you want the original presentation and proof of optimality, or when you want to appreciate how much can be said in three pages.

Ziv and Lempel --- ``A Universal Algorithm for Sequential Data Compression'' (1977)

The LZ77 paper. Remarkably short given its impact — it introduces the sliding window compression idea, proves that the algorithm asymptotically achieves the entropy of any stationary ergodic source (the "universal" in the title), and provides the theoretical foundation that later implementations are built on. The companion paper "Compression of Individual Sequences via Variable-Rate Coding" (1978, LZ78) is equally important.

Reach for it when: you want the information-theoretic justification for why LZ-family compression works, beyond the intuitive "find and back-reference repeated substrings" explanation.

Concurrency

Maurice Herlihy and Nir Shavit --- *The Art of Multiprocessor Programming* (2nd edition, 2021)

The definitive textbook on concurrent data structures. Herlihy and Shavit cover the theory (linearisability, progress conditions, the universality of consensus) and the practice (lock-free queues, concurrent hash maps, skip lists, counting networks) with equal rigour. The proofs are careful. The implementations are Java but the ideas transfer to any language.

This is a graduate-level text. The first four chapters on mutual exclusion and concurrent objects are essential reading for anyone who wants to understand what "lock-free" and "wait-free" actually mean, as opposed to what people think they mean. The later chapters on specific data structures build directly on the foundation.

Reach for it when: you want to go beyond this book's treatment of concurrency. Specifically: when you need to implement a lock-free data

structure not covered here, when you want formal proofs that your concurrent algorithms are correct, or when you want to understand the theoretical limits of what can and cannot be done without locks.

Jeremy Manson, William Pugh, Sarita Adve --- ``The Java Memory Model'' (2005)

The paper specifying the Java Memory Model introduced in Java 5. The JMM defined happens-before as the formal framework for reasoning about visibility in concurrent Java programs. This is the paper that made "volatile," "synchronized," and atomics formally specified rather than implementation-dependent.

The JMM is directly relevant beyond Java: the C++11 memory model, the Go memory model, and Nex's memory model all use happens-before and the same spectrum of memory orderings (relaxed, acquire, release, sequentially consistent). Understanding the JMM means understanding concurrent memory semantics in essentially all modern languages.

Reach for it when: you want the formal definition of happens-before and why it is the right abstraction for concurrent memory. Also useful when debugging a subtle concurrent bug where you need to reason precisely about which writes are visible to which reads.

Dmitry Vyukov --- Various writings on lock-free programming (2006--present)

Vyukov (currently at Google, previously at Intel) has published extensively on lock-free data structures through his website 1024cores.net and through the LMAX Disruptor project. His MPMC queue (the basis of Chapter 18's array-based queue) is described with a careful explanation of the sequence number protocol. His writings on the producer-consumer

problem, bounded queues, and memory ordering are among the most practically useful concurrency resources available.

Reach for it when: you want the most practically-grounded treatment of lock-free queues and concurrent data structures, written by someone who has implemented and benchmarked these structures on real hardware.

C.A.R. Hoare --- ``Communicating Sequential Processes'' (1978)

The paper that formalised message passing. Hoare introduces the process calculus that underlies Go's channels, Nex's task system, and Erlang's actor model. The paper is more mathematical than the other papers listed here — it is a formal specification, not a tutorial. But the core ideas are clear: processes communicate through synchronous message passing, the act of communication is synchronisation, and the complexity of shared-state concurrency is replaced by the simpler question of who sends what to whom.

Reach for it when: you want the formal foundation behind Chapter 21. Also when you want to understand why Go's designers chose channels as the primary concurrency primitive — they explicitly credited CSP.

Russ Cox --- ``Regular Expression Matching Can Be Simple And Fast'' (2007)

An article rather than a formal paper, published on Cox's website (swtch.com). Cox explains the difference between Thompson NFA simulation and backtracking engines, derives the O(nm) bound for NFA simulation, and shows the catastrophic failure of backtracking on crafted inputs. The article includes benchmarks comparing RE2 (Cox's NFA-based implementation) with Perl and Python regex engines. The article

directly motivated RE2's creation and the subsequent adoption of NFA-based matching in production systems.

Reach for it when: you want a clear, accessible explanation of why some regex engines are exponentially slow and how to avoid it. Essential reading before deploying any regex engine in a security-sensitive context.

On Going Deeper

For storage engines beyond what this book covers: the LevelDB source code is the most readable production LSM tree implementation available. The InnoDB source (MySQL's storage engine) is the most readable production B-tree implementation, though substantially more complex. Both are actively maintained and commented.

For distributed systems and how these algorithms apply at scale: Martin Kleppmann's *Designing Data-Intensive Applications* (2017) is the most practically useful book in the space — it treats distributed systems from the data structure and algorithm perspective, showing how the structures in this book become the building blocks of distributed databases, message queues, and consensus systems.

For the mathematical foundations: Knuth's *The Art of Computer Programming* (volumes 1–4) is the authoritative treatment of the mathematics behind sorting, searching, and combinatorial algorithms. It is not a book to read — it is a book to consult. The analysis of algorithms section in volume 1 and the sorting and searching volume (3) are the most relevant to this book. If you find yourself needing a rigorous proof of an average-case complexity result, Knuth either has it or has a reference to it.

The literature is deeper than any one book can map. The papers listed here are the primary sources for the ideas in this book. The textbooks are the most reliable secondary treatments. Everything else — blog posts, conference talks, Stack Overflow answers — should be read with the primary sources in mind.